Defence of the Heart

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/32289079.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

Categories:
F/F, F/M

Fandoms:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018), 逆転裁判 | Gyakuten Saiban | Ace Attorney

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), implied Mitsurugi Reiji | Miles Edgeworth/Naruhodou Ryuuichi | Phoenix Wright, Minor Catra/Scorpia (She-Ra) - Relationship, Minor Bow/Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Adora & Bow & Glimmer (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Naruhodou Ryuuichi | Phoenix Wright, Mitsurugi Reiji | Miles Edgeworth, Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Angella (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Ayasato Mayoi | Maya Fey, Light Hope (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Double Trouble (She-Ra), Hordak (She-Ra), Horde Prime (She-Ra), Wrong Hordak (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), The Judge (Gyakuten Saiban), Perfuma (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Lawsbians, Adora is a Dork (She-Ra), Adora is a lawyer, Catra is a prosecutor, Scorpia is a detective, Bow is in forensics, Unnecessary Feelings, Essentially this is how this project came about, will update relevant characters in forthcoming chapters, Catra is having a bad life, Light Angst, Childhood Friends, Trauma, Murder, Murder Mystery, Enemies to Lovers, Idiots in Love, Complicated Relationships

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by frichard_45

Summary

Adora had always wanted to be a prosecutor, so it's a strange thing when she becomes a defence attorney. Maybe it's her destiny, or maybe she just wants to help people. There's definitely someone she wants to help.

It doesn't help that she has to face off the demoness prosecutor herself, Catra, who seems ever more hellbent on tearing her down. But it doesn't help that the feelings the two have for one another are less than clear-cut.

And of course, there's that old incident from nine years ago, and it won't be long before it comes back to haunt them.

Notes

So the Ace Attorney brainrot hasn't gone, it's just been joined by some She-Ra. I thought the idea of Adora and Catra facing off one another in court would be fun for a drawing sketch, but then I realised there were a lot of parallel with certain story beats, characters and certainly the unnecessary feelings. Just some gay angst all around. So here we have a fic that's set post-Trials and Tribulations, but where the She-Ra characters casually exist. It's structurally similar to the first game but the story I feel does become it's own thing, just blending some choice elements from both franchises.

This may end up being quite a long project from my work perspective but I don't think it will be any longer than 100,000 words give or take.

Also another inspiration for this is SomePaperMoons' 'Second Star to the Right' (https://archiveofourown.org/works/27031108), double so

since I watched She-Ra specifically so I could read it, so please do give it a read, it's really damn good.

Turnabout Sword

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora took her first ever case as a prosecutor. That made sense, since she had always meant to be a prosecutor. She'd wanted to for as long as she could remember: as far back as her mind could reach, plying for memories of walking and talking, playing with her childhood friends. Of course she'd always wanted it. Growing up under Shadow Weaver at the height of her career, the path before Adora was clearly set. Studying for good grades, going to law school, passing the bar. It all culminated in this first case.

She meant to be a prosecutor, but she was meant to be a defence attorney.

The day started the best Adora could have wanted it to. Awaking with an electric tingle, she bounced to her feet and went for a morning run. She did up her hair —a pony tail and a gelled up front— and practised her 'Objection' into the mirror, before going on a second run. Adora liked to run. It helped clear her head, and thank god for that because otherwise she'd have to resort to punching the defendant. That'd be fun to see.

Criminals are a vile breed, Shadow Weaver often said. *It is the aim of every prosecutor to make sure everyone accused is placed behind bars, for the safety of everyone.*

Why do criminals do what they do? Someone (if it wasn't Adora, it would have been *her*) had asked.

Shadow Weaver had answered that it was quite simple. *They are criminals, so that is what they must do. That is what they are.*

So Adora was ready and knew what to do. She would barrage the criminal with the evidence and testimony until their crime was clear to see. Already she could taste the sweet sound of 'guilty.'

Polished tiles, shiny enough to glow with the golden light stretched out ahead in the courtroom lobby. The room had a few sofas upholstered with fine tufted leather, and the upper walls were girded with a series of portraits, each bearing the face of a judge, gavel in hand. She sat in the comfort of the chairs, and looked up the faces. Staring into their frightful eyes, she prepared herself for the real thing.

"I'm ready. I can do this," she muttered, "I can do this. I'm ready—"

"Adora," came a deep voice to her side.

Adora jumped to her feet.

"The Prosecution is Ready— uh, I mean, hello, Shadow Weaver."

Shadow Weaver was a tall woman, with long black hair hovering in a way to extend her total height. Nowadays, she wore a mask. It was always obscuring her face, but for her eyes, seeming white; they often narrowed when they apprehended something of her displeasure.

"We're about to go in soon," she said, "have you memorised the facts of the case?

"I'm on top of things. The defendant impaled the victim with a sword in the victim's apartment. A witness saw it happen."

"The case is quite simple really," Shadow Weaver said with a satisfied nod, "I'd say too rudimentary even for your first case."

"If I may ask, why not give me more of a challenge?" With a straighten of her back, Adora added, "I can take it."

Shadow Weaver gave a small chuckle, that, while like everything behind that mask was a little menacing, carried some warmth.

"You misunderstand. This will be a challenge. The Chief Prosecutor is interested in how you handle the defence."

Adora's eyes widened. She did not let up her proud, straightened pose as she breathed in what she had just heard.

"Chief Prosecutor Hordak himself is watching?"

"He specifically requested you," said Shadow Weaver, "You've been given a great opportunity here, Adora."

"I'm honoured," Adora said through a stammer. "But what's so important about the defence?"

"He is not to be taken lightly. The dents in the otherwise perfect prosecuting records of many prodigies can attest to that." Shadow Weaver looked down at Adora, a new gleam in her white eyes. "But I have trained you knowing that you can best all others, and this trial has been long in the making. There is as much for me at stake as there is for you. The Chief Prosecutor will be following this trial closely… for both our sakes."

"No pressure, then…," said Adora. "I can handle him."

"Yes, I believe you can," Shadow Weaver began to glide towards the courtroom doors. "You will win so long as you remember to do what it takes to win."

Adora followed, and the two went inside, met with the sight of courtroom no. 3. The collonnaded back wall was made of white marble and in its centre hung an emblem of scales. In front of that was the bald and bearded judge at his high bench. A chattering crowd filled the air with their murmurs from the surrounding galleries.

The two took their place behind the prosecution bench. Opposite them the defence, also two people, stood waiting. The smaller one grabbed Adora's eye first, for she was dressed in purple kimono. Next to her, the taller man was comparatively normal in dress; just a blue suit and red tie.

This man was Phoenix Wright. In some ways he felt just as nervous as Adora. Though he had been in this job for three years,

nothing unravelled a person like the terse moments before the Judge called for order and began proceedings. And Phoenix had only taken this case last night. He'd had little time to review the facts let alone undergo a proper investigation.

But to Adora, he looked composed, with a hand on his hip and looking out stoically in wait. Leaning in, she scrutinised him with a peering eye. Maybe some weakness lay under that calm expression, one she could exploit in battle. Yet there was nothing. Whoever this defence attorney was, he clearly had everything under control.

Phoenix Wright leaned to assistant, Maya Fey, and asked in a low voice:

"What… was our client's name again?"

The look that Maya gave him was one of utter wretched defeat, but before she could answer, the Judge's gavel came down with a sharp thunk. Silence fell over the courtroom.

"Court is now in session for the trial of ms. Glimmer."

"The Defence is ready, your honour," said Phoenix, straightening up.

The Judge looked to Adora and Shadow Weaver.

"And the prosecution?"

Swept up in new fit of energy, Adora pulled a fast grin and said, "as ready as we'll ever be."

"I don't think I've seen you before," said the defence attorney, "Are you a new prosecutor?"

"This is my debut," Adora explained, feeling the need to add, "I'm a prosecutor and I'm only 17."

"Man, these prodigies sure get younger all the time…."

“And… you’re what all the fuss is about?” Adora raised her brow. “You’re just some guy.”

Such words hit Phoenix like a slap from a gloved palm, and he slumped in response.

“I’m not just some guy, I’m Phoenix Wright! Don’t people know who I am?”

“Face it Nick, you’re old news” Maya teased, “Or maybe just old.”

“I’m only 26….”

“Enough of this repartee.” Shadow Weaver’s voice cut across the court. “Proceed with the opening statement.”

Thus, Adora’s work began. She recited the basic facts of the case —the victim impaled in her own apartment just a few days ago, between the time of 1 and 4— and provided key evidence to back up the groundwork to her argument. An autopsy report was the first to be submitted, but then Adora called for the bailiffs to bring in the murder weapon.

The first thing about it was the gleam. Light of silver and gold intermingled so at first glance what was what wasn’t clear. A second look and its form came into focus —a broad-bladed sword with a golden hilt, encircled in its guard a blue gem. That was the second thing about this object. The gem —either because of the way it reflected shapes in dazzling but subtle ways, or maybe the way it seemed to stare back at Adora— seemed the more interesting aspect.

For some reason, a hum seemed to emanate from the gem. It was barely perceptible to the ear and most all in the room didn’t notice a thing. Adora did, however.

But she pushed whatever that was out of mind. The next thing she showed the court was a photograph of the crime scene —the victim’s body lay on the floor, which was relatively spotless but for a picture frame, fallen flat on its face by the back wall.

“The victim was a student at Ivy U. University,” Adora explained, “Her name was Sverdhild Studley.”

“My, what a bizarre name,” the Judge remarked.

“She was danish… or something.”

Adora was in the middle of a minor panic about whether she had gotten the country right, when thankfully her awkward moment was saved by Phoenix Wright causing an even bigger one.

“By the way, it’s Ivy University. The second U is redundant.”

“What?”

Phoenix rubbed the back of his neck while flashing a sheepish grin.

“Just… I was an alumnus there, gotta stick up for my old college. Didn’t want to let that slide.”

Adora just stared blankly, internally screaming.

“Ignore him,” Shadow Weaver soothed. “Pointing out errors and contradictions are all defence attorneys have.”

“How does the defendant fit into all of this?” asked the Judge.

“Right, yeah,” Adora set back her focus, “The defendant was known to the victim. They were lovers.”

The Judge’s eyes widened. “Lovers?”

“There’s more. The defendant visited the victim’s room between 1 and 4, which we can tell from the condo’s security footage. The prosecution would like to provide screens showing her entering and leaving the complex.”

“Very well, the court accepts this into evidence.”

“What about a motive?” Phoenix scratched his chin, “If they were together, surely there must be a reason why Glimmer would want to kill Studley? Otherwise, what’s so suspicious about her visiting her girlfriend?”

“Oh love is often a destabilising force” said Shadow Weaver. “The two knew each other, that’s what matters. That, and she had opportunity to kill.”

Phoenix shook his head.

“The Defence maintains that Glimmer’s intentions were pure. Her visit is not relevant to the murder of Studley.

“Then let’s ask her herself. The Prosecution calls the defendant Glimmer to the stand, to testify about her visit.”

A short plump woman, Glimmer was as young as Adora if not a little more. She had a skirt suit of pastel purple and short side-swept hair of pastel pink. Both her eyes and the underside of her hair had a sparkling sheen to them, yet as she took the stand her expression was one of pain masked with resolution.

“What is your name and occupation?” asked Adora.

“Glimmer. I’m training to be a paralegal.” She said. Her voice was calm and her tone left no open ends. Or at least that’s how it seemed, but as Adora went on to pose her first question, the defendant spoke again quickly in a much higher and varying shrill. “Uh, by the way. Hilda and I… we weren’t lovers per se, or rather… I don’t know what I thought of it at the time.” She suppressed a groan and said “ *Anyway,* that’s really personal to just put in front of a crowd like that!”

Adora blinked. Then, feeling suddenly hot, she muttered, “I, uh, just repeated what the detective found. Didn’t mean to make it personal….”

There was a slam. Shadow Weaver, her palm flat on the bench, leant forward and told Glimmer in a firm voice, “The light of this

court will excoriate any and all hidden details. Expect no lenience here."

Though Shadow Weaver's interjection caught Glimmer at a jump, she now stared back at the tall woman. No more sparkle but a fierce fire burned in her eyes.

"Prosecutor Shadow Weaver…. You know my mother."

"We've met. How is Angella doing these days?"

"I know you were involved in the SP-0 case."

Slowly, Shadow Weaver pulled her hand back until it slunk off the bench. She then stood fully straight so that she regarded Glimmer from her most downward glare.

"The witness will not speak unless to answer a question posed by counsel." She turned to her side. "Adora, you must be as ruthless as possible. The defendant's guilt is her nature. It is your job to bring that nature out for the court to see."

"Right." Adora looked to Glimmer. "Tell me about your movements on the day of the crime."

In her testimony, Glimmer gave restrained statements, and kept her unerring gaze straight ahead. She didn't reveal any more than the court already knew, so Adora went to prod for some more info:

"In your own deposition, you said you and Studley planned to go out later that evening. Why did you leave abruptly before 4?"

That made Glimmer break eye contact with the spot dead ahead of her. Although she quickly fixed it, her hand went to grip at her other arm as she answered, "well, uh, I was having a bad day already, so I was tetchy."

"Did you get 'tetchy' with the victim?"

"I— okay, look, I sometimes unload onto her and I probably shouldn't. She was usually so calm and sweet that just being around her was enough to destress. But that day was important for her. So yes, I got tetchy, and maybe because of that she snapped back, one thing leads to another… but it wasn't a big argument!"

"Could you give more detail?" Adora asked. "What was so important?"

Glimmer shot the prosecutor an irritated look, as if that would make her recant the question. When it didn't, she sighed.

"The Sword," she said. "Her research is into old technology. That's why I came so early, because she needed the sword."

"Wait, that sword is yours?" Phoenix said agape before slumping again. He was seriously regretting not getting a chance to review this case beforehand.

"Well, I was lent it for safekeeping, really. I was interested in it because of its legal connection. But I was convinced there was no significant properties and that all the stories were just myth. I said as much to Hilda and that's what set her off."

Glimmer's throat tightened, yet she grew louder and more frantic as she talked. She stared down at her fists, tightened into balls.

"But I just had to keep it going! I had to pull her down because I was having a bad day, and she just didn't need that and— Then she said… she said—"

Adora leaned forward. "Come on, what did she say?"

"She said we should 'take a break.' And that's when I left."

Adora looked to Shadow Weaver, who gave a nod.

With that, Adora grinned and said, "no more questions, your honour."

Phoenix was up now, taking on the defence's cross-examination. However Glimmer's testimony had ripped much the life out of her and not once did she look up from her hands. She answered his questions, yet there wasn't anything he could really use. Well, there was one thing:

"You said it wasn't a big argument, but that was before you told us what she said. Would you still say it wasn't a 'big argument.'"

"I guess… it was."

"Oh."

"Sorry?"

"Oh, nothing. Well, maybe it wasn't a *big* big argument?" Phoenix pulled a nervous smile as he stumbled on, "maybe it was a medium argument… one you wouldn't walk away from feeling particularly murderous?"

From his right, Maya gave Phoenix an exasperated side-eye, her head lowered as if feeling the weight of his nonsense.

"Is this seriously *your* big argument, Nick?"

"I haven't got much to work with here!" he protested. "I hate having to cross-examine my own clients."

"I remember now," said Glimmer. "I threw the sword at her."

"You whaaaat!" Maya was blown back a pace, although she leaned forward again with balled hands and said "Glimmer, you can't do things like that!"

The Judge regarded Glimmer with wide eyes. "So you admit to trying to harm the victim!"

"Wait, it wasn't like that," Glimmer stammered. "It wasn't like I threw it like a lance, I just lobbed it in her direction; more at the wall than anything. It slammed against it so hard the clock fell

down. The point is, though I didn't kill her, I wasn't happy that day."

"Wait a minute, a clock?" asked Phoenix, recalling a recent memory.

"Yeah."

His eyes lit up. Knowing his memory had not failed and that that piece of evidence was in the record, he was ready. This was his time. Energy soared through him, thrusting out from his core and into his finger, which he struck into the air.

"Then, objection! Look at the photograph of the crime scene. Something has fallen from the wall, but it isn't a clock. It's a picture frame."

Adora perked up, and she stared across the court with a furrowed brow.

"Shadow Weaver, that's…."

"Yes," Shadow Weaver said, serene as ever, "he's pointed out a contradiction. But I have a feeling this one will sort itself out."

"Actually," Glimmer ventured, "I think Hilda had been planning to change her interior design for a while. She didn't like that clock and did say something about putting a picture up. She probably just thought to do it after the clock was smashed to pieces…."

"Oh…," Phoenix stared in disbelief. His insides deflated, before he let out a woeful, "Nnaaargh!"

"I'm sorry, mr Wright." Glimmer sighed. "That was the last time I saw Hilda, and I threw a sword at her wall."

Shadow Weaver uttered a tiny laugh, and leaned to Adora to explain, "Defence attorneys have to look for pitiful contradictions, so by putting his client up against him, you've placed him into a corner."

“I just hope he stays there.” Adora peered over at the defence, where Phoenix and Maya was conferring over some of the photographs in the court record. “They’re planning a counterattack, I just know it.”

In actuality, Maya and Phoenix were having a small argument over the correct terminology for a step-ladder. There was one curiously in the background of the security footage, and as useless as the discussion was, it did at least mean Phoenix was looking at the two screens.

In one, Glimmer was exiting the foyer into the street. Nothing was in her hands. Nothing should have been in her hands so that was in order. In the first screen, however, she did have something, though on her forearm as opposed to her hand. It was hard to discern by the monochrome of the picture, but it was a metal vambrace of sorts.

Phoenix had found his next contradiction.

“Well,” the Judge was saying, “if no-one else has any object—”

“OBJECTION!”

“Mr Wright!” the Judge shouted back in a warbling voice, “Can I at least end my sentence before you burst in?”

“Sorry, your honour. But look at this” Phoenix pointed out the first security screen. “If the Sword belonged to Glimmer as everyone says, how did it get to the apartment in the first place? It’d be difficult to bring a huge weapon like that in without it being captured by the footage! If anything, Glimmer’s the one person who couldn’t have done it.”

The two at the prosecution bench shared glances with one another.

“Do you wanna tell him or should I?” Adora asked with a wry smile.

“But of course,” said Shadow Weaver, “the prosecutor on the case should have the joy of destroying every last hope of the opposition.”

Phoenix frowned. Though he didn’t catch their conversation, he watched their interaction with unease. It didn’t help when Adora shot her smug grin back his way.

“Mr, Wright. I thank you,” she said. “You’ve segued us to the next proof the prosecution has to show. Witness, please testify what you know about the nature of the weapon known as the ‘Sword of She-Ra.’”

Biting her lip, Glimmer looked from the prosecution to the defence. But knowing what she did about procedure, it was no use. There was no excuse for not answering on the witness stand.

“The Sword belonged to— *belongs* to the reincarnation of Themis,” she explained. “That’s why I was interested in it. Hilda wanted to know about its mechanics, although ironically she bought the mythology around it more earnestly than I…. Between her and the researcher I borrowed it from at the Dryl Institute, they figured out it was a powerful piece of old tech. Among its functions, I only really cracked one; transformation.”

“How does this work?”

“I speak the passcode, and the sword can transform into a number of items.”

“Did you use this on the day?” Adora enquired.

Pain flashed across Glimmer’s face, and though she’d like to resist the flow of the questioning, she answered, “Yes. The Sword form is unwieldy, so I transform it into a bracelet when I want to carry it around.”

“If the court looks at the photograph again, they should see the defendant wearing the bracelet on her forearm as she enters.”

Phoenix's shoulders were slack and he stared agape. He leant over and asked, "is this all true, Maya?"

"I dunno," she said, scratching her temple,"but if I can transform into my sister when you get stuck, then I don't see why it should be harder for an object."

"Hell, I could use Mia right about now." Phoenix let out a groan. "Argh, come back, my sweet contradiction."

Shadow Weaver slammed the desk, speaking, "enough. Adora, it's time to put the end to the defence's misery. Direct evidence, now."

"Of course, Shadow Weaver," said Adora. "The prosecution would like to call an eyewitness, your honour, someone who saw the exact moment when the defendant killed the victim."

The Judge gave a nod. "I see. Well, call this witness."

"The prosecution calls Light Hope to the stand."

Glimmer, with a look of defeat, descended the stand and returned to her seat at the dock. She would remain there the rest of the trial. Taking her place, then, was a far taller woman, with large draping robes and dress, and a general blue hue. She had a fixed, entirely neutral expression, and made no motion, gesture or remark until Adora asked for her name and occupation.

"I am Light Hope," she said. "I am a facilitator for Prime Holdings."

"And what were you doing in the apartment block?"

"I was surveying the property, assessing it's value as a purchase for my employers."

"You're a businesswoman who deals in real estate?" Phoenix clarified.

There was a trace of a slight, almost managed smirk on the witness's face.

“The group I work for is a conglomerate with many investments in multiple industries. Prime Holdings has an interest and ultimately seeks a stake in every part of life. Residential housing is one aspect of that.”

Averting his gaze, Phoenix muttered, “sheesh, was only asking.”

“The point is,” Adora stressed, “while this witness would not have usually been in the area, it’s our luck that she was. Unfortunate for the defendant, to say the least.”

Light Hope recalled for the court how she was in the middle of her survey when she heard a commotion from the room belonging to Studley. She attempted to enter but it was locked. That was when she bent down to see through the keyhole. She saw the crime as it happened: Glimmer stabbed Studley with the sword, before rushing out the door, barely noticing the witness as she fled past her.

“So you saw the murder happen through a keyhole?” The Judge then mused, “Just a small crack, and otherwise no-one would have seen what happened.”

“Do we know for certain that she could see any of that, though?” asked Phoenix. “My apartment has a small corridor before you get to any of the rooms.”

“The prosecution obviously has a plan of the apartment it can supply” Shadow Weaver spoke in a dry tone. “We didn’t expect the defence to suppose such weak questioning.”

“Gotta admit Nick,” Maya concurred, “ ‘my apartment is like that’ is not much of a defence.”

“Hey! There’s nothing wrong with covering all bases,” he said. “And maybe that plan will come in useful.”

“Well you better find something soon. If you don’t knock that testimony down, Glimmer will be pronounced guilty in a snap.”

There was nothing off about her testimony, however. Phoenix knew that he'd need to get some more details, so he asked some questions. The first few were dead ends. The third, however, was all but.

"Can you tell me more about the moment Glimmer supposedly stabbed ms. Studley?"

"What is your query?" asked Light Hope.

"Uh… hm, can you tell me which hand she used?"

"HOLD IT!"

Adora slammed the table. It stung her palm.

"Ow. I'll get better at that," she said to herself. "Right, anyway. It's a pretty big weapon, mr. Wright. She'd have to use both hands, I'd say."

"Well… you don't know that until the witness says it, right?"

Adora cocked her head to the side. Even Maya was giving Phoenix an exasperated look. Light Hope, however, merely answered the question:

"I believe the killer held up the sword with one hand and then thrust it with the other on the end of the pommel. I cannot remember which hand was which. The hand on the hilt must have been the one which had the bracelet, if that's any help to you."

"You can find the arm the bracelet's on in that security photo, right?" said Maya. "But do you really think it matters?"

"I dunno," Phoenix said, "but I've got nothing else to work with so we might as well go for it." He looked up and pointed to the high bench. "Your honour, I'd like to have the witness append that statement to their testimony."

The Judge's heavy white brow deepened.

“Mr Wright, I don’t see how which hand she was using could be relevant. It doesn’t change the fact that this witness saw your client stab the victim!”

“Please, your Honour,” Phoenix slammed the desk with both hands flat, “this statement is the key to turning this whole case on its head.”

The Judged sighed, “very well. Ms. Hope, if you will?”

Adora watched the opposing counsel with a fixed and hard expression.

“He must be up to something now,” she said in an undertone. “He wouldn’t be so sure otherwise.”

“Not at all,” Shadow Weaver crooned. “The defence is just desperate and resorting to bluffs.”

“Urgh, I dunno, Shadow Weaver. I think we need to prepare for his counterattack.”

“There is no need —you’ve proven the case, as I see it. All that’s left is for him to fail this cross-examination and the Judge will give us the guilty verdict.”

Light Hope repeated her statement, almost word for word — one hand on hilt, other on pommel, the former being the one which had the bracelet. As she did so, Phoenix compared the two security screens. Glimmer exiting, empty handed, and before then her entering, with nothing but the bracelet.

Phoenix tried to think. All he need do is go back over what Glimmer herself said. Assuming she was telling the truth —she was his client, he had to believe her!— then there must have been a reason she doesn’t have the sword with her when she left; a reason other than it being stuck in Studley’s abdomen.

Then it hit him. A beautiful thought, and it’s all he needed to have his arm back up in the air, pointing, and shouting with real

conviction:

"OBJECTION!" All eyes turned to him. "Please turn your attention back to what Glimmer said only a few minutes ago. She said she threw the sword and then left. In that case, there's no reason it should have turned back into a bracelet —and furthermore, no way this client could know that the bracelet *turns* into the sword!"

"Wh-what?" said the witness.

"HOLD IT!" Adora called back. "But she does know about the bracelet; she must have seen it. If anything, someone must have turned it back before it happened."

"Why's that?" Phoenix held his hands on his hips and smirked, "This witness says that Glimmer murdered Studley just after the argument. She brought that sword in for Studley's studies, so why would she change it half-way through their conversation, just to change it back again?"

"I… aagh!"Adora fell forward, holding her heads in her hands as she found herself stumped.

"The way I see it," Phoenix pushed on, "this witness knowing about the bracelet reveals she knows more than she should."

"That is–That is untrue," said Light Hope. "There is nothing more to my testimony."

"I'm sure… I, uh… this isn't a big problem," Adora said in a weak voice, "there's a simple reason for all of this! Maybe she guessed?"

"Guessed? I don't think so."

Phoenix stepped from behind the bench and made his way to the evidence table. The sword lay there and he took it up into his hands.

“As you said yourself, this is a big weapon. I’m not sure anyone could mistake it for a bracelet, let alone guess it could magically transform itself into one. Of course, Glimmer didn’t see what happened after she left the apartment. For all she knows, Studley changed it back herself.” Phoenix gave a nod of his head. “But then that would mean Glimmer has to be innocent.”

“I-innocent?” Adora stammered. “That can’t be true, can it Shadow Weaver.”

Yet Shadow Weaver didn’t get to answer. In the next split second, Adora —and only she— heard a familiar hum. The very next moment, the court filled with light.

There was a bang. An electrical beam struck out, and a man let out a yell.

“Oh god! Nick!” Maya yelled out.

Phoenix Wright lay limp on the floor.

Clamour rose from the gallery, and no amount of bashing from the Judge’s gavel would quell the noise. Yet in no time at all bailiffs came in to whisk him away. Only by the time when someone pronounced him unconscious did the Judge regain control of the courtroom.

“Is Mr. Wright going to be okay?” he asked.

“No major damage…,” Maya held her hand over her mouth. “But they’ve taken him to a hospital.”

Adora remained motionless throughout. Her gaze hovered around, from Maya, to Glimmer on the edge of her seat in the dock, to the witness still agitated on the stand, and down to the sword. It lay much the same place it had before, flat on the table. Still, there was that hum.

“Glimmer…,” Adora spoke in softest murmur, “innocent?”

“This might prove an opportunity,” Shadow Weaver hushed into Adora’s ear. Though she spoke quickly, she was no less calm than before. “You were on the verge of victory, if you push now the Judge may see fit to render the verdict.”

“But there’s no defence….”

“What does that matter?”

“He was onto something.”

“All the more reason to put the lid on this case. Remember, Adora, you must win by any means necessary.”

The Judge meanwhile was shaking his head:

“Well if Mr. Wright is unable to recover, then we’ll have to suspend these proceedings.”

Shadow Weaver whispered even faster now, “at the very least, this trial must continue today.”

“This trial must continue.” Adora said, still staring ahead.

Still looking at the sword.

“Remember. Any means, Adora. Any means.”

“We need to resume the trial today.” She then said it again, loud enough for the whole court to hear, “we need to continue the trial!”

“We can’t!” said Maya, “Nick is no good. And without him there’s no defence.”

“Then… then—”

What exactly it was that possessed Adora in that moment, she didn’t know. She would never quite be sure, in fact. All she did know, right then, was that she had to do something.

She lurched over the bench with a clean swing of her legs, then rushed to the evidence table. She took the sword into her hands.

“Then I’ll take up the defence!”

“What!” Shadow Weaver exclaimed.

“What?” Glimmer tilted her head.

The Judge’s eyes widened, astonished, “wha….”

But Maya drowned them all what with a wide gape and a long, “whaaaaaaat?”

If Adora had been another person and watched herself, she’d probably have the same reaction. She looked around, almost searching herself, wondering if what she’d just done was at all real. But she found herself in this situation. The only sensible thing, it seemed, was to keep going:

“That, uh, well you know,” she said, scratching her neck, “I’m a lawyer, and someone’s gotta take the defence for this trial to keep going.”

“But, this is unprecedented!” said the Judge.

“Indeed,” said Shadow Weaver.

She peered down at Adora from behind her mask. Her eyes narrowed.

“And totally ridiculous. I’m sorry, your honour. This is my student’s first trial and nerves must have gotten the better of her.”

Yet for all the heat in her cheeks and awkwardness in her words, Adora felt more at ease than she’d had in the whole trial. Nerves she did not have. And somehow the hum had been vanquished as sound, and now was a feeling of power rising up her arm, willing her to keep going.

“Look,” she said. “You said this trial was as good as over. Plus, the defendant has a right to a speedy trial. If the contradiction’s nothing, it’s nothing, but we have to look into it. I’ll do it.”

With the tip of the blade, she pointed it into the air like it were her own finger.

“I’ll take the defence!”

Chapter End Notes

> In my plan, this first case is wrapped up in a single chapter, but as I wrote out the dialogue things just sort of ballooned, so now it's two chapters. Thankfully the middle of the case has this natural high point so I think it works.

Adora the Attorney

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Shadow Weaver, with those narrowed eyes, stared Adora down.

“Perhaps…” she said, “you were not ready for this after all. Your honour, I ask that we suspend these proceedings. Al least until the defence attorney has recovered.”

The Judge in his high bench considered this well and true. Through small movements, his head leant to one side as he thought of the one consideration, and then the other as he did the second; from the line of view where Adora stood, his head just touched the tips of each scale in the great emblem that hung behind him.

Finally he said, “my opinion is this. While mr. Wright has an uncanny ability to turn around whole trial from small details, the case against Glimmer is almost certainly watertight. And yet, some small doubt remains.” He nodded, “If ms. Adora can fulfill the temporary role as a defence attorney, all she need do is explore this avenue until no doubt remains. And the spirit of the initial trial law is to keep the length of all proceedings to a minimum. Therefore, I will grant the prosecution its request, and give Adora leave to take the other side of the bench. Ms. Weaver” He looked to Shadow Weaver, “will you consent to take the lead on the prosecution?”

Shadow Weaver held silent for a second. Her mask never changed, hence always the calm passive air that hung around her. Even her eyes, which might otherwise have betrayed whole thoughts and affects, were merely blank and white.

They were narrowed of course, but they couldn’t exactly get any narrower.

Despite this, she made no further protest. She merely turned back to Adora, and said, "It looks like I'll have to teach my student a valuable lesson."

Adora breathed. She was still pumped from having leapt over the table and grabbing the sword, and her temples still pulsed. Yet as she made her way to the defence table, the reality of this situation fell on her like crashing waves. Then she turned, stood at the bench. She looked across the room, seeing the prosecutor staring back at her.

"Oh god, what am I doing,"an incessant Adora muttered, "what am I doing, what am I doing. Shadow Weaver's right, I don't have any business doing this."

"Are you… talking to yourself?" asked Maya

"Sorry," Adora half-smiled, "I kinda vocalise my thoughts a lot. Better to let out then build up, I say."

"Heh, opposite of Nick then," Maya said. "He'll just stare so intently at something that you can just hear his thoughts."

The Judge gave a bang of his gavel, signalling the resumption of the trial.

"Ms. Hope," he said, "would you please explain how you came to know of the bracelet and its connection to the Sword of She-Ra?"

Light Hope stated her second testimony. It was as crisp and monotone as before, although perhaps a little quicker. She hadn't expected to be here this long. Briefly, she explained that she had followed the research conducted on the Sword so of course knew about its transformational power. Asserting that her knowing had nothing to do with the case, she reiterated that which she'd said before: she looked through the keyhole and saw Glimmer stab the victim.

Adora rapped the bench with two fingers.

"Okay, okay, that's her testimony. Okay…." Then she seized up breaking out in a sweat all at once. "Ah, what do I do!?"

"Nick always presses until the witness slips up and gives him a contradiction," Maya explained. "Just… get some details."

"Right, press for details. Pfft, I can do that," Adora muttered. "Just gotta find a contradiction." She looked to the witness and began, "you say you follow the 'research' but what research would that be? Surely Studley and Glimmer weren't publishing?"

"Adora," Shadow Weaver spoke in a mocking tone, "surely you haven't forgotten your *own* investigation already?"

"Uh… actually I think I kinda did."

"The defendant obtained the Sword from the Dryl Institute, which does make public some of its findings."

"Indeed," Light Hope concurred, managing that trace of a smile again, "I am all about that sort of thing. "For the Honour of Grayskull" and other such."

"For the honour of… wait, what?" Adora said.

"An enchantment of sorts, utilised by the First worshippers of Themis —those who created the sword."

"I see…."

Then with the crushing weight of realisation, Adora began to slump over the bench. She clarified, though without a hope," so, wait, anyone could have known that the sword turns into a bracelet? So long as they read this journal?"

"As I predicted," Shadow Weaver said, "not a contradiction at all, but a minor misunderstanding. Had you merely kept your resolve, Adora, you would be on this side to deliver this final blow to the defence. It's not too late of course."

Adora straightened up again.

"It's far too early," she slammed the table. "Ow— I mean, there's still a few more statements I can question on!"

What had Phoenix done? He'd asked about something as minute as which hand held which end of the hilt. She could try doing the same, but if she wasted the court's time the Judge would hit her with a penalty. Although, if she was correct in thinking, that penalty would end up Phoenix's record not hers….

Okay, that was devious, but she needed to do something to help Glimmer; anything —surely? For now, she needed to become Phoenix Wright.

"Light Hope," she began slowly, quickly trying to come up with a good minute detail to ask about, "when you said you 'saw' Glimmer stab the victim, how did she… she, uh, how did she… fall…down?"

"Fall down?" her eyelids raised a midge, "Ah yes, I believe the blow from the hit was quite strong. She hit the back wall with such force, causing the portrait to fall down."

"Portrait? You mean the clock, don't you?" asked Adora.

"No, I mean the portrait. There was a photograph of the two lovers on the back wall, and the force caused it to fall down on its face." Then her eyes fully widened upon something, "ah, is this another one of these contradictions you seek to impose on me? Was it really a clock and not a portrait? Therefore I am a liar and everything I say is wrong?"

"Uh… maybe?" Adora rubbed the back of her neck and mumbled something about needing to see the evidence again.

"No need," declared Shadow Weaver. "The prosecution has the photograph in question, as you should remember, Adora. This is it."

The portrait was a fine thing, so it was a shame. The glass had shattered and the black frames were coming undone. In the photograph itself, Glimmer seemed a completely different person to this trials' defendant. She was filled with cheer and nothing else as she wrapped her arms around the blonde scandinavian girl, the two of them in front of some sort of rustic pier.

Adora forgot herself, watching this photograph. She didn't really think of anything, just let herself be washed by a fondness for it, and a pain. A nostalgia for a moment she never had. Maybe if she did think, she would have thoughts of how tragic a figure Studley was, so alive and brimming with joy in the photo, and out of it, just the opposite. Then there was Glimmer.

Glimmer couldn't have murdered her.

"This appears to be in order," said the Judge with a nod, "and that appears to wrap all the questions up, correct? The defendant stabbed the victim with the Sword of She-Ra, and the witness who saw her do it knew it could transform because she had read about it. I think I am ready to call my verdict."

Adora looked up at the Judge with a look of horror. "What?"

"Finally." Peering down at her from behind her mask, Shadow Weaver crooned, "you shouldn't feel too much shame, Adora. This victory is still yours in substance. I just hope your next trial won't end with such an embarrassing display." She added a tut. "You really must be better than this."

Adora seized up and cried out. "Oh no, that can't be it right? That can't be it!"

"Adora, calm down!" said Maya, also tense in the shoulders and standing on the balls of her feet. "Nick's been cornered all sorts of time, you know. You just have to look at the evidence again."

"The evidence?" said Adora. "Right."

She skimmed through the court record. Something had to be there, for each second felt like the hand of a clock booming on each tick towards its termination point.

"Actually," Maya said, absently wrapping a finger in her hair by her temple, "wasn't there something about the clock and picture earlier?"

Clock. The word reverberated in Adora's head, but not in her own voice, nor Maya's.

"Yeah, I remember," she said vaguely, still trying to recall where she heard the word. "Studley hanged the picture after the clock fell down. But I don't remember actually seeing what was in the picture today."

"They do kinda look sweet together." Maya gave out a sigh. "Poor Glimmer, to lose such a close friend twice in one day."

Something has fallen from the wall, he had said, *but it isn't a clock. It's a picture frame.*

Adora looked down. Their copy of the crime scene photograph lay there, bearing the image of the dead body, the ruffled apartment, the shattered glass on the floor. The picture, at the end of the room. Face down.

"Wait a minute—oh, OH!" Adora thrust out her pointer finger. "OBJECTION! Light Hope, you say you saw all of this through a keyhole in the door, and that you did not enter the apartment."

"Yes, that is how things went down," Light said.

"Well, I say that's impossible" she took up one of the documents and battered it with her hand, "First, look at this floorplan. At the angle you look into the apartment, maybe you could have seen Glimmer and Studley — but you couldn't have seen the wall and the picture!"

"OBJECTION!" Shadow Weaver enunciated with that dark voice of hers, "Perhaps she did lie about not entering. Surely she must have wanted to confirm the victim's death before she called the police. But otherwise nothing about her testimony changes."

"OBJECTION!" Adora pulled a fast grin. "Actually, we know when she was in the apartment because she just told us."

"Wh-what?"

"She identified the contents of the picture, when no-one else in the court had yet seen it. That's because she saw the portrait before it fell *face* down!"

"I— argh," Shadow Weaver gripped the sides of the bench and hung low, strands of hair falling down around her face, "this cannot be."

Light Hope gave more of a smile than she ever had, but it was a pained smile, and sweat trickled down her cheeks.

"Yes, this is… quite… ridiculous," she said. "Surely it was impossible for me to have been inside during the crime. I would have been noticed."

"Yes, you should have been" Adora nodded, "But that assumes that one person was there to notice you."

"Wh-what?"

"Studley died, so whether she saw you or not doesn't matter. But Glimmer only would have noticed your presence in the apartment if she had still been there, which of course the defence believes isn't true!"

"But that would mean—" the Judge paused to think, "uh, what would that mean?"

"If Glimmer wasn't in the room, but Light Hope was, then it can only mean one thing —Light Hope, you stabbed Sverdhild Studley,

didn't you?"

Gasps drew from the court. It was followed by murmurs, and the Judge banged to quell the noise.

"Order, order, I shall have order in this court!"

"No! I did not do that," spluttered a cringing witness, "You have no proof."

"If you didn't," Adora posed, "then why were you in the apartment?"

Light Hope's expression struggled for a second, but then she straightened up, forcing back that air of neutrality from before.

"Yes," she said. "I shall testify again. I will explain why I was in there and how I didn't kill Studley. We will put an end to this foolishness."

The Judge nodded, and allowed another testimony. Maya meanwhile bounded up grabbing at Adora's arm:

"We can't let up now, Adora. She's already admitting to being in the right place, so I bet her next testimony will be even more full of holes than the last."

Adora grinned. "Let's do this!"

Light Hope fixed her expression and began.

"I entered the apartment between 3 and 4 with the intention to steal the Sword of She-Ra."

"Really?" the Judge's eyes widened. "You confess to larceny?"

"It was the only crime I committed that day," the witness insisted through grit teeth. She continued. "I did see the argument as it happened, but I was mistaken earlier when I said Glimmer stabbed the victim before she left. I believe she must have

returned shortly after I broke in. I assume the victim transformed the sword back into the bracelet herself, because I used it to knock her out."

"Then why didn't you take the sword with you?" asked Adora.

"I believe I panicked. I am not a thug, I have no experience in violence, but I needed to take that item."

"Why?"

Light Hope took a few moments peace, shutting her eyes and calculating the best way forward. Her decision was, "I will not say. It is not relevant to this trial, which concerns murder. I did not impale the victim, merely bludgeoned her, so it could not have been me."

"But then it couldn't have been Glimmer" Adora asserted. "Look at the photographs, she came and went once. And weren't you who called the police? Why would you come back to discover the dead body if you had panicked? This testimony is even more shoddy than the last!"

Shadow Weaver struck the table with a bang. 'This is all feeble nonsense. Perhaps this witness's mind is addled. Ultimately, only the defendant knew the code to transform the weapon. You don't have any proof to suggest otherwise." She looked to the Judge and implored, "Stand down the witness, and hand down the verdict."

"Well, defence? The prosecution raises a good point." Said the Judge with a tentative note, "As far as we know, only the defendant and the victim knew the passcode to transform the bracelet into a sword. If you want to suggest this witness was the true culprit, she must have had it too."

"Maybe she overheard Studley say the code," Adora said, now plagued with cold beads of sweat and grasping madly again, "Or maybe she was lying about it being a bracelet from the beginning!"

“Then where’s your proof for either of these statements?” said Shadow Weaver.

“My proof, where’s your proof!”

“Adora!” came a sudden loud voice from over at the dock.

It was Glimmer. She looked at Adora was a singular intent in her eye.

“You need to focus,” she said.

“I— what?”

“All these other questions are just a distraction.” Glimmer shook her head, explaining “You already know the answer, you’ve been feeling it this entire trial.”

“I’ve been…feeling it?”

For the first time since Adora had seen her, Glimmer smiled. It wasn’t the cheer that the Glimmer in the picture had had. It certainly couldn’t wipe away the anguish and anger this trial had wrought from her. But there was a light in Glimmer’s eyes that matched the feeling of lightness in her chest.

The defendant had been more surprised than anyone during this trial. Even as the Judge and Shadow Weaver had accepted the turn in events, Glimmer had silently resisted. How could Adora, a prosecutor, ever want to actually help her? Perhaps it was some ploy. At least, that’s what Glimmer thought at first. Now she knew better.

“Look at your wrist,” she said.

“My what?” Adora wrinkled her cheek. “Defendant, there’s nothing on my—”

There was something on her wrist. Glistening gold, formed all the way down her forearm over her white sleeve, it was a bracelet. In

its centre, the gemstone sparkled, staring back at Adora. And of course, there was that hum. Except now, the hum was inside her.

“Okay” Adora blinked. “Okay, this is a thing now.” She took in a calm breath. “Just gotta get this… to this”

She thrust her hand out, the light but definite weight of the bracelet resisting but succumbing to her motion, and whatever power it held joining the sudden feeling of confidence emanating from her body, and the hum that only Adora heard was overcome by her shout:

“OBJECTION! Shadow Weaver, you want proof, right? Proof that the witness knew how to turn the bracelet into the sword?”

“I don’t want something that doesn’t exist,” Shadow Weaver chided. “Look through the court record. Nothing points to her guilt.”

“I don’t need the record, I have the witness’s testimony,” Adora declared. “Earlier she told us something. A phrase she thought was interesting. Do you want me to tell you what it is?”

“What are you babbling on about, child?” narrowing her eyes, Shadow Weaver even tilted her head as she said, “Have you not embarrassed yourself enough? Embarrassed me? To see my student turn into a… mere defence attorney.”

Before Adora could think of a retort, Glimmer shot up again to say, “She’s not just a mere defence attorney. She’s the defence attorney.”

Many in the court were confused. Murmur from the gallery fled about, as well as some laughs. But despite a small twitch in her face, Glimmer held her gaze resolutely on the prosecutor.

“Order, Order,” said the Judge. “Defendant, we do not need any comments from you. Defence, tell us the phrase that you think is so important.”

Adora steadied herself, slightly widening her stance. Her foot touched the edge of Maya. The other girl barely noticed, gripping her fingers tightly in her palm. She watched the impromptu-defence attorney prepare. The reason Adora did this of course was because of the weight. She knew it would be quite something to bear. But it was a burden she was willing to take.

And because it would look very cool.

She held her arm out again. Not to point, not to call an objection. Instead she twirled her hand into a grip, feeling the air, but not quite closing her fist. She took a light breath. There was a flash of a smirk. And then, she spoke:

"For the Honour of Grayskull!"

A kaleidoscopic gleam burst through the courtroom, dazzling most eyes before anyone could tell what had happened. But soon the initial shock was replaced by the gasping of the crowd upon seeing the sharp shine of a heavy sword's blade.

The Sword of She-Ra, once again, in the hand of one who wielded it like it was always meant to be hers.

Horror broke across the witness's face, and she stammered, "wait, you… no, I—"

"How about it, Light Hope?"Adora brought the sword back behind her head, letting it laze across her shoulders, "Don't you remember telling us this exact same phrase earlier today? You've had an interest in attaining this weapon for a while, haven't you?"

"No— I mean, that is, yes, but—"

Adora slammed the table. "When Glimmer left, you saw an opportunity! An opportunity to take the weapon and pin the blame on someone else!"

"I didn't even take the weapon, it wasn't me who was going to—"

Shadow Weaver gripped her bench, suddenly leaning forward. She was on the cusp of uttering a remark like 'fool' or 'silence fool' but the chance was stolen by the witness yelling:

"Ah, aaah!"

Light Hope clasped the sides of her face. Her eyes darted about, and she could not perish the guilty looks twisted across her expression. Adora made a decision.

It was time to end this.

"See this sword? Remember what I just said?" she said, "You said you were all about this sort of thing. But it likes the only thing you're about to be… is finished!"

A moment of silence carried in the courtroom, even though Light Hope continued to throw guilty looked from behind her hands. Then she regained a sudden composure, stance straight and face neutral.

Then she screamed:

"NOOOOoooo!"

The best word for it was 'glitching'. The woman made a number of sudden janky movements. She twisted a number of ways, and as some concerned bailiffs came to restrain her she backed away, avoiding their approach —even edging towards the one escape from the room, the door. But then, she fell down. A thud, and she was out.

The following minutes slipped by. The breaths Adora took were hard and heavy, but slowly calming as the beating of her temple pulse began to recede. And she could no sooner blink when the Judge talking again, asking the whereabouts of the witness:

"She is being processed as we speak," Shadow Weaver stated, calm but a little quieter than usual. "Though I fear in her current

state of mind, the truth of her motivations may be hard to extract."

The Judge nodded then turned his attention to the defence.

"I must say, I have never seen a trial proceed like this one has today. Ms. Adora"

"Yes, your honour?" said Adora.

"You have shown remarkable nerve and talent today. I think we can expect great things from you in your career as a prosecutor… or a defence attorney, if you so wish."

Adora looked down and clutched at her own wrist, which by now had become quite sore. Finally she just managed to say:

"Uh, thank you…."

"But for now," the Judge said with a new briskness in his voice, "I can hand down my verdict."

NOT GUILTY

Shadow Weaver did not break her gaze from Adora for quite some time. Now out of the heat of the moment, Adora had less of a barrier to the ability that Shadow Weaver's stares to unnerve her. Adora tightened the grip she had on her wrist, although she made sure to return the look eye for eye —no matter how much it made her squirm inside.

"Adora," Shadow Weaver said, "you have made a terrible mistake in what you've done today, and I fear it may undo you. Remember, you were nothing before me, you will be nothing without me. When we next meet, you'll have realised that."

Shadow Weaver swept out of the courtroom, and finally Adora could loosen.

But not a moment later she was rushing out herself, following Maya through the lobby and out of the courthouse itself. They headed over to the hospital and got a speedy admittance to one of the room. Inside, Phoenix Wright lay, bedridden, but alive.

“Oh god, Nick, are you alright?” asked Maya

“Oh, I’m fine,” he said. “I’ve suffered worse.”

“That’s the problem,” Maya said, folding her arms. “You’re gonna wear out your body by your thirties.”

Phoenix laughed, and although it gave him a sharp pain in the ribs, he welcomed the hug Maya suddenly thrust upon him. Adora meanwhile made a cautious step into the room.

“Uh, hey, Mr. Wright. I’m sorry about what happened.” She gave a half-smile, “I guess we really should have checked if that Sword was safe to handle.”

“Do you know what happened?” asked Phoenix.

“Not really, but I guess that Sword has a lot of powers we don’t really understand.” She grinned and added, “Thankfully your client will be free to continue her research and find out.”

Phoenix quickly sat himself up in his bed. “Wait, what happened?”

“Adora took your place at the defence’s bench” Maya explained. “She took your contradiction and ran with it.

Placing a hand on her hip and tilting her head to the side, Adora commented, “Well, heh, I think I found a few contradictions of my own.”

“Contradictions in your own case, remember,” Maya noted.

“Yeah, that’s true. “

She let out a sigh, and took a seat on the end of the bed.

“How do you do it, mr. Wright?” she asked. “I never realised being a defence attorney would feel like that. So hopeless and on the edge all the time.”

“Did you believe Glimmer to be innocent?” Phoenix asked.

“Well, not really, not at first. Obviously I thought she was guilty. But then you pointed out some of the problems and, I dunno. Then when I was on your side of the court fighting her corner I just started to think, yeah, she couldn’t have done it.”

“Well, for me that’s enough,” Phoenix said, smiling. “I have faith in my clients, and I always want to help them.”

“Help….”

Adora looked down, her line of sight falling upon a dusty cream floor with chipped tiles. Her brows drew together. She found herself swallowing empty air and once against clutched at her still sore wrist. Maya observed this in the corner of her vision and decided to come sit by her side.

“What’s on your mind?” she asked.

“There’s someone out there I’d like to help,” Adora said in a vague voice. “I don’t know where, and I really don’t know how.” She took in a heavy breath, and after holding for a few seconds, let out. “But I always kinda thought just getting to the top as a prosecutor would do it. Now… I’m not so sure.”

Now Phoenix was watching her too.

“There’s a lot of good you can do as a prosecutor,” he said. “I’ve come to blows with quite a few now, and while they can be a little… abusive, I think they’re good people.”

“But I didn’t even consider that Glimmer could be innocent. If I had succeeded… she would gone to prison because of me.”

“But you did succeed” came a new voice. Everyone turned to look at the doorway, where Glimmer now stood, adding, “And I am still here.”

“Glimmer!” Phoenix beamed. “Glad to see you out of your cell.”

“Mr. Wright, are you alright?” she walked up to Phoenix with a concerned look.

“I’ll be fine,” he assured with a grin.

“Worn out by thirty!” Maya reminded him.

Adora stood up, and awkwardly hovered as Glimmer passed her by. She felt conscious of the fact she stood a good foot over the other girl.

“Glimmer I’m sorry…,” she said. “Hilda was very important to you. I could have been less mean about it.”

“It’s…,” Glimmer gripped her hand into a fist by her heart, so tight that her nails dug into the fabric of her fingerless gloves. “It’s fine. I made my mistake with her, and she didn’t want to see me again.” She looked to Adora with a forced smile, explaining, “but I think this was how things were meant to go. The Sword of She-Ra reacted to you, Adora, which means… well, I’m not sure what exactly. But I think you’re meant to be a defence attorney.”

“What, me?” Adora waved it away. “Pfft, I couldn’t be a defence attorney. Today was totally just a fluke. You saw how I flailed around in there”

“I saw how you turned the case on its head and proved me innocent.”

“But it’s a whole different set of skills,” Adora argued. “Pressing statements, finding contradictions, I don’t know about any of that really.”

“I think you do — or at least, who you really are does. That Sword wouldn’t have reacted to just anyone. She-Ra is a reincarnation of the Goddess of Law.” She chuckled, saying ‘’I guess I’ll have to explain the full story to you one day. But the way I see it, you just need a little training from a professional, and then you’ll be a real ace attorney.”

“Hey I’d give you some tips,” Phoenix offered, “but I still feel like a rookie half the time.”

Maya suggested, “maybe someone can take her as an apprentice. Mr. Grossberg or Mr. Shields perhaps?”

Glimmer shook her head.

“I know someone who was once one of the best defence attorneys around,” she explained. “If you come with me to Brightmoon manor, I can introduce her.”

“Woah, woah.”Adora pressed her hands out in a backing up motion. “This is still… a lot. I can’t just up and leave everything I know. I really should go back and apologise to Shadow Weaver or I may not have a place to sleep tonight.”

“Shadow Weaver?” Glimmer’s expression darkened. “That prosecutor. Adora, prosecutors are dangerous. You already said you almost put an innocent in jail, well that’s what they all do. They arrange witnesses, hide and forge evidence, make threats and backroom deals.”

“They’re not all so bad,” Phoenix muttered.

“Well, sure,” Glimmer granted with a huff, “some are better than others. But it’s not about the people, it’s the whole system. The prosecutor’s office itself breeds contempt and suspicion. If you really want to help people, the last thing you want to is go back there.”

“Wait, now come on that’s not fair. I mean… ugh” Adora let out a breathy groan, “Look, this is all so confusing and this has been a

weird day. I need some time to think."

"At least come to Brightmoon manor, you can stay there for the night" Glimmer took Adora's hand, "You won't regret it"

Adora pulled a pained expression. She looked to Maya, who merely shrugged, and then over to Phoenix. He looked over at the window, a wistful air about him, though he did speak:

"It's not an easy life, but we get by. My mentor would say what really matters is the evidence. If you look at everything from a different angle and look at the facts clearly, maybe the choice will be more obvious to you." Then he turned his head back, but his eyes passed over Adora, instead turning to the girl next to her. "You know, Glimmer, that's how I know people are never really gone. I think Adora has some evidence left that you ought to see."

"Evidence?" Glimmer turned back to Adora with an insistent look. "What's he talking about?"

Raising an eyebrow, Adora stared with a vacant eye. Then a neurone fired. A memory suddenly returned and Adora faced Glimmer and urgently bounced on the balls of her feet.

"You said that Hilda didn't want to see you again," Adora said, "but I don't think that fits with a certain piece of evidence. Remember the picture?"

"The one that fell down on its face? Yeah, we took that some time ago. It was a really precious memory…"

"Except it wouldn't have been relevant at all if Hilda hadn't hung it up, and she could only do that after you had left."

"… Oh," said Glimmer, in a very small voice. "To replace the clock."

"You said it yourself, Glimmer," Adora continued. "She was usually the calm one. Maybe you still felt angry but she let it go."

"I…" Glimmer looked down, better to hide the quivering in her eyes, though the same in her voice gave the game away. "Sorry, I really need to be alone now."

With that she ran off. Rushing through the open door, she left the other three behind, all in silence. Adora in particular recalled the picture —Glimmer and her friend together— and the power that object had to speak the truth, even when there were no words left to say.

"I helped her… with the evidence," Adora told herself. "Maybe I can do the same for her."

Adora was not the only one who would ruminate on that trial deep into the night. Glimmer was another, of course, but there was also Shadow Weaver. She returned from the courthouse with feelings so dark that they were indescribable. But her mind was clear. She only thought of what she'd say when she'd get back to the office.

Not far the courthouse, it was a tall building that imposed even upon the surrounding sky-rises. The office at the top of the room was darkly lit, every light was glaring and the shadows sharp. A large man with ashen skin and a grim face poured over the documents on his desk. Behind him, Shadow Weaver arrived. Tentative, but with intent.

Chief Prosecutor Hordak did not turn to face her as he spoke:

"The facilitator won't cause us any problems, will it?"

"I assure you," said Shadow Weaver, "She will be swiftly dealt with, and there will be no more questions. Certain affects of hers have already been placed in the vault. There will be no further problems."

"Yes there will," Hordak said. "The Sword was supposed to join us in evidence."

"That… was an unfortunate turn in circumstances. But as I recall it was only going to join the collection. Unless… you had a more

personal use for it in mind.”

Almost immediately after she said that, Shadow Weaver cursed her tongue. The air turned cold, as Hordak’s broad shoulders tensed in fury. He slammed the table with a fist.

“Watch yourself, prosecutor,” he growled. “I can easily dispose of you if you further displease me. I wanted that defence attorney’s reputation in tatters, not this.”

“M-my student proved herself even in—”

“I don’t care what she proved,” he snapped. “The fact is that this is another failure on record.” He turned to face her with glowing red eyes. “Where is the girl now? Has she turned for good?”

“Sometimes children resist their path,” she crooned, “only to mature later on. Time is our best bet. Reality will beat Adora back until she returns to us. She won’t be gone too long.”

“I do not have time. I had a role in mind for Adora, one that is now vacant.”

“She will come back—”

“You have another student, prosecutor,” Hordak stated. “I shall appoint her instead.”

Shadow Weaver paused. A pithy retort came to mind first but she shelved it.

“I have no other students worth mentioning,” she said.

She spoke in a low flat monotone. Placing careful emphasis on each syllable, she made herself clear.

“I disagree,” said Hordak, equally emphatic.

Shadow Weaver grimaced from behind her mask. And, perhaps wanting to express her annoyance, she brought up her arms in a

motion to cross them.

“Chief Prosecutor, I—”

There was a loud crack. Something caught one of Shadow Weaver’s arms before it could fold into the other. She looked to it. Restraining her by the wrist was the end of a whip. Suddenly it pulled her, twisting her around to face it’s wielder.

Shadow Weaver’s eyes narrowed.

“You,” she said, injecting the word with as much acid as she could.

Small, lithe, the silhouetted figure skulked just in the entrance way. But it was clear by the shape of her mane and pointed ears who it was. She grinned. A demonic sort of grin, illuminated just so the whites of her sharp teeth hovered in the shadows.

“Hey, Shadow Weaver,” said Catra.

Chapter End Notes

For some reason, getting through this chapter was a slog, and I had low confidence and motivation throughout. Yet looking back and reading through the finished chapter everything seems fine, so it's weird. But I guess I won't be able to guarantee a consistent output for this and it may take until the end of the year to complete.

Anyway, the next chapter should have a more chill pace and tone, but it will bring in some important characters so it should be worth any potential wait!

Investigation

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Buried under a cityscape awash in concrete, the Brightmoon estate was a world apart, a viridian realm onto itself. Entering it was to pass from tarmac to pale cobblestones, from busy streets to calming trails. The cacophony of cars and crowds thawed into a soft bird's song. Chirping insects joined. That and the trickle of a stream, which itself ran parallel to the path, where orderly vines wrapped around the surrounding trees the same as roses did to every passing archway. All leading up, and giving way, to the open terrace.

The broad Brightmoon Manor stood, magnificent in view.

Adora, having come through the trail, was stopped by the sight. Her eyes wandered down to the doorway where she anticipated a crescent moon engraved on the lintel — and there it was, suspended above the sleek mahogany and arched door. When Glimmer had mentioned a manor, Adora had envisioned something fanciful: columns and golden plinths and other features she must have picked up from fairy tales or movies deep in her memory. Her second guess was that it would be a simple but stately complex slotted into the affluent side of city.

Brightmoon Manor looked just like she had first imagined it, not what she had expected.

But for Glimmer —who was inside the building—, it was just home. It was also the last place she wanted to be right now. She had just woken up in her plush third-story room, spying immediately the window, still ajar from the night before. Although the makeshift rope ladder she had used was tucked underneath the inside windowsill, the window still posed a problem.

She got up and stumbled towards it. But then, just as she was pushing the window panes shut, a warm and cheery voice called from outside:

“Glimmer! Hey, down here!”

She looked down, upon a garden covered in shade. Since the morning sun was rising low on the manor’s opposite face, the figure down in this back area was but a silhouette. But it obvious who it was.

“Bow, shh,” Glimmer said in an urgent hush, “come up, quickly!”

Taking the ropes with the woodblock steps from under the windowsill, she threw it down for Bow to climb. He promptly came up, landing into her bedroom with a jump, and coming into the full light. He was a tall man with a high cropped haircut —dark brown with an purple sheen as the top reflected light. Dressed in a blue uniform with high polished boots and white gloves, he would have had an authoritarian aura had he not folded the hem of his jacket up to bare his lower midriff. And of course he wore a smile —wide and matched with a twinkling eye— that struck Glimmer with a feeling of sudden calm. Although she quickly began to fritter again.

“Bow! You weren’t seen were you?”

“It’s fine, no-one saw me come in,” he said.

“It’s not you that’s the problem….”

She rushed over to the door, pushed it a slither ajar, and watched the dark corridor beyond. As it remained quiet and undisturbed, Glimmer sighed in relief. She turned back to Bow:

“Can you do something for me?”

“Hey, I only just got here,” Bow slanted his mouth, “is everything alright, Glimmer? I was really worried about yesterday, I should’ve come to court with you.”

"You…," she let out a brief huff, "you couldn't. You had the mid-term."

"Which I know I flunked," Bow confessed, his voice creaking, "How was I supposed to focus on chemical analysis and striation matching when my best friend was on trial for murder? I could barely write a sentence without thinking you were about to be sentenced!"

"Bow," she raised her hand to stay his panic, and found a strange smile on her lips. It wasn't often that it was her calming him down. "I'm alright. I was declared innocent."

"Mr Wright pulled through, right?" asked Bow. "Man, I knew it was right to turn to him. I need to thank Ema for the recommendation."

"It wasn't just him," said Glimmer. "Speaking of which… I need you to head to the front garden."

Just as Glimmer and Bow were conspiring inside, Adora had winded her way up to the manor's broad front door. The crescent symbol on the lintel glowered down at her from a height. She rustled her fingers against her palm as she looked from the sleek mahogany woodwork, to a silver handle and its anterior knocker. But as she finally plucked the nerve to go knock, her hand hesitated, hovering just over the silver.

Shouldn't it be higher?

Adora paused, and pulled her cheek.

"Why… did I think that?" she muttered.

She shook herself, and pulled the knocker. There was no response.

Undeterred, she knocked again, before finally pushing the door open and calling, "Glimmer, you home?"

Stepping forward onto oak panelled floors, she came into the foyer and marvelled. A wide staircase faced her, lacquered to the last step. Hallways going off both upstairs and on ground floor were laden with doors to everywhere. And the room itself was big. Spacious was the word. Lots of space.

Way too much space. Dead space eery along the walls. Furniture was missing, such as a mantle removed and its fireplace boarded up, just under a patch of misapplied paint where a mirror once hung.

"Glimmer?" Adora called again, and this time the sound seemed to bounce off the wall and echo down a corridor.

Starting to squirm at a jittering in her stomach, Adora turned to leave. Perhaps she could try tomorrow. Yet as she opened the door, a high voice —but not Glimmer's— responded.

"Yes?"

Adora turned around again. Out of nowhere, there she was. Slender, tall and dressed in a casual gown so pastel it was hard to see where it ended and the loose locks of her pink hair began. Her face was pale, long and thin and with a scrutinising glaze in her eye; one she bore down onto the girl.

"Oh… hi," said Adora, "are you Glimmer's mom?"

"I am," the woman said. "Angella. She's not here at the moment. She's… AWOL."

"Huh," Adora blinked. "Well, I saw her yesterday and she told me to come here—"

"Hey, Adora! There you are!"

Bow was now jumping in down the stairs, and quickly lodging himself between the other two. Despite the absolutely puzzled look Adora gave, he just smiled and continued.

“Glimmer tell you to come here? She must be having us, I can’t find her in her room.”

“Bow?” said Angella. “I didn’t know you were here.”

“Sorry, mrs. Angella. Just let myself in,” Bow laughed, rubbing the back of his neck. “Didn’t wanna bother you and all.”

“And you know this one?” she gestured to Adora.

“Oh yeah, Glimmer knows Adora from her paralegal classes,” Bow said steadily, keeping his voice as natural as he could manage, “but she, uh, lives out of town, y’know. So it’s no wonder she’s never had her over before.”

Bow threw Adora some pleading looks, and nudged his head the tiniest of millimetres to signal her without Angella noticing. Adora’s eyes lit up.

“Yeah, yeah,” she said, forcing a smile, “paralegal classes. Me and Glimmer go *way* back, mrs. A.”

Bow stifled a cringe. Yet he he turned with hope to watch Angella’s reaction.

The woman was wearing a strange smile.

“Paralegal, eh?” she said. “A strange class to take for someone admitted to the bar.”

“The…bar?” Bow’s shoulders slackened.

“You must be thinking of someone else!” Adora stammered. Her thoughts were slipping by, and she was speaking before she could handle them. “I’m—I’m not a prosecutor.”

“Interesting,” Angella smiled further, “I don’t remember saying you were.”

Adora’s heart fell with a thud.

“I just meant,” she choked, “uh, I know you and Glimmer don’t like prosecutors, right? Just assumed that’s why you were concerned that I’d passed the bar.”

“Well I’m more concerned that you’re lying,” said Angella. “It’s true that Glimmer having a prosecutor as a friend all this time is unlikely; so that’s why I know it’s not true. She keeps secrets, yes, but if she knew a student of Shadow Weaver all this time, she would have told me by now.”

“Wait, Shadow Weaver? I’m not—”

But before Adora could either talk her way out of or further into this mess, Angella let out a long groan.

“Glimmer’s here, isn’t she?” she looked to Bow.

Bow had barely broken into a pained half-smiled before Angella whisked around and went up the stairs. After sharing a look, the other two rushed after. The woman fled down the corridor, her gown fluttering in tow like a royal train. She came up to a door, and started banging.

“Glimmer! Did you think I wouldn’t see through this ruse? You have a lot of explaining to do!”

The door slithered open. Glimmer, still mostly obscured, looked past her mother to shoot a dead eye at Bow.

“Hey, I tried,” he protested.

Angella wrenched the door open, revealing Glimmer in full. The girl had a look half guilty and half defiant with perhaps a hint of fear. Adora looked to Angella with sudden wide eyes and felt a tremor herself.

But then Angella ducked down. Scooping Glimmer up, she brought her into the tightest of hugs.

“Where were you?” she said, “you’ve been gone for days. I was worried half to death.”

“Mom, I’m fine,” Glimmer insisted, although there was a certain softness to her protest; a weakness in the voice, and even as she tried to push Angella away, her arms were slack as she did so. “I was… I was in court.”

“In court!?” Angella exclaimed. “Why is this the first I’m hearing of it?”

“Mom, it’s alright,” Glimmer tried saying again, “it’s all sorted now.”

“I’m your mother, I should have been told about this earlier!” Angella was starting to simmer with balled up fists and even stamping her foot, but her expression was one of aching. “You’re still a child, you can’t be expected to handle these things on your own.”

“I did handle it on my own—”

“You should have come to me for help—”

“What help?” Glimmer shouted, “the help we gave mr. Treble or ms. Andrews? ‘Take a plea bargain or wait for an appeal, but just don’t ever fight back in the district court?’”

That sent a lopsided grimace across Angella’s face. But Glimmer kept on going:

“Are we suppose to run from the initial trial forever? No,” she suddenly stepped forward and grabbed Adora by the arm, “we took on the prosecutor and won!”

“And this…?” Angella spluttered, “what, why do you have Shadow’s Weaver’s apprentice with you?”

“Uh, it’s a bit of a long story,” Adora mumbled, “but I was Glimmer’s defence attorney by the end of the trial. But you were

right earlier, I am a prosecutor."

"I brought her here to meet you," Glimmer explained. "You could train her to be every bit as good as you were. A real defence attorney."

"I can't," Angella said, "Glimmer, you *know* why I can't."

"Uh, why can't you?" asked Adora.

"That's no concern of yours," she said in a terse voice. "Although I'm sure your tutor already told you everything."

"Um, no," Adora rubbed her arm, "I hadn't even heard of you."

"Mom, it's okay, she's genuine," Glimmer said. "She switched sides to defend my innocence… because she's She-Ra."

Bemusement and disbelief broke at once over Angella's face and she looked from Glimmer to Adora and back again. Finally, she slid her hand down her face and sighed.

"I need a glass of water," she said. "And you, young lady," she said her daughter in a soft but still authoritative tone, "need breakfast. We should discuss… things further."

Glimmer acquiesced, and the two left, leaving Adora along with Glimmer's friend Bow to wait in the room until their return. It was a nice room, round with a high-vaulted roof and serene walls of lilac and lavender. The bed was a golden polonaise suspended from the room with a series of steps leading up to it. Bow went to sit at the foot of the bottom step. Adora stood stiff in the room's centre. Neither spoke at first.

But when silence became too much to bare, Adora asked, "are they… gonna be alright?"

"I hope so," Bow said. "They've had worse. I think they can get through this one."

“I don’t understand why Glimmer brought me here to meet her mother, but she didn’t even want her to know she was here….?”

“I’m sure she hoped to create a game plan once we were all in here.” Bow smacked his fist into his other palm, “if only I was a little slicker back there.”

“I mean I was the one who fumbled,” Adora admitted, coming down to perch herself on Bow’s step, but angled facing away from him. “She really put me on the spot. Cross-examined me, I guess.”

“Angella was quite a lawyer back in her day, I hear,” Bow explained. “She went toe to toe with the likes of Debeste and Von Karma.”`

“If she was so good, why did she stop?”

“I don’t really know,” Bow said, rubbing his arm, “but things changed a few years ago. Angella’s career ended just about the same time Glimmer lost her dad.”

“Oh god.”

“Yeah. It’s just been the two of them here ever since.” He let out a long deep sigh. “I’ve been really worried about Glimmer. Losing Hilda and then going to trial. I just kept thinking ‘they’re gonna make her talk through every detail’ and it’d be like having her die all over again.”

Adora just tugged a single knee into her chest and fidgeted with her wrist around it.

“For the longest time it’s just been me and her,” Bow continued to explain, “we go to college and Glimmer meets someone she really hits it off with…. She’s never been particularly outgoing but’s fine, you know. She’s Glimmer, she’s happy with the people’s she got. But then to lose half of your friends in one fell swoop….”

“You really care about her huh?” asked Adora.

“Course I do!” Bow said, tensing up his balled hands, “I’m gonna have to really keep an eye on her for now.” He took on a resigned half-smile, full of knowing, “but then, well, she’s gonna start feeling guilty that I’m spending my time to make sure she’s okay. Story my life, I guess: convincing Glimmer that it’s not wrong to want support from her friends.”

“Wow, you seem to know her inside out.”

Bow shrugged, “when you know a person for that long, you start to know how they tick. Best thing is that you know all their buttons. Comes in handy when you want to mess with them,” he grinned, but the warmth far outweighed the malice. “But more importantly, you know when it’s right to step in and help, and what to do.”

A tingle, birthed in Adora’s chest, spread upwards until it sat in the back of her throat. She let her leg fall and sat a little more inward-facing to Bow.

“What did Glimmer mean with that stuff she was telling Angella? The thing about not running away from the court?”

“Oh that?” said Bow, “well sometimes people still approach Angella for help with legal trouble. But she almost always tries to turn them away. Thing is Glimmer keeps bringing them to her. The most Angella really says is that going through the initial trial is futile, since the system is so broken.”

“Glimmer said something like that as well,” Adora recalled. “So Angella wants Glimmer to be a paralegal to try and reform things on the inside?”

Bow gave out a chuckle, “Angella does not want Glimmer anywhere near it. She hoped Glimmer would take history classes.”

“History? Didn’t her friend do history?”

“Yeah, they met in lectures there, but Glimmer only had it as a minor in the end,” Bow elaborated. “Against all of Angella’s

warnings, Glimmer really wants to get into the legal profession. Heh, my dads wanted me to do history too but I only took it as a minor as well. But I always knew my true calling was Forensics."

Adora raised an eyebrow.

"Why did you want to go into that?" She gave wry smirk, "I mean it's just a little dusting here and there, most of the real work is done by us prosecutors."

Bow pouted.

"That is absolutely a myth," he said, "forensics is a fine science! You have to discern whole movements from the trace-iest of fibre samples. We eliminate whole possibilities and make the work for you lawyers possible!"

"Hey, hey, I was only teasing," Adora laughed. "I guess that's one of your buttons."

He smiled, "hey, I don't mind an opportunity to rep the gig. I tell you with today's technology there's no circumstance we can't predict or alibi we can't bust."

Pulling it out from his inside jacket pocket, Bow brandished an elongated digital pad with all sorts of glowing buttons.

"I'm proud to say I'll be a forensic investigator at the forefront of this technological revolution."

"Well I can't wait to see you out in the field." She looked back at her knees, her smile not quite fading, as she asked, "so, how did your dads feel about not taking history?"

"Oh they understood in the end," he said, "although I, uh, might have tried to hide it for a whole year."

"Shadow Weaver would have flipped if I didn't want to become a prosecutor," Adora said a little quieter.

“Why did you want to become a prosecutor?”

“Well I was always going to be one,” she stated, “Shadow Weaver trained me to be the very best there could ever be.”

“I dunno Adora,” Bow furrowed his brow, “I know we’ve just met but you don’t strike me as the person to, uh, ‘stick with the plan’ if you get me.”

“What’s that supposed to mean?” she shot him a scandalised look.

“What I mean is you’re now seriously considering switching teams this late in the game. If there was something else you wanted to be growing up I think you would have taken it.”

“I mean I *considered* other stuff, sure.”

“Becoming a prosecutor must have been really intense, right? You must have really wanted it yourself,” he shrugged. “At least, that’s what I think.”

“You weren’t lying, you really are forensic,” Adora remarked. She then sighed and said, “I don’t really know how to explain it. I’m sure there was a calling because I really did want to be a prosecutor… I kinda still do. But things really got turned upside down in that trial.”

She fell silent for a few seconds, staring into the back of her hands laid lazy by her knees. She screwed up her eyebrows. Shaking her head, she added:

“No, I’m not telling the truth. There was something else.”

“What?” asked Bow.

“A few years ago… ah, it’s too much to explain now. Point is I used to… know someone.”

“A friend?”

"Best friend," Adora smiled, "but this was way back when; not sure if I'd even recognise her now. But I always thought she was in trouble and that's why she disappeared."

"Do you know she's in trouble?

Adora shrugged. "She was always getting in trouble, frankly. I guess I just thought if I became a top prosecutor and I ever found her again, I'd be in a position to help. *Don't* ask how, by the way," she quickly preempted, "I know it's not logical. This wasn't even a conscious thought or plan, I just kinda felt it. And suddenly that feeling came back big during the trial." She let out a low half-laugh, half-sigh, "I guess that's what makes me tick, huh. Some weird feeling, chock-full of nostalgia."

"I think it's really sweet," Bow said, "I'm sure you'll find her again someday."

"Like that'll ever happen."

The door opened, and Glimmer slowly marched in, followed by Angella. The two came together but stood a good metres distance from one another once in. Bow and Adora stood up, the latter fixing as much firmness in her posture as she could manage. The tall woman approached and studied her. Perhaps for the first time she looked at Adora without reproach.

"You helped my daughter, and for that I'm grateful." She took in a deep breath, then let out in a long sigh. "But I can't give you what you seek. I never want to step inside another courtroom again. I can't think about anything to do with it without feeling faint, the world spinning around me. What you want… well I don't know what it is. I find it hard to believe a student of Shadow Weaver would sway so easily anyway. But I'm sure your reasons are your own, but they will just have to remain your own."

"I…," Adora rubbed the side of her arm, "very well. I can't really think of anything to say."

Glimmer's eyes fell, and even Angella wore a look of pain and guilt. The tall women just shuffled away. The other three were left to themselves.

"I guess that's that," said Adora.

"I'm sorry for dragging you here," Glimmer said, and added with a grumble, "all for this. Why does she have to be like this!"

"Hey, you heard her," said Bow, "it sounds like the whole situation would make her uncomfortable."

"It's not discomfort! It's cowardice, it's—" Glimmer suddenly held up her hands and shook her head, "nope, I'm not gonna get into it."

"Probably for the best," said Bow.

"What are you two going to do now?" asked Adora.

"I could do with a drink and maybe another bite to eat.

"You just had breakfast," Bow gave a teasing smirk.

"Didn't get much yesterday between almost getting convicted, Bow. Not that you'd remember."

Bow chuckled, "alright, to make up for not being there yesterday I'll buy. Sushi Salinity?"

Glimmer nodded.

Bow looked to Adora and asked, "you coming?"

Adora looked around, then back at Bow, asking, "what, me?"

"Yeah, might as well not have this day be a total waste."

"I should probably go," Adora mumbled, "I mean I don't even know what Sushi… Salty… whatever that place is."

Bow's eyes grew to disks: "You've never been to Sushi Salinity?!"

"…no?"

Adora didn't have a choice after that. Somehow within the next hour she was out in the thick of the city, crossing perilous junctions to get to peopled streets, hurriedly following Bow and Glimmer. They passed into the Tiny Tokyo district. Even under the morning sun they were barraged with dazzling neon light. It was a world almost as unfamiliar as the secluded spot of the manor. Innumerable people and unreadable signs. It overloaded Adora's senses, yet being close to the other two —although basically strangers to her— filled her with comfort enough to weather it.

Sushi Salinity itself was a cross between a modern bar and an olde tavern. It was a long joint with an equally long bar facing tightly packed alcove-booths. Low hanging lights and dark-palette interior design gave the place an enticing atmosphere, while rustic wood panelling and a fur carpet rounded off the vibe with warmth. The trio placed their order. They sat down and the blue-haired waitress brought the food. They dug in and were treated to delight.

"Wow this is," Adora managed to say between jostling nigiri into her mouth two at a time, "amazing!"

"Isn't it?" Bow enthused.

Glimmer however just poked at her box with her chopsticks.

"I just don't get what will get through to mom," she opined, "she'll even pass up the chance to train She-Ra of all people!"

"I mean," said Adora, "I'm still not sure what She-Ra is. I know I can use the sword. That's pretty cool, I guess. But who—what is *She* … Ra. She-Ra… that— her! Damnit," she slapped her forehead with her palm.

Glimmer raised an eyebrow, "how did you pass the bar exam again?"

“Hey!”

“Look, all you need to know is that She-Ra was a legendary lawgiver and defender of the wrongfully accused in ancient times. She is the embodiment of the goddess of law, and you are probably this generation’s incarnation.”

“Oh,” Adora furrowed her brow and trailed the floor with her gaze, “do I… have to do something in particular?”

Glimmer gave a wry smile, “only restore balance to the legal world and expunge it of all corruption.”

“Right… easy….”

“I was hoping you could start by taking on cases as a defence attorney.”

“I mean, I could *still* do that if I wanted to,” Adora suggested.

“You do want to, right?”

Adora fell silent.

She wasn’t trying to hide anything. If she had clear feelings on the matter she would have blurted it out by now.

She just didn’t have an answer yet.

“Hey, it’s not like a case is going to fall out of the sky,” Bow offered, “and we know Angella won’t budge. Maybe we should give the legal talk a rest and just relax.”

It was at that point that the waitress from before sauntered up to them. She wore a rather dull expression, and spoke in an even dryer tone.

“I’m obligated to make sure that you’re having a good time.”

“I thought you owned the place, Mermista?” said Bow. “Why so dour?”

"I *practically* own the place," she clarified. "As in I manage everything, do all the work around here and have to maintain the premises. In a sense of actually getting the right to do anything or being paid enough to care, not so much. And either way I still do customer service so what do you expect?."

Bow folded his legs and nonchalantly took a sip of his drink, before asking, "have you seen Sea Hawk recently?"

Glimmer let out a small groan although attempted to stifle it. Mermista, however, did not.

"Uggghh, why did you have to remind me of his general existence?"

"He's usually hanging around here," said Bow.

"Well he's… busy, and I don't think I'm actually allowed to say what's going on."

Adora leaned a little sideways to peak into the conversation:

"Uh, who are we talking about?"

"Oh, just Bow's local celebrity crush," Glimmer said with a pained grin.

Sensing the wind of the topic, the waitress wandered off, just sparing herself from Bow's gushing about the man whom Adora could guess was part folk-hero and part someone at least acquainted with him. This was a figure of much daring and do, getting into scraps with ruffians, charting the high seas (or charting as much as one could between commercial cross-pacific liners) and generally exuding a charming confidence.

"And wow, that guy can sing," Bow added, "I wish he was here. You *need* to hear his shanties."

"Oh goddess," Glimmer buried her head in her hands, drenched in second-hand embarrassment.

“Not your kind of guy?” asked Adora with a half-nervous laugh.

“I…,” Glimmer stole a glance at Bow, “prefer softer men. Manliness comes out of action, not words. And Bow’s friend certainly *talks* a big game.”

“He’s a man of action,” Bow insisted, “and adventure! Look:”

Bow went to one of the square wooden columns —chipped for the authentic tavern look— on which was pinned a poster. He tore it down and handed it to Adora.

“Surprised Mermista allowed it to stay up,” Glimmer remarked.

Adora looked at it. The man certainly had glamour. A light linen shirt with a red handkerchief about his neck, blue jacket, black buckle boots and rousers that perfectly slimmed his waist and puffed out his broad chest. His face bore a devilish smile, and a shiny moustache. Superimposed on his image was the caption. It promised a recital of his own daring adventures fighting pirates off the coast of Zheng Fa.

Adora gently placed the poster down and just remarked:

“Manliness… is not my thing. Girls are better anyway.”

“They’re less showy, that’s for sure,” Glimmer said, folding her arms.

“Ohoho, that’s definitely wrong,” Adora said. “I’ve known girls who could eat this Sea Hawk for lunch.”

And lunch, -–or the closest approximation one could get in the late-morning— they had just finished. Adora lingered at her seat as the other two slipped off. Her mind was digesting quite a lot as she realised quite a lot had happened in the last few hours. Then she also realised that she had been in the presence of either Bow, Glimmer or both for most of the time she’d been awake today.

No-one would judge her if she said she had to go home now. She hadn't seen Shadow Weaver since the trial and it's not like she had anywhere else to go. And Bow and Glimmer were enough for each other. Adora watched them from behind. She smiled.

Sliding off her seat as well, she came along with them, and they never noticed that she had lagged. It wasn't as if they said something about her joining them only for the Sushi. She might as well tag along until they told her to leave. If ever.

They left the building and were back into the Tiny Tokyo streets, yet as they turned the corner, however, they bumped into a man in blue uniform, just the same cut as Bow's own. He stared at them —at Bow in particular— and blinked. Finally, he took on an angry expression.

"Investigator! No slacking on the job! Report to Detective Scorpia right now!"

"Uh," Bow creaked. His entire body froze.

"We'll do that, sir!" Adora blurted out, and she pushed Bow past the man and down the way he had just pointed.

There was a buildup of police at the entrance to an alleyway barely a metre wide. Instinct turned to curiosity as the three went down it. Adora's especially mentally switched track from getting out of trouble –by way of avoiding a shouty man— to ignoring whatever trouble they'd get into by going deeper into the alley. There was just something about 'keep out' tape that made her want to get in.

At the end, they found a dingy square, occupying the dead space behind the surrounding buildings, including the Sushi Salinity.

"Hey," came a booming voice, "what are you all doing here?"

The voice had belonged to a tall woman. A very tall woman, and well-built, with cropped white hair under a red fedora; a shabby

suit loose in the tie and high in the pant's waist, and with an overbearing red trench coat. She also had pincers.

"This is a crime scene. This area's off for civilians," the tall woman explained by way of pointing the large sharp tips of her claws in their faces.

"We're lawyers," Glimmer suddenly said.

"Oh," the woman's face softened. Then she smiled, "okay, then!"

"Hey wait a minute," said Adora, "shouldn't you be keeping all but the prosecution out?"

"Oh huh," the woman tapped her chin, "that is true, actually."

"Why would you say that?" asked Glimmer in an agitated hush.

Adora gave a sheepish hug, "it's standard! At least that's what Shadow Weaver always said.."

"Hmm," the Detective —the one called Scorpia— continued to ponder, "the boss did warn not to leak any of the investigation. Ooh, she's a feisty one. She'd be mad if she learned of this. But if you are the defendant's lawyer… oh, I got it!" She looked at them, excitement breaking across her softly butch face, "I won't tell you squat, right? But if you want to do your *own* investigation of the scene, I won't stop you. Deal?"

"I dunno, guys," Bow whispered, "is this ethical? We don't even know who the defendant is. Let alone whether they'd ask us to help."

"Come on, Bow," Glimmer grinned, "do you want to pass up the opportunity to show off your kit?"

"Well," Bow's gaze wandered over to the crime scene behind him, "I guess it wouldn't hurt to look."

In the centre of the alley was a line of white tape, demarcating the silhouette of the victim's body as it was found dead. A patch of blood, only half a day fresh, spattered the surrounding tarmac. Trash and the cans that had borne them were strewn about. Some were beaten and bent out of shape with scuffs in the cheap metal, imprints of boots on others.

"Perhaps there was a fight?" said Adora.

"Almost definitely," said Glimmer, herself having gone to one of the back walls which seemed on the verge of falling down. She squatted down to look at a large brick that had fallen from it. "Quite a ferocious one."

"I'm not sure what we're going to find," said Adora, "the prosecution is usually very thorough."

"Oh this one is, sir!" Scorpia offered with enthusiasm. "She left no stone unturned."

"The problem isn't with individual prosecutors," Glimmer knitted her pink brow, "think about how their work is structured. They have a guilty party and look for all the evidence to build their case. When you get into that mindset, even the most logical of people are going to overlook something."

Adora shook her head, "that's ridiculous, how about when—"

"Adora," Glimmer said deadpan, "are you telling me you never overlooked something yourself?"

"I…," her gaze fell. She just remembered everything from the day before. "Oh, yeah. Okay, never mind."

"Found anything interesting, Bow?" asked Glimmer, turning around.

Bow was crouched down, just between the tight alley entrance and the white tape. He was running his finger along the ground.

“Well, there is one thing,” he said, “the floor is wet. Was it raining last night.”

“Nope,” said the detective, “I can say personally there wasn’t a drop all night.”

“Why were you out all night?” asked Adora.

The big woman shrugged, “I just like to go on long walks when the sun is down. It’s real quiet, soothing. Good for the soul you know.”

The three others blinked at her.

“Oh,” she blushed, and, as she rubbed her neck with her pincer, said, “not supposed to leak secrets, am I. Right! From now on, my lips are absolutely sealed. No more words from me. Starting now. Just don’t tell the prosecutor I said anything, okay?”

“Who is the prosecutor, by the way?” Bow asked.

But Detective Scorpia, eyes closed and arms folded, merely shook her head and didn’t say another word.

“It won’t matter, I can handle most anyone from the office,” said Adora. “Klav and Simon are basically rookies like me, and there isn’t exactly much talent among the old guard.”

“Still, if we knew for certain it could help us prepare a real plan,” Bow said.

“Let’s just start with the evidence and work from there,” Glimmer folded her arms, “now what’s the significance of the water?”

“Well let’s find out.”

Bow produced a slim bottle of a clear liquid. It had a spray cap, and Bow proceeded to bend down and spritz the entire stretch of tarmac up to the alley entrance.

Adora raised an eyebrow, "um, Bow, I think you just made it more wet…?"

Chuckling, Bow chucked over strange pairs of goggles to the girls and said, "wear these, it'll make sense."

Adora put them on. The world became a haze of pink. That is except for bright swathes of blue, luminous along the path that Bow had sprayed. Studying the glowing patches for more than a split second revealed a spread texture, somewhat like if the colour has brushed watercolour.

"What am I looking at?"

"Blood," said Bow," or rather the chemical reaction that happens when luminol testing fluid contacts with blood."

"But the ground is clear?" said Glimmer.

"No, the ground is clean," said Bow, "someone went and mopped away the blood."

"Why?"

Adora took off the goggles and stared at the slight glisten of the wet ground.

"I guess someone didn't want us to find the blood." She looked back at the crime scene proper, "which means that *this* is what they wanted us to see. There is something here we were meant to overlook…."

The three continued to comb through the scene, with Bow in particular taking photographs on his digital pad. But there was nothing else of note. They considered going to to the entrance to the alley to see if more could be found there, but the police who had cordoned the area gave them a much harder time than Scorpia did. Ultimately, they gave up, and at last they were about to go.

Then, whirring its way up to the curb, a sleek and hot pink car drove up and parked exactly parallel. The door sprung open. Out came a dapper tall man dressed in red.

Adora gasped. Across them now was he, his red coat on black waistcoat, with greying hair despite his thin youthful face. Sprouting from his neck, an iconic white jabot (yes that's what it's called.) This was Miles Edgeworth —the greatest prosecutor in the entire district.

"P-prosecutor Edgeworth?" Adora spluttered in a winded voice.

"You're… Adora, correct?" the man's tone was deep and his dictation delicately crisp. "It's been a while."

"You remembered?"

"I try to keep track on all the up and coming talent in the office," he had a small but restrained smile, "I heard about your run-in with Wright as well."

"You know mr. Wright?"

He looked off to the side, saying vaguely, "the two of us are… acquainted."

"Mr Edgeworth, sir!" Detective Scorpia came bounding in from the alley, holding onto her hat as she rushed past the layabout police.

"Wait," Adora's heart suddenly jumped like mad, "y-you're not the prosecutor on this case, are you, mr. Edgeworth?"

"No, nothing like that," he said, "rather, I was in the area and I wanted to check up on the investigation. The detective is rather wet-behind-the-ears, as is the prosecutor. And it appears the defence is as well. You are the defence correct?"

"… Yeah?"

Edgeworth peered down at her, and then asked, “do you have a letter of request?’

“…no?”

“Don’t tell them that,” Glimmer hushed.

“Wait, wait, wait,” said Scorpia, “are you saying you lied to me about being the defence attorney? I can’t you’d do that. That’s just not on. And I trusted you guys!”

The crestfallen look on Scorpia’s face stabbed all three of Adora, Bow and Glimmer with wretched guilt.

“I’m sure there’s no real foul,” Edgeworth suggested, “the suspect can’t get a willing lawyer. And there’s still time for you to get to the detention centre. Although for future reference, you should really know who you’re defending before you stick your noses in crime scenes.”

“I’ll remember that sir,” said Adora, making a salute. Then realising that Edgeworth wasn’t her boss let alone a captain, she quickly snapped her arm down.

Edgeworth had a quick examination of the scene himself, and, being satisfied, offered to drive the trio up the centre. Adora rode up with front, still reeling with a rapid heart rate being in the presence of he who had essentially been her idol for the past half-decade.

“So, Adora,” said Edgeworth, “why did you decide to defect?”

“I’m not sure I did,” Adora sighed, “I still… I dunno, I kinda think of myself as a prosecutor even now.”

“Understandable.”

“The trial, well that was a specific circumstance.”

“I heard,” Edgeworth let out a tut, “leave it to Wright to royally screw things up.”

“I mean it was the sword really,” Adora explained, “it was like it was talking to me and it suddenly just knocked Phoenix out. Maybe it was contrived by fate. Would lend credence to me being She-Ra.”

“She-Ra?”

Glimmer quickly explained what she had told Adora. To compound, Adora let out her arm, to which the golden bracelet still clung. She spoke ‘for the honour of Grayskull’ and with a flash of light the heavy sword lay across her arms.

“Ah… right,” Edgeworth’s brow furrowed to many lines as he tried to see the sword while maintaining his driving, “well I don’t go for all that mystical nonsense. I trust what I can see with my eyes.”

“Uh, you just saw that sword transform yourself,” Bow noted.

“Yes, well…,” the man flustered before shaking his head and saying definitively, “fate or no, it all comes down to one thing. What do you think you should do, Adora? Prosecutor, or defence attorney, the path is yours.”

“But if I really am She-Ra, doesn’t that mean I’m meant to only take one of those paths? She-Ra defends people. That’s what she does, so that’s what I should do.”

Edgeworth raised and eyebrow, briefly looking at her. But then returned his view forward. They had just arrived at the station and he quickly and cleanly parked them to the sidewalk.

“Thanks for the lift, prosecutor Edgeworth,” said Bow as he and Glimmer exited the vehicle.

Adora also opened her door and got out. Edgeworth however leaned over to give a parting word:

“Maybe you are She-Ra, and maybe defending the weak is what she does. But when people start watching, it’ll be rather less who you are and more what *you* do what counts. But I’m sure you’ll come to the right decision when you go in there.”

He sat back up and started to reverse.

“How do you know I’ll make the right call?” Adora called after him.

Edgeworth let out a wayward smile.

“Because it’ll be the one you choose,” he responded.

“Come on, Adora,” Glimmer said, “we should meet the client.”

Inside the detention centre and they came upon the visitor’s room, divided in two by a separating acrylic window. The client was already there, laying his head back on his hands, and his boots kicked up to the windowsill.

Bow was already stunned, and Glimmer quickly recognised him as well. Adora however took a few seconds, blinking at the man. Her eyebrows alternated raised positions. Then she pulled out the poster she still had on her and unfolded it. Raising it to her face, then dropping it again, the image did not change. It was Sea Hawk.

“Well,” he said in a voice like velvet, “I hope this isn’t a social call.”

“You’re the suspect?” said Bow.

“Honestly, I have no idea what’s going on. I just woke up.” He pulled a fast grin, “but don’t worry, my lovelies. I have a plan.”

“What is it?” Bow leaned in, a sparkle in his eye.

“Well, Bow, my fellow, you help provide a distraction. I have a little experience sawing through bars and can fight myself the rest the way out!”

“You can do that?” Bow clasped his hands, “amazing!”

“Except,” Glimmer jabbed some sanity back into Bow’s ribs with her elbow, “we’re legal professionals, and not going to condone any criminality.”

“Right,” Bow said said, nursing his sore spot, “sorry, Sea Hawk. Perhaps you can tell us why you were arrested instead?”

The man shrugged, “that I’m afraid I cannot say.”

“I think I know why,” said Adora. “Mr. Hawk, were you found in the alley behind the Sushi Salinity?”

“I… do recall seeing something like that. But I was quite bleary eyed, and most of this day has been a strange whir to me.”

“Well please remember as much as possible because we’re gonna need it.”

“How did you guess he was found in the alley?” asked Bow.

“I mean, it sounds like he woke up there and was carted away by the police,” Glimmer said, “It makes sense that’s why they’d suspect him. That’s not unreasonable to suppose.”

“No there is something else,” Adora knitted her brow, “a trail of blood was wiped away. For whatever reason, someone wanted the police to think the alley was the only place connected to the crime. If they were trying to set someone up,” she looked at straight at Sea Hawk, “they would be found there.”

The man’s eye’s widened, slightly shining under the harsh detention light. But there was a gleam there nonetheless.

“You believe I’m innocent, don’t you, stranger.”

“Yeah.”

Adora felt a chill ripple through her body. Yet there was a buzz to it, and her head felt clear for the first time this day.

“Yeah, you’re innocent.” She smiled. “So I’m going to be your defence attorney, mr. Hawk.”

Chapter End Notes

> Yay a whole bunch of great characters showed up. Maybe a few too many but to be honest most characters are crucial so need to be introduced early and others are crucial for this particular episode, which comprises this chapter and the next.
>
> Things are going slower than I wanted in terms of writing. I have this 40,000 word detailed synopsis which I hoped I could just take and double in terms of words to get a novel sizes thing but between having to split chapter 1 up and chapter 2 between this goddamn long I am starting to fear. Plus the basic layout of this chapter meant it was a bitch to wrangle, with a lot happening which needs to happen but potentially choking things up by just being too much. I don't really know, so I would really appreciate any comments on what works and what doesn't.
>
> Anyway, the next chapter has everyone's favourite hot antagonist so I'm looking forward to writing that

The Demoness Prosecutor

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The Defence lobby wasn't at good as the prosecution's. Not to say it was a trash heap — it was virtually indistinguishable. But Adora noticed. A few more chips in the floor-tiles, some pockets of dust between chair and wall, it all enough to bring Adora to a sigh. She quickly stifled it though. She'd made her decision and she didn't want Bow, standing straight just next to her, to think she was having second-thoughts.

Glimmer and Sea Hawk were missing. The latter had been brought in for last-minute questioning, so they resigned to the fact there would be no chance to prep him before his 'debut.' Glimmer was… well, she had said she was going to tell her mother what was going on in the morning.

Indeed, as she finally arrived, Glimmer had a stiff expression, tensed up from her shoulders to her fists. As he watched her, a frown broke across Bows face. He imagined the argument the two must have had; locked heads, equal in their stubbornness.

Any natural order between mother and daughter had long disintegrated at Brightmoon manor. There were mornings Glimmer awoke at the peep of twilight, just to pre-empt Angella to the kitchen. Some years back —after the grim incident that started this all— the woman could scarce find the will to move from her bed for weeks at a time. Glimmer had learned to look after herself. Although Angella never let herself fall into those languid episodes these days, she couldn't undo what had been done to Glimmer. Now, both wanted to make breakfast for the other in the morning… even though both sucked at cooking.

That was the thing, Bow silently reckoned. The anger between them had nothing to do with hate.

“How’d it… go?” Adora asked Glimmer as the latter came up to them.

“Not great,” said Glimmer, “it was more of what you saw yesterday really. She just won’t,” Glimmer sucked in a breath through her teeth, “see reason. She disapproves of this, of course.”

“I’m sorry,” Adora scratched her head, gathering her ponytail in her hand as she did, “I kinda feel like I’ve brought this about.”

“It’s not your fault, don’t worry,” Glimmer gave a pained half-smile, “what happened nine years ago shattered her.”

Nine years? The number struck Adora with a familiar feeling. She had been counting the years back recently, lying awake one night.

Things changed nine years ago —was that a coincidence?

The court doors opened and the three went in. Adora started heading left, only for Glimmer to quickly turn her about —to the defence bench. The prosecutor’s bench remained empty. As the gallery continued to chatter, Bow leant over to whisper:

“Right, do we have a game plan?”

Adora shrugged, “with so little info, I don’t know how we can plan.”

“Just roll with the punches,” said Glimmer, “the prosecution gets to control everything in the early stage. They’ll bamboozle you with their accusations and evidence. You just need to survive until the opportunities come your way.”

“Right,” Adora said, breathing in, “I got this. And hey, not much chance of the prosecution rolling us if they’re not even here—”

Adora was cut off by a sound that went crack. Before she could decipher what it was her hand yanked back, and she was met with a sharp pain.

“Ow!” she yelled, “was that a… wait, was that a whip?”

It was a whip, the thin end now trailing along the floor as it was gathered up, wrapped around an arm. The wielder strode in, their cape flapping about their maroon knee-length jacket. The cape had a high collar and was fastened around a jabot similar in ruffles to prosecutor Edgeworth’s. No shoes they wore but skin-tight leggings, toeless so as to not obstruct the claws tapping on tiles.

This woman took the prosecution’s stand. A twist of their head and a whole mane of bister brown hair rustled about her broad ears. She looked at Adora, penetrating her with thin eyes — one blue, one green.

Adora was sucked of breath. Could it be?

“Prosecutor, I try to run a tight ship here,” the Judge said, “what is the meaning of—”

A twang, as the feline prosecutor snapped her whip taut between her fists, claws curled around handle and the now-gathered thin end. The Judge fell silent.

Adora’s hand still stung, but it was a numb pain quickly forgotten. Her mind was blank, filled with nothing but the sight of the other girl. Lithe, ginger in complexion, and with a sea of freckles across her cheeks. There couldn’t be any mistake now. But Adora’s head began to swim. That and a sweat came on. If she put a name to it, it became real. Maybe even now she had been mistaken and this wasn’t the same person.

Then the prosecutor grinned.

“Hey… Adora.”

“…Catra?”

It was barely even a whisper. Yet Glimmer and Bow both turned to look at Adora, both with puzzled and questioning expressions.

“I’m not familiar with you,” said the Judge, “this is your first trial, correct?”

“First one in LA,” prosecutor Catra spoke in a dancing tone, somehow always on the cusp of disinterest but also mockery, “I was recommended for this position by the Chief Prosecutor himself. I *hope* you find me acceptable, your honour.”

The Judge nodded, “of course, of course. I’m always impressed by the level of talent from our young people.”

Adora stared at Catra. Her thoughts, once blank, were now racing, trying to read, trying to comprehend. All question of how… this person could be here had to be thrown aside. What really mattered was this: did she recognise her? Nine years had passed. They were children back then. But Adora remembered her — sometimes it was just associations, freckles, the sound of a laugh, but other times there were whole memories, so vivid they were like a time only yesterday.

But they were two different people now. Adora had changed. Now doubt *she* had too. They’d both grown up. Whatever Catra remembered, it wasn’t Adora as she was now.

Catra, however, faced her directly and said:

“I have to thank you, *defence attorney* .”

“Wh-what do you mean?” Adora said, trying to remain as still as she could.

“You made space for me. You know, at the office. Except,” though not losing her sardonic smile, Catra’s brow lowered, “I’m not going to throw this opportunity like you did. I wonder what *changed* for you? To make you wanna throw away all you’d worked for.” She laughed, “I bet nothing has changed. You just lack conviction, don’t you.”

“Hey,” Glimmer slammed the desk with both hands and almost toppled over the table to shout, “I don’t know who you think you

are but you have no right to insult the defence. You're supposed to be giving us an opening statement!"

"Oh I see you're all sparks," Catra gave a malicious smile as Bow restrained Glimmer from falling off the edge, "is that why you switched, defence attorney? To have a few underlings to fight your corner."

"They're my… friends," Adora muttered, still giving a fixed stare.

"Friends, eh?" the prosecutor's smile seemed to waver for a second, but then she kept on going, "here's my opening statement. I'll tell you exactly how this trial is gonna go. You get distracted and confused way too easy. You'll have no idea what you're doing until it's too late. And then when you lose you'll start to blame yourself —how could you not even a rookie have the place of a real attorney and risked your client's freedom. It's going to be great! Watching you tear yourself up after this. If only I had the time to stay and watch."

"Well, uh," the Judge mumbled, "that's an unusual opening statement, but if you'll willing to call your first witness then so be it."

As the bailiffs went on Catra's command (the whip was involved in a few places), Adora continued to stare bereft of words and breath. Glimmer was grumbling incessantly:

"What's her problem? And what sort of opening statement was that, it told us nothing about the case!"

"I think that was the point," said Adora in a distant voice.

"What's going on, Adora?" asked Bow, "do you… I mean, maybe I was imagining things but it almost felt like you two have met. Do you know that girl?"

"No," said Adora, "but she knows me."

Somehow, it was true. Prosecutor Catra knew everything about Adora. And even now, years later, knew just how to get inside her head.

Detective Scorpia looked particularly big against the witness stand, especially as she lay her cumbersome pincers on it. When she saw the trio at the defence stand, she gave a broad smile and a little wave. This was met by a whip. That and a scowl by the prosecutor sent Scorpia straight into her testimony:

"The victim was a man called Amir Scurvy. He was stabbed and died of significant haemorrhage in the back alley of a joint called the Sushi Salinity, where we found the defendant."

"You're certain that was the scene of the crime?" Catra asked lazily as she focused on readjusting her whip.

"Absolutely, sir!" said Scorpia, "the blood loss was significant, and we found a large stain around the body as it was found."

Glimmer grit her teeth, and muttered under her breath: "So show us the autopsy…?"

The Detective however mere continued listing details of the crime scene, including the weapon which was found nearby; a rapier, belonging to Sea Hawk. Adora wondered if this one was magic as well.

Scorpia then said, "our background check confirmed that the defendant is a smuggler, well-connected with the maritime black market. The victim was a former colleague of his, but they had fallen out. The defendant even had a substantial debt to him. Seems like enough to establish motive, if ya ask me."

"Hold on," Adora interjected, "a smuggler? This guy's a pretty well known performer. Are we really to believe he's involved in illegal activities?"

"Tut, tut," said Catra, "Poor naive defence attorney."

“What’s naive about what I said?” Adora snapped.

“He’s a smuggler, not the ripper. Criminal affairs have kept tabs on him for a while without the need for an arrest for ages. Not to mention bribes to the particular customs office he deals with are notoriously common. Combine that with a histrionic personality, what’s so implausible about his fanciful double-life?”

“I… I….” Adora looked over to Bow and asked, “did you know anything about this?”

“Don’t look at me,” he threw up his hands, “I just thought the pirate thing was for show too!”

“Unless you have a little something called evidence,” Catra said in a derisive purr, “don’t waste the court’s time. By the way, you do realise this testimony means your client is guilty of murder in the first degree? He’s facing the worst punishment when he gets that guilty verdict.”

“No!” now it was Adora leaning over the bench, “you can’t deduce that!”

“All you have is a motive,” Glimmer added, “what about intent?”

“It’s obvious, sparkles,” came Catra’s retort, “the defendant led the victim out of the bar and to a back alley, taking the murder weapon with him. And we have a witness who saw everything up to what transpired at the actual scene. Your honour, we have what they’ve said in writing.”

The Judge nodded, “of course. Well if—”

“Is that it?” Adora shouted, “that’s what you arrested him on? It could easily have been, I dunno, that very same witness who did it!”

Catra let out a cold laugh. “Oh my god, you’re so predictable even to your little outbursts. Come on, defence attorney, have you

already forgotten that the good detective here said they found the defendant at the scene."

"That's right," said Scorpia, "as the only other person present we suspected him right away, especially with his sword being the weapon. And he was unconscious after being bludgeoned on the forehead. No doubt got that from the fight. Here we got a picture."

'I…," Adora was gripping the table, still leaning over it, and panting. For her alone it seemed to have risen twenty degrees higher in the chamber. "Ughh."

"You wanna stand up straight there, attorney?" said Catra. "Perhaps not, you'll just fall over again. It's time to end this."

Catra stepped out from her bench and prowled over to the evidence table. There she picked up the sword, covered to the hilt in blood. Nothing happened. Of course that's the usual thing with swords, but Adora braced for another explosion as had happened with Phoenix Wright, and at this point Glimmer was half-hoping it did. Instead, Catra merely twirled it between her clawed fingers as she strolled over to the defendant's chair.

Then, without a word, she tossed it over to Sea Hawk, who by instinct caught it in one hand. Upon the first touch of skin, a bolt of energy burst out. From the hilt, electrifying the rim of the steel it went up the body of the blade, until it had enveloped the whole thing in a whirring aura of yellow.

"The wound on the victim's chest has a burn mark consistent with this energy." Catra came right to the defence, glancing at Adora with a side eye. "Oh, perhaps you'd like to have a look a the autopsy report and check for yourselves?"

She dropped the manila folder just before Glimmer, who regarded Catra, now walking back to her own bench, with a bitter look. But she shook herself, opened the report and slid it to Adora.

"Give it as thorough a rundown as possible," she hushed.

There wasn't much. Just the same details Scorpia and Catra had told them. But with the tautness in her throat and woozy feeling in her head, it was harder for Adora to parse anything they might have overlooked —or intentionally missed out. Blood loss — copious, cause of death, between 2 and 3:30 am. Stab wound — shallow. Burn marks —energy pattern.

Meanwhile Bow was looking at a photograph —the one of an unconscious Sea Hawk Scorpia had given them just a few minutes ago. Between his perusal and Adora's, with Glimmer just generally seething, the defence bench had fallen quite silent.

"Well," the Judge ventured, "if there are no questions from the defence, I will stand the Detective down. And it seems to me that this case is clear enough, so it might be time for me to hand—"

"Wait," said Glimmer, "the defence requests that they be allowed to question the eyewitness testimony the prosecution mentioned."

"That's unnecessary, your honour," Catra fired back, "the witness in question is both very busy and was quite distressed by the events. We feel her written testimony would do."

"A written document cannot be questioned thoroughly, and the defence has a right to cross-examine all testimony given!"

Though she gave Glimmer a hard stare for a moment, Catra turned to smile at Adora:

"She's got a better grasp of the legal system than you do. Perhaps you should switch?"

"Yeah well," Adora spluttered, "I'd gladly!" She blinked. "Wait, I mean —urgh, shut up!"

Glimmer buried her face in her hands. At the very least, she had convinced the court, and the Judge summoned their witness —— who turned out to be a very familiar someone.

With hair the colour of the sea and dark skin, the barmaid from yesterday came up to the stand. She wore the same dull expression. She even held a large dinner plate and a menu against her chest. And most of all she ignored the friendly waves and air kisses the defendant was throwing her way.

“Name and occupation,” said Catra.

“Mermista, I’m in the never-ending torture that is customer service. Specifically I work at the Sushi Salinity.”

“Was the defendant Sea Hawk at the bar two nights ago?”

“Yeah.”

“And the victim Amir Scurvy?”

“…yeah.”

“Tell us all that you saw of them that night.”

The trial continue with Mermista’s testimony. Sea Hawk and his colleague had given her headaches from the start, although this was more through their general presence rather than causing any trouble. In fact, most of the evening they spoke in low tones and she could ignore them. However, as evening went into night and the hours past midnight, recriminations over missed payments and burned ships came to the fore. Anger had swelled — particularly that of Sea Hawk towards the soon-to-be victim.

After visiting her staff office for a few minutes, Mermista returned to find them gone. Later, after closing up, she saw the two men head into the alleyway, one never to come out alive.

“Can you identify when this was?” asked Catra.

“Well I didn’t have a watch on me,” Mermista admitted, “but the lamppost outside the venue is broken and goes off for like an hour from three onwards. So the last glimpse I got before total darkness was Sea Hawk and Scurvy going into that alley.”

Adora's cross-examination did not go well. Already angsty, every snide look the prosecution gave her made her grit her teeth and stumble over her words. It didn't help that the witness spoke in such a bored flat voice. Few of Adora's questions got more than a one-word answer. The others just went around in circles. Catra didn't even need to make a single counterpoint.

Eventually Mermista was so disengaged from the actual moment that she produced a sharp knife and honing tool, and started scraping the two together. By that point, Adora just collapsed on the bench in defeat.

"I think that's enough," said the Judge, "it's clear that there's little more the defence can get out of this witness, and I see no misinterpretation of any of the other facts. Now can I—"

It was Bow's turn to interject, "wait a minute, your honour."

"Clearly I cannot," the Judge said, ruffled. "What is it, co-counsel?"

"The prosecution gave us this picture earlier but we didn't get time to discuss it," Bow said, "I think it might be worth circling back."

"Well this is quite irregular! Why wasn't a point registered earlier?"

Something lit up in Adora's eyes and she pushed herself up, quickly saying "the prosecution moved on too quickly. A-and you can't accept that evidence until its been examined." She forced a grin directed at Catra, "anyone with a basic grasp of the legal system should know that."

Catra bared her sharp teeth. "This is a waste of time. Stand down the witness and hand down the verdict, already."

"Shadow Weaver said the same thing in my last trial, and she turned out wrong!"

The feline eyes of the prosecutor widened, the pupils drawing thin. She began digging her claws into the woodwork of her bench, but didn't say another word.

Meanwhile, Adora turned to Bow.

"So what are we looking for?"

"I think you should compare these two images," he said, handing her the prosecution's picture and the one he'd brought up on his pad.

They both showed the same spot. One had Sea Hawk in a slump, the other was just of the wall. Of course the difference beyond that was clear. Adora had her first contradiction.

"Well, defence?" the Judge peered down at her, "is there something wrong with the photograph?"

"There is, your honour," she said. "Earlier the detective said that the defendant was bludgeoned from the fight. The question I have is how this brick fits into that story."

"Brick?" Catra tilted her head, "what brick?"

"The brick on the floor just next to where Sea Hawk was found."

"Clearly he was knocked into the wall from his blow. That's why he was found slumped there. The force must have knocked the—"

"OBJECTION!" Adora thrust her finger out, "I'm sorry but that just can't be the case. Have another look at the two pictures. In the one Bow took, there's the brick. But in the one the Detective took some time before that —there isn't anything at all!"

"What?!"

"Oh I see," the Judge said, eyes widening, "quite a conundrum."

“What does it matter,” Catra protested, “it’s just a stupid brick. I… Detective get back in here right now!”

On the prosecutor’s command, Detective Scorpia came rushing back into the fore, squeezing into Mermista’s space behind the witness’ stand.

“Sorry about that.” She scratched her cheek with the thin end of her pincer. “I think I might have an explanation for all this.”

“Explain. Quickly.”

“I… mighta accidentally… knocked the wall and some bricks came tumbling down. It wasn’t a big mess I swear!” she tried pre-empt Catra who, fire bursting in her eyes, had drawn up her whip, “I put most of it back together good as new. But… maybe one of those bricks did hit the defendant.”

“If what you say is true,” said Adora, seizing upon the new testimony, “and not just one but several bricks fell, then it’s unconceivable it didn’t!”

“Oh so what?” Catra hissed, “so he got hit afterward? It doesn’t change any of the facts of the case.”

“Uh, it does.”

“No it doesn’t!”

“Can I leave?” Mermista said in a drone, “since you don’t seem to need me.”

“Ah yes,” said the Judge, “you and the Detective can both leave the stand.” After they had, the Judge turned to Adora again. “Well the prosecution has posed a relevant question to you. What is the significance of the brick? Think carefully. Your answer will decide whether this case proceeds or not.”

“Surely you guys had something with this?” Glimmer asked, leaning over to Adora and Bow.

“I mean I was basically just bluffing,” Adora admitted, “but I think there is something here. I don’t know if it will turn the case around but it should keep things going.” She turned and spoke up for the Judge. “Your honour, this leave open a big question. If Sea Hawk wasn’t bludgeoned on the forehead, then why was he found unconscious?”

“Heh, I can think of many reasons,” Catra said, “maybe he was thrown to the wall, maybe he passed out from seeing all the blood. Whatever. It all leads to the same conclusion. He fought the victim. He killed the victim.”

“We’ll see about that. The defence requests that Sea Hawk be placed on the stand.”

“Wait, Adora,” Glimmer knitted her brow, “he already told us he can’t remember anything.”

“It’s the best chance we’ve got,” Adora argued, “he’s the only one who could possibly know what happened, unless we can prove the presence of a third person.”

Catra twisted her cheek, and then said, “the prosecution….accepts this request. But only because the defence will regret it.” She met Adora’s eye, “a defendant can easily incriminate themselves, y’know, but if he refuses to answer a question this whole trial’s over for you.”

Adora fixed her stare right back at her. “Bring him onto the stand.”

Sea-Hawk did not need ushering by the bailiffs. He waltzed up the stand, gave a small performative cough, and then burst out with:

“Ladies and gentlemen of the court! The pirate has been caught in the law’s trap, but through his wiles may escape yet. Just another day of danger for one such as myself. I believe there’s a shanty to be had here—aieee!”

Sea Hawk just dodged the strike of Catra’ s whip on the stand.

“One note out of you and you’ll be fish bait,” she snarled. “Testify to the court about that night. Now.”

“Well, I uh,” he straightened out, “I don’t remember all too much, now that you mention it. I,” his eyes darted to Adora and with a pained look pursued, “might have gotten into a fight. I’m a master fencer as I’m sure you all well know. If —and I say if!— I were to dispatch with someone, I’d go for the light hit. Perhaps in my haste I lost my balance and stabbed to the hilt…..”

“Hold it,” said Adora, “what are you talking about? Stabbed to the hilt?”

“Sounds like a confession to me,” Catra interjected.

Sea Hawk shook his head, “well I don’t remember that happening, but you can see the sword. It’s covered in blood.”

“That’s not what’s in the autopsy report,” Adora mused.

A few seconds of silence passed. Adora looked up. The realisation made her take a short step back, but then moved forward again and slammed the bench.

“Wait a minute, that’s a contradiction! OBJECTION!”

“The blood got on the sword, so what?” said Catra.

“If it stabbed the victim all the way to the hilt then there should have been an exit wound, but the wound was shallow!”

“Maybe the blood trickled down, who cares? Those burn marks mean that only the defendant could have stabbed the victim with that sword.”

“We have to understand every fact on the case until we can say for certain that this man I guilty,” Adora pointed her finger again, “this contradiction needs resolving.”

“Then resolve it!”

“Okay, I will! Sea Hawk,” she turned to the defendant, “do you possibly have any other wounds?”

“Another wound?” he looked back, slightly agape, “why would you suppose…?”

“I have a hunch, so just tell me. Something must have knocked you unconscious if it wasn’t that brick.”

The man hesitated for a second, slowly nestling his lower mouth closed under his moustache. Then he undid his vambrace, and lifted his sleeve. A darkly-strained wrap of linen was tucked around his elbow. A tourniquet.

”That—“ the gobsmacked Catra dug her claws into the table again. Then she groaned, “the detective and I will be having a word after this, believe me. But there, your contradiction’s resolved. Nothing’s changed, defence attorney.”

“What do you mean?” Adora shot back.

“Clearly the victim fought back and took the defendant’s sword. He stabbed him but the defendant got the weapon back and dealt the killing blow. This is still consistent with all the evidence and the only explanation.”

“Yes, I agree,” said the Judge.

“Finally,” sighed Catra.

“Although…”

“Ugh!”

“Hmm,” the Judge thought, “there’s just one thing on my mind. Before we thought only the victim had been stabbed and lost a lot of blood.”

“Yes, it was found around his body in the alley way,” Catra rambled quickly, hoping the Judge would get wise and wrap this

up soon.

The Judge continued to mull his words slowly, “but then, if the defendant was also stabbed.”

Adora leaned forward, “then where’s his blood?”

“Indeed. Where is the other patch of blood?”

“We know that your honour,” Adora said, almost shouting. “Bow show him the luminol scans!”

Bow provided the court a copy of hidden blood traces they had found. Adora was alert. Filled with the feeling of being more awake than she had throughout the trial. Tingles reached the ends of her fingertips. This was her court now.

“This evidence throws everything into a new light,” she said, “it shows that one, this crime might not have happened in the alley at all, and two, someone covered it up. Since the victim was dead and the defendant was fast running out of consciousness, this clearly points to the existence of a third party!”

Though she had grimaced at the unfurling of this new argument, Catra had become suddenly calm again. But then she started to break. First into a sneer, then a chuckle. Finally she burst into a maniacal laugh, high and mocking, with each ‘ha’ making Adora falter a little more until she was completely sapped of the confidence she had only just found.

“Wha… what are you…?”

“Oh come on, Adora, did you really think you’d turned this trial around? You think your forensic assistant was the only one to think to use luminol?”

“I don’t understand,” said the Judge, “are you telling me you knew of this wiped blood? And you didn’t tell the court.”

Catra shrugged, "it wasn't relevant. It *isn't* relevant. That blood only goes up to the entrance of the alleyway. So maybe the fight started there and ended up at the eventual crime scene. After killing the victim, the defendant realised his blood could be traced back to him so he goes to clear it up, but by the time he's done it he's lost enough that he passes out."

"You," Adora's hands were shaking as she stared across the chamber to that prosecutor, "you hid the evidence!"

"I didn't hide anything. You just weren't particularly thorough. So unprofessional, these new defence attorneys are."

But before Adora could lash out again, Glimmer gripped her by the arm.

"Adora," she hushed, "she wants you to get unfocused remember."

"But I don't know what to do now she undermined my whole argument—"

"No, think about it! You don't think Catra's actually right, do you?"

"No, but—"

"Then you must be getting close to the truth. Someone covered those tracks. They wanted to hide where the actual crime scene was."

The Judge all the while was rubbing his temple with his palm "It seems we're back where we were before. The evidence is still in contention. Perhaps the defence or prosecution could propose some more testimony to shed some light?"

"The washed blood is irrelevant," Catra restated, "no more testimony."

"Defence?"

“Think,” Glimmer insisted, “there must be someone who would know about the real crime scene whereever it is.”

“Well there can’t be too many places for that to be,” Bow added, “it was somewhere near or in the Sushi bar.”

“Then,” Adora was trying to keep up with her own thoughts, “the only person who would know is…. Your honour,” she called out, “the defence requests we hear from the barmaid Mermista again!”

“Her?”

“M-Mermista?” stammered Sea Hawk.

“Really?” Catra raised an eyebrow.

“Your honour there is precedence here,” Glimmer quickly cut in, “if important questioning was neglected then we have a right to recall a witness.”

“I suppose that is so,” said the Judge. “But do you have the right question?”

“Give us a recess. We’ll need to access the court record and we’ll have it when we return.”

Quite miraculously, the Judge allowed it. Adora was soon pacing up and down the lobby, streaming her fingers through her hair and muttering:

“What the hell am I doing. What the hell am I doing! She was right. How was she so right? I’m going to get an innocent man locked up!”

“Adora, calm down,” Bow said, although through a creaking voice.

“I think you all need to stop being so jittery,” said Sea Hawk, gently leaning against the wall by the door. “A real adventure requires a steely nerve.”

“Look, Sea Hawk. You’re amazing but you could have told us a lot more before we went in there,” Bow frowned at him, “why didn’t you even tell us about your wound?”

The pirate shrugged, “I don’t remember patching myself up. But whoever helped me two nights ago didn’t want to be found in the morning. Guess I felt I was honouring their wish to be remain anonymous.”

“You’re telling me there’s a fourth party?” said Adora, “we don’t even know who this third one could be. Come on Glimmer tell me you have something?”

“No, no! There’s nothing in the record,” Glimmer said, madly flipping through pages. “Maybe…. Maybe I wasn’t ready for this.”

At that moment, a hand, light but sure, was placed on Glimmer’s shoulder. She flinched and turned to see who its bearer was. Her mother’s face greeted her.

“M-mom?”

“Angella, what are you doing here?” Adora finally stopped pacing and gawked.

Angella, dressed in a pastel pantsuit, turned away from the many eyes looking up at her as she said:

“I… had a change of perspective. And since you were all so intent on going forward with this anyway,” she looked back at them, “I thought you could use my help.”

She walked up to Adora and looked her in the eye, but not close enough that looking down would seem imposing. Adora mouthed a stammer but then felt silent and calm. Finally a half-smile touched Angella’s lips.

“You’ve done well,” she said, “far better than anyone would have guessed. Do you still want me as a mentor?”

"… Yeah?"

"Then this is lesson number one. A lawyer is someone who is brave. That's the first thing you must be. And a brave person doesn't let those who depend on you see fear. They depend on you. So show a brave face."

"That's um…," Adora restrained the urge to squirm, "all well and good but right now I need to get a witness back on the stand or this is all over."

"Adora, your back is to the wall, but that's okay. Just use the time to look at everything and see the possibilities. Review all your base assumptions and leave nothing unturned. And you've already started haven't you —with the crime scene not being in the alley. I think Glimmer was right about you, you have a real knack for this. Glimmer?"

Glimmer perked up, although her head still swam with this sudden turn of events. "Y-yeah?"

"Go back to the witness's first testimony and find any reference to the Sushi Salinity's layout, and then tell me the progression of the victim and defendant's movements."

"Uh, okay," Glimmer flicked through the pages again, "she didn't say much other than she had her own office she was in for a bit. As for the movements… oh hey she said something about them being missing for a few minutes before she saw them again in the alley."

"Thank you, Glimmer, that should be enough."

Bow frowned, and said, "mrs. Angella, I don't see how this is going to help—"

"No, it's okay, Bow," said Adora. "I think I got it."

Angella nodded, "then I'll see you after the not guilty verdict."

They returned to the court and to the bench; Sea Hawk to the dock. Catra was waiting with a bored expression, twisting her whip in her hands. Although upon seeing Adora she let out the smallest of smirks.

“Has the defence found a question that will warrant recalling the witness?” asked the Judge.

“We have your honour,” said Adora.

“And it is?”

Adora leant one hand on the bench and explained, “I’d rather ask the witness herself.”

The Judge stumbled for a second, and turned to look at Adora. She looked back at him, not breaking from her calm. The Judge acquiesced.

Mermista, as sedate as ever, returned to the stand.

“Why am I back here again?” she said in her drone.

“I have a question for you,” Adora stated.

“Ugh, what is it?”

“What… is your alibi?”

That did the trick. Mermista’s eyes fully opened and she stood unusually straight.

“What do you mean?” she asked, slowly.

“Well, you admit you were close to the scene on the night that the murder happened. There must be some reason the police didn’t consider you for arrest.”

“Well, obviously I was very busy,” Mermista creased her brow, “I’m always pretty busy you know. Like I’m supposed to be at work right now but you keep dragging back here.”

“The witness provided us with an airtight alibi when we questioned her,” Catra said, in a voice almost as scathing as Mermista’s. “She was in her office for when the altercation took place. Only she has a key to the room and entering and exit is recorded. Your honour, this is a meaningless line of questioning. Can we just call it a day, now?”

“Catra!” Adora slammed her hands on the desk, “that’s the key! Everything starts to make sense when we turn around one of our base assumptions — the scene of the crime!”

“So you’re really saying the crime scene was a place other than the alley?” the Judge asked. “Then where was it?”

“Mermista told us already. She said that Scurvy and Sea Hawk left their booths before they supposedly headed to the alley. The place they went was Mermista’s office.”

“That’s—”

“Ridiculous!” Catra shouted, “I knew you were naive, I knew you would flail about. But I didn’t realise you would actually be embarrassing to watch.”

“But it makes sense,” said Adora, “the fight began in the office, and Scurvy gave Sea Hawk the wound that knocked him out. Then the real killer stabbed Scurvy. But they couldn’t have the crime scene be in the office it would draw too much suspicion, so they changed everything to make it look like it happened in the alley. Tell me, Catra, who is the only person who could have worried about the crime scene being Mermista’s office?”

“I… urhgh,” Catra stared with the grimmest of snarls and smallest of pupils. She looked ready to spit back a counterargument, —or fire off with her whip.

But it was Mermista who spoke up next. Once again she had her very sharp kitchen knife in one hand, and the honing tool in the other, and glowered at Adora as she said, “that’s… a really

interesting story you've got there, attorney. So I'm the killer now? Never heard anything so far-fetched."

"Well," Glimmer swallowed, "you do have a somewhat misanthropic personality, and a knife."

"Yeah, but a murderer make me it does not. What motive do I have to kill some pirate?"

"Maybe to frame Sea Hawk," Bow suggested, "you don't seem to like him very much."

"Ugh, he's annoying but he's still a frequent customer. Not like I'd have an incentive there."

"Self-defence," said Adora, "Scurvy attacked Sea Hawk and still had a weapon. You saw what happened and he must have gone for you next."

"Then why am I still alive?" the barmaid said, letting out a mirthless half-laugh, "I couldn't overpower Scurvy, not when he had a sword. If this actually happened then why am I not skewered; let alone how did I stab him."

"You had a different weapon. In fact that makes sense," Adora grinned, "you kept the weapon in and then pulled it out to release the blood at the alley. So it must be small. Maybe that knife?"

"Oh come on, Adora," said Catra, "do you really think that knife matches the entrance wound?"

"It's a wide thin blade," Bow reported, "the wound is small and circular. Fitting Sea Hawk's rapier."

"What I want to know is why the police would have missed this," the Judge added, "didn't they search the inside of the building for clues?"

"That's the whole point," Adora said, "the killer made the fake crime scene so they wouldn't even check near the real one."

“So many problems with that,” came Catra’s cold chuckle “For one we checked the whole ground with luminal. There was no blood anywhere outside of the alley. And are you telling me that this supposed real killer would just risk being seen with two limp bodies across the street?”

Adora slammed the desk, “Mermista knew it was dark! She knew that every time it hits 3 in the morning the lamps goes out. As for the blood, I think it was just luck that nothing fell onto the street itself. But send detective Scorpia or Bow to the witness’s office right now and I’ll bet you there’s blood.”

“No.”

Adora’s grin faltered.

“What do you mean no.”

“No,” now Catra’s grin grew. “I’m not gonna sanction that. This trial ends right now.”

“You can’t do this—”

“Either you do what a lawyer does and produce some evidence — hard evidence that shows that this witness is the killer as you say —or you shut up and let the Judge hand down a guilty verdict. I told you things would end this way. You’re too predictable.”

“Adora, what do we do now?” Bow was gripping the sides of his head, and looking desperately at the attorney.

“Adora?” Glimmer’s eyes were quivering.

Adora looked to the backs of her hands, laid flat against the table. She fell quiet and just whispered to herself:

“My back’s to the wall… need every possibility.” She looked up and said aloud, “we have everything we need.”

“But Adora, we can’t do a luminol sweep of her office and if we can’t do—”

“We don’t need the office,” said Adora, “we just need the weapon.”

“Ugggggggh,” groaned Mermista, “can I go already?”

“Not yet,” said Adora, “I just want to have a look at something.”

The barmaid smirked, “you already know the knife won’t save your argument, so why don’t you—”

“Not the knife. The other thing. Uh… what is it?”

“It’s a honing tool, Adora,” Bow said.

“Yeah, that thing.”

Mermista seized up. Her eyes slowly tracked down until she looked straight at the metal tool in her hand; long, thin, and with a small circular footprint. She tried to smirk again, although it was pained and weak.

“Yeah…, sure. I mean, I know what you’re thinking, but it isn’t proof—”

“Bow, the luminol?”

As the witness watched in a horror just restrained by the passiveness of her face, Bow took the tool into hand and sprayed it with his bottle of testing fluid. He put on his goggles. Bright it glowed, no doubt the marking of blood.

“It reacted!” Bow exclaimed. “Guys it reacted!”

Glimmer and Adora quickly took turns to verify. The three burst in uncontrolled cheering and whooping. Glimmer pulled Bow down into a hug, and Adora turned to face the court.

“TAKE THAT!” she said, her heart frantically leaping as she thrust her finger into the again, “take that, Catra! How’d you like that for evidence.”

“That… that….”

Catra was holding back a furious bellow. Instead she hurled her whip, whacking the witness stand, finally breaking Mermista from her own horrified spell.

“Explain yourself!” Catra demanded.

“Why?” Mermista spat back, “it’s all over. There’s no point now.”

“Mermista… dear.”

It was a voice as smooth as silk that had spoken, and Mermista turned to see the defendant reaching out from the dock.

“I think I know a little of what you did,” he gestured towards his arm, “it seems my lawyers were a little wrong. There was no fourth party was there.”

“I… I…,” Mermista hung her head, “it wasn’t self-defence. It was revenge.”

The ecstasy that had swept through the defence team died down, and Adora shoulders fell as she looked upon the crushed killer.

“What happened?”

“Scurvy attacked Sea Hawk. Not a fatal wound, but in the moment I lost any sense of judgement. I thought… I thought he was…. Well he’s fine, isn’t he, it doesn’t matter.”

“You thought Sea Hawk was dead so you attacked Scurvy?”

“Yep,” Mermista wiped away a sudden tear, “drove the tool right through his chest.”

“But that was a defence of a third party!” Glimmer protested, “you should’ve gone to the police… although…. Huh.”

Having regained her composure, Catra wore a disinterested look again and was stroking her whip. Although she deigned to comment:

“So you decided to frame the defendant anyway, once you realised he lived. You dragged the bodies under the cover of darkness than wiped away the tracks. For good measure, you put the sword in Sea Hawk’s hand and had him stab the victim too. But in that darkness you could not see inconsistencies like the blood on the sword. You undid yourself.”

“Well I helped,” Adora muttered, although more to herself, “and you weren’t exactly pointing out the inconsistencies, Catra.”

Though she did not turn her now hanged head, Mermista spoke out for Sea Hawk:

“I’m sorry…. I really screwed you over.”

“You don’t need to say anything now,” said Sea Hawk, in a calm breath. “I still owe you for my life. Heh, what’s a little framing compared to that.”

“Still, you’ve been a great customer over the years,” her voice shook, “and I’ve served you poorly.”

“I cannot understand it,” said the Judge, “but it seems to me that all the facts of this case are laid bare. To the defendant Sea Hawk I can finally hand down my verdict.”

NOT GUILTY.

The feel of exhilaration was full and thriving as Adora, Glimmer and Bow returned to the lobby where they were shortly greeted by Angella and Sea Hawk. But there was a touch of reservation, especially for Adora, who could not get Mermista’s revelation out of her head.

“I don’t understand why she did it,” said Adora, “killing in the heat of the moment I get. But then to try and frame the person you wanted to save?”

“It doesn’t matter so much,” Sea Hawk made a smile although his words sounded stiff, “I’m no saint, not particularly worth saving.”

“Even now you can forgive her?” Bow seemed on the verge of tears, “you’re such a great guy, Sea Hawk!”

The pirate grinned, “well, I’m always happy to hear your praise in particular, Bow. But I speak from the heart — I feel sorry for Mermista more than anything.”

“I don’t blame her too much,” Glimmer said, looking out to one of the windows, “when she realised what she’d done she must have known there was a risk of her being accused of murder —and that’s almost a guaranteed guilty verdict.”

“Almost,” Angella smiled, glancing at Adora.

“And even if she had confessed, defence of a third party is… well, even self-defence isn’t always the strongest plea in this broken courthouse. She shouldn’t have framed Sea Hawk, but any system that forces people to choose between honesty and survival is rotten to its core.”

“Will you visit her at the detention centre?” Angella asked Sea Hawk.

“Whenever the winds return me to the shore, there I will be!”

“Come by to Brightmoon Manor some time,” she said, “Glimmer and I can give you advice to help her.”

“We can?” Glimmer’s eyes darted between the two, then widened, “oh, yeah. We can.”

“But I will be busier these days,” said Angella, “with my new student.”

On that note, Adora turned to Angella, picking up on a question that had been on her mind ever since her mentor had shown up.

"How did you know such much about the case? You seemed to know exactly where to push me. And what made you change your mind about helping us?"

"Well the wisdom I gave you was elementary," Angella let out a titter, "although yes you're correct in that I had some foreknowledge. I still keep contact with one of the High Prosectors here —his father was an old colleague of mine. I believe you met yesterday. We talked about you and your potential —especially your choice to forge this new path. And with what Glimmer said yesterday I just thought——"

"Oh, prosecutor," Sea Hawk said, looking up across the room.

Every head turned to follow. Catra stood there, cape, whip and all. Somehow Adora had expected a sullen look, maybe even a pout. In fact, Catra seemed quite smug as she approached.

Still, being out of the courtroom, seeing her face to face for the first time in so long, something tremulated throughout Adora's body. She resisted the urge to drop her eyes or look away. But she couldn't quite look this girl in the eyes. Scared perhaps, but of what? That she'd see someone who didn't remember her? Or was it worse if it were the reverse?

"Not bad out there," said the prosecutor in a cool tone, "not bad for your first real go."

"Not bad yourself," was Adora's mere reply.

"Heh," Catra uttered, "I'll get you next time."

She turned, and was ready to prowl away, when she lingered. Turning back, but not face Adora, rather she looked up at Angella.

“Haven’t seen you in a long time,” she said, “What’s it been? Nine years since you were disbarred?”

Angella maintained a flat expression and just said, “I’m not banned from coming to court.”

“Heh, well.” Catra turned to give Adora one last passing look, and muttered, “see ya, Adora.”

Adora watched as the girl walked away. Her eyes even lingered till the last flick of Catra’s tail disappeared behind a door. All the happiness of victory, the joy of gaining a mentor, the somber note about Mermista; it was all gone. All that remained was Catra, who had now left.

That had been Adora’s best friend in the whole world. Once.

Chapter End Notes

There she is :)

The Princess Promenade

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Having spent several weeks getting lost again and again, Adora was starting to figure her way around Brightmoon manor. She had been late to things a lot recently, especially her tutorials with Angella, but this was no fault of her own. Hallways were long, desolate and monotonous. But she pushed herself to learn the layout by rote. Soon she was timing herself, trying to shave travel time by the minutes and then by the seconds on each lap. And at long last she could make it to breakfast before noon.

Adora came into the kitchen, finding Glimmer already there. A full set prepared comprising bacon, eggs, sausages all sizzling and adorned roasted mushrooms was spread across the table towards the far side of the elongated room. Adora instead hovered by the door.

“Hey can I grab a breadroll or something?” she called over to Glimmer, “I wanna do a few laps around the gardens.”

Glimmer frowned, “sure… they’re in the high cabinet behind you.”

There it was as said —a large box up by the wall with a vertical lid. Adora reached up to it, grabbing the handle. She pulled, yet it wouldn’t budge.

“Next one over,” Glimmer said with a half-smile, “that one’s been busted for as long as I can remember.”

“Angella never got it fixed?” Adora said as she found the more pliable cabinet door.

“She’s against the idea, I guess.”

Adora would have asked more on such a strange thing, but was cut off by the arrival of Bow.

“Glimmer it’s— oh, this actually looks good,” he grabbed a side of bacon.

The paralegal harrumphed, undecided as to whether Adora or Bow had been more rude about her cooking. Sensing this, Bow lay a hand on her shoulder and disarmed her with a warm grin. Glimmer let slip a flustered smile before turning away again and putting her focus decidedly on her breakfast, although it wouldn’t stay there for long.

“We’re on!” Bow said.

“Really?” Glimmer bounded up from her seat, finding her arms around him as he still hand his about her shoulders, “Bow, you’re brilliant!”

“What’s going on?” asked Adora.

“Oh you’re coming too,” said Bow, “or at least you better be.”

“Coming to what? Come on guys, I can read contradictions but I can’t read minds… yet.”

“We’ve got confirmed invites to the Princess Promenade,” he explained.

“What’s that? Some sort of ball?” Adora looked at the two of them while taking a bite from her roll, and muffled, “You gotta be royalty or something to get in?”

“It’s not like that,” Bow chuckled.

“That’s the name of the bar,” said Glimmer, “it’s a Jazz club. But you kinda have to know people to get in. We’ve been meaning to get in for ages. I can’t believe this is actually happening!”

"Wow. I mean I probably shouldn't get between you two, y'know…," she threw Glimmer in particular a look with the smallest shifts of her eyebrows —one Bow would not see.

Glimmer squirmed at the recognition, fidgeting and biting her lip. But it was oblivious Bow who said, "we can go as a squad! I'm meeting up with Sea Hawk there anyway. You know," he rubbed the back of his neck, "for a dance to the Moonlight Serenade."

"Oh," said Adora. "Well, I still have a lot of case files Angella wants me to read."

"Adora," Glimmer said, pleading in her tone, "you've already gotten two clients off charges at the age of seventeen! You don't have to rush. Really."

"In fact that's more reason to come," said Bow, "you've missed way too many of these kind of things to get where you are. You deserve a break."

Scratching at her elbow, Adora didn't quite meet the others' eyes. "I'd like to come, it sounds fun but…. I am She-Ra, right? There's something big I have to do, I have to train myself. And you can bet the prosecutors won't rest to make things difficult."

Bow and Glimmer shared a glance. It was clear that by 'Prosecutors', Adora meant one.

Adora had been dedicating every moment of the past few weeks to furthering herself as a lawyer. If she wasn't pouring over Angella's texts, then she was exercising, but even that was just to keep her mind sharp. She hadn't neglected her newfound friendship with the 'squad' of course. Glimmer was instructing her on the historical context of She-Ra herself, and Bow organised outings into the city to get their minds away from all the lawyering every once in a while. And Adora loved every second of it.

But it was hard to escape from that feeling. The urge to be doing the right thing, getting herself ready for whatever her big test would be. And every session with Angella just fed this even more.

“What is the second rule of evidence law.”

Adora didn’t answer. A moment passed, and Angella gave a puzzled look to her student.

“Did you hear me?” she asked.

“Sorry,” Adora shook herself, “the second rule of evidence law is… uh, police, police, —no that’s number one —it’s… it’s that any unregistered evidence may not be permitted in court unless directly relevant to the trial at hand.”

“Correct,” Angella said. She paused for a second, then asked, “did you just need a minute to think or is something bothering you, Adora?”

“It’s just…,” Adora looked around, as if the words would be appear in the sitting room in which they trained, “this doesn’t feel like the best use of my time.”

Angella raised her brow, “well if you’re certain you know what you need to know, why do you need me?”

“Hey!” Adora grimaced, “look, it’s like… it’s not the law that’s causing me any trouble in there. I think if I’m going to keep an edge in court we need to strategise about the prosecutors. The one in the Sea Hawk trial threw me off my game in the first salvo and it took me the whole trial to figure out where I was. I need to know how to fight her.”

“Prosecutor Catra?”

“Y-yes I… you know her, right?” Adora recalled the mocking sneer Catra had given the former lawyer.

“We’ve crossed paths,” Angella said, lower than a murmur, “it was…” she shut her eyes, mouthing something. Then she looked to Adora in a flat expression again. “You don’t need to know about my past with prosecutor Catra. I have met many up and coming

prosecutors in my time. There isn't anything significant about her. Now, back to evidence law."

Out of the secluded enclave of Brightmoon Manor, and far fast across the high-rise city, prosecutor Catra was also spending most of her time preparing. She had a good office, with a sleek panelled floor and an even sleeker desk, yet she hadn't done much with it. The shelves were empty. The desk carried no happy effects. She didn't intend to stay here long. All she had was whip to one side, and a laptop in front of her on which to work.

Of course, she'd work a lot better if detective Scorpia wasn't making as much noise moving a simple box. Carrying the weight wasn't the problem —she was a beefy woman— but her pincers lacked in finessed. Still she landed it on the desk with a crash, and only a choice few files had fallen onto the floor in the process.

Worse was that the detective was yapping off on something. Catra gave a curt sigh and continued typing away.

The detective had not been her decision. Prosecutors were assigned one for investigations, but the Chief Prosecutor was much too busy a man to deal with personnel issues, so he'd designated it to one of the High Prosecutors —to Shadow Weaver. Clearly she thought it apt. No doubt she'd gotten what she wanted as Catra, upon the first meeting with her new partner lost all the air in her lungs, being lifted up and pulled into that bone-cracking hug. Scorpia was far too affectionate. Catra didn't do affectionate.

Catra sighed again and looked at the detective, still talking. The thought to dismiss her crossed her mind. Better yet she could shut her up with a crack of her whip. Instead she just let Scorpia talk. She had gotten used to her, after all.

"Oh man, I don't know how I can even think about working today," Scorpia was saying.

"A real change, huh," Catra said in a dry tone.

“I’m just buzzing, sir! They’ve got a legend booked for the Princess Promenade tonight. Chas Singer himself. Heh, a singer called Singer. Just noticed that, funny.”

“Right….”

“You should come too,” Scorpia suddenly knelt by the table and looked with shining eyes, “you’ve done more paperwork than half the prosecutor’s office and criminal affairs put together, you can take the night off. And, you know,” she tilted her head as her gaze fell away, “we could, kinda, use the opportunity to hang out maybe.”

Catra regarded her with glazed eyes. Then she flicked her attention back to her laptop, its contents scattered across the screen —all the work she had been doing, yes, just as Scorpia said. Yet no victory in court. On the other hand, Scorpia’s pleading eyes bored right into her, such that her skin started to prickle with the rising heat, to the point that to say no felt impossible.

“Ugh, alright,” she said, “could do with the r and r. But I want overtime from you tomorrow!”

Scorpia beamed with a “yes sir!” before yanking Catra across the desk into another suffocating squeeze.

“Hey, watch it!”

So the evening came, with a gentle patter of drizzle. The Princess Promenade was down by the seafront, yet tucked away behind a winding alley. The door was unassuming, rusted and metal. The facade was like a warehouse long forgot. Yet it gave way to luxury. Low light punctuated the dim moody glow of velvet tufted walls and a polished chequer floor. The sounds of rain and the busy outside world were drowned in the sea of brass, the warm wash of saxophones and the crashing waves of a hi-hat and bass. There was a piano too, tinkling away through the chords, finding new colours and chromaticism through thirds and thirds, and a double bass that wasn’t doing much but did it was style.

And a voice sang above it all. Deep, with a slight husk and yet magnificently controlled on the vibrato:

We're in the Money

We're in the Money

Let's Lend, Spend it, send it rolling along~~

Adora, dressed in a bright red dress, came to the bar. There Glimmer was sat with a lemonade in hand (old enough for a legal profession, not old enough to drink; it was a strange world theirs) and watching the singer on stage, now in the middle of a muted trumpet bridge. Adora ordered her own drink and took a stool next to her.

"You were right," she said leaning over, "this place it's like wow, fancy."

"Yeah," said Glimmer in a vacant voice, before taking a sip from her glass.

Adora was blown back by this, and felt her own enthusiasm diminish, as if slipping into Glimmer's black hole of gloom. She thought to ask what was wrong but that seemed like it would just make things worse. Glimmer had been so excited earlier that it was sort of perverse that she wasn't now —and to point that out, even implicitly, would just throw more guilt onto her.

But the answer was standing only a few metres from the bar where they sat. Bow was with Sea Hawk, quite close side by side as they were chatting to some others. By his wild gesticulations and booming voice it was clear Sea Hawk was in the middle of one of his daring tales. Bow was conspicuously enjoying himself.

"You could be happy for him," Adora said, trying her most nonchalant non-offensive voice possible. "Or not, but then just forget him for tonight. You gotta enjoy yourself, right?"

Glimmer just pouted and took a large swig from her lemonade, wishing that it were alcohol. Adora frowned. So much for not making things worse.

Then Glimmer's eye widened and she straightened up.

"God, they're coming this way."

Turning her neck, Adora caught the briefest of glimpses of Bow and Sea Hawk turning, before her head was lurched back again. Suddenly she found herself right up against Glimmer, who pushed her lips into hers. A series of garbled thoughts rushed across her head. First ascertaining that this was in fact real life. Second she realised her urge to break away struggling with the soft warm feeling against her mouth, spreading warmth across her cheeks and down into her chest. Third she was assessing how she felt about this situation and her friendship with Glimmer —wondering how cute she thought she was and how well they might work as a couple —and fourth, the context of this whole situation slapping all sense out of the other thoughts as she realised what this actually was.

They broke away. Both looked to Bow to see his reaction. He was turned away, as it happened, since the song had ended and he was giving a hearty clap to the performers. Despite Glimmer's intention, he hadn't seen anything.

Adora shoved Glimmer away.

"What the hell! You can't use me like that."

"I-I'm sorry," a now blushing Glimmer spluttered, "I just—"

"Hey guys," said Bow, who was now reaching them. "How are we enjoying tonight?"

"I'm gonna go," Adora jumped from her stool.

"W-what?" Bow was taken aback, "but we just got here."

“I need some air,” Adora muttered, “I can brace the rain.”

Adora left Bow completely confused, and Glimmer so red that she let Bow returned to Sea Hawk without another word.

Dripping with fury all the while, Adora strayed across the room, repeatedly folding her arms then letting them fall as she silently castigated Glimmer. Yet contrary to her words she didn’t make it to the exit. Catching sight of two heads, one spiky black, one adorned with grey wings, made Adora turn.

Phoenix Wright and Miles Edgeworth were there, sitting at their own table facing the dancers and the stage beyond. They weren’t focused on any of that, however, instead being preoccupied with a game. Adora approached.

“Hey,” she said.

Edgeworth looked up first and gave a small smile, “ah, Adora. I didn’t expect to see you here.”

“I didn’t think I’d see you either, especially together,” Adora chuckled.

“Oh,” said Phoenix, now looking up from his cards, “hey, good to see you again. Yeah, Edgeworth invited me.”

“I don’t see why two old friends can’t meet up every once in a while,” the prosecutor murmured.

“Are you… playing poker?” asked Adora, suddenly catching sight of the red and blue chips across the table.

“Not my idea,” said Edgeworth, a little ruffled. “It’s a rather nonsense game. Blind luck and bluffing wins, rather than any application of logic.”

“Heh, you’re only saying that because I beat you,” Phoenix chuckled.

"I–," Edgeworth grimaced, "well I concede that this sort of game fits your skillset more than mine."

"You wanna sit down?" Phoenix directed at Adora, "I hear enough of this guy at court. How do you know him, by the way?"

"At the prosecutors office," Adora explained as she took a seat, "I worked there a bit as you know, but I also went there a lot growing up because of Shadow Weaver."

That struck Adora with a thought. Edgeworth would know about the people at the office now. Perhaps she could ask him about Catra. She silently shook herself though. She came here to get away from all that.

"Angella tells me you're training has been progressing well," Edgeworth noted, "so I take if you're certain on your path now? No lingering doubts?"

"Yes," said Adora. It was the truth, or at least, the one she assumed. But then she found herself saying, "well, maybe. It's… hard to explain."

"What do you mean?" asked Phoenix.

"I don't want to go back to the prosecutor's office, and I know I'm doing the right thing by training to be She-Ra —uh, a defence attorney. But there was this… big thing guiding me for so long, the reason I was doing any of this —prosecutor or lawyer— and it's suddenly not as clear as I thought it was." She let out a sigh, "I wasn't supposed to get hung up on this, not tonight."

"I'm sure it's fine," said Phoenix, "just get some coffee, listen to the jazz. I hear that's a great way to push past the pain."

Edgeworth raise a solitary brow, "what sort of counsel are you getting?"

"Well clearly better than yours, considering your hang-ups."

“Wright, my acute anxiety about elevators is a trigger, not a hang-up. If you have a psychiatrist you should fire them immediately.”

Phoenix laughed, “come on, Edgeworth, raise or fold?”

“This is still an illogical game,” he muttered.

“Tell you what, you beat me in a single game, then I’ll agree to play you at chess.”

Edgeworth smirked, “interesting proposal. You’re on.”

Adora remained at the table, drawn into conversation with the other attorneys. The music and crowd swept around her such that nothing in particular could distract her. She didn’t even notice when Catra arrived.

Scorpia and the prosecutor arrived together. Catra’s gaze tracked across the room. Her nose wrinkled. There were many people, each in fantastic suits and dresses, well combed and well groomed all of them in their high manner. She had not bothered to change. She was already sharper than them all.

Not so much with the detective. She had given up her grungy police garb for something quite fetching; a dark dress of sequins, reflecting light with a iridescent glitter. Smiling always was Scorpia, who was warm to having Catra hanging her arm against her own, however lazily.

“Detective, glad you could come,” a bass-baritone voice called their attention. A black grey-haired man in a tuxedo and white gloves was approaching them and quickly took Scorpia’s claw for a firm handshake. “And prosecutor Catra no doubt. With so much law enforcement, should I be worried?”

“We’re off duty, mr. Singer!” Scorpia insisted. “We’re headed to the bar first. What do you recommend?”

“Order the single malt, they’ve got a good 17 year old number from Oregon. Aged in four barrels, cask strength, pungent on the

nose with the taste of ripe berries," he inhaled as if tasting it in the moment, then smiled, "but go easy on your first swig, it's 57% alcohol. But worry about that later. Catra, has the detective ever told you about that little business down at the Fright Zone club?"

Seeing the sudden sheepish look striking across Scorpia's face, Catra smirked and said, "no, she's failed to mention it. Should it have come up in the background checks?"

"Oh nothing to be ashamed of, quite the opposite," Singer laughed, "I worry our big friend here sells herself short. Come on, detective, why don't you sing our next piece."

"M-me?" still blushing, Scorpia almost fell back.

"You're a singer?" asked Catra.

"I, uh, dabble," Scorpia scratched her cheek, "but not in front of all these people when they're expecting *the* Chas Singer!"

"You're capable of it," Singer beamed up at her, "anyway I need to rest my voice. The upcoming "I Remember You" has some really adventurous trills, and a real tough one in my trumpet break."

"Why not," teased Catra, giving Scorpia a shove forward, "I wanna see what you've been holding out on."

Arms snapped to her side, Scorpia regarded the stage ahead of her, and gulped. However, brave as she was, she took a step forward and made her way up. She stood herself by the microphone. Saxaphones then began to hum at a fast pace, followed by a punctuated shake of brass. This cue was repeated, and suddenly the shaking detective murmured the opening lines.

It's too darn hot

It's too darn hot

I'd like to sup with my baby tonight.

Scorpia quickly looked to the side, perhaps hoping there was an emergency exit to run away. The bar or two of instrumental break fled by in a second and she found herself continuing her song. Catra watched smirking all the while.

Refill the cup with my baby tonight.

I'd like to sup with my baby tonight.

But I ain't up to my baby tonight.

'Cause it's too darn hot

A quick brass shake threw Scorpia into the second verse. Nerves seemed to have settled as she began to sway her arms and sing just a little louder. Even Catra started to tap her feet to the rhythm. Then the second verse ended with a shake, throwing the whole band into something raucous, and a new soul birthed from Scorpia voice as she sang:

According to the Kinsey Report, every average gal you know

Much prefers her lovey-dovey to court

When the temperature is low

But then the thermometer goes way up

And the weather is sizzling hot

Ms. Sweetling, for a swing, is not

Her voice was soaring now, and she threw some heavy-eyelid looks Catra's way. For the prosecutor's part, she was entranced in the scene, laughing and cheering at the performance. She calmed down into the third and fourth verse and considered grabbing drinks for her and Scorpia for when the song ended.

Then she saw the blonde girl.

All her previous thoughts left her. Even the song faded into white noise. Catra took on a new grin, but a much more inward one, the meaning of which only she would ever know.

She was going to have a lot of fun this evening.

As the song played, Chas Singer bobbed his way over to the bar, his fingers snapping without thought to the rhythm. Glimmer was still where she had been all night, and after getting his drink, the man frowned to see her.

“Everything alright, ms. Glimmer?” he asked.

“It’s fine.”

He shook his head, “I can tell when the mood is not with the music.”

“I shouldn’t be like this,” Glimmer sighed, “it’s not right.”

“Is this about the young gentlemen you came here with?”

“He came with someone else.”

“Ah, well, these things happen. It’s fine to feel a little guilty, you know. You just learn to take these things in stride.”

“But I should be happy for him,” she said, “he’s my best friend. For the longest time he was my only friend.”

“Well, no doubt you’re a little protective. Wasn’t there another one recently?”

Glimmer shook her head, feeling her throat dry up, “she’s dead.”

“That’s horrible. I think events have been stirring you up. That would make even a night like this hard to enjoy. I think losing her must make you want to hold tighter him, and that’s okay, even in friendship. He’ll understand.”

“I know,” she said, “but still I can’t help but want it to be… different from friendship.”

“Well let’s say things were different. Would that be good for you now? After losing someone so soon?”

Glimmer fell silent, staring into her empty cup.

“You’re punishing yourself. Just like me kicking back from the last song, you’ve gotta take a breather. And who knows, things are never set in stone. When you’re ready, maybe mr or mrs perfect will be right there waiting, whoever they may be.”

Rubbing her eyes with the palm of her hand, Glimmer nodded. She didn’t feel much better. She didn’t think anything could make her feel much better. But her chest was noticeably less tight, and she could bare to look up now. Singer was smiling a warm smile.

“I think you need a drink,” he said.

“I’m too young.”

“You’re a professional. I don’t care how old you are, you can take one drink. Anyway the detective is,” he gestured to the woman coming to the close of her song, “a little distracted. So you don’t tell anyone, and neither shall I. Then you go and have a great evening with your friends.”

“Okay,” Glimmer smiled weakly, “thanks, mr. Singer.”

Indeed, Adora had either decided she had forgiven Glimmer, or by now had forgotten about the kissing thing. She was wading through the floor crowd, trying to get a visual on her. But by now the amount of tipsy revellers and dancing couples was obscuring most everything from view.

Then a voice spoke from behind, “hey Adora,” and her heart stopped.

She whisked around. Catra was standing there, smile wide but eyebrows creased. The girl was unfastening her collar. Adora was stunned for words, frozen down to her fingertips, that she just watched without saying anything until Catra finished. She swept her hand to the side, throwing away her cape and jabot both, and leaving her jacket unbuttoned to show her gracile décolletage.

"Wh-what are you doing?" Adora stammered.

"Haven't you heard?" Catra crooned, "it's really damn hot in here."

As if an incantation, Catra's words became truth. Sweat caught on Adora's brow, and fire flashed beneath her cheeks. She grimaced.

"What the hell do you think you're doing?" she spat, "back in that trial you… you… you were horrible!"

Strings. Slow and soothing, they played a strange melody, wafting through uncertain chords and semitonal drops. There was no singing. The band was just playing, strings joined in with warm saxophones and a gentle piano.

Catra didn't respond to Adora's outburst. Instead, still wearing a smirk, she lay out her hand with a flourish. Adora didn't know why she took it, but she did. Catra pulled her in close, so their feet rested against one another, hands were clasped in each other's grip, with the other arm rested on the other's body.

They danced to the wordless song.

"What's your deal?" Adora asked again, quieter but between grit teeth.

"I don't know what you're talking about," Catra said cooly.

"Manipulating the trial, hiding the evidence," she listed off, "the whip!"

“Well I wasn’t going to go easy on you. I did what I needed to win.”

“This isn’t a game, Catra,” Adora said as they twirled about one another, “Sea Hawk was innocent. You were trying to put him in jail!”

“That’s my job, didn’t you know?” Catra tutted, “and I didn’t know he was innocent at the time. That’s what the court is for. Hey, I’m sorry if we got off the wrong foot here, but I don’t see why we can’t have a productive relationship as colleagues.”

“What about those things you said,” a taut pain tugged at Adora’s chest, “trying to undermine me.”

“Well I have to play up the ruthless prosecutor thing to the crowd. You’ve got to do your little underdog thing. That’s how it always is. No hard feelings?”

Suddenly the brass was in uproar. Trumpets in hazy thirds blared the melody as shaky trombones and crash cymbals punctuated the off-beats. Catra tugged Adora along, swinging her around. Adora’s legs seemed to be giving way, losing her footing, losing control. Yet the rhythm seemed to be filling her with movement, directed along by Catra, with one clawed hand enmeshed in her own, and the other gripping along the small of Adora’s back.

“But… how did you know?” Adora asked.

“Know what?”

“The…ugh,” Adora felt silly trying to recall, “you know what I’m talking about! Your whole opening testimony was directed at me.”

Catra shrugged, “not really. You defence attorney types are all the same. I prodded you the same I would any other. It’s not like I could do otherwise, I barely know you.”

“Barely know…,” Adora’s voice weakened, but she held it from cracking, “we were best friends, Catra!”

“That… was nine years ago,” Catra stated. “People change, Adora.”

“So you don’t know me?”

“I know one thing about you and one thing alone.”

She pulled Adora in with a sudden yank, bringing their faces together but for an inch of space. Her teasing purr mixed with Adora’s raggedy breath, and the latter girl watched with wide quivering eyes and a thumping heart.

Then Catra leaned forward and to the side, her hair brushing across Adora’s cheek. Reaching up to her ear, she whispered:

“You’re *sooo* easily wound up.”

Adora shoved her, pushing her away. She turned and walked off, followed only by the sound of Catra’s laughter. The sound of it was like an icy dagger stabbing her in the back, even though she was hot by the halter-collar of her dress. Her throat was tight, and her temples ached as if something were pressing them inwards, drilling into her skull.

She made it back to the bar where Glimmer and Bow sat. Falling onto a stool next to them in a slump, she stayed there scowling out to the stage, planting her head into a propped hand.

“What’s it with girls and toying with me?” she muttered, massaging her head.

“Look I’m sorry about earlier!” Glimmer said with pleading tone.

Bow looked from one to the other.

“Uh did something happen?”

“N-nothing,” Glimmer said, suddenly sitting up straight and a blush come upon her face.

The double bass plucked up. With harmony picking up on every off-beat, a piano improvised above it all. Another song began. It was Chas Singer, back on stage and singing deep, quiet, both dirge-y and rhythmic.

When Israel was in Egypt's land

Let my people go!

Oppressed so hard they could not stand

Let my people go!

Adora calmed down and soon explained what had just happened to the others. It served plenty distraction from Glimmer's own troubles and Bow listened with an unsure expression.

"Perhaps she was being sincere?" he suggested, "if she wants to work better with you that can't hurt right?"

"No, she can't be trusted," Glimmer said, "the only reason she'd approach you is if she had some ulterior motive."

And the Lord Said Go down,

"But what would it even be?" asked Bow, "she's just a prosecutor, she's not some mastermind."

Moses

"She said it herself," Glimmer argued, "she's trying to screw Adora over by exploiting her confused feelings."

Way down in Egypt land!

Tell old,

"Wait, hang on," Adora stood up abruptly, for reasons even she didn't understand, "I don't have confused feelings for Catra—over Catra! Wait, I mean—" She sat herself down, "I said over Catra."

Pharoah

To Let My People Go!

Go Down—

Before either Glimmer, Bow, Adora or even the players nor Singer himself could continue, there was a loud crash. Something above had splintered and cracked. A black mass plummeted and struck the stage. Singer fell backwards.

Music was replaced with mutters and confusion from the crowd. Then someone screamed.

They had seen the dead body.

Chapter End Notes

> An excuse to throw in some jazz. Obviously Scorpia had to sing. Plus a whole lot of character drama.
>
> For once I'm actually ahead (in a relativistic sense.) I've got the next two chapters nearly ready, so I'm hoping to release them quite soon after this one. Together these three form the third episode.

The Blonde Girl and the Cat

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Alright nobody panic!" Scorpia said a loud, gruff voice, having commandeered the microphone. "I've called backup and emergency services. Everything is under control."

Worry held a firm grip over the crowd at the Princess Promenade. It spilled over into fear when what was happening became clear. A man had fallen from rafters. He was dead. Most assumed it was accident, but that didn't mean the shock of it was any less. Chas Singer had passed out and was currently being nursed by his bandmates. Collectively people seemed willing to sit quiet until the services arrived.

Others was dissatisfied, however. Edgeworth for one went up to check the body, and called over Bow to assist him.

"I want to you to ascertain the time of death as best as you can."

"You don't think it was the fall, prosecutor?"

"I think nothing until we have the right evidence," Edgeworth affirmed, "let's make sure we have every detail right."

Adora meanwhile rushed to the exit. Opening the door she was greeted to a barrage of rain. Storm clouds had gathered and the evening air was so grey she couldn't make out most of the alley ahead of her. She peered to the end, trying to make out the opening to the street. Her shoulders slumped, and she let out a groan.

"Damnit."

"What do you read?" came the voice of Scorpia behind her, raised to be heard over the downpour.

“The road’s blocked by a tree,” Adora shouted back, “I think the storm must have knocked it over,” she looked up at the big detective, “we could go over and try budge it?”

Scorpia shook her head, “just got word from the squads. The roads are blocked anyway and I don’t think we’re getting help for an hour or so.”

“So no-one’s coming in?”

“And no-one’s getting out. I guess we gotta do what we can in the meantime.”

The two returned to the floor, thankfully warmer and quieter than the outside. There they were met by the other prosecutor, who had put back on her ruffles and cape.

“This is a murder,” Catra said. “Detective, round up everyone and make sure every individual is accounted for. Then block off the exits.”

With that, she swirled around and left. Apprehensive, Adora watched her go. It was hard to push away what had just happened from her mind, even with a murder on their hands.

She was so lost in her thoughts that things fell into a whir. Scorpia was to do as Catra ordered, but before she did she sent Adora and Glimmer to go check behind the stage area for anyone not in the main hall. The two went, and found a few stragglers, sending them back as asked.

The backstage corridor had no tufted walls or dark ambience. It was lit by harsh cool light, bright grey by the hard concrete floor, and a chill bit the air. No-one was back here.

Adora and Glimmer were about to turn back, when something dark caught on the latter’s shoe, and she picked it up. It was a sheathe of fine velvet.

“What is it?”

“I think it’s a cloak,” said Glimmer, spreading the fabric out, “maybe it belongs to one of the players.”

“Or maybe the murderer,” Adora mused. “Anything could be a clue. And we’re stuck in with whoever did it. It’s like uh, a Sherlock Holmes, right?”

“Herlock,” Glimmer correct, “Sherlock is the public domain character, since the Wilson estate still owns the rights. Anyway, this is more like Inspector Voirot.”

Adora furrowed her brow, wondering if this was Glimmer being the know-it-all or Adora being out of touch again. But then the sound of a yawn from behind one of the doors cut the conversation short.

The two girls shared a look. They hadn’t checked that room. Adora went ahead and turned the handle. It wouldn’t shift. She yanked it to the side and slammed herself into the door. With that, it gave way and Adora stumbled into the room. But she quickly hoisted herself up again, having come face to face with the occupant, a person who was now watching them with an amused look.

“Well it was about time someone came looking for me,” they said in a delectable manner of speaking.

“Who are you?” Glimmer said coming in after Adora.

“Oh my name is long and hard to remember, but I’m sure my stage name will stay with you. I’m Double Trouble.”

‘Double Trouble’ was a lanky green fellow with wide yellow eyes and eldritch ears, and an imperishable smile hanging on their mouth. They wore an elegant black bodysuit with heels, and had windswept peroxide hair which they gave a flick as they came to stand.

“You’re a performer?” asked Adora, “why weren’t you on tonight?”

“I was supposed to be on after ‘Go Down Moses’, but I seem to have missed that. Well, the door was stuck, as you just saw. Could never open it from the inside so I was waiting for some intrepid rescuers. Then you came along.”

“So you don’t know about the murder?”

Double Trouble gaped and held their hand to their mouth. Although then they let out a groaning sound and what might have passed for a gasp quickly became a yawn.

“Oh dear. Well I don’t know anything about that. I’ve been here the whole time. Chas was supposed to come get me out, but he never showed.”

“Mr. Singer?” Glimmer said, concern creeping into her voice.

“Maybe he’s woken by now,” said Adora, “we should check with him. Maybe he saw something.”

“He might have,” Double Trouble chimed in, “Charles is always getting into places where he shouldn’t.”

“What’s that supposed to mean?” asked Glimmer.

The person grinned, “oh, just insider gossip.”

Adora and Glimmer shared a look, before looking back at them decidedly unimpressed.

“Come on, diva,” said Glimmer, “into the main hall with everyone else.”

They themselves went there as well, greeted again by the low-lit ambience of the hall —although this was unsettling rather than soothing by now. Glimmer checked on Bow, who was still looking over the body. Chas Singer was still out cold nearby. Meanwhile, Adora’s attention was drawn to the sounds of arguing by the tables.

“I’m telling you, we don’t need more hands on this! Butt out.”

“Hold your tone, prosecutor, I can pull rank if I must.”

Adora asked, “what’s going on?” as she came up to the two prosecutors staring each other off.

Before Catra could tell Adora to butt out as well, Edgeworth quickly explained:

“I don’t take kindly to being frozen out of an investigation, especially for a murder that took place before my very eyes.”

“I can handle this without meddling,” Catra fired back.

“No way am I letting you look at everything unsupervised,” Adora blurted out, so fast and so sudden that it caught Catra’s tongue in her mouth.

The other girl stared back at Adora with a look of fury first but then morphing into one of sullen calm.

“Hmm,” Edgeworth looked at the two of them, though he kept his thoughts of the pair to himself. Instead he said, “if Adora were keeping an eye on your investigation, making sure everything’s thorough, then perhaps I can be satisfied with that.”

Catra growled, though she did not look at either Adora or Edgeworth directly.

“I’m a prosecutor, she’s a defence attorney,” she said, marvelling that she had to explain such obviousness.

“I’m aware,” Edgeworth said, “but she was a prosecutor until recently. I know her quality, and the quality of her mentor.”

There was a lot that Catra would like to say to that. Even just to vent the gnawing fire in her chest by talking to herself, with no-one to listen. But she kept these words to herself.

“Fine.Tthe blonde girl can come. But this is my investigation,” she shot at Adora.

“Permit me to at least check the victim’s background,” said Edgeworth, “the crime scene is yours.”

Adora remained silent for the most part in the following ten minutes. She merely watched as Catra ordered Scorpia to check the alibis of those who were in the hall. The prosecutor herself then cycled through those stragglers that Adora and Glimmer had found in the backstage area. She moved through them with efficiency, menacing them into talking even with her whip left back at home.

Then they went to Bow. From somewhere he had conjured tape and was just finishing lining it around the body when Catra demanded his preliminary report.

“Blunt force trauma to the head,” he cited, “multiple contusions, although quite precise. I don’t think the victim had much time to resist, and the killer knew what they were doing. There is some extra bruising from the fall but those were after death.”

“Time of death?” asked Catra.

“A while before the fall, though not too long. Main thing is he didn’t die during the ‘Go Down Moses’ but during ‘I Remember You’.”

A prickling sensation burned across Adora’s face at that. The memory of Catra pulling her into the dance was seared on her mind. She looked up to the ceiling, letting out a heavy sigh. She stared up for a while, as the sound of Catra consulting with Scorpia’s findings blurred into the background.

There were beams of wood. They lined the whole upper space of the hall, intersected with rods of steel from which the lights hung. Though it was hard to make out fully, one of the beams in the rafters looked askew. The sound of splintering and cracking

echoed in her mind, and she suddenly looked down again, eyes wide and clarity filling her head.

"Catra," she said, "we should check the rafters. The body fell from there so the crime scene must be there too."

Catra craned her neck and surveyed the beams.

"You got a ladder?" she remarked.

"There must be a way up. Let's check backstage."

The prosecutor looked at Adora with narrow eyes, but followed with an acquiescent shrug. They went through the backstage corridor and indeed found a well of metal-grate stairs that led up to the rafters.

Chill gave way to literal frost. In her sleeveless red dress Adora shivered violently and the clattering of her teeth resounded inside her skull.

"H-h-how can it be so hot down there and freezing here?" she managed to say.

"Maybe it's so cold up here because it is hot down there."

"Why can't it be warm? What's wrong with warm?"

Catra looked at Adora and the two met eyes. Adora was pathetic, shaking, rubbing her hands against her arms. With a short sigh, Catra reached for her neck and unhooked her cape. Then she swept it around wrapping it about Adora's arms. It wasn't fur or anything, but it did stave off the bite.

Adora stopped shaking but her eyes remained with a quiver as they regarded the other girl.

"Ugh," groaned Catra, "don't make a big thing about it. Let's just look at this crime scene."

The first thing to catch their eye was a loose iron pipe, laid across a small patch of frost. It was bone cold to the touch, but Catra gripped it nonetheless and brought it up for a closer view. She gave it a swing in the air, landing it clean into her other palm with a satisfying clap.

“We have our murder weapon,” she smiled.

“How did no-one notice?” Adora wondered, sizing the pipe up, “just the thunk or the victim’s scream and someone would have looked up and see the murder happen.”

“I remember you.”

“Wh-what?”

“The song, remember. It had a big middle section. Loud enough to cover any distant sound, clearly. Thing is,” Catra slid a finger down the length of the pipe, “that song doesn’t usually have a bombastic middle. This was a specific rendition. It was written that way for *this* night only.”

Pulling her cheek, Adora looked around the rafters.

“Was everything planned?” she muttered, mostly to herself, “but why would they… unless....”

She saw it. The beam out of place she’d seen not a few minutes before from the other angle. It was broken and splintered. Kneeling down, Adora went to have a look.

“If the victim died during I remember you, why was there a delay until he fell?” she wondered aloud.

“As if you’re going to find anything,” Catra snorted. “You look ridiculous.”

“At least I’m not wearing ruffles,” Adora retorted.

“It’s a jabot, it’s dignified.”

“Catra, you’re a whole world away from dignif—aagh!”

“Adora!”

Catra had almost screamed it. Feline reflexes took hold of her every nerve and she pounced forward. The beam lurched down. Adora slipped.

Eyes shut, Adora braced for the fall. But she had stopped, mid air. She looked up, daring to open her eyes again, and saw Catra. The other girl had her grabbed by the arm, with her feet dug into the remaining beam, and her tail held out for counterbalance. Then she took Adora with her other hand and pulled her up, until she was safely back onto the rafter. Stood, safely, in Catra’s arms.

They stared into each others’ eyes for just a few moments. Then Catra shoved her away and shouted:

“Idiot! What the hell were you doing?”

But her face was not one of anger, but the leftover terror that her flurried through her during that brief danger. And even that was breaking into smiles as the adrenaline rushed through her. Adora matched it. Suddenly they were just laughing.

They were laughing! Adora didn’t even know what happened, it had all flown by so quickly. Even this was just a fleeting moment as the two girls remembered who they were, who the other was, and the situation they were in. They stifled themselves, although the cold air could not undo the warm feeling inside them both.

“Maybe we should—”

“Do you remember the stuff we got up to?” Adora asked rapidly, “like, like, that time I fell from a tree because I thought I could land on my feet like you?”

Catra spat out laughing. She had remembered, and now the memory appeared to her, strikingly vivid.

“No,” she wheezed, “no, I don’t.”

“You do!” Adora smiled.

“Okay,” Catra conceded. “Didn’t I break my arm too one time?”

“I think you were trying to break my fall.”

“Then we went back home as a pile of fractures and Shadow Weaver was mad.”

“We were grounded for months at a time,” Adora chuckled, “but that just wouldn’t stop us.” She paused for a second. Then she threw Catra a wistful smile and said, “I really miss those times, you know?”

“I…,” Catra caught herself on her words and mouthed for a second before shoving Adora again and looking decidedly the other way, “shut up. I don’t miss you at all. And things are way better now.”

At this height, the heavy patter of rain as it hit the roof was clear, although muffled through the layers of ceiling. Adora sat down on one of the more secure beams, letting her legs dangle in the air. Her head was still a little dizzy, and her heart pumped from the near-miss fall. Catra came to sit —or rather perch herself with knees hugged in tight— by Adora’s side, though angled outwards so as not to face her.

“Would...,” Catra drew in a sharp intake of breath and spoke again, “would you have stayed? At the prosecutor’s office. If you knew I was coming?”

The obvious answer would have been no. People didn’t shift careers or not because of friends they hadn’t seen in a decade. But Adora couldn’t say anything right away. The truth was she didn’t know. Over the past few weeks, ever since Catra reappeared in her life, confusing feelings had surrounded Adora, submerging her, distracting her from every present moment and replacing every certainty with a question.

But then, Adora said, “probably not.”

Catra was taken aback. So was Adora. Even she hadn’t expected herself to say that.

The other girl buried her head into her arms so her mouth was muffled when she asked, “why’d you even make the change anyway?”

“I had to,” Adora said, “I almost put an innocent woman in jail. She’s now my friend.”

“Your friend….”

“Now I know how corrupt the justice system is here, I can’t go back. Especially since I’m this She-Ra thing. This must be what I’m meant to do.”

“Ugh,” Catra groaned, “why’d you always have to be so perfect.”

“I’m not perfect.”

But she was. Catra’s face darkened though Adora could not see it. She tightened her grip on her own arms, claws digging into the fabric of her jacket.

Why did Adora have to be perfect?

“What about you?” Adora said, looking up with a sudden starlight in her eyes, “you could always… I mean, what if you joined me? You don’t have to be a prosecutor.”

“What?” Catra looked up at her, twisting her face into bemusement, “don’t be ridiculous.”

“It’s not ridiculous!”

“Come on, you blundered through you’re last two trials and got lucky. I’m good but I’m never gonna win as a defence attorney.”

“But—”

“Look,” said Catra, “you wanna throw away a great opportunity, fine. But I don’t have to be like you.”

“Okay, okay, forget I asked!”Adora stood up, “we should probably get back to the investigation anyway.”

Catra gave a sullen nod, said “sure,” and then they were making their way back downstairs.

After the freeze up in the rafters, the main hall was blistering, and Adora handed Catra her cape back. Just well that she did, since Catra reassumed her menacing demeanour, and the high collar of the cape worked well for that.

“Detective, report on those alibis,” she barked at Scorpia, who was stood near the stage with Bow.

“Nearly everyone is accounted for, sir. Mr. Singer hasn’t woken up so we haven’t talked to him.”

“Has anyone seen anything?” asked Adora, “potential witnesses?”

“Mr. Wright saw someone with a velvet cloak pass down the corridor while going to the bathroom. I’ve just had the forensic investigator look for any skin samples on the cloak, but nothing.”

“There are some hairs,” Bow chimed in, “but I can’t seem to get any positives on them.”

“Tell him the check the murder weapon,” Catra said, tossing the pipe over. It bounced between Scorpia’s clumsy claws but she was able to just catch it between them. “I don’t expect any prints, though. Our murderer has been very thorough.”

Adora scanned the room. Most people were calm now, although nervousness drenched the air. The killer was still among them. That fact wasn’t lost on any of them, although one in particular seemed quite as ease with the whole situation.

Feet kicked up and sipping from a martini glass, Double Trouble was unfazed by the general mood. Adora knitted her brow.

“Did you ask any questions to that performer, detective?” she asked, looking to Scorpia.

“Uh, no,” said Scorpia, “they were locked in their dressing room so their alibi seemed pretty strong.”

“Yet that means they were backstage the whole time,” Catra mused, “we should make sure they didn’t hear anything of interest.”

So Catra went forward, with Adora following, and they sat themselves across the green minstrel.

Eyeing them, Double Trouble gave a broad sharp-tooth smile and said, “I hope you don’t mind me hitting bar,” they shook their glass, “didn’t get much chance earlier.”

“You were backstage all night?” Catra enquired.

“I believe I was in there from 9:20 until little blondey here rescued me. But I don’t complain. Makeup is so laborious.”

“What exactly were you here for?” asked Adora, “you’re not part of the band, right?”

Double Trouble tittered, “oh, Charles had me in to to give a comedy routine. Dreadful really, I’m much better for drama. But hey, it’s good pay so I wasn’t going to turn it down.”

“You’re a comic?” Catra raised her brow.

“I’m very good at impressions,” they said. Then, taking on a sudden stern face, they said in a voice unlike their own, “ugh, I’m running an investigation and I don’t know if this get-up is poncey enough to be taken seriously as a prosecutor!”

Adora couldn't help but laugh. Catra was scandalised by having to hear her own voice thrown back at her.

"Hey! Stop that," she protested so loudly her voice broke.

"Just don't ask me to do that other prosecutor right now," Double Trouble said, back in their own sultry voice, "I'm not sure yet if it's meant to be an English accent or Mid-Atlantic. And I prefer to be precise."

"And you're saying you couldn't leave at all throughout the evening?" Adora leaned over the table as if it were her court bench.

"That's right."

"No-one can corroborate, though, can they. For all we know someone might have let you out, and then you went back in before we found you?"

"Fancy idea," Double Trouble grinned, "although I wonder what you're getting at. Still, that's not what happened. Ask any of the band, ask anyone here. No-one will say they let me out, because it was Chas who was supposed to. Unfortunately he never showed."

"Wait, what?"

The mimic shrugged, "the plan was that he was supposed to open the door and let me out before he went on to do 'I Remember You.' Then I get ready to do my set after 'Go Down Moses.'"

"Objection," the word sprung from her mouth automatically, "'I Remember you ' didn't have a singer, it was an instrumental."

"It usually does have a singer," Catra murmured, "I thought it kinda strange when it played without one."

Double Trouble leaned their head on their hand, and crooned, "sounds like our prosecutor here knows her jazz."

Catra sat a little straighter and said, “no. Singer told me he was going to be singing that song earlier. That’s how I knew.”

“Well either way, you have a little mystery. Where was Charles? He didn’t show up for me or for the song.”

Adora stared at the person with narrowing eyes. They just looked with that lingering smile. Then they added:

“Perhaps he went to his own dressing room?”

“Did you hear him? Footsteps?”

“Not really, the backstage speakers blare out the live recording from the hall. But it’s the only place I can imagine he’d go. No reason to go up to the rafters, right?”

“We’ll go check his dressing room then,” Catra said, standing up, “thank you for your time.”

“Wait, Catra,” Adora stood up, as Catra was now heading off. “You don’t actually think it was Singer, do you? This witness is clearly… well, I don’t know, but it’s not gonna be Singer. He was more shocked than anyone with what happened.

Without turning back, Catra just said, “we don’t have many leads, we have to follow every one.”

Adora sighed, but followed. The path took them back into the backstage corridor, going past Double Trouble’s dresser but short of the stairwell. Taking the left, they ended up in another dressing room. It was still lit by the row of bulbs around the mirror, and a lineup of pressed tuxedos hung on the wall, each as fine as the last.

“Okay,” said Adora, “so we just need some evidence to show he was here, right? So what if he didn’t show up for the song, he still couldn’t beat a man from a different room.”

“There’ll be plenty to show he was here,” Catra noted, “but timing him to ‘I remember you’ won’t be so easy. If there’s nothing… well, we’ll get to that later.”

Suddenly, Catra dropped to the floor. Adora watched with blinking eyes as the feline started tracking along the carpet, incessantly sniffing. Her mouth twisted a little:

“Uh, remember what I said about dignified?”

“Yeah, just before you fell off a beam,” Catra retorted.

“And you saved me,” Adora admitted, “I guess I didn’t even thank you for that.”

“Heh, how rude of you.”

“Well, thanks for catching me,” Adora said, finding that saying this brought back a little of that warm feeling in her gullet from earlier.

She turned and started to trawl along the walls, marvelling at the tuxes, and eventually making her way to the counter, adorned with brushes and salves —though little in the way of hard evidence. Catra meanwhile continued her scouring of the floor, though it was too spotless to note.

Then a glint caught her eye. It came from the shadow beneath the counter. She crawled over and took it into hand. It was a watch, gold, and weighty to the touch. She was about to inspect it, but then Adora spoke again, asking a question that ripped Catra’s full attention away:

“What happened nine years ago?” Adora’s breath grew heavy as she asked the question, but she persisted, “just, one day you disappeared. Shadow Weaver refused to say anything about it, like you never even existed.”

Catra stood up. She faced Adora, and upon her brow was a heavy feeling, and her lip could almost quiver. Her gaze couldn’t quite

meet Adora's, so she just stared ahead at her neck.

But then she shrugged, and muttered, "eh, she would like that."

Adora tilted her head, "would? You're still in contact with Shadow Weaver?"

"Obviously, Adora!" Catra raised her voice, "I didn't stop being her ward."

"But I thought she sent you away…."

"She did, but no matter how much she wanted it she couldn't get rid of me. I did everything I could to prove myself. Studying, law school, the bar, everything I could so I'd be a worthy prosecutor." She shot a look directly at Adora. Thin pupils and a twisted cheek, and the shadow of a sneer. "Then there's you. I can't even believe it, that you'd leave everything when you didn't even have to fight that hard to get it. Just to be some sort of hero. Why! Why did you do it?"

"I meant what I said," Adora shouted back, "it was the right thing to do!"

Catra's grimace flashed deeper across her face. Though Adora didn't quite realise it, 'right thing' was the wrong thing to say.

Then Adora took a deep breath to steady herself, and added, "there was one other thing I didn't tell you. I wanted to become a defence attorney because of a promise I made. I promised I'd help someone and I thought I could better do it as a defence attorney —I know it doesn't make sense, it's more of a feeling than anything logical. But I promised."

What Catra would have liked to say was 'what are your promises worth' but she held back. Indeed, she had promised herself that she wouldn't let any of this happen. She shouldn't have allowed Adora to come with her on this investigation. She couldn't be unravelled like this.

So instead, Catra hoisted a smirk, and said, “there it is. Hopelessly naive, that’s just so you.”

“Wh-what?” said Adora, “what do you mean?”

“The only way to help anyone is to make sure every criminal you find is put behind bars.”

Adora watched Catra for a few moments, expectant. But there was no further discussion. The room was clean anyway, so it was time to go.

They returned to the main hall once again, which had started to thin out on people, and those that remained were in uniform — the police who had just arrived. Singer was awake although holding an icepack to his head. Adora thought to approach but they were cut off by an inquisitive Edgeworth.

“What have you found?”

“Little,” Adora said, “Bow’s got the murder weapon and Scorpia’s checked for alibis. Only one unaccounted for is Singer. Did you get anything on the victim?”

“Yes, ID’d as Ma-Nan Jia. He runs the Princess Promenade from out of the limelight. Usually only comes during the day, so it’s odd that he was here tonight at all.”

Catra wasn’t contributing to this discussion. She hovered a little ways back from Adora, silent and without thought until she remembered the gold clutched in her hand. Laying it out on her palm, she looked at it. It had a rippled, segmented look, apart from the face of some black quartz. The glass was cracked, now that she saw it. The hands were stopped. 9:33 was the time. That would have been during the ‘I remember you.’ When she and Adora were dancing.

A smile touched her lips.

“The trombonist saw him I believe,” Edgeworth was saying, “last night, during an argument with mr. Singer over contract negotiations. No-one had seen him since.”

“They had an argument?” said Adora.

“More of a shouting session from Ma-Nan’s end. Consensus is he was a rather contentious person.”

Edgeworth and Adora. Adora and Edgeworth. They were both even wearing a similar shade of red. Catra’s face fell flat watching them talk. They were both as naive as the other.

Indeed, whispers flurried fast at the prosecutor’s office, such that even a newbie like Catra could hear them. Edgeworth’s working relationship with Phoenix Wright was all too well-known. They had a bond. Even across court, they trusted one another.

Edgeworth was weak. How many times had he left a perfect case flee his hands? Given the defence leeway to bluff and bluster their client out of trouble.

Because of his dumb trusting nature.

Catra slipped the watch deep, deep into her pocket.

Then she said, “I know what happened now. We can wrap this investigation up.” She looked over to Scorpia among the other police who had gathered. “Arrest Chas Singer on suspicion for the murder of Ma-Nan Jia.”

Scorpia mouthed for a second, blinking. But she got her poise and sent the officers to grab the still-dazed singer. He offered little resistance. Adora meanwhile gaped as the scene unfolded.

“On what grounds are you basing this suspicion?” Edgeworth said, folding his arms.

“I’m not getting into one of your arguments, high prosecutor,” said Catra in a cool tone, “the time for it is the court.”

“You must have some reason for an arrest, I just want to hear it.”

“It’s easy,” she said, “he has no alibi for when the murder took place, virtually the only one here who doesn’t. You have just described a valid motivation —contract disagreements. Oh, and that cloak you picked up,” she directed at Adora, “the one from Mr. Wright’s mystery person? That belongs to Singer as well.”

“What!” Adora exclaimed, “but there weren’t any skin traces. You couldn’t possibly know who it belongs! to”

Catra merely tapped the end of her nose and said, “I’ve got a good sense of smell.”

Adora held a fixed clenched look at Catra. As she tried but failed to read what was going on beneath Catra’s smug smile, Catra saw every confused thought and feeling from the subtleties of the Adora’s face, and reading it all began to chuckle:

“Well, see ya in court.”

“What?” Adora shrunk backward, “how did you know I was going to—”

“Just a guess,” Catra shrugged, not letting her mocking smile falter, “after all,” she turned and began to walk away, “I don’t know you at all.”

Chapter End Notes

> 'There was only one bed' trope but it's an investigation which they have to share :)
>
> Drama's brewing up for the next chapter, which will conclude this episode. It's already written so I just need a few edits and it'll be up in a few days.

Turnabout Jazz

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Detention did not suit Chas Singer. The man was made for the stage, projecting out in his bass-baritone, or fingering away on a trumpet. Now his fingers rustled against one another, or rubbed at his wrists or neck. It was a sore sight for Adora, Glimmer and Bow.

“Are you holding up well?” asked Glimmer.

“No worse than when I have to play Detroit,” he said, cracking a heroic but ultimately weak smile. “At least I can make a career move. Prison work songs ain’t so different from jazz.”

“You didn’t kill Ma-Nan Jia, right?” Adora took the seat directly facing the accused across the glass-pane.

“I’m no killer,” Singer said, in a deep solemn voice, “I may have had disagreements with the man but Jia paid me, to kill him served me no end. And more than that, he was another human with a soul. That’s something no anger in me could compel to destroy.”

“R-right,” said Adora, “well, I believe you. But I need you to answer some questions before I can defend you. Why didn’t you free Double Trouble from their dressing room like you promised?”

“I was in a rush,” he explained, “I had to get back to my own dressing room, and it all pushed that obligation out of my mind. I hope they ain’t too displeased with me over that.”

“We checked your room,” Adora hung her head, “we couldn’t find anything. Catra thinks that means you weren’t there.”

“That doesn’t mean much,” Singer waved a hand away, “I don’t always go dropping evidence to prove I’m in every room I’m ever in. Surely you’ve got something to prove my innocence?”

Adora wouldn’t meet his eye. Singer’s expression fell, and he looked to Bow.

“Brother, you were looking at the pipe, right? The real murderer’s prints must be on there!”

Bow shook his head, “I couldn’t find any prints. The prosecution thinks that means it was you wearing gloves.”

As if to believe the words he was hearing, Singer looked to his own gloved palms. Brow furrowed, he looked like he was on the verge on some terrible collapse. But then laughter, albeit a strained one, broke across his face.

“You know I don’t usually wear these. Jia wanted me to put them on for last night’s performance. He came up just before the show began —very unusual, you know.”

“Why would he do that?” Glimmer wondered.

“Perhaps we’ll never know now,” he sighed, “fate is a strange game of dice.”

Adora turned to Bow, and asked, “what about those hair traces? Was there anything there?’

Bow shook his head, “negatives. Not Singer nor anyone else. They might just be dust caught while it was on the floor.”

“It couldn’t be anything else?”

“My pad is pretty good at picking up dna, although hair tends to have very little in itself. Bleaching is enough to destroy it.”

“Slightly reassuring,” said Singer, stroking his low grizzled hair, “all natural colouring here.”

“Not enough to prove it wasn’t you in the cloak, I’m afraid.”

Indeed, despite all their wrangling, none of the four of them could think of a good angle. Before they knew, it was time to go. Detention would be closing up soon, so the three said their farewell and promised what they could to Singer before turning to leave. Yet as they reached the door, the man called back.

“Adora? Could you wait, I’d like to speak to you alone for a second.”

Adora shared a look with the others, who nodded and took their leave. She returned to the seat. There was a twinkling look caught in Singer’s eye as he watched her. Tentative, he asked:

“The prosecution… it’s that Catra girl, isn’t it?”

Adora nodded.

“I met her briefly that night. Now I don’t mind uncomplicated people, but you meet them and you’re like ‘yeah, this person is exactly as they read.’ But then there are people you meet and you know there’s so much more underneath, buried that maybe they don’t know what’s going on.”

Adora’s eyes lit up. But then the weight of her limbs pulled her shoulders down and she could not sustain a fool’s hope.

“I don’t know, mr. Singer. Catra wants to win. We’re going to have to give it our all to beat her.”

“You have a thing for each other, right?”

“What?” a familiar prickle itched her cheek, “what do you mean?”

“I saw you two dancing,” he wore a knowing grin, “just before I left the hall. Man those were some sparks —fireworks! You could see it a mile away.”

“Those were sparks alright,” Adora muttered, “she’s got a drive. She’s determined to defeat me. But I won’t go down quickly.”

“There’s more to it, isn’t there? You carry the weight of an old friendship.”

“That was a long time ago. It shouldn’t matter.” She sighed, “and yet it feels like she’s known me my whole life. I don’t know why this is so… so….”

“Overwhelming?”

“Yeah,” said Adora. “You know, Glimmer and Bow don’t know. I haven’t told anyone that I used to know Catra. She wasn’t… she wasn’t like *that* back then, right? The Catra from my past, and the Catra I see now… how can one person be someone else?”

“You think she’s not the same person anymore?”

Adora couldn’t answer.

Singer shook his head, “it would certainly be easier that way. But easy isn’t always right. You might find she’s every bit as confused and scared as you are.”

“Maybe,” Adora whispered, “but she is a prosecutor. I’m a defence attorney. That’s how things are now.”

Singer smiled. Not a weak or queasy smile but deep and warm.

He shook his head, saying, “those are but titles. The battles lines are not between forces of good or evil, but between our better and worse natures. Maybe your friend is gone. Who knows? But if her memory remains in your heart, then that’s good enough, I say. ”

Night passed, rough and with another bout of the rain such as had held them locked in at the Promenade. Yet the next day hastened and it was no time at all before Adora found herself behind the defence bench. Catra was facing across from her.

“The trial for Charles Singer is now in session,” the Judge was saying, “are the defence and prosecution ready?”

“The prosecution is always ready,” said Catra, stroking her whip now in hand, “I wouldn’t be so sure about the defence.”

“I’m— I mean the defence is ready!”

The Judge looked ponderously at Catra, saying, “I hope your opening statement will be a little more illuminating this time. I’ve heard so many good things about the defendant. I find it hard to believe he would murder someone.”

“The evidence is clear,” she said, “Chas Singer struck his own manager with a lead pipe. He did it during the performance of ‘I Remember you, ‘specifically written to cover the sound of his crime. Here’s the lead-sheet.”

She provided the court with a scrap of paper, etched with many small rounded notes. Across the middle eight was scratched a whole new section. So Catra had been right about the expanded brass.

“This was pre-meditated murder, and the world will only be safer once the criminal is locked away.” She shot a look directly at Adora, “this trial will be decided in only an hour or so.”

Adora gripped the table. She stared back as fierce in eye as she could. But Catra merely tittered and turned to called the first witness.

Detective Scorpia took the stand. Expression stony, Scorpia just about concealed the glum that otherwise weighed down her shoulders. Yet she went through her testimony all the same:

“There were four songs performed between 9:15 and 9:45. ‘We’re in the Money,’ ‘It’s Too Darn Hot,’ ‘I Remember You’ and ‘Go Down Moses.’ The body fell onto the stage during the last song.”

“Hold it,” interjected Adora, “are you sure about that order of events? Maybe the body fell during a different song?”

“I mean… you were there?”

“Interesting new strategy,” Catra laughed, “but tell us, since you were witness to the same events. What song did the body fall down in?”

“….the ‘Go Down Moses,’” Adora conceded in a small voice.

“Adora, think before you press on the statements,” Glimmer sighed.

“It’s important to note,” Scorpia continued, “that mr. Singer only performed the first and last song of this set. After a conversation with one of the attendees at the bar, his movements aren’t accounted for.”

“Hold it,” Adora said again, “if he didn’t sing the middle two songs, who did?”

“Adora,” Glimmer groaned.

“Uh, well the I Remember You was an instrumental,” Scorpia recounted, “and I sang the It’s Too Darn Hot.”

“Well,” Adora said in a loud frayed voice. Stuck for words, she blurted, “well you were real good at it!”

Scorpia smiled, “aw, thanks.”

“Is this exactly relevant?” raising an eyebrow, Catra glared at the detective.

“Well can we verify this?” asked the Judge, looking to the prosecutor, “you were there, weren’t you ms. Catra. Was the detective’s performance good?”

“I—” Catra stammered, “I, well, sure. Yeah, it was lovely, you really nailed it.”

“Aww!” Scorpia held their pincers to their mouth as their eyes sparkled with adoration, “you really mean that, boss?”

Blushing, Catra shouted, “get on the testimony, what am I paying you for?”

Scorpia regained herself and continued, reiterating the fact about the edited score. Only a few performers saw the forte section, so only they could have timed a murder to happen during it. Among them, only Singer was absent from the stage during the song.

“But to throw off suspicion, he set it up so the victim would fall off the rafters during the Go Down Moses, where he’d more clearly have an alibi.”

“We know for certain he died during the ‘I Remember you?’” asked Adora.

“Your friend did the initial look-over, and our forensic team confirmed the time in the report,” Scorpia drew out the manila folder as she explained this.

The Judge nodded and accepted the autopsy report into the court record. But Adora was left in thought. The notated music sheet was on the evidence bench and it drew her eye, followed by what was just said about the order of events and the wheels of her mind began to turn.

“Isn’t it strange?” she wondered aloud now, “the killer went through all this trouble to screen the murder itself, and make it look like he had an alibi, but it was figured out with a simple forensic analysis? Why didn’t he plan for the time of death?”

“Criminals screw up all the time,” said Catra, “and Singer is a musician, not an expert in forensics.” She pull a wry grin, “should we ask him how autopsies are done?”

“Pfft, everyone knows that.”

“Really?” Catra grinned wider, “wanna explain then?”

“Well, it’s… uh, it’s… Bow, help me out,” she muttered.

“It’s to do with body heat—”

“It’s to do with bod–!”

But before Adora could finish cutting Bow off, Glimmer cut her off:

“The defence will take up your offer,” she said, drowning out Adora’s faux-confidence. “Let’s ask the defendant what he knows.”

“Well, I suppose you can,” said the Judge, before directing his next comment to the dock, “mr. Singer, do you know how time of death is established for an autopsy report.

Catra shook her head, “I was being rhetorical, you don’t actually have to ask him that.”

But Singer had stood, hands awkwardly together by his front, and eyes shifting about the room. “I’m a little lost, here, but you want me to answer that question? I believe it has something to do with… body heat?”

Then both defence and prosecution watch in total surprise as the defendant delved into an explanation —the fact that body heat decreases at a constant rate, and so time of death could be calculated by temperature.

“Of course, if you froze the body,” he mused, “that throws the time off. So I suppose if I was gonna do any of this, that’s what I’d do.”

“You knew all that?” asked a gaping Adora.

“I’m a bit of a crime thriller afficianado,” Singer chuckled, “you learn these things.”

“Well, I guess Catra, you were wrong,” Adora pointed, half confused but still taking the vindication where she could. “If mr. Singer were the killer and had planned this murder from the beginning, he would have taken care of the time of death!”

Catra just laughed. Whatever light feeling Adora had, it faltered. Always Catra had something to laugh about.

“Don’t you remember?” said the prosecutor, “that attic was a icebox. The perfect place to throw off the time of death, just as the defendant said.”

“Could that work?” said Adora, crushed. “The air was cold, but it wasn’t like he was surrounded by snow or something.”

“Frost,” Catra recalled, “there was a patch of it on the rafters remember.”

“Why does that matter?”

“If the body was there, then perhaps it was on the body as well. By the time anyone looked in the hot main hall, it would have thawed away. My guess is that the killer threw liquid on the body just after they struck him. And there was no shortage of drinks at the Promenade.”

“So the murderer did seek to throw off the time,” said the Judge, “although not successfully, I might add.”

It was at the moment, that Bow whipped out his pad and started typing away some calculations. Adora leaned over, wondering what he had come upon, but Glimmer pulled her back.

“Focus,” she said, “if Bow has something he’ll say.”

Bow gave an acknowledging thumbs up and continued. Adora turned back to Scorpia, but found that there was nothing left to

press her on. Thus the detective left the stand.

Next, Catra called Phoenix Wright to the stand. He held himself well, used to the blaring lights of the courtroom, though it had been many years now since he last took the stand. Upon Catra's prompting, he recalled what he'd said in the investigation —that he had seen a figure scurrying down the backstage hall under a velvet cloak.

"We have confirmed," Catra explained, "that this cloak belongs to Chas Singer."

"Sure," Phoenix frowned, "but just because the article of clothing someone wears belongs to someone doesn't mean that they are that person."

"The court does not need to hear your opinion, mr. Wright," said the Judge, "you are a witness now. Testify only what you saw."

"You didn't see the person's face, right?" Adora said, perking up, "that's what you're getting at."

"I didn't see their face. However, I did hear something. It sounded like grunting, a kinda deep voice. Probably male."

"Hold it! You couldn't have heard that clearly," Adora argued, "the backstage had speakers playing the music from the hall."

"I guess," he said.

"So there was music as well?" the Judge said, "mr. Wright, why didn't you put that in your testimony?"

Taken aback, Phoenix replied, "noone asked and I didn't think I needed to mention it. I'm sorry."

"Well, consider this a warning," the Judge puffed.

His brow furrowed, but Phoenix didn't respond. Just a few more questions and he was sure to be let down.

“The point is,” Adora continued, “we can’t be sure from this testimony that the figure was Chas Singer at all!”

“Oh please,” Catra scoffed, “Singer was the only one not accounted for, and it’s his cloak. Maybe it could have been worn by someone else, but it was very likely him, and it was impossible that it anyone else. No-one else was backstage, save for the witness who returned to the main hall to play cards.”

“That’s not true, remember,” Adora smiled, “Double Trouble was backstage.”

“Locked. You’re the one who seems to be forgetting things. And consider what the witness just said. Deep grunts, that of a man. You may think it would be hard to hear, but the witness identified it nonetheless.”

“Well, this Double Trouble person might not have a deep voice,” the Judge considered, “but can someone state for the record what range of voice they have?”

“It was mid-register,” Catra granted, “nowhere near Singer’s voice.”

“Well,” Adora twisted her mouth, “they were able to go into your range.”

Catra stiffened, “my voice isn’t particularly high.”

“It gets high.”

“No it doesn’t,” she growled.

“But still, Double Trouble was able to mimic you pretty close.”

“Don’t remind me.”

“They said they were an impressionist. It’s not beyond the realm of possibility that they could have pretended to have Singer’s voice.”

“Well it’s irrelevant,” Catra said, forcing a note of finality in her voice, “they were locked! The door was broken, and Singer never came to free them.”

Adora lowered her head, and fixed her expression. Glimmer leant over and asked in a whisper:

“What are you thinking, Adora?”

“This testimony can’t stand, right? If the court accepts that the person mr. Wright saw was Singer, it’s over.”

“So you need to show that Double Trouble could have been out of their room by that time?”

“Right! But how? I mean, I guess they could have been lying.”

“The door was busted, Chas told us so,” Glimmer said, knitting her brow, “but they could have entered anytime before you found them, right?”

“But we don’t have any proof. I mean if this was before the ‘I remember you’ then they’d have no alibi.”

Adora blinked. Her face screwed up in confusion, as if staring at something beyond comprehension. But she wasn’t looking at something baffling, but thinking it. A thought, rattling around in her head. It was ridiculous.

“Yeah, that’s ridiculous,” she muttered.

“What?” said Glimmer.

“Nothing. I mean, unless….” Suddenly she lost all filter and blurted out the question to the witness, “what was the song that was playing while you were in the backstage corridor?”

“The song?”

“Adora,” Glimmer was cringing, “are you sure you know what you’re doing?”

“Trust me,” said Adora, even though she didn’t, in fact, know what she was doing. But she just wanted to see for certain. “You confirmed that was music on the speakers. So what were they playing?”

“I mean, I don’t know,” he said, looking around, “it was just music, my mind wasn’t on it. Okay, just give me a sec, I’ll try to remember. It was soothing, lots of strings, you know.”

“The ‘I remember you,’” Adora’s shoulders began to fall. “It wasn’t even worth the try,” she quietly castigated herself, “Why’d I even ask something so stupid?”

“Uh, the guy sang something about angels and bells. Wasn’t quite following it but it sounded nice.”

Adora stared at the bench. Her ears muffled out the sound of Phoenix, confused as he described the song he only just about remembered. A light sparse feelings caught in her lungs, filling her to her brim to the point she let out a small laugh. She knew what she was doing now.

“Objection!” she threw out her finger, “we have a serious contradiction on our hands.”

“Really?” said the Judge, “I don’t see a contradiction. The witness heard the song ‘I remember you,’ which I believe was the song during which the murder happened? So he saw the murderer as they sneaked across the corridor to reach the scene of the crime. It’s so airtight I might give my verdict soon.”

“Then you’d have to resign your judge-ship in shame!” Adora laughed.

“Why I—”

“Catra, do you remember when the band played ‘I remember you?’”

The prosecutor smirked, “yeah. What about it?”

“Do you remember Chas Singer singing at all during that?”

“I… no, but—”

“In fact, doesn’t it seem strange that Phoenix Wright supposedly saw Chas Singer under the velvet cloak while also hearing him sing on the speakers?”

“I… wait, what?” Catra flinched as realisation struck her. She slapped her whip against her bench and shouted, “what’s going on here? Singer was absent from the stage during that time, that was the whole point!”

“Well this is a strange situation indeed,” the Judge’s eyes widened. “How can we resolve it?”

“You wanna know what I think?” said Adora, still holding her point, an electric feeling shooting across her limbs, “someone tampered with the speakers on purpose! To throw off the time the witness would think he saw the murderer running past! Mr. Wright,” she turned to the witness again, “try to remember: when you returned to the hall, what was happening? Anything at all that would suggest what time it was?”

“Again, I don’t really remember —oh ,wait,” Phoenix said, “that detective, she was just wrapping up her own song when I got back.”

“The witness is clearly confused,” Catra argued with a sneer, “a defence attorney’s mind is obviously addled easily by a defence attorney’s tricks.”

A slump fell in Phoenix’s shoulders as he complained, “hey, you didn’t need to make it personal. That’s just what I saw.”

“This is ridiculous,” Catra spat, “the murder happened during the ‘I remember you’ why would they go to such lengths just to make people think it happened at the same time?”

At this, Bow looked up and said, “I think maybe I have the answer to this. The murder didn’t happened during ‘I remember you!’”

Catra cracked her whip, reaching all the way across the chamber and spooking Bow into dropping his pad.

“Aagh!”

“It was your own damn report!”

“I know,” he said, with a genuinely apologetic look, “but that was before I realised someone tried to throw off the time. So I just did the calculations,” he picked up his pad and revealed, “and I think the actual time of death should be a little before. During ‘It’s Too Darn Hot.’”

It was the Judge who exploded next, “It’s Too Darn Hot’? Mr. Wright,” he brought down a grim look onto the witness, “you said it was during the ‘I Remember You!’”

“Wait, your honour—”

“There’s a serious question here as to whether you’ve perjured yourself.”

“P-perjury!” Phoenix’s was hit with a look so scandalised his eyes almost turned white, “your honour, you can’t be serious. I’ve seen you let a calvacade of liars and murderers get away with far worse on the witness stand, but now you care about perjury?”

“I don’t care for your tone, mr. Wright,” the Judge retorted, “if you continue I’ll have to write you up on contempt of court?”

“Contempt of court?” Phoenix shouted, “nggggghAAAAAARGH”

The poor defence attorney slammed his head to the stand, and sagged to the floor.

The Judge leaned over his high bench to peer down, and then shook his head.

“What a display. Anyway, where does that leave us?”

“Simple,” Adora said, “the whole premise for the prosecution is that only Chas Singer could have murdered Ma-Nan Jia. That was because we don’t know where he was during the ‘I remember you.’ But now we know that the murder happened during an earlier song, and that someone tried to make it look like it happened later. The defence believes that the murderer was trying to pin the blame on Singer.”

“Maybe,” Catra murmured, “but maybe not. Singer was still free during that other song. In fact, he was the one who called Scorpia up to replace him.”

“What about your argument that he changed the ‘I Remember you’ to specifically hide the sound of the murder?”

“Well, ‘It’s Too Darn Hot’ has a pretty loud chorus anyway, so maybe that worked for him too.”

Catra was leant over her bench, her mane of hair fraying, and a bead of bitter sweat trickling down her temple. Her blue and yellow eyes stared ahead at Adora with fury as she bared her grit fangs. The urge to fight was brewing inside her, and if she didn’t turn this case around soon, she didn’t know where that fight would go.

“Noone else could have done it,” she said.

“That’s not true,” Adora said, breezy in her smile, “one other was free in the backstage area. The defence requests we bring them to the stand.”

Catra stood up, “very well,” she said, “I call Double Trouble to the stand.”

Standing up straight did not suit Double Trouble. Instead they propped themselves against an elbow, and let their legs stand diagonal. With their free hand, they waved one finger at a time, and gave a deep, delightful smile to the crowd.

“Name. Occupation,” said Catra.

“I am called Double Trouble, of course, and occupation? I’d say I am an artist of the highest order.”

“You’re a mimic,” said Adora, “you said so yourself.”

“Imitation is a part of my wide and varied skillset.” They suddenly stood at a straight angle, and shot out a finger to the Judge, shouting, in a rather shrill voice “objection, your honour. I find a contradiction between your bald head and beard!”

“My what?” the Judge sat back as if punched in the face.

“Who’s that supposed to be?” Adora folded her arms.

But then the sound of giggles from her left and right sent heat creeping up her cheeks.

“…guys?”

“Nothing, nothing,” said Glimmer, covering her mouth.

“It was pretty accurate,” Bow said.

“Wait, that was me?” Adora whined, “I don’t sound like that!”

While Catra might have otherwise taken joy in a moment like that, she was not having it right now.

“Witness, testify on your movements during the performances of ‘It’s Too Darn Hot’ and ‘I Remember You.’”

“I was in the audience earlier on in the show,” Double Trouble said, returning to their usual pose and voice, “knowing that I had to be in my dressing by the second song, still I went for a bit of a walkabout. Had to stretch my legs, you know.”

“I don’t remember seeing you,” Adora noted, “did you, Catra?”

“Not that I recall.”

Nodding, Adora directed her question to the witness, “did you go backstage then?”

“Oh, quite good. Yes, I had a pass to so I ventured that way.”

“Well, then you must have come across a certain someone.”

“Oh?”

“Phoenix Wright. He was coming out that from the bathroom. I find it difficult to believe he’d miss you.”

“You’re right of course,” Double Trouble grinned out their sharp teeth, “no-one who meets me can ever forget me. But perhaps we simply didn’t cross paths?”

“No,” Adora said, slamming her hand on the bench, “you were there, weren’t you. You were wearing the cloak and imitating Singer’s voice!”

“Honey, isn’t a court? If you don’t have evidence to prove that, can’t I sue you for defamation or something?”

Adora straightened up, and replied, “there was a trace of hair found on the cloak. It should belong to our mystery person.”

“Oh please,” scoffed Catra, “we tested that trace there was no DNA. It was just a piece of dust caught on the cloak when it was on the floor.”

“Looks like hair to me,” Adora fired back, “and I can explain why noone could be identified… and how that identified the person in front of me!” Adora grinned, “did you know that bleaching destroys what little DNA is there?” She looked to Double Trouble, “your hair is peroxide, isn’t it, witness.”

Tittering, they retorted, “as if you’re innocent, blondes.” They stood up straight, with a little stretch, before saying, “fine, you got me.”

“If that—” Adora blinked. “Wait, I did?”

“I was the one who stole Charles’ cloak and pretended to be him for a bit. Even switched out the song on the speakers.”

“So you admit to trying to tampering with the evidence?” asked the Judge.

“It wasn’t evidence at the time. How was I supposed to know there was a murder?” They shrugged, “I just wanted to have some fun. Mess with people. And uh,” they chuckled as they flitted their eyes down to the floor where an unconscious body had been a few minutes prior, “seeing the consequence, it really paid off.”

“But why pretend to be Singer?” asked Adora, “I mean look at the trouble you’ve gotten him in because of it.”

Double Trouble’s smiled waveerd. “well, we aren’t exactly the best of friends. I never really liked working with him. Always had me doing the comedy routines, when I’m clearly meant for dramatic roles!”

“You headed towards the stairwell,” Catra stated, “assuming Wright’s testimony is correct.”

“I headed that way, but I didn’t go up. I swerved off at the last second and went into Singer’s room to hide. Waited for the coast to clear and then headed back to my own dressing room.”

“You were in Singer’s dressing room?” Adora’s mouth dropped.

“I was, for quite a while actually,” Double Trouble rambled, “it such a nicer room than my own. I played with a few things, he has so many trinkets you know. Ah and it was nicely scented,” they sighed, “anyway, eventually I returned to my own, locking myself in.”

“But you didn’t say any of this before,” said the Judge, with a ruffle in his beard, “I can’t believe you’d omit this fact during a murder investigation.”

“It looked suspicious,” they softened, “I didn’t want to cause any extra trouble. But my alibi remains the same, I’m pretty sure I was locked in my room for most of the song if not all of it. But I was just being silly and a bit nosy. I didn’t murder anyone.”

“You don’t have an alibi anymore,” said Adora, “the murder didn’t happen during ‘I remember you.’ But the fact you insisted that you were there the whole time while now admitting that you confused the witness makes you look more suspicious than anyone.”

“But I didn’t go up to the rafters at all that night,” Double Trouble shrugged, “I was in Singer’s room, and then my own.”

“We can’t verify that,” said Adora, “for all we know you’re lying and you did go up. There’s no evidence to help you.”

Catra’s ears pricked up. For the first time in twenty minutes, a tightness in her jaw that she didn’t even realise she had loosened. Her hand slid down to her pocket, feeling the cold rippled metal within. A grin of her own touched her lips. Now she could fight.

“That’s where you’re wrong,” she suddenly called out, in a dancing, breathy voice, “sweet, naive Adora,”

“What are you on about now, Catra,” said Adora back at her, quite unfazed.

“The prosecution has new evidence.”

Adora raised a single eyebrow.

“Oh really?”

“Really.”

“What is this new evidence, prosecutor Catra?” asked the Judge.

“Double Trouble claims they were in Singer’s dressing room. They claim they played with some certain objects. I believe they are telling the truth, and that they dropped one of these.”

The witness watched the prosecutor with a vacant, but intrigued smile.

Catra continued, “this is the object in question. A watch, belonging to Chas Singer.”

She drew it out. The watch. Cracked, with the hands stuck at 9:33. Broken during the performance of ‘I remember you.’

“Witness, you were wrong on one thing. You missed most of ‘I remember you.’ You probably reached your dressing room by ‘Go Down Moses.’”

“Oh really,” they said, tapping with mouth with a long finger, “I suppose that means that Singer didn’t go to his dressing room like I thought he did. I wonder where he was all night.”

Adora was just staring. The significance of the watch hadn’t settled in. It was just a lump of gold. Just a cracked piece of glass. Just a piece of evidence, that told the time. Just a piece of evidence, that Catra had found.

“Wait, didn’t you and Catra search the room together?” asked Glimmer in an agitated hush, “why didn’t you mention a watch.”

“I… I didn’t see a watch. Catra didn’t mention….” realisation was shattering across her face, a look of horror that began trembling in her eyes.

“I don’t understand,” said the Judge, “what is the meaning of this watch?”

“The witness dropped this halfway between ‘I remember you,’” said Catra, “meaning we know they were there at the time as they said. And that Singer wasn’t—”

“Why didn’t you show me this earlier?” Adora cried out, “that could have helped us establish his alibi!”

“Don’t you remember the second rule of evidence law?” Catra said, twirling the watch around her fingers, “Sparkles, you should know.”

Glimmer recited, “evidence not approve by the police must be—”

“I know what the second rule of evidence law is,” a scowl flashed across Adora’s face. “How isn’t the watch relevant?”

“Well it is now,” Catra spoke in a dancing tone, “because we know the witness dropped it. Before then there was no telling who did.”

“You—” involuntary heaves puffed in her chest, as she tried to restrain the urge to splutter.

Catra, with her lowered eyelids and evil smile, was an image to bring bile to her mouth. To think Adora had been sucked in, even momentarily, by the hope that she was the same person as her old friend.

“They could still be lying,” she spoke in a low, hot breath behind clenched teeth, “it could have been Singer who dropped that watch!”

“Then let’s bring him up,” said Catra, “and cross-examine his account of things. If it’s as you say, there should be no contradictions with the facts.”

“Fine! Bring him up.”

“Adora are you sure this is a great idea?” asked Bow, “Catra seems really confident about this.”

“Yeah, which is why I want to wipe her smug face with a not guilty verdict. She won’t be so confident then!”

Bow and Glimmer shared a look. Adora wouldn’t notice, huddled forward, staring fixedly at the stand.

Double Trouble let out a short titter, shrugged, and departed, as Chas Singer was now called up. His nerves were settled now. He didn’t rustle with his gloves, but rather clasped them together, beaming as he looked from defence to prosecution.

“Well, what a fantastic show this has been,” he said, “I was wrong about sparks. This is a firestorm between you two. And to think you can go home with no hard feelings and have a dance together.”

“Shut up,” Catra grumbled, “it’s nothing like that.”

“Defendant,” the Judge looked down on him, “the prosecution believes you have no alibi for the murder of Ma-Nan Jia. The defence asserts that you do, having went to your own dressing room around that time. Can you testify to your movements.”

“That I can do, but…” Singer tugged a little at his collar, “it’s going to be a little difficult to explain.” He then turned to look at Adora. Her insides were still churning, but met with his stoic expression she softened her own. “You must not let your heart be hardened like pharaoh.”

“Wh-what?” she said.

“This is going to hurt. And it’s going to get harder before it gets any easier. But you must forgive those who know not what they do, or rather why they do.”

She shook her head, “I don’t know what you’re talking about. But I do know something.” She lifted her arm, raising her fist, where

just below it the golden brace of She-Ra gleamed.

“I’m going to prove you innocent. That’s a promise.”

“Heh,” tutted Catra, “what are your promises worth.”

Singer meanwhile just gave a soft, pained smile. He turned back to the Judge.

“I’m going to tell the court everything I did and saw, as truthfully as possible. Even though I fear it condemns me:

“I went backstage halfway during the Detective’s performance. I went to my dressing room, yes as the defence believes. It was my intention to go free Double Trouble from their own room and then go sing ‘I Remember You,’ but I was delayed.”

“Why?” Catra enquired.

“I had a visitor.”

Adora’s eyes lifted, “Double Trouble?”

Singer just shook his head. “No. It was my boss. Ma-Nan Jia.”

“Wh…. WHAAAT?”

There was a rumble of murmurs from around the room, as the gallery wondered how this could be.

“You do realise,” said Catra with a raised brow, “this doesn’t fit anything we’ve heard before?”

“I know,” Singer said, continuing, “but there he was. We talked for a while, and nothing pleasant. But it was him. I can’t have mistaken it. When he came down dead during the next song it was a real shock, I tell you.”

“I… I…,” every thought fled Adora’s head.

Glimmer looked over with an intense eye and hushed, "Adora, you need to question him. You have to make sense of it."

"I don't even know what to ask," said Adora, her voice frantic, "I mean what *do* I ask? None of this makes sense."

"Maybe he's telling the truth," said Bow, "it would mean Double Trouble didn't go to the room for one."

"But if the victim was there and Double Trouble was away then—"

"If the defence isn't gonna do its job," Catra called out, "then the prosecution will supply the cross-examination. Witness," she turned her gleaming eye onto Singer, "you do realise what you've claimed is in direct contradiction with the evidence."

The witness didn't respond, but merely gave a vague smile to the prosecution.

Catra swept from behind the bench. Heading to the evidence table, she snatched up the manila folder containing the autopsy report and flipped it open:

"Updated, thanks to the forensic investigator over there," she explained, "but we now know the time of death was during the performance of 'It's too darn hot.' Ma-Nan Jia could not have been with you in your dressing room, especially since he was being frozen in the rafters as part of the cover up!"

Singer nodded.

"I don't understand it."

"Recant it then," Adora slammed her hands on her desk, pleading in her eyes, "just recant it and say something else!"

"Mr. Singer," the Judge said with furrowed brow, "I must remind you that you are under oath. I cannot permit lying in my courtroom."

“That is why I cannot recant, your honour,” Singer explained, “I do not lie. I am telling what I saw.”

“Evidence does not lie,” said Catra, “murderers do.”

“What about the watch?” asked a desperate Adora, “please tell me you at least were the one who dropped the watch!”

“I’m sorry, Adora,” he shook his head, “I take it off for performances, I don’t remember even seeing it after I started my set.”

“This is bizarre,” the Judge said, closed eyes, lowering his head, “let’s see if I can make sense of this. The evidence tells us that Double Trouble was in the room at the time. The defendant has no proof of time, but is certain he met the manager. Perhaps it happened earlier than he thought. In which case, the most likely order of events are that he met the manager, killed him, and took him to the rafters while the other witness entered his dressing room and dropped his watch. It’s the only scenario consistent with all the evidence.” He nodded, opening his eyes to say, “yes, this is my conclusion. Otherwise, how else could the defendant and witness both be in the same place and not cross paths?”

“M-maybe they did?” Adora threw out the first thing that came to mind, anything to keep the trial going. The racing of her heart was telling it to her plainly. The clock was running out. “The defence proposes that it remains a possibility.”

“Oh this is too good,” Catra laughed. “The prosecution has no objections to letting the defence try and explain this one.”

“Well, nonetheless,” the Judge frowned, “I do not take kindly to frivolously drawing out the court’s time.”

“Please, hear me out,” Adora pleaded, “just give me this one.”

She was shaking. Her voice was dying, cracking up by the weight of it all. She looked to Bow and Glimmer but both looked crushed of all air. Adora looked back to the Judge.

“Chas Singer and Double Trouble crossed paths that evening because… because,” the thought hit, and she was so stripped for time she couldn’t even consider if it was something brilliant or stunningly foolish. She just said it, “Double Trouble was disguised as Ma-Nan Jia!”

Catra folded her arms. The grin was not yet wiped from her face.

“They’re a mimic,” Adora continued, “we saw their ability to impersonate earlier. Who’s to say they couldn’t have disguised themselves too?”

“But Adora,” said Chas Singer with a resigned expression, “they don’t have kind of skill. No one does, surely? I saw him. It was Ma-Nan Jia’s body, his face, down to the last wrinkle. His skin wasn’t green to start with. Perhaps there’s some makeup out there in the world to pull that off, but not that quickly.”

“Why are you arguing with me?” Adora said in a squeak, “I’m trying to help you!”

“Adora, I just see how it can work. How can one person be someone else?” He shook his head, “I’m sorry. I think it’s over.”

“No! It makes sense, it’s the only explanation!”

A sharp sound of a crack forced Adora backwards with a yelp. Having grabbed her attention, Catra was now pointing at her, middle and ring finger holding the handle of her whip, index gently outstretched.

“This is a courtroom. If you want to make a claim such as that… show me the evidence.”

Adora thought back. Across the last few days, everything they looked over at the Princess Promenade to today’s trial. Everything she had seen flashed before her eyes, and yet there was nothing. The final piece that could make sense of it all. Did it exist? Did it matter if it existed? Perhaps the evidence had been there all

along, but like the watch, had been snatched away. Taken by a prosecutor bent to hell to defeat her.

How was she supposed to win against someone like that?

"I…," to speak was a great effort, finding the strength to push the air from her lungs lest she croak or whisper, "I have… no evidence."

She slumped upon her bench. Face down into her arms, she surrounded herself in darkness. The trial wrapped up, so seamlessly, with such speed and with all the voices merging into one slurred echo in Adora's mind. Then the memory of someone speaking —in a purring tone that seemed to twist her heart, even though it was a voice that once made her laugh and smile.

And then when you lose you'll start to blame yourself —how could you not even a rookie have the place of a real attorney and risked your client's freedom. It's going to be great! Watching you tear yourself up after this. If only I had the time to stay and watch.

A guilty verdict. Catra was dripping with glee, as she almost tiptoed her way out through the court lobby and onto the street. Soon, detective Scorpia emerged and hurried up to walk with her.

"Aw man, great job today, sir," she said, giving Catra a pat on the shoulder that almost knocked her over.

"Hey, watch with the claws," she protested, although it could not dampen her mood and she fell to laughing.

"Sorry sir, but I'm just real happy for you. I knew you'd show them all the stuff you're made of."

"You're not bothered?" asked Catra, surprising herself with the considerate tone she struck, "I know you liked the defendant."

"Yeah, well if he's a guilty man, that's on him" Scorpia said with a harrumph, "I just wished I could have seen him for what he really was."

“Yeah well,” Catra rustled, “you gotta be careful with who you trust. It’s a dangerous thing, you know.”

Arriving at the prosecutor’s office, they took an elevator until they reached a level midway up the block. Catra took a step out.

“I’m going up to the High Prosecutor,” Scorpia called after her, “I need to file a report with her. Do you… want to speak with her at all?”

Catra didn’t turn around. “Just tell her I won, I don’t need anything more than that.”

With that she kept on walking, until she reached her own office. She sat down on her chair with a long exhale, letting out a victory-drunk breath.

“This is what winning feels like,” she said to herself with a grin.

The room was quiet. It was dark, blinds down even in the afternoon, and it was somewhat cold.

“This is… what winning is like,” Catra said again, a little muter this time.

She shook herself, and drew up her chair to the desk so she could begin filing her report. There was work to be done, always, not just completing this case and sending the guilty party to jail, but future cases she’d need to prosecute. She was ready. She would beat them all.

It was quiet. She sighed.

Perhaps it wasn’t a conscious thing, although maybe she had wanted to do it: her hand went to press a few keys, opening a second tab. A few more button presses and she returned to her work. The strings perforated the air, followed by the trumpets and saxophones. And this time, someone sang:

I Remember You

You’re the one who made my dreams come true

A few

Kisses ago

Leaning back, she let out another sigh. The were no thoughts going through her head, and later she wouldn’t even recall this moment. A good thing too, for she would not like to dwell on the meaning. But memory, absent from her mind, was caught in her fingers. Hand against hand, the other gripped into the red dress.

When my time is through

And the Angels

Ask me to recall

The thrill of them all

Then I shall say that

I Remember You!

Chapter End Notes

> That brings a very dramatic end to the third episode. Next up will be an intermission of sorts (a Catra focused chapter!), followed by the start of episode four which will be quite long.
>
> If the whole ice body heat thing seems unscientific, it probably is. I'm following the logic of AA6 on that one, but mainly just wanted the cold setting as an excuse to have Catra wrap Adora in her cape last chapter.
>
> Anyway, expect a new chapter around this time-ish next week. I've already got the next chapter mostly done and have been working on the one after it, but my daily writing output is super inconsistent so I don't want to push it. I'll try to stick with a weekly update schedule going forward.

King of Prosecutors

Chapter Notes

An intermission

Catra had been to the Chief Prosecutor's office only once before. It was just as dark, with shadows creeping along the walls under the dim lights. Catra stood, resolute, facing the man at the desk, just sitting there. Just writing.

Ashen faced, with long pointed ears and thin but dark hair, Chief Prosecutor Hordak drew to an impressive height even when sat down. The silence and the waiting was his idea, meant to set Catra on edge. She liked to think it didn't work. With only the smallest shudder in her hand as she brought it up to her mouth, she gave a deliberate cough.

The scribbling of his pen stopped, at least.

"Prosecutor Catra," said Hordak. His cold voice bounced off the room's ambience, "I have brought you here to discuss your recent victories. They have not gone unnoticed. I am impressed."

"Of course, chief prosecutor. But it's only natural," a wry smile touched her lips, "those cases weren't even hard."

"Curb the arrogance," he said in a suddenly curt voice, "I have not forgotten your first failure."

Her cheek twitched at the mention, but she didn't let her smile fade.

Hordak continued, "a prosecutor must be perfect in every way. But I grant that Adora was a match for you. She was supposed to be here in your place, after all. She is skilled, but unreliable, clearly."

"She's not that impressive," Catra said cooly.

“That’s also true. Three times, is it? That you have bested her.”

“The Chas Singer case, the Tom Fulery case, and the Thaymor incident. All guilty verdicts.”

“Which is more than I can say for any other rookie. In fact, to call you such is improper.”

The man gave a certain nod. It had a strong, decisive movement to it. Following this, he stood and turned to face the blinded window.

“ In light of your consecutive wins,” he said, “you will be awarded as this year’s ‘King of Prosecutors.’”

Catra’s eyes widened, blinked, then opened full again. Her bemused grin was spilling into a genuine smile.

“R-really?” she said, “King of prosecutors?” She restrained her enthusiasm, stating “I mean, very good. I appreciate this recognition of my talents.”

“There will be a small ceremony at the precinct tomorrow,” Hordak explained, “now, you are dismissed.”

Catra left the Chief Prosecutor’s office and made her way down to her own. Her arms swung loosely by her side in her strut. There was a clacking of her claws against floor, as each step she propelled off the balls of her feet at high angles. The consequence of this was that she bobbed up and down with each stride.

Soon Scorpia emerged, overburden with files slipping from her arms. As she rushed to join by Catra’s side, she started babbling:

“I got those reports from the last case sir, the evidence receipts, the uh, what’s this one,” she attempted to pull the paper out from her own clutch with the thin end of her pincers. She ripped it. “Ah, no! Wait, phew, that was just a dud from the printer. Okay I think this one is the victim profile you wanted, and down here’s the stuff from the QT-5—”

“It’s okay, detective, just give them here,” Catra said, lending out a hand to relieve Scorpia of her carry, “I’ll put them away myself.”

“Really? You don’t want me to…,” Scorpia peered over at the smaller woman, and saw her clearly for the first time. “Sir, are you… in a good mood?”

“Guess you could say that,” Catra smiled. “You’re looking at the youngest King of Prosecutors recipient in history.”

“King of Prosecutors?” Scorpia’s jaw went slack, “was that what Chief Prosecutor Hordak wanted to talk to you about? That’s amazing!”

“Amazing? It’s more than that,” Catra said, unable to stop the warmth in her chest from gushing out, “this award has the names of Von Karma, Edgeworth, Skye, all these famous prosecutors. I’m getting it in my first year! It’s awesome.”

“I can’t remember ever seeing you this happy before, sir. I’m glad for you. You thinking of celebrating?”

Catra’s ears fell an inch, “hadn’t thought about it, really. There’s still a lot of work to get through.”

“Man, you’re always saying that,” Scorpia said, shaking her head, “if anything this award shows you’re way ahead. You can at least take an evening off.”

“I don’t…,” Catra wasn’t even watching where her mouth was going. She was puzzled as to why she was admitting it, but she was, “I don’t really know what I’d do if I did have the evening off.”

“Well, what do you do to have fun?”

Catra couldn’t answer. It wasn’t as if she didn’t have fun, but it usually involved someone else distinctly not having fun. And sure, there were things that gave her thrills. Running around, climbing up trees, hiding. As much as she’d never dare admit it to a

breathing soul, she'd never really outgrown that kind of play. The kind of fun she'd had as a child.

Before the incident. Before Brightmoon.

"Well you can't not do something," Scorpia argued, puffing out her chest, "I won't allow it. We should go out this evening, find some place to bunker down, have a few drinks."

"What… what would you have in mind?"

Scorpia tapped her chin, "well, I heard some things about the Lordly Tailor."

"Heh, as if you could afford that on a detective's salary."

Bowing her head, Scorpia shaded her eyes with the brim of her hat, "yeah, well it keeps getting cut."

Catra gave a curt sniff, "yeah well I don't want to go to a place like that anyway. Who needs fancy people, let's go somewhere rough."

"Oh, I dunno, sir. Rough parts of town can get real dangerous that time of day."

"Come on, detective, you're not scared of a little risk, are you? Hey how about that place you mentioned. What was it, 'Crimson Wastes?' Now that sounds like a bar with some action."

"Oh I did let that slip, didn't I," Scorpia said, a frown deepening into her face.But it was one she quickly plastered over with a smile, "well, if that's what you want, then I'd be happy to tag along!"

A day light on work wrapped up sooner than Catra would have expected. Soon she and Scorpia were heading out of the prosecutor's office together. A vehicle branded police-blue waited for them in B block, down in the depths of underground parking. Catra clambered into the front passenger seat, where she became

flushed to learn her feet didn't quite reach the floor. Scorpia drove.

It was not long —about fifteen minutes— when Scorpia turned the wheel and said, "I'm gonna park around here. Think there might be a riot if I bring this old girl right up the Wastes."

She stopped them at the small driveway adjunct to a lush green park, so they'd know where to find it again. They walked the rest of the way. The green quickly dissolved into dry beige, as they came upon dilapidated mid-rises of a semi-arid corner of LA. The Crimson Waste bar greeted them like a watering hole in a dustbowl.

Inside was dark and dingy. The walls were mustard, with torn wallpaper, on one hung an old television set from the 70s — currently playing an inaudible advertisement for Prime Industries with severe static. The bar was barren, but for a lonely tender and a bunch of foggy glasses, as the bar's clientele all seemed to cling to the shadows on the far side of the room.

Catra strode up to the counter and rapped it with her knuckles. Once the sole man saw her she jerked a pouring motion with her hand. He nodded, and went to pour a shot of whiskey.

"Oh, I'll have a cider, please," Scorpia said, nudging her pincer up. Catra stared at her, but she shrugged, "I like the taste, okay."

The tender slid the shot glass across the counter, right into Catra's hand whereupon she snatched it up. She downed it in one. By now, the other customers were eyeing them. They were big, mean people, many reptilian, and all wearing matching jackets of ripped leather. A few stood and sidled over to the visitors, keeping close formation with one another, and drawing to their full height.

"You don't belong here, kitty," the ring-leader bore down upon Catra, though she remained quite unmoved. "We know who you are."

“Hey, back off, Sally,” Scorpia shot them a look, with a coldness in her eye she rarely ever had.

“We’ve got your number, Scorp,” another one of the reptiles said, “we don’t take kindly to prosecutors, or their Quisling friends.”

“That’s like way too highbrow a reference for you,” Scorpia retorted, “anyway, what are you gonna do? Lay a hand on officers of the law.” She leaned over to Catra and said, “come on, Catra, let’s go. We can find somewhere.”

But Catra merely held up a hand, and finally turned to face the thugs.

She looked them up and down and then asked, “you got a problem with me?”

“You got our boss locked up,” said the ring-leader. “No-one touches Tung Lashor!”

Catra spat out a giggle to their face, “heh, still can’t believe that’s their actual name.”

Even Scorpia let out a smile at that. Catra had spent much of the Thaymor incident trial in fits of laughter. It was probably just a new strategy to undermine the defence, but Scorpia, having never like Tung Lashor that much, had been quite tickled by it.

“Look,” said Catra, “if your boss didn’t want to see the inside of a cell, he should have hired a better lawyer.”

“Yeah, that’s true,” conceded one of the thugs, “I saw the trial myself, that girl really flubbed it.”

Another agreed, “I ain’t no law-person, but even I could have given a better defence. Who’s idea was it to hire her!”

As the jacketed reptiles started conversing with themselves, Catra called for a second shot and went to drink it. The fiery brew raged through her gullet, leaving a pungent taste wafting through the

back of her mouth. Bitter, but followed by something sweet. After the second flood of alcohol, her head was started to grow a little light. A fuzziness pulsed through her head, and the conversation was blurring across her ears, although she did hear the name now, 'Adora,' and all the other bad things they were saying about her.

She mostly agreed, of course. But the feeling of fire in her chest was lingering. In fact, it seemed to expand. Enough that heat was creeping up her neck and into her face. Her hands were shaking, even after gripping them into the counter.

Adora was hers to torment. No-one else's.

"Yeah, that girl, scum," one of them was saying, "perhaps we should find her and teach her a lesson about—"

With a thwack, he fell. Before the ring-leader could respond, Catra punched him too. Dead silence engulfed the room. The reptiles all stared. Even Scorpia had to blink a few times to gather what was happening.

Then the people in jackets jumped to their feet, raising fists, producing knifes, withdrawing chains and bats and whatever else they had on them. There were shouts as mayhem grew. The closest one to Catra lurched forward to grab her.

They were caught mid-air by a large red claw. It was Scorpia, now holding him in a tight grip, before hurling him five feet across the air and crashing into three or so thugs now charging them. Catra pounced. Jumping off one poor man's head she threw herself into the crowd, and started scratching away.

A few minutes later, mayhem became pandemonium. Still, Catra and Scorpia managed to crawl up to the bar and over the blaring din called for another round of drinks. They clinked their glasses together and downed them, just in time to hurl their fists at another column of thugs attacking.

By the hour's end, their heads were swimming. Catra had a cut on her jaw, Scorpia a few bruises. Nothing compared to the pile of groaning bodies scattered across the floor. They had to stumble their way to the exit, and Scorpia possibly broke the handle trying to manipulate it between her cumbersome pincers. Yet they made it out, suddenly washed with the cool air of night.

Laughing, they crossed the street and said farewell to the Crimson Wastes.

"Right, where's the car?" asked Catra between giggles and hiccups.

"Oh, it's this way I think," Scorpia slurred, "just gotta find the park."

"Your old friends certainly know how to treat guests."

"They're just hot air. Nothing to be worried about. B-but, you know, you, you," Scorpia shook her head, trying to find her misplaced words, "yours is one wild cat, sir."

"I like the sound of that," grinned Catra.

"I mean, you shouldn't really be starting fights." Scorpia shook her head as if to throw off the torpor. Then she looked at Catra with eyes that quivered by the lamplight. "But even if you do, you know I'll always have your back, right? I'm loyal like that."

"Can you give me your back?"

"What?"

"I wanna see what it's like up there," Catra said, suddenly pawing up at Scorpia's broad shoulders, "lend me a ride."

Scorpia stared for a few seconds, before givng a laugh. She lifted the lithe girl without effort. Then, with Catra seeing the world from the perspective of a very tall scorpion, the two made they way over to the park, barely lit in its low greens by the occasional

lamppost, although given a general blue haze by the cool light of the moon.

They might have overshot the car. Scorpia was following the patio path, which took them deeper into the park, until she decided to make a stop at a bench. Placing Catra down on one end, she took the other. They rested there for a time.

Eventually, Scorpia pulled up her pincers and starting babbling again:

“Oh man, did you see us back there? What a rush, huh?”

“Yeah,” Catra said in a low but amused tone.

Her eyelids were lowered and she felt a yawn coming. Head still awash in spirits, she could very easily take to bed soon. She’d rather stay.

“I was like this, woah, and you were like that,” Scorpia was recounting the recent battle, thrusting out her pincers to hit imaginary thugs. “Oh, and the way that guy went for you like hyaah!”

She poked her claw into Catra’s belly, and the cat clutched it with both arms, laughing.

“Mine now,” she said.

“Hey, give it back, I only have the two.”

Thoughts slowing, Catra didn’t respond with words but merely slid her hand down, rubbing the length of the claw. Although she did ask, “can you feel with these things?”

“I mean, faintly,” said Scorpia, “not as clear as skin but the feeling’s there. Why?”

Catra leaned her head to the side, until her cheek lay against the red face of the claw, and a soft blush grew red in Scorpia’s face.

“What was it you called me?” Catra asked in a vacant voice, “wildcat?”

“Something like that.”

Reaching up a hand to lay on the detective’s high shoulder, Catra then gently towed her down, while lifting herself up. Her vision was a little faint. The black gloss of Scorpia’s upper lip guided her.

Her aim was off. She pressed her mouth into the corner of Scorpia’s own, although she quickly slid to the side so lips brushed against one another. The big woman’s eyes were wide all the while, but she made no motion to resist. Lifting herself up, coming to her knees on the bench, Catra pushed the kiss deeper. It was masked by the slightly sickly taste of alcohol, but it couldn’t ruin the soft texture, or the warmth of skin or breath.

Catra broke away, quite quickly. Scorpia remained still, watching as Catra shifted in her seat, pulled her knees into her chest, and stared steadfast at the tarmac below.

“You shouldn’t have done that,” she muttered.

“Sorry,” Scorpia said, as if she had been the one to do it. Indeed, she felt like she made it happen.

There was a cold silence. The nighttime wind, calm but nippy, was the only sound that disturbed it. That was, until Catra spoke again:

“Why are you so friendly towards me?”

Scorpia blinked, then buried her brow, asking, “why shouldn’t I be?”

“No-one else is.”

“Well, everyone else gets the wrong idea about you. You got that edge, you know, the sniding sneer— the sneering snide, the— you know what I mean. But you do that to be cool, to keep

people on their guard, to put wrongdoers at unease. You're bad cop, I'm good cop! But I know the real you, you're great gal!"

"No," said Catra. "I'm not."

Scorpia's whole body slunk. She had no reply but to look crestfallen. Catra just let out a tired, spirit-stained sigh:

"I'm not cool, I'm not putting on a show," she said, "I'm just like this. All the time."

There was nothing more to say after that. With Catra on the verge of sleep, and with a whirlpool of emptiness and confusion inside, Scorpia couldn't find any more words. They soon found the car and drove away.

The day that followed started normally, although there was a distant mist. It didn't quite engulf streets in fog, notrhold any portents of rain, but it was always at the road's end, obscuring the far-away. Always threatening to descend in full.

Having functional but sleek architecture, the police department seemed far less grungy than anticipated for a building with its budget. That said, the mess of paper documents and bullpen office space, only just cleared away to make space in criminal affairs, had not outgrown the mid-2000s.

Prosecutors, police, and a few other law enforcement staff were gathered. Between the memories of last night, parasitic on her mind, and the eyes of everyone in the room watching her, Catra was hot all throughout the ceremony. Yet she remained focused. She kept a flat expression and proud poise. Came to the front, shook hands with the Chief Prosecutor and Chief of Police, received the trophy — a large K emblazoned on a broken shield. Her picture was taken, and finally the crowd dispersed into smaller groups for mingling and champagne.

"Well done, sir!" Scorpia gave an enthusiastic salute as Catra came down from the head of the room. She clutched the trophy in both hands. "We're all proud of you down in the precinct here. I

just saw Bobby crying, although he does that a lot now I think about it."

"Thanks," Catra said.

She couldn't look Scorpia in eye without blushing, and certainly couldn't look at her lips. Instead she kept her gaze off face, looking at the doorway just in the line of sight behind the detective. A few latecomers were arriving. A couple were rookie prosecutors she neither knew nor cared to. The third was a tall woman, with voluminous and flowing black hair, and decked in red.

Catra tightened her jaw. It was Shadow Weaver. She was crawling over to them.

"What do you want?" Catra said, causing Scorpia to turn and realise the woman's arrival.

"I just came to say…," Shadow Weaver began in that low, dancing tone of hers, "congratulations."

"Con— really?" Catra said, suddenly finding her tight grip loosening.

"You have exceeded my expectations. Very few have ever shown the skill or determination you have over the past few months, especially at such a young age. I agree with the Chief Prosecutor's decision — you've earned that award."

Ears falling flat, Catra reached to scratch at one arm with the other. For a few moments, she was bereft of words. That was until Scorpia gave her a gentle nudge, forcing Catra to stammer out:

"Well, uh, thanks, Shadow Weaver."

Though with everything going on making her feel hot, for the first time she was struck with a tingling warmth, growing deep within her. She quickly gestured to someone serving a platter.

“Um, have something to drink,” she told Shadow Weaver, who gladly took a tall glass of champagne. Then Catra turned to Scorpia, “a-anyway, you were going to introduce me to your colleagues.”

“Oh yeah,” said Scorpia, “there’s some great guys you’ve gotta meet. We’ve got some real characters here.”

Despite all this sudden rushing, Catra was caught with an unprecedented ease. Perhaps she was accelerating things because she thought if she didn’t, she’d lose good feeling. She tried to tell herself it was fine, and she could slow down to enjoy herself. But something deep within her was urging. Anxious.

With good reason too.

“It can’t last, of course.”

Shadow Weaver had finished her drink. It was her who had called out.

Catra froze. Dead still, even as Scorpia, shortly oblivious, kept walking. But even she stopped upon realising what had been said. She turned with a concerned look to see Catra immobilised.

“C-come on, wildcat,” she said, forcing a pained smile, “let’s meet Dick. He’s got a lot of juicy stories about mr. Edgeworth—”

“What do you mean by that,” Catra said, slowly turning to face Shadow Weaver.

The woman in red had taken another glass however and was taking a few slips underneath her mask. Whatever warmth there was washed away, replaced by a constriction in Catra’s chest as she grit her teeth. Once again, she asked:

“What do you mean by ‘it won’t last’?”

“Merely,” Shadow Weaver said as she lowered her mask over the bare sliver of face she’d revealed, “that you’ve hit the peak of your

journey. More significant than I would have guessed, but ultimately, just an obstacle to overcome."

Only one word crossed Catra's mind, but it came repeatedly; the word 'no.' Shadow Weaver couldn't possibly be saying what she suspected she was. Not here, not surrounded by all these people; certainly not now?

"Now you compare with someone like," Shadow Weaver took another sip, before saying, "Adora. She's just getting off the ground. Take these past few cases —they weren't quite as decisive as you pretend. I'd argue the Chas Singer case was only one hurdle away from a victory for her."

"But she didn't win," Catra growled, "I beat her. I've beaten her three times!"

"True," Shadow Weaver conceded, "but you have one advantage over her, and only her. Against any other competent lawyer you'd have no hope of winning."

"What?" Catra's voice cracked.

"Adora is confused now, partly because of her straying, but mostly because of you. But as I said, you're the obstacle she has to overcome, and then she'll be ready."

"You're a joke," Catra spat, although as she continued she found herself short of breath, "you're just… a pathetic… I can't believe you're still putting her on a pedestal! Just because you thought that through her you could get the glory you never could under Von Karma's shadow," she waved the trophy in front of Shadow Weaver, "even now you're so delusional! Adora's gone, but you still put all your hopes on her."

Now the attention of the whole room was on them. Everyone watched in silence, even the Chief Prosecutor, grim in face as he saw his top operative arguing with the woman he'd just commended. Catra cared not for what thoughts or judgements passed around the crowd. She just saw Shadow Weaver.

“But I’m better than her!” she shouted, “You didn’t give me anything, so I took it for myself! I fought every step of the way to get here, and I didn’t throw it all away for some dumb noble quest or magic sword!” Catra laughed, a mad cackle, although still disrupted by her gasps for breath. “But you can’t see it.”

If she thought a high, derisive laugh would be enough to unnerve Shadow Weaver, she was gravely wrong. The woman simply bore down on her a look, narrowing her white eyes from behind her mask. Despite her previous gusto, Catra now shrunk back in a flinch.

“Why would Adora have to fight for every step?” she said, “when she’s naturally perfect. Just look at her temperament compared to you. She can be a little unpredictable, sure, but she’s a marvel under pressure, when cornered. You on the other hand,” though no-one could see it, a smile crept along the woman’s mouth, “quarrelsome, unbalanced. Adora might be gung-ho, but she doesn’t go and start petty brawls in bars. ”

Catra’s eyes quivered, though a twitch in her fists urged her to pounce. The mentioning of the brawl brought back the satisfying feeling of smashing bones and wrecking a stupid face. But Shadow Weaver’s narrowed eyes held her back.

“Adora will soon be back in her proper place, and reach her potential as a prosecutor.”

With that, Shadow Weaver turned. But no longer restrained by her glare, everything within Catra let loose.

She leapt forward, and screamed:

“That’ll never happen!”

But she stopped long before reaching Shadow Weaver. Scorpia caught her mid-air. Despite the girl’s bellows, and mad kicking, the grip held Catra firmly back. Shadow Weaver did not turn around, but she gave a tut nonetheless. Then she left.

Catra didn't know what happened next. Places and people were blurred, but she definitely did not stay at the department for very long. Perhaps she had stormed the whole of Los Angeles, reaching the Prosecutor's Office and her own desk, followed all the way by a concerned Scorpia.

Slamming the table, Catra yelled again, a long shout that echoed in the room and began to scratch her throat before she could shout no more.

"I know how you must feel," Scorpia ventured to say, "look, what Shadow Weaver said… she was terrible, I think everyone must have agreed. Hey, do you wanna talk—"

Scorpia gently extended a pincer to lay on Catra's shoulder. But just as she grazed it, the prosecutor whipped around, and batted the claw away.

"Get out!" she shouted, "I don't want you here, just leave!"

Scorpia cringed. There was hurt in her face. But seeing the utter wretch before her, she stood up and gave a calm nod. Turning, she went to the door, and was about to leave. However, she lingered, and said:

"I'll give you space, but please know I'm in your corner… wildcat."

Scorpia had spoken too softly, not feeling the strength to speak any louder lest Catra snap again. In the end, Catra didn't hear what she said, as she could only hear the sound of her own, repeated muttering.

"Adora," she said, "Adora, Adora, Adora."

Again she said it, and again. She kept saying the word until, once she was alone in the room, she was speaking it loudly. Then she was shouting it. She kept saying it until 'Adora' was the only word in the world. A world that only knew hate.

Bow's Stressful Day

Chapter Notes

Bunker down, this one is long

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora was buried, face first, in a much too soft bed. Her bedroom was bare. She hadn't had many effects to laden it to begin with, and never felt it right to do so. It wasn't right to even call it her room. With the shutters down, she didn't even fill it with light. The only thing she had really put in there was the sword. The sword was in its bracelet form right now, far out of sight.

She wouldn't be needing it.

Just outside was Bow and Glimmer. They'd figured out how to open the door just a slither so they could see her, buried away, without disturbance. With a forlorn look, Bow closed the door again.

"Do you think she's starving herself?" he wondered.

"No, she goes down to grab food," said Glimmer, "it's just she does it at night so she doesn't have to see anyone."

He shook his head, "it's not like her last client was a saint."

"Yeah but he was still clearly innocent," she sighed, "it was my fault for convincing her it'd be an easy one. I just thought it could help her regain her confidence."

"You did good, Glimmer, don't be hard on yourself," Bow said, "I think Catra showing up at the last minute really threw her off that time."

At the mention of the prosecutor, Glimmer's face hardened.

“She shouldn’t have trusted her.”

“What do you mean?” asked Bow.

“Adora and Catra,” she said, “they were doing the Chas Singer investigation practically together. I think Adora must have let her guard down for some reason and Catra used it.”

“Now that you mention it,” Bow stroked his chin, “she seemed real shocked when Catra hid that evidence. Maybe… Adora wanted to think Catra was okay? They’re both kinda similar.”

“They’re nothing alike,” Glimmer protested, “Catra is ruthless. Adora’s a good person.”

Bow shrugged, “they’re both pretty young. Hard-working prodigies, stubbornly determined. And they were both prosecutors, so maybe Adora saw a lot of herself in Catra?”

“Well whatever it was, she shouldn’t have trusted her. Still, she shouldn’t blame herself. It was Catra who did that terrible stuff, not her.”

Bow stared at the door.

“If only we could turn this around….”

“We have to redouble our efforts. We need to move on and move forward, and—”

“No, we can’t stress her out anymore. You’ve been overworking her for weeks now, and that’s on top of Angella’s training.”

“But—”

“But nothing,” Bow said, quite forcefully.

Glimmer fell silent. She wore a look of hurt, though she did well to hide it.

“Then what do you think we should do?”

“Adora is naturally an overachiever. If she’s going to work herself to exhaustion, she’ll do it. But right now she just feels bad. So we need to do whatever we can to lift her spirits.”

Then something lit up in his eyes.

“We’ll plan a perfect day for her. No care, no worry; no stress. And certainly no Catra.”

“You think that can work?”

“Hey, if the two of us can do it, we can make it work for her!”

Glimmer smiled, although it quickly faltered when she looked away from him.

“Yeah….”

Adora barely left the grounds these days, so Bow and Glimmer had found themselves hanging out without her. It wasn’t all bad. The two hadn’t spent much time just in each other’s company ever since Adora came into their lives. Not that they ever resented her, but they’d forgotten the simple joy of a quiet moment together outside by an umber dusk. Only last week they’d gone to the pier, intent on just an hour there. They lost themselves in conversation until it was the tired evening and they were left leaning into one another on a bench drenched in the glow of sunset. Bow liked these moments.

But Adora was still their friend, and this situation could not stand. So he spent every minute he could spare over three days planning for the outing. It wasn’t so much he needed to stuff the day with endless activity. In fact, just as much time was dedicated to trimming, questioning whether a certain point in the itinerary was worth the time. He considered logistics —Los Angeles was a broad city that had declared war on pedestrians generations ago, so finding the least strenuous routes between locations would be key. But in the end he had the schedule.

A grand day out —all fun, no stress, no problems.

Of course, the problems started before he even left Brightmoon manor. The doorway was closed off by the presence of a small yet remarkably space-taking woman, with enormous pink bunches and dressed in heavy overalls. She looked up at Bow with a toothy grin.

"Hey, Bow!"

"Entrapta? What are you doing here?"

"Ooh, your place is nice… and *big."*

Entrapta bounded past Bow, coming into the broad foyer and giving it a sweep with her eyes.

"Although," she said, with one of her bunches forming a finger to slide against a dusty console table, "it's a little threadbare, dontcha think? You should install some lasers, a loudspeaker, try and make entrances a bit more exciting."

"Uh, thanks for the advice but it's not actually my place," said Bow. "I just spend a lot of time here cause of Glimmer. Are you looking for her? Is this about the sword?"

"The sword?" Entrapta tapped her chin with a heavily gloved hand, before her eyes lit up. "Oh! The sword. Nah, I don't need that for now. I have the notes from Sverdhild."

His shoulders slumping at the mention, Bow asked, "did you hear about her…?"

Entrapta didn't seem to hear, instead continuing to look around the hall with a vacant smile. Bow didn't push it. Thinking about Hilda only served to remind him of how bad things had been for Glimmer.

Though he didn't know, Entrapta had heard. She knew her acquaintance was gone. But she preferred to shelve thoughts on that for later.

“I’m here because I need legal help,” she explained, lifting herself up by her hair and placing herself cross-legged upon the console. “My work colleague is under arrest. They said he killed someone. A murder that happened in our lab only a few days ago.”

“Oh really?” said Bow, “I’m sorry. Are you okay?”

“Should I not be?” Entrapta said, still in a chipper voice, her smile having never faded even with the turn of conversation.

“Uh,” Bow’s face twinged, “your friend is in trouble and could be sent to jail for life. I thought you might be worried for him.”

Entrapta knocked her knuckles together while looking up with a ponderous look. Then she seemed struck as if coming upon a brilliant idea. “Oh, I see. Makes sense when you put it like that. Thank you, Bow!”

“Uh, sure,” Bow smiled.

Perhaps it was for the best Glimmer had already headed out. She didn’t quite have the same patience for Entrapta’s unique way of looking at the world.

“So can you help up?” Entrapta asked, leaning forward with an expectant gleam in her eye.

“Well, I wish we could but,” Bow looked down, “Adora’s the one who can take trials and she’s not accepting cases right now. Plus we’re busy today. Angella should be around but the most she can do is give you advice.”

Entrapta’s smile did fade there.

“Oh, I see. Caught you at a bad time.”

“I’m sorry,” said Bow, and feeling like he hadn’t explained to satisfaction continued, “Adora isn’t on her game right now. This day needs to work so she can defend people like your friend.”

"Ooh, then send her over to my lab anyway," Entrapta was suddenly smiling again, "whenever I'm stressed I work on science! We could work on a few breakthroughs and she'll be up to peak efficiency again!"

"That… would be a bit too taxing for her," Bow said with a small pained laugh, "but I'm sure she'd appreciate the offer. Anyway, I've planned things perfectly to set her at ease. We need to do everything *right.* " He blinked. The last word slightly rebounded off the walls of the Brightmoon halls, though not so much as it did within the confines of his own head. "Right… Wright! Entrapta, you don't need Adora, you just need a damn good attorney. Maybe even better than that."

He took Entrapta by the arm and launched her off the console, with such sudden speed that she yelled a warbly yell in confusion.

"W-wait," she said, "we're heading off to find another lawyer? But what about your planned day?"

"It'll be fine," Bow said back with a confident grin plastered on his face, "he's down by People Park. Glimmer and Adora should be near there already."

Glimmer was questioning Bow's judgement. The place they arrived to was a dilapidated shack in the middle of a tight street. Sure, the building next door looked respectable, but the loose barrel in front of them, joined by a mangy dog under its ramshackle kennel and washing-lines haphazardly above, certainly was not going to lift anyone's spirits.

That said, Adora didn't seem quite as put out as before. Getting the sun and the breeze might have helped. Not that she was glowing or the picture of joy. But she at least held herself with poise and wore a neutral expression.

There was a noodle stand in front of the shack, with the title "ELDOON" written out on cloth banners. Adora and Glimmer took

their stools and weren't waiting long before Bow arrived to join them. The man had a doubly satisfied expression now, which to Glimmer meant he'd probably just figured out a way to help someone else. She smiled.

"Glad to see you finally arrive," she teased, "wouldn't want everything thrown off before we'd begun."

"Why are we starting with noodles?" asked Adora. "It's a bit… I dunno, simple after you've been talking up this day for a while."

"It's about simple joys, Adora," said Bow, "they're filling, but not too complex. Even the way it's from a vendor is about the virtue of simplicity."

Adora shrugged, "I've never had them, to be fair."

"Did… Did Shadow Weaver let you do anything growing up?" asked Glimmer. "Or did she just grow you in a box — "lawyer-in-progress, do not open until court case"

That made Adora chuckle, "something like that."

The vendor gave them their broths and Bow and Glimmer were quick to dig in. Adora poked it with her chopsticks.

"What do we have planned for today then, Bow?"

"A good amount," he said, "but don't worry about what's ahead. Today is about living in the moment, and enjoying how calm things can be."

Glimmer nudged Adora and murmured, "he booked us a pretty expensive spa for later on."

"Wow, sounds nice," said Adora.

She looked back at her bowl. Finally she shrugged again, and threw some ramen into her mouth. The taste overloaded her

senses. Resisting the urge to cough, she swallowed, before panting for air.

“How is it that… salty.”

“You don’t like it—”

But before Bow could finish the question, Adora had gone right back in for a second bite. He watched with a half-smile.

“See, there’s always a reward for trying new experiences,” he said. “I think today will be the best we’ve had in a while. Just a slow, nice, relaxing—”

“Hey, what’s that sound?” Adora shot up, suddenly looking back to a street.

A galloping sort of noise had caught the air, although it was more distinctly the sound of feet as it got closer. A whole group of people were now streaming down the road. From their seats by the noodle stand, the three of them watched as this whole group of fifty or so runners rushed them by and turned the corner onto the next road.

Adora jumped up.

“I wanna know what that’s about.”

“Wait, Adora!”

But protests failed. Adora had kicked off with amazing speed, sprinting down the road before either Bow could react or Glimmer could catch her. In a blink, she was gone.

“Damnit, what happened?” Bow said upon a voice crack.

“Don’t think she does calm,” muttered Glimmer.

“Oh this is not good,” Bow fretted.

“Hey at least she’s thinking about something other than Catra. This might be her way of dealing with things.”

“But constant activity isn’t going to deal with her stress it’s just gonna delay it. She’s needs to learn how to switch off.”

“Hey guys!”

They turned. It was Adora, having just arrived from the other side. She’d done a full lap around the block. Glimmer and Bow shared a look but didn’t say anything. Adora meanwhile hopped back onto her stool and wolfed down the rest of her bowl.

“Did you guys know Phoenix Wright works nearby here?”

“Yeah, I came around this way to find him back for my trial,” said Glimmer.

“I just saw him going out of his office.”

“A-alone?” said Bow, a terseness springing into his back.

“Yeah, or maybe. Well, I didn’t see him for very long. Why?”

“Oh, nothing,” said Bow, fixing his attention back onto his own bowl, nearly finished. “I’m sure he’s having a quiet day too.”

Phoenix Wright was not having a quiet day. Entrapta did not have very much in terms of volume control, and there was a lot she needed to explain to him, especially as they were now approaching the big grey building known as the Dryl Institute.

“My work partner is Ron Guy,” she explained, “I don’t think he’d even hurt a fly, not even a really small one like a member of mymaridae. So logically it’s super unlikely he’d ever kill a person. Sure it’s not materially impossible, but statistically is a whole different matter. You know I figure out a way to chart in percentages the chance that a person would commit a crime, but the Department of Justice wouldn’t give me funding — plus, Ron

tells me it would violate several constitutional rights, so that's a bad thing."

"R-right," said Phoenix, "well if you're certain he didn't do it, then I'll believe you. Do you know anything about the victim?"

"Nellie McRaker. A journalist, I think. Someone always looking for the next exposé."

"And she thought it would be found at your lab?"

"Maybe she wanted to write a piece on all the new discoveries we've been making!"

"Maybe…," Phoenix knitted his brow, "or maybe she found something she wasn't meant to."

The Dryl Institute was laid out like a labyrinth. If it hadn't been for Entrapta, Phoenix was certain he would have gotten irretrievably lost —and even then they were still having to double back along the dark hallways to continuously get back on track.

"Here we are," Entrapta announced as they came to triangular-shaped room. It was loaded with chrome countertops on which various trinkets of iron and copper and cord were strewn. To the undiscerning eye, it looked like junk.

Entrapta however pulled a small recorder to her mouth by her prehensile hair and noted, "workstation 3b has been rediscovered, that brings one of our longest-running mysteries to an end."

"This isn't the crime scene, is it," said Phoenix.

"Nope, but not all failure is a setback!" Entrapta rushed up to one of the counters, rummaged through the junk, and pulled out a small green card, "I've been looking for Emily's original isomatrix for five months now! Finally I can run those comparisons with her beta version."

"What's an isomatrix?" asked Phoenix.

Entrapta's eyes filled with starlight, and Phoenix soon regretted he asked. He was given a long, highly technical and somewhat tangential explanation to explain cognitive-mapping in robots. The girl never seemed more alive when explaining detail upon detail of this process. It was like Ema all over again, except a version who actually knew the science.

"So it's about…," Phoenix felt his brain about to burst trying to keep up, "calculating human-style decisions within a computer's software? God and I thought law was complicated."

"Robots fascinate me," Entrapta said in a dreamy voice, "so many potential paths, so much potential. Plus, they can be switched off and back on again; it's not the end…." She trailed off.

"Entrapta?"

"I find robots easier than people than sometimes. Even with an isomatrix, they're more logical. Inputs have defined outputs. People meanwhile have a lot of variables."

"Hey, I feel you there," Phoenix said, quite softly. "But we should probably go and find the actual crime scene now."

It was only a few more twisting corridors before they finally came upon a huge cavernous chamber. Blue lights were built into the wall which rose vertically to a high point, and they lit it so it wasn't quite as dark as the rest of the building —although they flickered weakly.

"What's with the lighting here?" Phoenix asked. "You don't always work in the dark do you?"

"We've been having electricity problems for years," Entrapta explained, "we're constantly rerouting power to new subsystems for our experiments. It's not healthy, I'm told, but we've gotten used to it."

A few police were about, but scattered. Notably, Detective Scorpia in her heavy red coat and hat was squatting by the white tape

that demarcated where the body fell. Phoenix approached.

“Hello detective. We met briefly before— I’m Phoenix Wright.”

“Oh hello,” she said, quickly standing up, “no I remember you. You’re pretty famous at the precinct.”

“No doubt Gumshoe’s mentioned me.”

“Calls you a pain,” Scorpia smirked, “although he’s fond of ya.”

“Feeling’s mutual. Anyway, I’m here to defend Ron Guy. I don’t suppose you could tell me why you arrested him.”

Scorpia shook her head, “I’m sorry, mister, but this is the tightest case I’ve been on yet. This facility is locked down every night, patrolled only by a robot staff.”

“This true, Entrapta?”

Entrapta nodded, “I’ve yet to figure out their sleep functions, and it’s easier than hiring a security company.”

“The victim sneaked in before the lockdown was operable. Then they were thrown down this whole chasm,” Scorpia gestured up to the ceiling of the chamber, so high up it was barely visible. “The impact killed them.”

“Can you rule out suicide or an accident?” asked Phoenix.

“They didn’t have any reported tendencies, and despite the, uh…,” she shot a look at the smiling girl in overalls, and carefully said, “post-modern architecture, the building isn’t hazardous. The railings up there are absolutely secure. You’d have to physically lift and throw someone off that edge.”

“And Ron Guy’s your suspect?”

“He was the only other living person in the building. And we found it locked up there in the upper levels. It couldn’t have been

anybody else."

Scorpia seemed to take no pleasure in saying this. She had a heavy expression, and half-tired eyes that wandered off a lot.

"Are things alright, detective?" asked Phoenix.

"Oh, nothing," Scorpia said, suddenly standing up stiff, "just got up really early, and the prosecutor has us running things real tight."

"The prosecutor? Is that Catra?"

Scorpia rubbed the back of her neck. "Yeah…."

"I heard a rumour about her. Some sort of incident?"

"Uh, it was nothing serious!"

Phoenix raised a single eyebrow.

"There was a thing, some drinks, provocation ——no-one was hurt anyway, just a conduct issue…," Scorpia's trail fell to a barely audible mumble. Then, looking away, she wondered allowed, "you ever… care about someone yet they always seem so distant no matter how close you try to get?"

"I know what that's like exactly," said Phoenix.

"How did you handle it?"

"Not really sure in the end. Things just sort of changed." He gave a smile, "the other person had to figure things out for themselves. All I had to do was be there when he needed me."

Entrapta was watching Phoenix. Though with her goggles down he wouldn't have seen her thoughts behind her eyes if he were looking. Scorpia however hoisted her shoulders and managed at the very least a half-smile.

“You know, I can do that,” she said, “I’m loyal, me. Hey, there’s only so much I can give you —not helping the defence and all— but I can let you look at some evidence.” She rummaged around in her coat pocket, before drawing out a picture, “this was taken by McRaker. Her camera was one of those, uh, y’know one of those print-y camera things. She dropped it down by one of the corridors.”

Phoenix took it. It depicted a white-faced man, though mostly shrouded in shadow. He seemed tall and gaunt, with long ears and thin hair, and an expression that could not possibly be any more stony.

“That looks like Ron alright,” said Entrapta.

“There could be a contradiction here,” Phoenix pondered.

“I dunno,” said Scorpia, “thing is, Catra already said she doesn’t want to use this one. It helped confirm our suspicions but she thinks the other evidence is stronger. Anyway it’s the photo that’s missing that’s of interest.”

“What about it?”

“Well the fact that the victim definitely took it, and yet we can’t find it. It was probably destroyed, but Catra thinks that it shows the defendant’s motivation. McRaker caught something mr. Guy didn’t want anyone to see.”

Phoenix turned back to the picture with a grimace, “well there must be something I can use here. What’s this down by his hand?”

It was hard to make, fuzzy and dark as it was. In the man’s hinter hand, there appeared to be some sort of black block, tightly gripped within his fingers. But there was so little they could draw from for an answer. Meanwhile, Phoenix’s attention was taken by the more clear hand in the fore.

“Hey’s he got a cut,” he noticed, “does this match the victim as you caught him?”

“The scar of on his left hand?” said Scorpia, “yeah he had one.”

“Oh I can explain that,” Entrapta lifted up to Phoenix’s height to look at the photograph too, “some of our doors have a security mechanism that punishes people trying to break in. Essentially you have to get the puzzle right to show you’re allowed inside. Thing is… Ron has a habit of getting it wrong.”

Phoenix looked at her with a horrified side-eye.

“Hey, it’s not serious,” Entrapta shrugged, “but it can hurt.”

“There was something like that up where we found the suspect, but…,” Scorpia looked to her pincers, “I wasn’t able to figure it out.”

“Was there anything you found up there?” asked Phoenix.

“Nothing but the man.”

“Still, could be worth a look.”

“Then let’s go,” Entrapta said, grabbing Phoenix by the arm and tugging him away, “there’s a secret path up, I’ll show you!”

Outside, and many blocks away, the path Bow, Glimmer and Adora took was long and leisurely, winding its way through People Park under a shower of glorious sun rays. Bow hoped that this would have soothed her by now, but even here Adora was finding a way to pace her stroll. There was jitter to her, some sort of urge itching to work its way to something active. And there was only one thing that could touch her mind.

“You think if we head to the detention centre we could find a case?”

Bow briefly froze. But thankfully he was at the head of the group so noone saw the flash of panic on his face.

"I-I'm pretty sure it's a slow day," he bluffed, "I heard, uh, from the forensics team that there just aren't any crimes these days."

Glimmer rolled her eyes, but thankfully she was second behind him, so Adora couldn't see that either.

"Angella hasn't been getting any requests either," she said, although with less enthusiasm in her lie.

"You and your mom are still doing advice then?" asked Adora, "I wonder why she doesn't try and get her right to practice again."

Glimmer ruffled, but quickly said, "well, once disbarred it's not easy overturning that. It's a… mark of shame. Theoretically permanent. And Angella wouldn't want to even if I asked."

"Oh?"

"She's been getting moodier recently. Your defeats haven't exactly helped."

"Though noone's really at fault there!" Bow cut in, trying to preempt the slump in Adora's back.

"She keeps asking me where I've been if I haven't told her I'm going out. As if I still need her permission," Glimmer sighed. "But yeah, you guys know what's she's like. It's nothing really."

"Uh, speaking of the team," Bow said in a suddenly loud voice, "did I tell you guys of our DNA sequencer? It's amazing, we can actually simulate the PCR process for blood analysis, at least partially." Though he'd started to distract the conversation, soon Bow was away explaining the new piece of kit, "so long as we've already denaturated the acids the old-fashioned way most of the actual reproduction can be done by a computer, and it's already connected to a databank of our profiles so we can do the analysis

there too. I've been thinking about trying to hook up my pad to the software but it's been difficult."

"Um, what's that in English?" asked Adora.

"It'll be a revolution in forensics!" said Bow, "we can identify blood samples with greater efficiency and reliability!"

"Bow and his toys," Glimmer grinned, "always on about the white heat of technology."

Throwing her a sullen pout, Bow protested, "this can decide cases!"

"The prosecution already has most of the forensics done for us anyway. It's not like having She-Ra on side."

Adora chuckled, "and Glimmer's read all the legal books. When you gonna start pulling your weight, Bow?"

"I mean… the fact you haven't read your books is a bit concerning," said Bow.

"Hey why worry, I already got Glimmer."

"You two—," Bow gave a short huff, but then he smiled, "I'll prove to you the importance of forensic technology, someday."

"Well before that happens," said Glimmer, turning in the direction of a chiming sound, to where a kiosk on the park common stood, "anyone want anything?"

Bow and Adora were happy to give Glimmer orders and she went off to join a queue. Yet as the mirth from teasing Bow fell away, Adora's expression fell to her neutral, somewhat tired gaze. She stood, cross-armed, and staring down at the paved ground. It provoked a frown from Bow, although one he quickly suppressed.

If a sunny day in the park wouldn't cut it, then the situation called for drastic measures. Directly addressing the problem:

“You know, Adora, we are your friends,” he said.

“I know that—”

“No, what I mean is, you know you can talk to us if you’re not feeling great.”

She looked up quickly and said, “wait, I am enjoying. I don’t want us to stop hanging out. It’s just—”

“Adora, please,” he stressed, “the whole of point of this is for you to feel comfortable. You don’t need to prove you appreciate us, because we know that. But you know,” he started rubbing one wrist with the other other hand, pulling the white fabric of his glove down and up again as he said, “things might be easier if you told someone about what you’re feeling. I think there’s something you’re hiding, and it’s been eating away at you. You can tell me, right?”

Something glowed within Adora’s eyes, even though they still hung low, staring at the floor. Still, she turned to face him again, and taking in a deep breath, spoke:

“I… Glimmer kissed me to make you feel jealous!”

“See, it’s — wait, what?”

He watched her, even as she fixed her expression back at him. The seconds passed with heat rising in her face until she could manage to look at him no more, and broke away to stare down again. Bow was left confused more than anything. He hadn’t even comprehended what Adora just said because he had been so certain that her problems concerned the prosecutor she’d seemed so hung up on; he hadn’t even considered it was about Glimmer… and him.

Then her words actually hit him, with quite an impact. He almost fell over backwards.

“Glimmer… what?”

“At the Princess Promenade. Because you were with Sea Hawk.”

“I knew she was bothered but… that much? Wait, ah my head….”

He pressed his palm against his forehead, beneath which his mind was a-swirl and a faintness swept through him.

But before he could think any more about it, Glimmer returned with cones. They continued out of the park, with Bow unsteadily trailing behind.

“So where next?” asked Adora as they were passing along a residential block.

“Just keep walking along here,” Bow said, “we’ll… we’ll get there. No more distractions, today is going to be a day of calm. A day of rest. Just a relaxing day where nothing—”

Sirens. Blaring away, in the distance, but still approaching, and sudden enough to cut Bow off. Then, jumping out from an alleyway, a man in green hurtled into them. He crashed into Adora. She fell down just as he regained his footing and chased off, hauling something heavy and silver under his arm.

“What was that?” cried Glimmer.

“It’s a robber, he’s running from the police!” exclaimed Bow. “We’ve should go tell them where he went.”

But Adora, having fallen to her knees, palm slightly grazed at they landed flat on the tarmac, was in the best position she could be. With a kick-off, she sprinted.

“Adora, wait!”

“Not again!”

Glimmer and Bow were far behind her now. Adora’s eyes were dead ahead, on the man in green. He had jumped onto one of the

black-grate outside stairs on the block, and was swinging his way up to the rooftops. She followed.

Once atop the building, she saw the man in his broad hat with two white plumes running. He made a leap across the slim crevice to the next building. She matched him, keeping to just a few metres on his tail. With another leap, he made it to the third building across an even wider gap. She jumped too, but landed just on the edge. Almost losing her footing, she could feel gravity tug her backwards —and a terrified scream of one Glimmer seeing her from below.

With a swing of her arms, she stabilised. The thief was on the far side of the roof.

"Urgh, get back here!" she shouted, before chasing him down again, just as he slipped from view.

Once on the other edge, she looked down. He was swining down some more grate-stairwells. Though she rushed down, she was less nimble than she would have liked. She slipped her footing once, then twice. Then she lost it all together and made a short plummet the last few feet down. With a crash, she planted the ground with a sharp pain across her face.

"Nngh," she shifted herself back onto her knees. "Where are you?!"

He wasn't far. Facing her down from the end of this alley with a sword brandished, he leered.

"You'll never catch Mask ☆ DeMasque," the man boomed at her.

"Oh yeah, well," she stood to face him, "you'll never escape She-Ra! For the Honour of Grayskull!"

The man's sword faltered a second. He blinked and so did she as the alley fell silent.

“Oh,” said Adora, “I don’t…,” she groaned, “the one time I need the sword and I don’t have it!”

“You are defenceless, so I shall leave that you may live to recount this day!”

“Nah,” Adora raised her fists, “you’re not going anywhere.”

Huffing, sweating, and drenched with panic, Bow and Glimmer finally reached the alley, whereupon they found Adora, who was just as worn out as they were. Her forehead was wet and strands of hair were loose from her ponytail. Her jacket was off and her white shirt was ripped in a few places. But she was grinning and gleam rested in her eyes, especially as she had her foot down, binding the unconscious criminal in place.

“You actually caught him?” Glimmer marvelled between a breathy heave.

“Pretty cool huh,” Adora said with a laugh, “perhaps I should quite the law and become a full-time hero.”

Bow started laughing too, although a strained one and matched only by wide vacant eyes.

“Aah,” he muttered in a breaking voice, “this day….”

“What should we do with him?” Glimmer asked, looking at the fallen Mask.

“Maybe we can find detective Scorpia and return this,” Adora said, picking up the silver trinket —a glittering and carved orb. “We can find her at the precinct right?”

“She won’t be there, will she,” muttered Bow.

“Why not?”

Bow clamped his mouth shut, realising what he’d just said.

“U-uh, actually,” he stammered, “well, it’s more that she’s got a lot of procedural work. Very busy.”

“I thought you said there wasn’t much crime—”

Bow suddenly snatched the orb and loudly said, “let’s just find the owner and give it back directly. I’m sure there’s something on here I can use to identify the owner.” He started turning the object in his hand, searching, “maybe a fingerprint or…”

“Bow,” said Glimmer.

“Wait, I can find it and then do a quick analysis on—”

“Bow, underneath!”

Bow gave her a blank look. Then he lifted up the orb where on its underside was a tag. ‘Fragile: Handle with care’ it read, shortly followed by a brand logo ‘PRIME HOLDINGS.’

“Are you alright Bow?” a frown fell on Adora’s face, “you seem jittery.”

“I’m fine,” Bow said through gritted teeth, “come on, let’s find Prime Holdings and then, hopefully, finally, get back to this day I had planned!”

Back at Dryl, the investigation continued. A huge iron-bolted door now stood before Phoenix Wright and Entrapta, although the latter gave it no regard.

“Now I just need to find the entrance,” she said.

“I mean I’m seeing a rather big one in front of me….”

“That door was locked all night, remember. We want the secret path.”

“I can’t imagine all these hidden paths help with your research,” Phoenix noted in a dry voice.

“Science is problem-solving. A mind must always be up to solve problems!”

“So is law in a way. Maybe I should refurbish Mia’s office. Don’t think Maya would like it though, unless she thought she could use it to bother me.”

“I found it!”

Entrapta pushed two metal panels of wall inward, and both receded into the floor. Then the whole wall began to open up, giving way to a tight corridor that led, winding, until they reached another laboratory room. This wasn’t quite as overborne with loose technology, although it did have a large metal ball on segmented stilts. Phoenix walked up to it, looking it up and down, pulling a cheek as he tried to figure just what it was meant to be. Perhaps it a new type of sculpture?

A light, purple, began to glow from a crevice in an upper latitude of the sphere. Again, Phoenix assumed it was some sort of display, although that thought quickly fled him when the contraption started to move.

Heart racing and a bead of sweat glistening at his temple, Phoenix asked, “uh, Entrapta, what’s going on?”

“It’s Emily! Say hello.”

“Uh, hi?” he said in a weak voice, “you’re Emily?”

“YES,” the machine recited, its voice harsh, high and sibilant with digital screech, although still carrying a bit of girlish inflection, “HELLO!”

“Emily, I found your original isomatrix,” said Entrapta, “when this is over we can do some broad metrical analyses together!”

Emily gave out a ringing sound, though it conveyed her glee. Still, Phoenix was a bit shaken by this whole experience.

“So, this robot is consciousI?”

“I already told you about her cognition-mapping, but I got the personality-mainframe technology from some of my colleagues in the robotics community. A robotics engineer and psychologist duo who really should be married by now.” She shrugged. “But yeah, I took their research further by incorporating Kurainist spiritual power.”

Phoenix was absently nodding until he heard those last few words, which stopped him.

“Wait, you know about the Kurain channelling technique?”

“Well it started coming back in vogue a few years ago but I got wind of it even earlier.”

“I didn’t even know there was a science behind it.”

Entrapta’s eyes glowed.

“Every phenomenon has a scientific explanation,” she hushed, “the difference between magic and science is perspective. Look!”

She rushed over to one of the benches, scrabbled between some of the pieces until she came upon what she was seeking. Pulling it up, she showed the metallic object to Phoenix, and his face broke into understanding. The shape was that of a 9.

“A magatama?” he said.

“An artificial magatama,” Entrapta clarified, “with it, I was able to bind a fully developed continuous consciousness, bringing together cognition, personality and sensory function into a fully realised living being.”

She then went over to Emily, holding the magatama close to her. Despite its metal frame, light filled the object, causing the metal to glow with heat, such that Phoenix had to shield his eyes. But he understood.

“You gave her a soul?”

Entrapta nodded, smiling in the afterglow of the magatama’s reaction.

And if that hadn’t been enough to make Phoenix doubt whether what he was seeing was even real, the next room had a winged horse.

“Wh-what?” Phoenix could barely even lift his eyebrow as he stared at the improbable equine.

“Yeah…, Entrapta vocalised, “I’m not sure how he got in here. We did make a stable for him but he seems really resistant to the idea.”

“Oh, don’t tell me he talks too!”

“Of course not, horses can’t talk. Only humans and robots can.”

“Why does he have wings?” asked Phoenix.

“That particular phenomenon remains unexplained. Further research needed. But the cause was something we did involving the Sword of She-Ra.”

“Oh, that thing. I heard it came from the Dryl Institute.”

“We were doing a few tests on it on the side, but couldn’t make any breakthroughs apart from…,” she looked at the horse, “well, ‘magical transformation’ is the preferred term for now. When ms. Studley asked to run some tests on her own we were really hoping she’d make progress where we couldn’t.”

Phoenix took a survey of the room. It was about as threadbare as the last, save for a few shedded sheathes of horse-fur. There was however a computer by some sort of large container. He was about to go up to it and take a closer look when one of Entrapta’s hair bunches physically grabbed him and lifted him all the way back to her side.

“Don’t… look at that.”

“What is it?” he asked.

“Blood.”

“Oh. Well that’s…ominous.”

“It’s connected to sensitive research. I’d rather you didn’t.”

“Entrapta, someone was murdered and potentially over secrets at the facility. I might need to know what those were to help best defend mr. Guy.”

Entrapta didn’t look at him, rather blankly staring away, her eyes hidden. It seemed whenever he wanted to get a read on her she had her goggles down.

“Let’s go to where they found Ron,” she decided at last, and said nothing more on the matter.

Phoenix sighed, but ultimately he was powerless but to acquiesce. They continued on and it wasn’t a few more winding paths until they reached the large chasm of a chamber once again, but this time viewing it from the near-top. Scorpia had been right. The guard-rail was fool proof, and would require a serious effort to throw someone over. No doubt Ron Guy was a tall man.

Going up the guard-rail, Phoenix was able to see down through its acrylic glass shielding. Even with the safety precautious, his heart jumped at the sight. The distance down seemed to stretch as he looked at it. The people on the ground level were insignificant to view.

“Poor McRaker,” he said, “to fall from such a height.”

He looked up, trying to see the ceiling although it was receding into darkness.

“What is this place for?” he asked.

“I’m not sure.”

“You’re not?” he turned to gape at her, “it’s your facility.”

“We run a lot of tests here and we haven’t worked on this project for a few years. Not since… uh, well not since a while. I don’t think Ron even ever worked on this, so it’s weird he’d come up here.”

“You just forget tests you’ve worked on?”

“I record things,” she produced her voice recorder, “although that’s just to keep things ordered in my mind. If I could just get this thing working I’d bet everything would come back to me in a snap.”

With her hair, she started pressing a series of buttons on a nearby panel. She grabbed two levers with her hands as well, sliding them forward as she gave a joyful cackle.

“Let’s see what this does!”

“Wait, is this safe?”

But whether it was or no, they would never find out. Instead, the lights burst with mad flashing, before going out entirely with a flicker.

“Aagh!” Entrapta panicked, “activate emergency power!”

A low ambient light sprang up.

“Note to self, main chasm chamber remains inoperable,” Entrapta began muttering to her device, “still unsure about function, will have to check records.”

“Well we’re not going to find anything with this lighting,” said Phoenix. “Is there somewhere we can check the electricity in this place?”

“I can restore everything from the office just a few floors up from here,” Entrapta noted, “plus we can grab a record of the electricity usage to see what happened last night.”

Phoenix nodded. Now he thought about it, such a thing could come in useful. So they agreed to go back through the large iron-bolted door rather than the winding path. Then they took another flight of stairs to come to one of the top floors in the building.

The office was actually rather cosy, though darkly lit but for the crackling fire of the hearth. Entrapta found her computer and started tapping away, not just dealing with the current energy supply but printing off a record as she’d said. Phoenix meanwhile began pacing around the room. Sliding his hand off the mantle by the fire gathered dust to his fingers, the same as when he found an antique globe on the desk.

Though she wasn’t looking at him, Entrapta picked up her recorder with a free bunch and spoke into it, “lawyers appear to touch everything they can as to utilise sensory learning in their evidence gathering process.”

“Hey, don’t study me,” he protested, “just thought there might be something worthwhile for the case.”

Then, a oval-shaped picture frame on the desk caught his eye. By the low light it was hard to make out who it was, though the distinct feeling he recognised the person was gripping him. They had a rather fixed, stony expression, a pale face, dark hair, and long pointed ears. The shape of his head was similar to the person in that other photograph.

“Is this Ron Guy then?” he asked. “I guess he must be pretty important for you to have in your office.”

Entrapta didn’t say anything. She was engrossed in her activity and even Phoenix’s incessant investigating wouldn’t shift that. Still, he was cognisant of a light but determined feeling in his chest, one he only ever felt when he took on cases.

“Don’t worry,” he said, “I’ll prove him innocent.”

It wasn’t far —not far at all— from the Dryl Institute to where Bow, Glimmer and Adora were walking to. Prime Holdings headquarters was one of those buildings that prided itself on being the most flashy and glassy places that reached further and further into the sky that it became quite impossible to comprehend just how it was until you stood at the very base.

“Do we just go in?” Glimmer rubbed her shoulder, “or, do we like, need to make an appointment?”

Adora just strode forward and pushed through the door, and the others just accepted it and followed. Inside, they had to climb a good fifty steps in the lobby just to reach the reception desk, where a woman was completely engrossed in her computer.

“Uh,” said Adora, “we have your—”

“I’m sorry ma’am, but we’re not accepting business today unless you’re with the police.” The receptionist looked up, scanning Bow’s uniform, “are you with the police?”

“We’re just civilians today,” he said.

“Then I must ask you to please leave.”

Adora would not move, “listen lady. We’ve got your stolen artefact thingy, just let us return it and we’ll be going.”

The woman shot up a foul look, such that Bow instinctively grabbed Adora’s arm and tried to tug her away. Adora ripped it free, and was unmoved from her spot. She stared the woman down.

“It’s alright,” came a soft but cool, high voice. It perforated the air with a strange ring. “Let me deal with them.”

A man, tall and pale in both skin and suit and with long white hair proceed towards them. He bore down on them a look with

glowing green eyes and a small but invading smile.

“I am Prime, the CEO of this conglomerate. I assure you I am burdened with much important work but I can make a short time to deal with you. Your name,” he looked down at the lawyer in particular, “is Adora, is it not?”

“Yeah,” she stammered, “how do you know me?”

“It is in my interests to know about everyone of any significance in this city,” said Prime, “a prosecutor, protege to Shadow Weaver, defecting is quite newsworthy in my books. But what brings such a person to my door?”

Adora held out the silver orb, which was enough to provoke the lights to flicker in the man’s eyes and his smile to deepen.

“Ah, the Heirloom of Saint Jacinta, an early Borginian masterpiece, and utterly priceless. I was quite worried when that thief stole it.”

Suddenly, Prime turned, although leaving a hand with long spindly fingers outstretched, enough to wave at the three behind him. They understood to follow as he walked. He led them to a large elevator, framed in gold and with baroque patterns on its face. Hauling them up through the skyscraper, it delivered them to the fiftieth floor, which comprised a single but large room that contained nothing less than the greatest collection of treasure any of them had or would ever see.

Rows of rows of plinths holding gold, silver, pearls, glittering jewels, old rocks from ancient civilisations, statues and paintings and on and on this vault went. All else was forgotten as Bow, Glimmer and Adora were silently struck with awe as they followed the man through his obscenely opulent collection.

“Just here, Adora,” he said, pointing to one notably empty stand.

With now shaking hands, Adora placed the orb onto its ‘rightful’ place.

“What is all this?” asked Glimmer.

“This is the Prime collection,” said Prime, “one must make something of untold billions in wealth. Asset valuation is ultimately just numbers but this,” his eyes swept around his treasures, “this is how I measure success.” He reached into his inner jacket pocket, and pulled out a series of photographs, “every masterpiece from every medium, of course. Take for example this,” he showed them one from the pile, “one of the earliest pictures of Piccadilly Circus, from the time of the old empire. And this,” another, “just a wonderful shot of Eagle mountain that I purchased from a amateur.”

“You like to keep some of your treasures in jacket?” Bow said.

“Would that I could keep all of my treasures on my person, but alas, most must remain here in the collection.”

He turned back to look at the three fully, and said, “now as to your reward for helping me in this matter.”

“Oh we just wanted to help, we don’t need much,” said Bow, quickly, “just let us go and we can get back with our day.”

“Nonsense, you must stay, I insist.” Although he was smiling there was a darkness under the man’s deep-set eyes, under the harsh light of the treasury.

“We had this whole day for relaxation planned out we can’t afford any more distractions.”

Prime clasped his hands, “if it’s relaxation you need, then by all means make use of the penthouse suite! It’ll far more luxurious then even the best facilities across the city.”

“That… does kinda sound nice,” admitted Glimmer.

Bow could offer no more objections after that and so resigned. Prime directed them to use the elevator up, and once more they rose through the tower. Once they arrived, Bow quickly realised

this was better than anything he could have planned. The walls were mostly glass and the ambient colour of the rooms white, so it seemed as if they were on clouds floating in the sky. They were bathed in broad natural light, that glittered off the water of the hot baths. Staff attended their every needs once the notification from Prime came through, and they were treated better than guests, better than gods. Soothing oils, deep massages, enmeshed in calming scents, soon it was Bow more than anyone else who had forgotten the stresses of not just this hectic day but just everything in general.

That said, Adora was loosened up too. At long last, she was just laying on a reclining chair, not fidgeting, not urging to rush, or even consumed in dark thoughts about a persecuting prosecutor. She was just lying there, calm, even happy. Bow was warmed just to see that

By now, he was by the window with the suite's telescope. The supreme height of Prime Holdings gave the best views of Los Angeles —its dense cityscape, its golden waters and its rolling hills— than any other. Glimmer meanwhile came down to sit by him.

"So, today ended up a success after all."

"Yeah," Bow chuckled, "I guess in the end I just needed to let things happen rather than worry about everything. I think Adora's all runned out."

"Think mom would kill me if she knew I was here," Glimmer said, looking out to the scene. The Brightmoon estate was just a speck in the depths of the city below.

"She worries too much," said Bow.

"I know it comes from a place of love…."

"Right, but you're still your own person, she should understand that by now," Bow gave a half-smile, "of course, you can still afford to empathise, you know."

“I know. I’m trying.”

“Good.”

“Mom got destroyed by the legal system,” Glimmer ruminated, “we couldn’t get justice for dad. I don’t want to see anything similar happen to Adora.”

Bow didn’t say anything.

“Things are getting tough but she’ll need to stick to the right path. She has to do things right… right?”

“Of course she does,” said Bow, “and she will.”

“But we can’t keep letting Catra get the better of us,” Glimmer said, suddenly perching up, agitated, “we need to take her down before she does some damage we can’t undo.”

“Glimmer—”

“How many lives does she need to destroy before we—”

“Come on Glimmer, I say you’re right for once and you immediately start saying the opposite?”

Glimmer stopped herself. She looked at Bow, a fixedness in her stare that was half defiant, half guilty.

“Hey, it’s alright,” Bow said, a little softer this time, “I guess now you’re the anxious one today.”

Glimmer gave a weak chuckle, “yeah I guess.”

“Is this really about Angella or Adora then?” asked Bow.

“It is!” Glimmer insisted, “but I guess maybe it’s not just about them….”

“It’ll all be okay. You don’t have to do this alone. Neither does Adora. We’ll face whatever’s next together.”

Glimmer smiled, as she looked up into Bow's eyes. They were dark and wonderful. Bow however was struck with a sudden memory as his eyes wondered onto Glimmer's lips, and he quickly turned away to fidget with the telescope some more. Looking through it, he saw the docks area, some of it quite familiar to him.

"Hey I think I see the Princess Promenade," he muttered, "oh and that ship's on fire. Probably Sea Hawk."

Glimmer's insides sightly squirmed. But she pushed the feeling away and asked:

"How are you and Sea Hawk?"

"Oh we still text a little. But his work takes him out to sea most of the time. And when he's back it's more important that he checks up on Mermista's legal situation."

"So you're not seeing each other anymore? That's kinda sad."

Blow glanced over, "really, you didn't mind."

She shifted.

"Well, uh…."

"You know," Bow tentatively mulled, before deciding to throw himself into the problem, "Glimmer, I know you kissed Adora."

"You, wait, you do?" Glimmer flashed scarlet, "oh god I thought you didn't notice. I just wanted to pretend it never happened."

"So you did mind."

"I was… being possessive. But I was wrong to be."

"Yeah, you were."

"I know that!" Glimmer insisted. "Please, it doesn't matter. See, I even wanted you and Sea Hawk to be happy. And I just want to cherish what we have."

“I mean, you are the most important person in my life,” Bow said, letting the truth fill into his words, “have been for a while.”

“Yeah, well you were the same for me.”

“Well that’s no excuse to get jealous when I spend time with others.”

“I know that now, I was being stupid.”

“I mean kissing Adora out of nowhere does sound pretty drastic.”

“Look, I’m trying to forget about that okay,” Glimmer said. “I just want to enjoy being with you without getting possessive.”

“Sure, but it’s,” now he was thinking about it, he was sure he was approaching something. A clarity, he knew was close, just a little way ahead. He talked it through, “we don’t keep many secrets from one another. We’re comfortable enough talking about our vulnerabilities. In fact, we really know each other, even how stupid we can be and we don’t mind that so much. And recently, I want Adora back to her old self but the two of us going out to places has reminded me how much I really like you. I comfort you, you comfort me. Emotionally, physically, we’re comfortable with one another.”

“What are you— what are you saying?” asked Glimmer, watching Bow with barely a blink now.

“I… I don’t really know what I’m trying to get at anymore. I guess I wonder why you feel so anxious about me when we can’t really get any closer.”

“Well that’s not true,” Glimmer furrowed her brow, “We can get closer. We could always—” then she blushed. “Ah, never mind!”

“What?” Bow blinked.

Quickly changing tack, Glimmer stammered, “but like, even if we are so close, we don’t have a name on it.”

“A name?”

“We’re just friends… going out to places.”

Bow just laughed.

“Come on, it’s not funny,” Glimmer growled. “It’s the way you frame it. Naming it gives it meaning.”

“Okay, how about this,” said Bow, “next time we go out —just you and me. We’ll call it a date.”

Glimmer’s eyes lit up.

“R-really?”

“But,” Bow said, “on the condition that you take back what you said about forensic science.”

The girl blinked for a few seconds. Her head was swimming having just drunk in the last few things Bow had said. But then a grin spread across her face, and she lurched forward to shove Bow:

“Oh so that’s how it’s gonna be, huh?”

“I’m serious!” Bow laughed, “if you we’re gonna do this, you’ve got to make peace with my profession. Unless, I dunno, you want me to be a house-husband or something.”

The smile quickly washed from Glimmer’s face.

“U-uh, let’s not get *that* far ahead, Bow.”

“You’re right, you’re right,” Bow said, “we’ve gone steady enough all this time, no need to rush.”

“But you mean it, right?” asked Glimmer. “About you… and me....”

“No reason why we can’t give it a go,” said Bow, looking her straight in the eyes. Her eyes, glittering pink, his eyes dark and

wonderful. “But we’ll, um,” he said, feeling hot now, “we’ll discuss that another time, if that’s okay.”

“Sure,” she whispered.

And, not quite knowing what to say or do next, Bow turned to look into the telescope once again, which was now pointed almost straight down to the building next door. Some people were coming out onto the street. The first was tall, dressed in red, followed by descending height a man with black hair and a woman with very large purple.

“Hey it’s Phoenix and Entrapta,” he muttered, “and I guess that’s detective Scorpia.”

“What are they doing?”

Bow turned, expecting to see Glimmer. But it had actually been Adora, having wandered over to join them. Bow froze.

“Uh-uh,” he said, “nothing. Guess they’re just hanging out!”

Adora raised an eyebrow, “are mr. Wright and Scorpia friends?”

“…maybe?”

“Bow, are you hiding something?”

Then, realisation smacking her a few times over before it really sunk it, Adora’s eyes widened.

“Wait, they’re investigating a case, aren’t they!” she exclaimed, “Bow, you said there weren’t any cases.”

“I–I,” Bow was sweating, and he looked to Glimmer for help. She just gave him a face that counselled him to come clean. “I lied,” he said, “I didn’t want you to think about law stuff today.”

“So there is a case?”

"A friend of ours, Entrapta, came to me this morning about a murder trial. I passed it along to Phoenix Wright because today was supposed to be about rest."

"You…," Adora's fists curled into tight balls, shaking.

Her breaths turned into heated heaves, and she looked down that her eyes were covered in shade.

But then she loosened her hands, and sighed, "you were right. I can't go to trial."

Bow let out a sigh of relief. But Adora continued:

"I can't… defeat Catra."

"This isn't about Catra," Bow said. "You just needed to clear your head."

"No, I can't beat her," Adora said. "She knows everything about me, exactly what I'll do, exactly how to take me out." Her voice began to quaver, "And everytime I go against her, someone's life is ruined because of me."

She shook her head, barely keeping back the tears.

"It's better this way. Mr. Wright has never lost a case. Catra won't know how to beat him, at least at first. He'll have a better chance."

Bow and Glimmer shared another look. They had both known things were bad. Both had worried for weeks about their friend, but neither could have guessed that Adora —Adora of all people— had truly given up.

When they looked to Adora again, she had turned away and taken a few paces from them. Yet even in this she couldn't fully execute a decision. She just stood still, awkwardly in the middle of the room.

“Adora?” said Bow.

“Thanks for today,” she said in a small voice, still facing the opposite wall. “It was… real fun.”

But Bow couldn’t help but feel, despite everything, that this was a total failure.

Chapter End Notes

So I've actually gotten into the habit of writing every day, which has really held sustain productivity across the weeks, even if individual days aren't great. I've actually got reserves of chapters now, which gives me a bit of time between writing them and proofing them, which means my eyes are slightly fresher when going back through what I've made. I think this chapter had a lot of enjoyable stuff even though it's a bit bloated and juggling several subplots, but genuinely I don't think I could have legitimately cut anything unless really doing a fine comb-through.

I've been a bit disappointed with how little engagement this work is getting but that's on me for doing such a niche crossover I guess. Still, I'm still genuinely passionate about the story plan, especially this episode and the one after it, which will form the climax of this work. Even though it's an episodic structure, things will still feel like they're coming together, the various strands and through-lines and I'm hoping it'll be very satisfying.

Also just wanted to say I'm very fond of Entrapta and it's fun to write her, even though it was difficult to figure out how at first. She's clearly autistic-coded and while I'm not that myself I've a lot of relatives on the spectrum and my mother works for an autism charity, even then I knew I had to do a bit of research just to get the sensitivity right and avoid common pitfalls and tropes. I'm hoping I got the balance right and especially getting the comedy to emerge from her unique personality rather than being the butt of the joke

The Chief Prosecutor's Intervention

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The court was arranged no different from usual. A prosecutor —Catra— at one end, a defence attorney in Phoenix Wright at the other —Entrapta as assistant by his side. The Judge looked down from his high bench and was surrounded by raised galleries containing a crowd of noisy onlookers, while down at the dock was the defendant. It looked like a normal trial. It was a simple thing —a locked box mystery, one the prosecutor would try to prove, one the defence would try to foil. Nothing that couldn't be wrapped up in a day.

Ron Guy, the defendant, was sat straight on the edge of his seat, hands on his knees which were closed and rustling together . Being accused of murder had been an ordeal for him, and he'd been just as jumpy when Phoenix and Entrapta visited him in detention the day before. At least he was calm today. Phoenix had had some difficult witnesses before, but one who was prone to existential crises and wailing beyond hope was not going to win him any favours with the court.

With a bang of his gavel, Jhe judge dispelled the din of the crowd and began:

"We may now proceed with the trial of Ron Guy. Are the defence and prosecution ready?"

"I'm ready, your honour," said Phoenix.

Catra didn't say anything.

"Prosecutor, are you read—aghow!"

A wayward whip had sharply struck his hand.

“Silence, I need this moment,” said Catra.

The Judge just gave a mournful look but withdrew any further complaints. Phoenix bit back a remark. So much for contempt of court.

“Many,” Catra finally started, “have underestimated the man opposite me. I’m not going to be one of them. Phoenix Wright, I’m gonna be the woman who finally beats you.”

Phoenix watched her, his mouth slightly parting as he saw the unrelenting look in her two-coloured eyes.

But he set his brow and retorted, “my client is innocent, prosecutor. That’s all that matters here.”

“Then I hope you have evidence to show that,” Catra said in a croon, “I sure hope you don’t have to rely on an attorney’s tricks to keep this trial going.”

Phoenix only registered an objection to that in his head: they weren’t tricks per se; more tactics.

Catra called the first witness to the stand —detective Scorpia—, who started giving details of the case. Mostly they were a recap of what they’d learned yesterday, gleaning through the victim profile —Nellie McRaker, investigative journalist— the lockdown system of the building, and finding the defendant at the scene of the crime. There were a few more details. The autopsy report noted bruising on both sides of the victim’s body as a consequence of her fall.

“And most conclusively,” Scorpia was finishing, “we did a fingerprint analysis on the victim’s jacket. Since it was leather it held a super accurate imprint where the murderer must have grappled her. The results were the same as Ron Guy’s.”

Phoenix flinched, “seriously?! Why didn’t you mention that sooner!”

“Uh,” Scorpia gave a nervous smile, “I don’t know what you’re talking about….”

Catra snapped her whip taut, “I sure hope you’re not suggesting the police should be leaking information to the defence?”

“O-of course not,” said Phoenix. “How stupid of me....”

Still, it was up to Phoenix to find a good contradiction from that testimony, and he’d need a good one fast. But having not even expected the fingerprints, he had no clue as to how to contest that evidence, even though it was the most incriminating. For now, he thought to just press around on a few other statements.

Unfortunately, the details were trifling. Sure, Scorpia could be caught slightly unawares at some of the probing, but Catra usually had a good response. Phoenix was soon at the end of his rope, and starting to manifest it in a heavy slump across his back.

“What about,” he searched, “what you said about the murderer throwing the victim to the ground?”

“Uh, what about it?”

“Well, do we know for certain that’s how it happened?” asked Phoenix. “Perhaps he was tossed?”

“Tossed?” the Judge scoffed, “mr. Wright, is this line of question even relevant?”

“Well, the claim that Ron Guy killed the victim is dependant on a couple thins. Her being up in the room where he was found, and then ending up the floor of the chamber, right? If that’s not necessarily how it happened—”

“Perhaps stop right there before you make a bigger fool out of yourself,” Catra laughed, “the prosecution can easily provide evidence to show that the victim fell.”

“More evidence?”

Catra produced a electronic disc, “the chamber was fitted with a high-speed camera to record results from its tests. It shows the body falling from a great height.”

Entrapta reached out with her hair and snatched the disc. Catra grimaced and was about to protest, although she held back. Instead she watched as the defence placed the disc into a portable screen the scientist carried in her overalls. As promised, it showed the body hurtling down, striking the ground, with most of the shock absorbed by the floor so that there was only a slight rebound before it lay flat on its back. The video played. Falling, hitting the floor flat, slight rebound, landing flat.

“I guess the prosecutor really foresaw all possibilities,” Entrapta murmured.

“I dunno,” Phoenix stroked his chin, “she didn’t show us this earlier so it wasn’t much help on its own.”

Entrapta shrugged, “guess she didn’t need it. Like when we purged the whole east wing at the Institute because we had enough particle accelerators in the west.”

“Uh, sure,” said Phoenix, “but at the very least I can’t let this opportunity for a contradiction slide. There must be another side to this evidence… another side?”

“Well, this seems to put the defence’s question to rest,” the Judge noted. “The victim fell, clearly having been pushed. If that’s clear then—”

“OBJECTION!” Phoenix shouted, “prosecutor Catra. This evidence shows that there’s something wrong with your version of events. And if you looked at the autopsy report, you’d see what I’m talking about.”

Catra didn’t respond but to look back at him with a slight twitch her in lip. Scorpia however picked her copy of the autopsy report and scrolled through it, best as she could with her pincers.

“Oh, is it this thing, wait, nah,” she grunted, “sorry, could you just explain it for me uh, mr. Wright?”

“The body had bruising from the fall, of course,” said Phoenix with a grin, “on both sides in the report. But in video… we only see the victim fall flat on her back!”

There was a small though rather lax flurry of murmuring from the court. The Judge was quick to dispel it with his gavel.

Catra bared her teeth. Although she merely said, “this is more of an inconsistency than a contradiction. I fail to see how it proves anything.”

“The victim has bruises she shouldn’t according to the evidence as you’ve presented them,” Phoenix argued, “how do you explain this?”

“How do *you* explain this. You’re the one bringing this up and I fail to see its relevance.”

Frowning, Phoenix glared at Catra. The prosecution was playing tricky, but that wasn’t going to stop him now he had his first foothold.

“Let’s see,” he thought aloud, “perhaps I was right earlier? She was thrown into the wall but then fell?”

“Oh,” Catra said in a mocking purr, “so you agree Ron Guy threw the victim to her death?”

“Wait no! Okay, how about this. She was dropped before Ron Guy even arrived, then set up to fall again when he was about to frame him!”

“Ron Guy was always present, this isn’t going to work for you,” Catra grinned, “not to mention that there was only one bloodstain on the floor of the chamber, unless you mean to tell me the second drop perfectly matched the first?”

“Well, maybe it wasn’t at the chamber,” Phoenix suggested. “Maybe it happened elsewhere.”

“The autopsy report is very specific about when the victim died, down to the hour. You’re telling me someone was able to kill the victim and then sneak them into the building without being noticed by any of the guards? Plus take a number of pictures with the victim’s camera?”

“You might be on the wrong track,” Entrapta muttered.

“B-but,” Phoenix whined.

“When a theory fails to stand up with the evidence, you’ve gotta change the theory,” Entrapta said with a broad smile, “adaptation is the core of the scientific method!”

“Yeah, well the lawyer’s method means I can’t give up on this contradiction.”

“Well, consider the options.”

Phoenix let out a low hum, and ran through it in his head. The two drops idea was faulty, but how could it be explained in one drop? McRaker landed flat on her back, so there shouldn’t be any bruising on the other side of her body. Going down doesn’t explain it. Going sideways, thrown into the wall, doesn’t change anything for him. So what about going up….

“Maybe… the direction of the fall was reversed?” he said in perhaps the weakest voice he’d ever offered an explanation.

Catra let out a spurt of laughter, “yeah, sounds nice if it were possible.”

“Well…,” Phoenix said, “I thought it was weird that there was such a small amount of blood where the body impacted. The only place we wouldn’t have been able to see a larger stain of blood would be the ceiling because of the lighting.”

“Again, a nice notion but you can’t argue for something physically impossible,” Catra cocked her head with an toying smile, “or do want me to prove gravity to you, lawyer?”

“Gravity….,” Phoenix stared. His eyes were dull for a second, no thought behind them as so often happened when he was stumped. But then something glowed in them. A realisation. “It was a long vertical chamber, right? Maybe it was… well, I’m not a scientist, but I saw a lot of weird contraptions in that facility. Maybe it was an anti-gravity chamber?”

The court was silent. No-one had anything to say to that among the gallery. They all just looked at Phoenix, wondering if this was finally the day that mr. Wright had slipped from active imagination to actual delusion. The Judge in particular was shaking his head.

“That’s a ridiculous idea,” he said, “I know you wish to keep an open mind for the sake of your clients, but I worry that you’ve let in the air.”

“Look at this electrical usage record,” Phoenix said, suddenly producing the print-out Entrapta had given him the day before, “the chamber was drawing massive amounts of power at the same time the autopsy gives as the time of death! Can anyone else explain what was going on in that chamber?”

“Well, I—,” the Judge spluttered, not used to being posed questions so directly.

Catra however was just laughing. It had started off as an amused chuckle but it was quite higher now, both derisive but somehow not at the same time.

“I mean, wow,” she finally said, “I heard about your ability to bluff, but that was something else.”

“Do you deny the possibility?” Phoenix asked.

“No, it’s possible. In fact, it’s true.”

“It’s… wait, wHAAA!?”

“I knew there was something strange about the scene of the crime so I took some data and left to find a… well, I know a very skilled scientist myself. He verified that it was an anti-gravity chamber.”

“So I was right?” mouth slackened, Phoenix gazed at his own hands on the bench. “it was an anti-gravity chamber.”

“Note to self,” Entrapta spoke into her recorder, “lab 12-3 is the graviton-reversal and hyperacting experiment. P.S, lawyers are good at figuring things out, consider getting one as a permanent assistant.”

“When I learned that,” Catra continued, “I suspected that the victim possibly fell both ways.”

“Why didn’t you mention any of this?” asked the Judge, although cautious in tone and keeping an eye on Catra’s currently resting whip.

“Well, we could have tried to look at the ceiling but the effort to do so wouldn’t have been worth it. So what if the antigravity chamber was used? It doesn’t change the fingerprints, or the video recording. The victim was thrown down.”

“But this changes everything!” pronounced Phoenix, “because this means it’s possible the victim started on the ground level. Someone murdered her with the gravity without ever having to touch her!”

“OBJECTION!” Catra cracked her whip to stop Phoenix’s drivel, “first, tell me who you propose did this? No-one else has been identified as present at the facility, there’s no way we could have missed them! Second,” she grinned, “do you know where the controls for the anti-grav chamber are?”

“The controls? Uh,” he looked to Entrapta, “you remember it now, right? Where were the controls?”

Entrapta looked at him with a nervous smile, “uh, Phoenix, we saw the controls.”

“Oh right, you tried to activate them. They were up at the… oh no.”

“It seems the defence,” Catra said, delight in her tone, “have finally realised why this whole line of argument has been worthless. The controls were up on the platform where Ron Guy was locked in alone. The only person who could have activated the controls to kill the victim was the same as the only person who could have grabbed her and thrown her down —the person we know grabbed her, Ron Guy!”

Phoenix flinched with a loud, “nggghaaargh,” and felt so heavy as to collapse.

“That seems conclusive,” said the Judge, “on multiple accounts.”

“Wait, you can’t call a verdict now,” Phoenix protested, “we’ve not even had any witnesses or cross-examination yet!”

The Judge shook his head, “I just don’t see how there can be any misinterpretation of the facts, mr. Wright. Ron Guy was the only man in the room, the only person capable of dealing the killing action.”

“Wait, the room!” Phoenix seized upon a thought, “we glossed over that fact too quickly, but the prosecution is wrong to assert that only Ron Guy could have accessed it.”

“But I thought the door was locked?” the Judge frowned, beard ruffling, “was I misinformed?”

“They omitted a key fact,” said Phoenix, slamming the desk with both hands, “one concerning a secret tunnel—”

“Oh please,” Catra laughed again, “you think we didn’t notice that?”

Phoenix felt his chest deflate again, “you know about it…?”

“We have a witness deposition that confirms no-one entered through that pathway.”

“A witness,” Phoenix perked up, “yes, a witness. The defence requests that we cross-examine that witness.”

It was the only way to keep the trial going. If this witness claimed that no-one sneaked onto the platform, then that witness must be lying, and a contradiction Phoenix would find.

“From the look on your face,” Catra teased, “I’m guessing you’re hoping the witness is lying.”

Phoenix went immobile, caught in Catra’s mocking gleam.

“Unfortunately, we’ve got a witness who cannot lie,” she said. “I know you like theatrics, mr. Wright. Cross-examining a parrot, and a radio. Well enjoy cross-examining a robot. The prosecution calls the automaton designated as ‘Emily.’”

Entrapta smiled gleefully and gave a wave. Phoenix just watched with a deeply confused expression. The large ball stood about twice as wide as the witness stand, but only came up high enough that their gleaming purple eye was visible above it. Designed as it was, reading an expression was difficult, but it was tilted horizontally, looking with pleasant expectation from the defence to the prosecution.

“Name and occupation,” Catra began, although she was quickly cut off by the Judge:

“Uh, excuse me. I don’t know if I’m able to allow this testimony.”

“You can, your honour. If anything this witness is more reliable than the usual. As a machine, its power of recall will be accurate, and with a programmed mind, it must tell the truth.”

“Hmm, well, very well. Proceed.”

Catra asked what Emily was doing on the night of the murder, to which the robot explained. She was patrolling the room Phoenix and Entrapta had found her in, although that mostly consisted of occasionally pacing from one end to the other. If a person had walked in, it was inconceivable that they would have missed it. To drive the point home, Catra asked a number of questions. Did she see anyone? Did she hear anything? Were there any vibrations recorded that could suggest the passing of someone nearby. On and on, Catra asked, and down and down, Phoenix's heart sank. The testimony was simple. No-one passed by Emily.

How was he going to take this down?

"Maybe I can look through my notes?" suggested Entrapta, "there might be some way to pass by and leave no trace. Perhaps some sort of phasic shift —no wait, that was proven theoretically impossible in 2003 — okay what about— nah, that wouldn't work either——"

"Emily," Phoenix struck up, "can I ask about your functionality as a robot?"

"Mr. Wright," the Judge widened his eyes, "don't you want to cross-examine her testimony?"

"I think the testimony is airtight, but we can't accept evidence if it hasn't been thoroughly examined in itself. She may be a witness, but in a way, Emily is like a recorder or a video."

"Very well, what do you want to ask her then?"

"Emily," Phoenix said again, "you have an, uh, isomatrix that maps your decision making. You also have a personality core. So your mind is quite human-like."

"OH, YES," said Emily, and she seemed to lower herself, as if bashful, "T-THANK YOU!"

"Why can't you lie then?"

“WHAT DO YOU MEAN?”

“You’re telling me there’s no context in which the most logical thing to do is lie?”

Emily swung forward in a nodding motion.

“LYING ISN’T IN MY FUNCTIONALITY, I CANNOT CREATE FALSE INFORMATION. LOGIC CANNOT CHANGE THAT PREMISE.”

“Well then not logic,” Phoenix said, “what about your emotions? Emotions can make people do irrational things.”

“She’s not a person,” Catra retorted, “ultimately she can’t go against her programming; even with all her little add-ons.”

“I wouldn’t put it so rudely,” Entrapta said, folding her arms, “but she is right. I don’t think Emily could lie even if something provoked her emotions.”

“I disagree,” said Phoenix, “Emily is really advanced. Look at some of the ways she’s reacted already. You’re telling me she couldn’t be threatened.”

“THREATENED?” the ball perked, “N-NO, I WOULDN’T CHANGE UNDER THOSE PARAMETERS. PLEASE DON’T QUESTION FURTHER ON THIS.”

“Well, why not? Even if an animal thought something could destroy it, it would feel frightened.”

“F-F-FRIGHTENED! NO, I CAN’T BE FRIGHTENED.”

“You sure?” Phoenix leaned forward, pushing further. “Nothing in the twisting hallways as you were patrolling? Lights going out intermittently, leaving you in the dark? No-one showed up and said they would tear you apart plate by plate if you said anything?”

“I-I-I,” the static stuttering was accompanied by sparks, “PLEASE STOP ASKING ME. PLEASE STOP ASKING—”

“She’s scared!” a fretful Entrapta shouted.

“Maybe so,” Catra growled, “but so what. She can’t lie, that would go against her programming.”

“What if there was a way for her to ignore her programming… to make a decision for herself? She already has the isomatrix—”

“So what?”

“Well, a person might have instincts but they can always choose. I mean that’s why we’re here right? A person can be judged for their choices in a court of law!”

Catra grimaced, and looked down for a moment, shadowing her eyes.

Phoenix continued, “if someone threatened her, then she might have deliberately overcome her programming as a way of choosing self-preservation.”

“Hmm, well this is getting awfully philosophical,” said the Judge, “but for someone to choose, surely they must be conscious, uh, self-aware. An animal might fight or flee to preserve themselves but that’s just part of their nature. For a robot to overcome a specific program to preserve themselves, surely they must have, I guess, a consciousness?”

“Or a soul,” said Phoenix, suddenly smacked by the full implication of his reasoning. “Of course,” he whispered, breath tinged with a gentle spark. He spoke loudly again, “the defence would like to provide evidence that would show the witness has a soul.”

There was no response, but for stares from around the room. The Judge merely watched, mouth slightly parted, eyes fixed on Phoenix. Taking that as enough, Phoenix brought out the evidence:

“TAKE THAT!” he retrieved the metal 9-shaped object, “this is an artificial magatama, a piece of technology that can channel the same energy as used in Kurainist spiritual practice.”

“Really?” said Catra, “you’re trying to tell me this thing is alive?”

“Not just that, I’m saying that Emily is able to lie to preserve herself. It’s true right,” he looked at the robot, “you were threatened. Who threatened you?”

Emily was shuddering, as if her internal machinery were about to burst.

“NOOOOOooooOOOzzz~,” the witness’s screech declined into static, and briefly her lights went out.

It was the detective who went up to her and checked up on her. With some words of comfort and a soft smile, Scorpia seemed to calm Emily down, and the large ball was able to push itself up again.

“IT’S TRUE,” she admitted, “I WAS SCARED.”

“Why?” asked Phoenix, “who scared you?”

“A MAN. HE TOLD ME TO SAY NOTHING.”

“Can you identify him to the court?” asked the Judge.

“THERE WAS NO LIGHT,” Emily tilted down, “I’M SORRY.”

“No light at all? But you just said he was a man, maybe you saw his silhouette?”

“At the very least you heard a voice,” said Catra.

“YES, A SILHOUETTE AND VOICE. RETRIEVING….,” Emily paused as a clattering sound signified the swift processing of data, “THE SHAPE OF THE SILHOUETTE AND SOUND OF THE VOICE MOST CLOSELY MATCHES THOSE OF RON GUY.”

Catra smiled, “oh, what a surprise.”

“Wait,” Phoenix said in panic, “that doesn’t make any sense!”

“It seems consistent with all else we know,” said the Judge, “the defendant passed by the patrolling witness on his way to the platform, at which point he activated the gravity and killed the victim.”

“But think about it! We now know someone threatened the witness—yeOOW”

A thwack had left a sharp welt on his outstretched hand.

“The *defendant* threatened the witness,” Catra said, “that’s what it just said.”

“The witness couldn’t clearly identify them though—”

“You were the one who insisted she judge from his silhouette, and you seemed ready to accept it before she called out your client.”

“Let me finish!” Phoenix wined, still nursing his hand, “the witness was telling us before that no-one passed through. But she was only doing that because someone threatened her.”

“What’s does that matter? Either way the defendant is implicated.”

“Because before there was no chance that anyone else could have done it. But if someone were out to frame him, they’d tell her to keep quiet about them moving through the secret passage!”

“I’m a little lost here,” said the Judge, “if that’s true, then why would the witness identify this the defendant anyway?”

“I don’t know your honour,” Phoenix said between clenched teeth, his mind whirring, “maybe it was a precaution. He disguised himself as Ron?”

“Down to his voice?”

“We’ve seen in this very court people who could change their voice.”

Catra rolled her eyes, “but not their appearance as well. How do you propose that one person could be someone else, mr. Wright? Do you have any evidence?”

The Judge gave a nod.

“Yes, I believe this trial has come to its end, unless the defence can prove that the person the witness identified could have been anyone other than Ron Guy.”

With his hands closed tight upon the woodwork, Phoenix dug his knuckles into the bench. He thought. No, there was nothing, surely, he was stumped for good this time. And unless Entrapta had suddenly engineered a way to channel Mia, he’d be getting no help from beyond the grave this time.

He mentally scoured through the evidence. The autopsy report, the video, the photograph of Ron Guy, the electrical data, the photograph of Ron Guy.

No, that was more of a picture.

Phoenix stood up slightly straighter. The picture, and the photograph, supposedly of the same person. But they didn’t look quite the same. But he was certain he had seen the exact person before. That same fixed expression, long ears, and dark hair.

Ron Guy had been sitting in the dock the whole time, constantly rustling but quiet in his terror. His hair was white.

Memory shot, not fit to pull any name out of a hat to put to the face, Phoenix had to do this, he had to try. It was a bluff. There were a hundred ways he could be wrong. But his head took the backseat now to the driving force of energy that shot up through him, filling his chest with a light air and propelling his arm forward to a point:

“HOLD IT! Your honour, I have the evidence!”

The Judge stopped. Entrapta looked up with a gasp. Catra sneered.

“I direct the court to look at this framed picture,” said Phoenix, “I think it shows quite clearly how one person can seem to be someone else.”

“I don’t understand,” the Judge rubbed the side of his bald head, “how does this show anything?”

“First, let me ask the witness,” Phoenix turned to Emily, “who do you see in this picture.”

“IT LOOKS LIKE RON GUY,” she said, “ALTHOUGH RON USUALLY LOOKS A LOT HAPPIER.”

“Right, and your honour, why don’t you have a look.”

“Well, I’ve only just met the fellow, but I’m sure if its him I should—,” the Judge’s expression went blank. He stared at the picture that had just been delivered to him. “I say,” he murmured, quite amazed, “I know this man. He’s the Chief Prosecutor. But… where did you get such a picture?”

“OBJECTION!” Catra struck her bench with the whip, “what the hell does this have to do with anything? So you have a picture of Hordak. So what?”

“You don’t think the fact that Emily identified him as Ron says something?”

“So they look similar. But whatever, she wasn’t prepared to think of anyone else so that’s the person who came to mind.”

“But she would have far more expected him than Hordak anyway—”

“This is ridiculous!” Catra said through clenched teeth, “you’re talking about the Chief Prosecutor, you don’t just throw his name around in a murder trial.”

“She is right,” said the Judge, “you’re treading on dangerous ground. I don’t see how I can allow this evidence to be accepted into the record unless it’s more clearly tied to the case.”

Phoenix placed his hands on his hips and grinned. Sure, he hadn’t fully explained it to them yet, but it was still quite a marvel to see both the Judge and the Prosecution so far behind. It gave him a bit of a tingly feeling. But it was time to lay the heavy blow:

“You must let me finish, your honour,” he said, “for I was just about to say how relevant this picture is. Do you not wonder why I have a portrait of the Chief Prosecutor in my hand?”

“Hmm… perhaps as a mark of respect for such an eminent man?”

Phoenix stifled what might have been either a groan or sigh. What did he think he was, a bootlicker?

“No,” he said, “I found this picture at the Dryl Institute.”

“Th-the… the Dryl Institute!” the Judge was shaken, and by the agitated sounds from above, many others were too. “But what was it doing there?”

“I don’t know, your honour, but clearly the Chief Prosecutor has some connection with it. And considering how the witness just mistook him for the defendant, then we can’t end this trial until we know what it is!”

“OBJECTION!” Catra now just slammed the bench with a fist, “this is completely irrelevant! Hordak has nothing to do with this case, so whatever connection he might have to the place has nothing to do with it!”

“I’m sorry, prosecutor Catra, but you have no basis to make that kind of argument anymore,” said Phoenix. “We deserve to know

what the connection is!”

Catra snarled. She threw her gaze to the side for a few seconds, and after a quick rumination, looked back at Phoenix with spite. Then she turned to Emily.

“Witness, answer the question.”

“M-ME?” Emily said with a sudden shudder.

Catra bared both whip and fangs, and it seemed to be enough. Emily quickly rattled off:

“HORDAK WAS THE NAME OF A PREVIOUS EMPLOYEE OF THE INSTITUTE. THAT IS PROBABLY WHY A PICTURE OF HIM EXISTED THERE!”

“An employee?” Phoenix repeated.

He quickly turned to Entrapta, although she was just staring ahead. She wouldn’t be meeting his eye the rest of this trial.

“The prosecution was already well aware of this,” said Catra. “We investigated it. and can confirm there is no relevant information for establishing the facts of this case.”

“HORDAK LEFT ON UNFRIENDLY TERMS,” Emily continued, “I CANNOT RETRIEVE ALL MY MEMORY BECAUSE HE REMOVED FILES OF HIS TIME AT THE INSTITUTE. PERSONNEL FILES RELATING TO HIS RESEARCH ARE… GONE. THEY WERE VERY IMPORTANT.”

“His research?” said Phoenix, “why did he want to delete the files on that?’

“METADATA SUGGESTS HE DIDN’T WANT THEM TO BE SEEN BY ANYONE?”

“Your honour,” Phoenix whipped around to look up at the Judge, “we need to see those files. They could reveal motivation for

breaking into the facility. If McRaker learned anything about his research, that could explain why he killed her!”

“Mr. Wright, I don’t like any of this.” Deep concern was wrinkling into the Judge;s face, “this is the Chief Prosecutor we’re talking about. To indict him is… this is a grave matter.”

“Dismiss it,” Catra demanded, “don’t drag the court through the mud for the sake of his bluffs!”

“Hmm, I am inclined to agree, but,” the Judge paused, “the resemblance is striking. I can’t discount the possibility. I will grant the request. Bailiff, go to the prosecutor’s office and get those files.”

Phoenix could breathe. The trial was turning about before his very eyes, and it filled him to the brim with a buzz that only a lawyer knew. Across from him, Catra rapped her claws on the bench, scowling. The main door swung open and shut to admit the bailiff, now gone. The chamber was silent.

Ten terse minutes marched on with the trial at a complete standstill, with such anticipation caught in the air that the Judge dare not call for a recess lest the bailiff made sudden return. Finally there was a sound of footsteps, clacking with echo from the lobby beyond. But it wasn’t with any rush, such as a man hurtling to get back from the prosecutor’s office with the evidence he’d retrieved. No, instead it was a stride, hurried but still of the pace of someone who knew they had time. Then the door burst open.

Tall, white faced, long ears, dark in hair and with the firmest foulest expression dug into his harshly angled face, Chief Prosecutor Hordak stepped into the berth of the chamber. There was shock but no murmurs. Even Catra stood up a little straighter. Entrapta however, seemed to shrink behind Phoenix, who was staring ahead at the man with an unbroken gaze.

The Judge, like all others, was most perturbed, "Chief Prosecutor Hordak? You're here?"

"These are sensitive matters," Hordak said, coming up to the stand. "This court has no right to discuss them. I am calling for an immediate end to these day's proceedings."

"OBJECTION!" Phoenix slammed the bench, "on what grounds?"

"On *those* grounds," Hordak snapped. He glared with glowing red eyes, "and on my authority."

The blood drained from Phoenix's head, and his arms began to shake. But he held his grip, and maintained his look forward. He just needed to stall until those documents arrived.

But before he could object again, Catra spoke:

"Chief Prosecutor, you don't need to do this. I've seen the documents in question, there's nothing incriminating about them. Just let the defence look them over and then the trial will end with a guilty verdict."

"I cannot allow—"

"I'm so close!" Catra pleaded, "and it's Phoenix Wright! You wanted him beaten, didn't you?"

"I, nnrgh," the Chief Prosecutor made a snarling face, but he couldn't repudiate Catra in that second. He folded his arms and looked down for a moment, in bitter thought. Then he looked again and said, "no, it simply will not do."

"Hordak, please—"

"ENOUGH!"

He had bellowed. Catra, shrinking and ears flitting back, fell silent.

Phoenix wasn't going to bend so easily, "Chief Prosecutor, I have evidence that connects you to the Dryl Institute. We can't discount you from being involved in the murder of Nellie McRaker."

"You have no power to offer evidence."

"I'm a lawyer, and I must defend my client. It is my prerogative—"

"Phoenix Wright," Hordak said with a loud declaratory ring. He produced a sheet of paper, "I have obtained confirmation for you to be disbarred. You are a lawyer no longer, and cannot offer evidence!"

"D-disbarred?" Phoenix almost fell back. "You can't do that!"

"As a member of the Prosecutorial Investigation Committee," Hordak explained, "I have the right to make the request to the Bar Association. But they're the ones who made the decision. They have noted your long service of improper conduct and violation of discovery protocol. Now," he turned to the Judge, "with no lawyer present to represent the defendant, this trial cannot proceed until tomorrow."

A blunted ringing filled Phoenix's ears. It seemed as if the walls were collapsing in on him, and he fell to the bench, head in hands. Disbarred? The trial delayed when he was so close. The fate of Ron Guy now lost to an indeterminate future. How had everything turned about in such a short time?

The doors opened again, and this time it was the bailiff who returned, with a folder under his arm. Though worn out from rushing, he wore a smile of satisfaction from having completed his task. But he looked upon the scene ahead of him and it washed away. The Judge looked with a rather defeated, fallen look.

"I… cannot accept this evidence, I'm afraid," he explained. "Even I cannot give leeway to allow a disbarred lawyer to continue in court. I will have to suspend today's proceedings."

He banged his gavel.

Chapter End Notes

Wow has it been a week already. As you can see things are getting pretty wacky. The made-up science is one thing, but Phoenix v Catra? How do you contain the snark.

I've just had a really productive weekend, writing about 4000 words each on Sunday and Monday. 3 chapters are more or less completed and waiting in reserve, but I think I'm going to keep steady releasing one a week. If I keep this surplus up, I might increase the scheduling, but you never know when a slump might come so it's always good to keep a buffer.

Covering all the Bases

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Of the first day of the Ron Guy's trial —gravity chambers, living robots, Catra's tricks and Chief Prosecutor Hordak's entrance — Adora and the others had seen it all. Bow might have objected to their going: if it been before their day out, he'd worry that even just seeing a trial with Catra would send her further down her spiral. But now he felt it was a step up. When Adora had told him and Glimmer that she didn't believe she could ever win against the prosecutor, they realised the scale of the problem was far deeper than they could have imagined. At that point, Bow assumed seeing Phoenix put her in her place would at least give Adora a boost of nerve.

They hadn't expected what they saw.

It was parasitic on Adora's heart as they returned to Brightmoon, eating away at her, hollowing her out. She just couldn't stop thinking about what a sham it all was. To think there was someone who could even make Catra look ethical. Everything Glimmer had ever said about the corruption within that they needed to fight, it all seemed so real now. And having seen it so clearly, it left her wondering. It left her numb.

She went straight to her room, and threw herself into the bed. It was harder now. She'd replaced the mattress at last. But now she regretted doing so. Why couldn't she just fall away and forget about this whole law thing for good.

"Adora?"

Looking up, she expected Glimmer or Bow. It was Angella. The woman wore a face of concern.

"You didn't show up to training… again."

“Sorry,” Adora muttered.

“It doesn’t really matter, although I’d prefer forewarning. In this case… is something wrong?”

“Yeah. Quite a lot.”

Unable to stop herself, Adora delved into it all. She was quite thorough, and if the situation described hadn’t been so grave, Angella might have remarked on Adora’s ability to absorb everything that had happened, down to listing every piece of evidence debated in the trial —even she had struggled to keep on top of her own court record back in her best trials. But instead she listened with patience. Although, she couldn’t contain her shock when she learned of Hordak’s entrance.

“I’d never think they’d get so brazen,” she said in a marvel.

“He took mr. Wright’s badge,” Adora said, feeling hot steam fill her lungs as she recalled the injustice, “just so he wouldn’t uncover his wrongdoing!”

“That’s terrible. I can speak from experience,” a shadow of pain crept along Angella’s face, “although in my case it was deserved.”

Adora let out a heavy sigh. Her glance tracked over the drawer on the other side of the bedroom. “I’m She-Ra. This is what I’m meant to do, isn’t it? Take on Hordak, end the corruption… something.”

“I wouldn’t know, that’s more Glimmer’s area of knowledge.”

“But I don’t know what I’m supposed to do! I can’t just go fight him with a sword, he has power. He has the law on his side, all I have is some stupid prophecy.”

“Adora, I think you’re letting everything get ahead of you,” Angella said. She came to sit by Adora’s side, and continued, “we aren’t heroes, at the end of the day. We’re only human.”

“But I can’t just… not do something.”

“Coming to your room to hide because the problem is too big seems a lot like doing nothing,” Angella said, a little dryly. But she was more tender when she said, “I know that because that’s been me for the past decade.”

Angella held out a hand, laying her palm on Adora’s cheek. It was cold to the touch, but it sparked her with a wave of warmth.

“Adora, I want you to succeed where I couldn’t,” Angella said, “not because I think I can live some glory through you, but because I want you to be happy. And I want you to help people, not least because I know you want to help people. Glimmer does too, and I’ve made the mistake of trying to protect her when all it’s done is hinder her.”

“Angella, I….”

The woman let her hand slip from Adora’s face and looked forward again, “so I think you need to focus on that. Who is it that most needs help?.”

“Well, Phoenix is in trouble but I think he can handle himself. It’s the defendant, Ron Guy. He’s innocent, isn’t he.”

“Perhaps you’ll have to go find out yourself, but if you come to believe that he is, then what you should do next will be clear.”

“And Hordak?”

“That’s trickier, but he can’t disbar every lawyer in the world. They stopped the trial today because Ron Guy doesn’t have a representative.”

Adora stood.

“Then…, that’s what I should do, isn’t it.”

"You'll have to make that choice for yourself. If it were me, well, perhaps I wouldn't." Angella gave a weak smile. "But I'm a coward, so what does that matter."

Adora steadily stepped forward. She came up to the dresser, opening the draw to find the bracelet, which she retrieved. Holding it in her hand, the gold hummed, vibration emanating from the jewel in its centre.

"I…."

Adora's insides were twisting, half going one way, the other the opposite. But she fixed her brow, and slid the bracelet on. It felt right.

"What about Prosecutor Catra?" asked Angella.

"Catra…," Adora repeated.

"You'll have to face her again."

"I know. But I guess it was always going to come to this." Adora breathed in, "but I'm an attorney who must defend her client. I'll try to prove his innocence and if Catra beats me well…. If I'm going to lose either way, it's better to lose having tried."

Angella didn't respond but to give an encouraging smile. She knew Adora would need nothing more from her.

Across the city, near People Park, Phoenix Wright was not quite as stoical about the whole situation. He was still convulsing with anger as he returned to the Wright and Co. office, Entrapta on his heel.

"I have been whipped, I have been tasered, accused of murder; I've had the Chief of Police threatened to sue me, but I don't think anyone has ever had the gall to stop me from pursuing the case as a lawyer before!"

With a groan, he collapsed onto a chair behind the desk. He almost knocked Charley the plant over, and quickly sent a hand to stabilise it. If he lost his badge and the lily, the ghost of Mia would probably haunt him for the rest of time.

Entrapta was just stood. She had a welding mask down, completely obscuring her face. The two circles for eyes in the metal placing just stared out forlorn.

"How come you didn't say anything?" asked Phoenix, "about Hordak working at Dryl?"

"I didn't want to bring it up," Entrapta said in a small voice.

"It's important. I need to know everything, anything that could give me a clue."

Suddenly a hair lifted Entrapta's mask, revealing a smile, "okay!"

She jumped onto the chair opposite Phoenix, sitting cross-legged and throwing herself into an explanation. She and Hordak had indeed worked together. Prosthetics, portal technology, even the early research into Kurainism, the two had enjoyed a productive partnership. They had broken new scientific ground every other day.

"But we had different approaches to the research," said Entrapta. "I believe in the scientific method. You try every option and test every theory —negatives are part of that experience. You eliminate the possibilities to narrow in on the truth. Hordak," her head fell, "he was always different. When he got attached to an idea, he'd never give it up, even when evidence seemed to run contrary to his hypotheses. I'm not saying he was wrong —some of our greatest breakthroughs came through his inabilities to let a notion go; we just needed to modify his proposal to hone in on the truth. But… he couldn't take failure well. He could get emotional about it." Entrapta looked up to the ceiling, smile lingering, but a weakness held within. "His was the way of

perfection, mine was of imperfection. Maybe it was those creative different that led him away?"

"So Emily was right?" asked Phoenix, "he left on bad terms?"

"Yeah."

"What happened?"

"I don't… I don't know really," she said. "It was sudden. I couldn't understand… well, I don't understand. Or maybe he wasn't very communicative about it —he could be reticent at the best of times. But I don't know. People sometimes get angry with me and I don't know why unless I get them to explain clearly… and people don't want to explain things in logical terms when they're emotional."

"Then why did you want to make your robots more like people?" Phoenix said, Emily's episode resurfacing to his mind, "wouldn't that make them harder for you?"

Entrapta shrugged, "I don't really know. In a way, maybe it was because of Hordak that I did."

Phoenix was about to question further, when there was a knock on the door. It opened, as in came Miles Edgeworth. A serious look bore heavy on his furrowed brow, although there was a touch of irony to his lips.

"I turn my attention away for, what, five minutes?" he began. "What the hell happened, Wright?"

"I didn't do anything wrong!" Phoenix said, standing up to greet him, "how much have you heard?"

"Enough. The Chief Prosecutor had your badge removed while your trial was still going. I've never known the Bar Association to act with such efficiency."

"Can you believe this?"

“Wright, you need to stay calm,” Edgeworth said, laying his hands on Phoenix’s arms, “I’ve opened my channel of communication with the Bar. We can smooth this over. I—”

Voluminous pink hair caught Edgeworth’s notice by the corner of his eye. He looked to Entrapta, and then back to Phoenix.

“Wright, have you adopted yet another teenager?”

“Uh, she’s not a teenager,” Phoenix gave a silly grin as he rubbed his neck, “if anything, she’s adopted me.”

Entrapta whispered into her recorder:

“Members of defence and the prosecution collude behind closed doors. These two greet one another as old friends… or, judging by their proximity to one another, perhaps more?”

Phoenix and Edgeworth shared a look, then quickly each took a pace back.

“Look, Wright,” he said, “I can get you your badge back as soon as possible but I can’t guarantee less than a few days. In the meantime you can’t approach the crime scene, and you certainly can’t represent mr. Guy in court.”

“But he’s my client,” said Phoenix, stressing the last word, “I can’t just do nothing.”

“Nothing is precisely what you must and will do,” Edgeworth said back. “But I believe a solution will present itself to us. In fact, I believe it will present itself shortly.”

Phoenix barely had time to raise an eyebrow. There was another knock on the door, although this was more of a frantic banging.

“Mr. Wright, Mr. Wright? Are you there?” came a familiar voice.

Phoenix went and opened it. Two girls, one in her red jacket, one in her pastel skirt suit, and a boy in his blue uniform. All were

huffing, although each had a determined look in the eye as they looked up at Phoenix.

“Adora? Glimmer, Bow?” he said. “Is something up?”

“By all means, come in,” said Edgeworth, “Wright is certainly not going anywhere soon.”

The squad entered, standing in trio by the door as Phoenix went to lean on his desk.

“Mr. Wright, I saw everything,” said Adora, “I want to help.”

“I mean, damn, Adora,” Phoenix gave a chuckle, “at this rate you’ll be finishing all my cases.”

“I’ve studied the court record and I’ve considered— wait, what?”

“Keep pace, Attorney,” said Edgeworth with a cool tone, “Wright isn’t quite as slow as he lets on.”

“Hey!” Phoenix gave his protest to Edgeworth, before turning back to the three, “but yeah, you want to take the case, right? It’s the most logical solution.”

Entrapta propelled herself up by her hair, and climbed her way to the door.

“I’ll go update Ron,” she said, “you three find us at the detention centre when you’re ready.”

After she left, Edgeworth was the next stepped forward.

“It would be improper for me to aid the defence in any capacity, so I’ll take my leave too. But I suggest you overview your plan and investigate quickly. Who knows what the opposition is up to as we speak.”

With that, he followed Entrapta out, and it was just the four remaining.

“So, you guys know the case?” asked Phoenix.

Bow nodded and listed off, “Nellie McRaker, death by blunt force trauma, bruising both sides, manipulated to fall both up and down by a gravity chamber; Ron Guy the defendant was supposedly the only person at the platform, but potentially an imposter was seen by a witness entering as well.”

“And that guy is Hordak,” said Adora, “why else would he force the trial to end like that?”

“It does seem like it,” said Phoenix, “he worked for the Dryl Institute, that has to mean something.”

“We should check it out ourselves,” suggested Glimmer, “but we also need those documents you requested.”

“The Judge wouldn’t admit them because I wasn’t an attorney anymore. But if you guys go to the prosecutor’s office, maybe you can request them yourselves?”

“Then we should go right away.”

Adora turned and yanked the door open. There were only so many hours left in the day, and they would need to make effective use of them. As the three slipped through, Phoenix called out after them:

“Make sure you get some hard evidence!” he said. “I’ll just be here. Alone. Without my badge….”

It was no easy route to the Prosecutor’s office. The path took them to some of Los Angeles’ most human-hostile roads, and with busy traffic enmeshing them in the harsh noise of motor vehicles. But they moved speedily along. Adora headed them, walking such a pace that it was almost a run. Though they certainly didn’t enjoy it, the other two kept up and refrained from complaint.

Finally they reached the office, and did not tarry getting in. Adora knew her way, and led them through the lobby as if they were

meant to be there, finding an elevator, and going up. When they reached the level, they streamed past along a carpeted floor. A few people were around. Many of them turned their heads at Adora, wearing wary faces. She just gave them back an awkward smile.

"Old friends of yours?" asked Glimmer.

"It was bound to happen," Adora said, "and I guess no-one's happy about me leaving. But it should be fine so long as we don't bump into—"

" *Hey, Adora* ."

Adora grimaced.

It was Catra. She stood across the hallway, facing them. Facing Adora. Holding a series of files under arm, she wore a smug look. Adora could guess what those were.

But she quite forgot about the reason she was here for a second. The sight of Catra filled her with apprehension. The other regarded her with thin pupils. Her eyes were far colder, far more on edge than her smile would suggest, and even that seemed to falter the more she looked at Adora.

"What do you want?" Adora asked.

"Nothing," said Catra, looking away with a sudden bored air, "apart from getting this trial over as quickly as possible."

"Maybe you should take that up with your boss?" said Glimmer, watching Catra with a foul look.

"I have no idea what's going on with Hordak. And I don't care."

Adora closed her fist, though it was out of sight.

"Not even if it turns out he's guilty?" she asked.

Catra narrowed her eyes.

“I’ve been thorough. Phoenix Wright can rattle off about the documents all he wants, they don’t reveal anything incriminating.” A grin then split across her face, and she lobbed the folder, soaring the space between them, landing right into Adora’s clutch. “So I don’t mind you having a look. That’s even the hard paper copy which Hordak took from the facility.”

Adora marvelled at the papers in her hand, and her face lit as she looked up at Catra again. But then she knit her brow, and accused Catra with a glare.

“Oh come on,” Catra scoffed, “how tacky do you think I am?”

“You’ve hidden evidence before.”

“Yeah but not tampered with anything.” She smirked at Glimmer, “I’m not Angella, am I.”

”You—“

Glimmer made a sudden lurch forward, but Bow restrained her. Catra laughed.

“Why are you all so easily ruffled?”

“Catra…,” Adora grit her teeth. But she decided to hold back any more remarks. Instead she looked down and flipped though the documents. “‘Genetically similar blood,’… wait a minute, this is an experiment involving both Hordak and Guy!”

“If they’re genetically similar, then they must be related,” said Bow, “that explains why they look so similar.”

“Yeah, obviously,” said Catra.

“Why keep this a secret?” Adora asked her, “the defence could have shown the fingerprints were not necessarily Ron’s?”

Catra rolled her eyes, “okay, genius, do you not know how fingerprint’s work?”

“I… uh….”

“Fingerprints are more or less unique,” Bow quickly explained, “even between brothers.”

“And we checked the all the records,” Catra continued, “there’s no match with Hordak.”

“Maybe…,” Adora muttered, “maybe he changed the data? He’s clearly using his power for his own ends, we can’t count off the possibility.”

“Whatever,” said Catra, “your can make all the claims you want. But without evidence, you have nothing.”

Adora kept a wary eye on Catra for a second, before rummaging through the documents to see if there was anything else. There was little. The only other thing pertained to a research grant from Prime Industries, one that went directly through Hordak.

“Prime Holdings is involved in the Dryl Institute?” said Adora.

Catra shrugged, “maybe. They were at least.”

“Is there anything more to the connection?”

“Obviously not. What would some investor have to do with Hordak and a journalist?”

“Maybe McRaker found something she wasn’t supposed to,” Adora wondered, “something to do with an illicit flow of money?”

Catra peered at her for a few seconds, only to break with chuckle, “ah yes, how nefarious. Science money, the new racket. Whatever, we’ll see how far your claim stands in court tomorrow.”

The prosecutor strode forward, ready to push through them and brush past. But Adora stopped her, holding her back by the wrist. Catra tried to wrest free, but Adora's grip was too strong. For a moment, a flash of worry struck across her face. Then there was a tinge of awe as she met Adora's gaze. Perhaps if they held like that for a second more it would have become a blush.

Instead, Adora spoke in an agitated whisper, "I know what you are now. Fine, that's your problem. But you told me you hated criminals."

"What, of course I—"

"If Hordak is a murderer, are you really comfortable letting him get away with it?"

Catra quarried for a retort. She thought to spit a laugh in Adora's face for her naivety. But she couldn't find either. Instead, she just glared, before finally ripping her arm free. Then she walked off at last.

"Come on," Adora said to the others in a curt manner, "let's go to Dryl."

Getting to the Institute wasn't as hard a journey. They knew the way from yesterday when they had gone to the sister building of Prime Holdings. Scorpia was there to greet them at the entrance, accompanied by the robot Emily.

"Got a heads up that you'd be coming," the detective hollered, waving her big pincer. "So you're taking the case?'

"That's right."

"Detective, have you found anything more at the crime scene?" asked Bow.

Scorpia shook her head, "we've sifted every last particle of the place, I'm afraid. Both the chamber and the platform. There's just nothing to suggest there was a third person that night."

“Do you still think it’s Ron Guy?” asked Glimmer.

“Well, Catra seems sure, and she’s got a good nose for things.”

The three looked at the detective, all with scepticism.

“I mean,” Scorpia nervously scratched her cheek, “not that she never gets things wrong of course. Personally,” she looked away, “I don’t know why the Chief Prosecutor would obstruct things if he didn’t have anything to hide. So I just don’t know what to think anymore.”

“I DON’T THINK IT WAS GUY OR HORDAK,” Emily pined, “I DON’T WANT TO BELIEVE IT.”

“Aw,” Scorpia smiled, “you’re a good cookie, Emily.”

The robot shook with glee at the compliment. Scorpia turned back to the others.

“We were just going to have a look down in the maze.”

“The maze?”

“That’s what the team called the lower labyrinth. We weren’t able to go far because of how lost we’d get, but with Emily to guide me I thought I’d just have a look. What about you guys?”

“If Hordak did come here that night,” said Adora, “then he went through the secret passage. That’s where we need to start.”

With a nod of acknowledgement, Scorpia led them in. The detective and her new robot friend took them through the initial twisting ways of the Institute, and then gave them directions up, as they took a stairwell down.

“Take this,” Scorpia gave them a walkie-talkie, “just in case we find anything big, we can communicate.”

With that, Bow, Glimmer and Adora continued alone. It wasn't long before they arrived at the same passage that Phoenix and Entrapta had investigated only a day prior.

In the cluttered first room, they were greeted by the magic horse. Majestic, pure white in his coat down to the pinkish tips of the hooves, and with a luscious mane of orange and peach. His frame was strong but agile, it had the body of an Andalusian but the gracile nozzle of an Arabian. Adora overflowed with wonder.

"Oh my god," she said in a hush.

She approached the beast, and it did not resist. With a careful hand, she placed a palm on the side of his cheek and gently brought his head into her chest, at which he playfully nudged.

"You like horses then," Glimmer giggled.

"I could have been an equestrian," said Adora, nostalgic for a life she never had.

"With those wings, you could have been a pilot," remarked Bow.

When they entered the second room, they found it empty but for the station at the far end. Glimmer went up to the computer and started typing some of the keys.

"What do you think it is?" asked Adora.

"Well, let's open it up," said Glimmer

She pressed something that caused a jet of steam to eject from some tubing. This was followed by the container at the computer's side to open up, and its frigid blue interior was revealed. It was filled with a series of glass vials, each with a dark liquid inside.

"Blood," said Bow, "maybe this is the experiment referenced in the document. Let me have a look."

He took the folder and flipped to the record of the blood experiment. Yet as he did so, his brow furrowed, and he looked up half-resigned.

“What’s wrong?” asked Adora.

“This is incomplete. There should be a letter designation to identify it with one of these vials but it’s missing from the text.”

“Maybe it wasn’t part of the report,” said Glimmer.

“No, I mean it’s physically missing, there’s a space where it’s been rubbed out.”

“Damnit,” Adora scowled, “she did tamper with it!”

“It might not have been Catra,” said Bow, “more likely Hordak did it himself.”

“Then why get so anxious about someone seeing the documents if he already covered his tracks?”

“That’s it!” Bow said, realisation washing over him, “there’s something in his blood he doesn’t want found. The designation is on this paper.”

“But you said it was wiped off?”

“Bow…,” said Glimmer, still clicking away at the computer.

“Forensics, Adora,” Bow said, quickly withdrawing his pad, a smile plastered across his face, “I can easily find the traces from when the ink was still on the paper. We can retrieve the letter designation.”

“Bow, just wait—”

Bow started tracking his pad over the white-out spot on the page. Then he tapped away on the screen, reconstructing the data from the trace elements of ink and the grooving from where it was

printed. Soon the screen came up with the letters in succession, and Bow punched the air.

"We've got it! CXIPQRCS. Type that in Glimmer. Heh," he chuckled, smug, "I bet you wanna retract what you said about the usefulness of forensics, don't you, Glimmer."

"Bow, I already found Hordak's blood," said Glimmer, showing him the vial, "and Ron Guy's."

"Wh-what?"

"It was labelled on the computer."

Bow's entire body slumped.

"B-but…."

"Wait, I thought Hordak removed all references to himself from Dryl's computers?" Adora recalled. "How could it be labelled?"

"Well it's deduction, isn't it," said Glimmer, "the only vial not labelled was the one that must have belonged to Hordak."

"But my forensics…," Bow whimpered.

"Maybe next time," Glimmer said, with a conciliatory half-smile. "At the very least, we need to compare these. Hang on."

She slotted the vials back into their chambers, and pressed a few more keys.

"For something designed by Entrapta, the interface is remarkably user-friendly."

"What's happening?" Adora asked. There was a churning sound accompanied by digital scratching.

"I'm guessing it's the PCR?" Bow said, looking up and down the combined computer- container, "although I wonder." He came up and leaned over Glimmer (who only half begrudged this) so he

could type away on the keyboard. “I think this is an entirely simulated process, just like our station back at the lab. Although this code is much more streamlined.”

“Look,” said Glimmer, shooting up in her seat that she came up cheek to cheek by Bow, “the results!”

The computer had stopped churning. The data was displayed. Hordak’s DNA on the one hand, Guy’s on the other. An absolute match.

“They’re not just related,” said Adora, wide-eyed, “they must be twins.”

“How close are fingerprints for twins?” asked Glimmer.

“Distinct, but pretty close,” Bow murmured, “it might give us leeway, at least.”

“You think this is what McRaker found? Is this the motive?”

“Hordak tried his hardest to hide this information,” Adora noted, “it’d be stupid to pretend this doesn’t matter.”

There was a buzz, and the muffled voice of Scorpia emerged from the walkie-talkie in Adora’s pocket.

“Hey, guys,” the detective said, “we’ve found something real interesting down here. Come to the bottom-most floor.”

Sharing a look, the three agreed. They closed up the container after taking a record of their findings, and headed back down. Scorpia guided them down the intricate path of corridors, walkways and stairways that descended deep into the lower levels of the building. There they were surrounded by utter darkness but for the glowing red lights of robots on patrol, and small flashes from various computers buttons and other spare technology in the labs.

But when they found Emily and Scorpia, they were greeted by a huge atrium that was covered in flood-lights, so blaring that it burnt their eyes after the long trek in darkness. When their eyes acclimatised, they saw what the other two were looking at; a huge seam in the wall.

"I think it's a gate or door or something," Scorpia said, tapping her head with the thin end of her claw, "but how to open it? Not even Emily knows."

"I DIDN'T EVEN KNOW THERE WAS SOMETHING DOWN HERE."

Adora looked it up and down and gave a whistle.

"Don't think we'll be able to budge this.'

"Maybe Entrapta knows how to open it, we could go find her?" suggested Glimmer.

"Will we even be able to find this place again once we leave?"

"Well unless we can open it there's no point staying."

"Wait, I've got an idea," said Bow.

He took forward and started feeling his way across the wall, as if trying to find a weak spot. Glimmer and Adora shared a look, exchanging knowing smiles. Bow however found what he was looking for. He started manipulating a thin sheet of transcluscent paper, pressing it into his pad. Then he pressed the same paper into the wall.

"I wonder if… aha!"

There was a rumbling. Even the ground was vibrating, although most of them kept a sure footing. With a great groan, the walls started to part.

"What did you do?" asked Glimmer.

“Just thought to replicate the fingerprint data we had,” he said, “Hordak must have tailored this room to his hand.”

“Oh wow, good thinking.”

“See, told you forensics are useful.”

“Yes,” Glimmer grinned, “in some limited circumstances I can admit having a forensic scientist can come in handy. I am slightly impressed.”

The doors were fully parted, and the five of them stepped the threshold into another field of darkness. There was some light, but it was barely a glow from circles lining the perimeter of the floor. The room was broad. Yet it seemed completely empty.

“THIS PLACE IS RUNNING ON BASIC POWER,” noticed Emily, “MAYBE IT ISN’T EVEN CONNECTED TO THE MAIN GRID.”

“It could have been operating unseen for years,” said Scorpia, “but… why?”

The answer was the thing that drew all their gazes as it its small gleam of illumination grew just enough to shape its outline. It was a tank, filled with viscous liquid, thick bubbles within iridescent as the light bounced off their edges. There was also a solid shape inside. A figure, small, hulked, and though hard to tell in the dim, pale.

“Y’know,” Scorpia said, taking a few paces back, “I think I’m starting to get real weirded out by this place.”

“Yeah, I don’t think I want to know what that is,” remarked Adora, queazy in her expression.

The image was enough to burn in her eyes, and she was thankful to be rid of it when she looked away. The endless darkness of the floor was a pleasurable relief. Although she noticed something was by her feet. She bent down and picked it up.

“Paper?” she said vacantly, “no, card.”

“What you got there?” asked Scorpia.

“I think it might be one of the pictures printed from McRaker’s camera.”

“Let’s have a see!”

They went back into the atrium, where the floodlights, though searing to the eye, at least gave them better bearings on their surroundings. That and it showed the contents of the picture. It was blackness, though with what was unmistakably the tank in the view. But the luminosity was so poor and the vision so blurred it was no wonder that the piece was thrown away.

“A dud,” Scorpia said, brow falling, “but at least we know the victim was down here. If that’s worth anything.”

With that, there just didn’t appear to be anything else of value at the Institute. They were thankful to be free of the building. No more encroaching darkness and constricting mazes, the outside air a cool welcome friend.

“So,” said Scorpia, “you think you guys have a case?”

“It’s… not as strong as I’d like,” Adora said.

Tomorrow weighed heavy on her mind. She still had that obstacle to overcome. No doubt there were three or more ways she could undermine her new evidence, not to mention use her own doubts against her.

“But,” she said, through a slightly restricted throat, “I’m ready. I have to do this.”

“We should go check with Entrapta and Ron Guy,” said Glimmer, “we may have a few questions for them.”

Adora nodded. After saying Scorpia farewell, they headed off.

This left the detective alone, her coat flapping in the gentle breeze. Emily had stayed inside, there to remain until Entrapta and hopefully Ron returned. All other investigation had been wrapped up, so Scorpia was done for the day.

She let out a great sigh, and surveyed the scene. A busy road lay out ahead, choked by the late afternoon rush. The sky was growing orange and the sun yawned its way down. The neighbouring skyscraper towered above her, its tip vanishing in the sky. At its base, a figure was walking up to the entrance. A figure in a flowing cape.

"Catra?" Scorpia murmured. Then she spoke more loudly, "Hey, Catra!"

The cat froze just at the first step. She turned, and saw her, Scorpia rushing up.

"You're doing a follow-up right? You sure you don't need the team for this?"

Catra just turned forward ahead.

"Ohh, I see," said Scorpia, "this is a more subtle mission. Don't worry, I can do subtle. What're we looking for?"

" *We're* not looking for anything," said Catra, "I'm the prosecutor. I can conduct this investigation how I see fit. This is something that requires me go in alone."

"Oh don't be like, you can always use backup." She reached out a claw to hold Catra by the shoulder. "Just tell me what to—"

Catra ripped away from Scorpia's touch. She looked to her with minute pupils in her stare.

"What about 'alone' don't you understand? Can't you take a hint?"

"Hint?" Scorpia's voice was small. "I-I'm sorry, I don't…."

“God, why are you so,” Catra struggled for the word, “clingy?”

“Hey,” Scorpia’s brow set deep and heavy over her eyes, “is this about last week? I know things have been really stressful… look if what happened made you uncomfortable we can forget about it. We can remain friends.”

“We’re *not* friends! We’re not even coworkers.” Catra spluttered, amazed that she even had to explain this, “you are my subordinate. You do what you’re told, and I’ve told you to beat it!”

Scorpia was stumped for words. Pallor sunk into her face, down to a chin that hung with a tremble. Watching Catra, as the girl turned once more and entered the building without a further thought, Scorpia felt dizzy, almost sick and with a wrenched tautness in her chest. Admittedly, Catra didn’t feel much better. She was angry. Surely it was anger towards Scorpia. Fool was also bugging her. But that explanation didn’t quite scan in the back of her mind, especially at the writhing feeling was compounded with one of guilt.

That didn’t matter now. She had a job to do.

The suite was nearly empty when she arrived. The chairs were folded up, many shutters closed — even the pools were void. Prime, however, was there, standing by the window, and looking out through the telescope.

“Marvellous,” he said, “there’s nothing that quite beats a sight like this. Nothing that makes you feel as in control as seeing the city minute before your feet.”

“I know you’re connected to Hordak,” said Catra, bluntly. No point wasting time. “In fact, I’m guessing the reason he’s throwing a fit is he doesn’t want that connection found out. So, what is it?” she cocked her head, “cash for influence? Do you get insights to the legal world? Amnesty for illegal dealings. Rivals locked up?”

“This is… and interesting investigation method. I thought you were prosecuting someone already.”

“I’m not here for you,” she said, “I just want to get ahead of the defence. A cornered lawyer will pull out all the stops just to keep things going. I need to be able to cut off every avenue. That’s how I win my guilty verdict.”

Prime never let go of the smile that hung upon his lips. Nor did he break attention from his vista.

“Have you considered,” he said, “that perhaps Ron Guy is innocent after all?”

“What?” breathed Catra, “no, that would mean… no, the evidence doesn’t fit.”

“Well, I wouldn’t know,” the man said, nonchalant, “I have no knowledge of the case apart from what I read in the papers, you see. But you are right, I do know the Chief Prosecutor. What sort of man of importance would I be, if I didn’t know the most important people? And of course, I am with you. I want a guilty verdict, for the health of the prosecutor’s office is important for the city. If a criminal like that went free, well, what a shame that would be. And if Hordak were implicated in a crime,” he gave a mock shudder, “ that would leave chaos. But if that’s how things must go, then it must go.”

“What do you mean?” Catra said. Her stance was uncertain. She didn’t know where to place her hands, so she held one in the grip of another.

Prime meanwhile turned to face her.

“I wouldn’t have built Prime Holdings to be what it is if I hadn’t accounted for every possibility. I understand you’ve proven yourself as prosecutor for that exact same reason. Should Hordak fall, then we need to make sure such a well-proven prosecutor takes the role of chief.”

That gave Catra pause. Her mouth fell open, and when she closed it again it was dry. A lightness filled her chest. The implication was sinking in, and she hadn't felt something like this since her private audience with Hordak the week prior.

"R-really?" she said, "Chief Prosecutor… me?"

"Well, it's only a suggestion. I'm just saying that would be a fortuitous outcome to all of this."

Catra lowered her brow, and regaining her composure, said, "right…. Look, I can read between the lines. I'm not looking for a handout, and I don't need your help to get what I want."

"You'd turn down the opportunity?" said Prime. "I wouldn't be so quick. Do you truly believe skill alone is enough for advancement? Without recognition, you'll be stuck where you are. I don't want someone as good as you are to have peaked so soon."

Catra's gripped into her hand, claws digging enough to mark flesh. She turned to the side, vaguely looking at the shutters over the window.

"You think someone at the office would hold me back without… recognition."

"Possibly," he said, "but that wouldn't matter if you became Chief Prosecutor."

Catra let slip a smile, although she quickly held it back.

"But… what would you want from all this?"

"I just expect the same amicable relationships with the new Chief Prosecutor as I had with the old one. And should Guy go free, well," Prime let out a chuckle, cold as it filled the room, "I'd want to make sure certain effects of his were reviewed; for security, reasons of course."

“I…,” clenching her jaw now, Catra was racked by throbbing in her temples. Simultaneously, the light feeling in her chest never fell. It was a torn moment. “I am not going to let Ador— the defence win.”

“You must seek out your guilty verdict of course,” Prime nodded, “but like you, I look out for contingencies. But even then, should Hordak’s name be cleared, his reign shan’t last that much longer, I should think. And then the issue of succession will come up again. And you’ll be glad for my friendship.”

Chapter End Notes

Me: man, that scene when Catra hurts Scorpia's feelings sure was painful. Good thing fanfiction exists to imagine happier scenarios with the characters I like

Also me: *reproduces the same moment in fanfic*

Anyway, this is part 3 of 5 in this episode. The next two will collectively form the trial, so this is build up for that. I do really enjoy what I've got written here and in those two chapters, not the mention that as big and dramatic as this episode is, it pales compared to what I've got planned for the final one. So yeah, big hype and I hope you're enjoying it as much as I am!

Synthesising the Soul, Part 1

Coming back to the defence lobby after so long possessed Adora with a wave of dread. But she had to be strong, forcing what might have been her weakest ever smile. Otherwise she'd be letting down her client, who standing a few feet from her, was a bundle of nerves. If it hadn't been for Entrapta's presence, no doubt Ron Guy would have broken in a heap on the floor by now. His shaky limbs and twitching expression wasn't doing any good for Adora's own constitution.

Bow and Glimmer were nearby. The latter was sat, in thought. Bow was pacing. Every minute or so someone would be hit with the sudden fear that the Chief Prosecutor would arrive and detain them at any moment. It was a testament to them all that they most of them kept resolve.

What a trial this would be.

The door opened, someone rushing into the room. Adora turned.

"Mr. Wright, what are you— wait, what are you wearing?"

Phoenix was mostly in his usual blue suit. He had started putting it on by rote this morning, only to remember he didn't have his badge and ran out of willpower in that very second. On top of his tie-less open collar shirt he had a drab grey hoodie zipped up half-way.

"I am your future if you don't get this right," he said, in a rather hollow voice.

"Okay, no pressure," Adora turned away with a thin mouth and held back the urge to scream.

"I don't suppose you have anything?" asked Bow, "we're going in. I think a few minutes now."

“I wish I could hand over some real evidence, but,” he flared out his empty arms and let them fall. “But okay, we don’t have much time. Adora?”

She looked back at him.

“You’re all the client has, he’s depending on you. I’m sure you well know that. Because of that, it’s your duty to consider every option no matter how bold. His future may depend on it.”

“So you’re telling me to bluff?”

“Well, not bluff per se,” Phoenix tilted his head, “but sometimes it’s possible to borrow against he future, if you know what I mean? When the prosecutor is trying everything to close every avenue, you’ve got to take from a time where everything is more clear to you, and that’s how you make that time happen.”

“…okay?”

“Yeah, so you bluff. But it can work, I’m telling you. You feeling ready?”

“Not at all.”

“I’ve been where you’re standing,” Phoenix said, now gazing off to the stand. “I’ve faced my share of power and corruption.”

“The Chief of Police right? But you at least had Edgeworth on side.”

“I’m sure he didn’t see it that way,” Phoenix let slip a wry chuckle, “and hell he was making it hard enough to begin with.”

“But he came to help you. Catra…,” Adora shook her head, “she’s not going to give me a moment’s peace.”

The bailiff called for them to come. Adora sighed and turned to the door.

Phoenix began again, saying “You know with Edgeworth—” but he stopped, holding a fist and shaking himself. “No, don’t let me keep you. Just remember what I said about borrowing time.”

Adora went in, followed by Bow and Glimmer. When she reached the bench, Adora slid her hand along the woodwork, refamiliarising her with the feel. Her head was light, being back here, but there was something else. A gentle electrifying underneath her breath. She looked up, and there the other girl was; already ready, and watching her.

“Hey, Adora,” Catra purred, “surprised to see you here. You must really like humiliation.”

Adora didn’t say anything.

“You ready for a fourth defeat?”

“Not this time,” said Adora.

The Judge banged his gavel, bringing silence to the chamber. He opened his mouth to speak, but then closed it again, as the contortions in his wrinkles and brow did the talking.

“Should I just get on with my opening statement?” asked Catra.

“I feel like I should say something for the record,” the Judge admitted, “something to acknowledge how, uh, sensitive this trial has been. Yesterday the defence was appearing to indict the Chief Prosecutor of the district in having something to do with this case. Then the Chief Prosecutor himself arrived to reveal that the defence had been disbarred. But I have to assume he had good reason.”

“He did, your honour. Phoenix Wright is an incompetent lawyer, who should have lost his badge long ago.”

“OBJECTION!” Adora slammed the table, “you have no basis to make that kind of claim.”

“He’s defended two from your own office,” Glimmer added, “you could show a little gratitude.”

“This trial isn’t about the skill of your predecessor, it’s about the guilt of your client. And because of the shenanigans of mr. Wright, we’ve wasted a whole day to decide what we already knew. Ron Guy is guilty of murdering Nellie McRaker. Of that there’s no doubt. All that remains is some contention about whether Chief Prosecutor Hordak could have had any involvement, to which the prosecution will show, is irrelevant.” She let slip a small grin. “To that, call Hordak to the stand to testify about the documents he retrieved from the Dryl Institute.”

“Hordak?” Catra breathed, “she’s bringing him out already?”

“At least we don’t have to drag him out ourselves,” noted Glimmer. “But be careful.”

Hordak stood strong and resolute behind the stand. His red eyes glowed as he peered across the chamber, letting none who came across his gaze fall under the mistaken impression that he was any weaker for standing where he was —not even the Judge, who shrank a little under his vision.

“Uh, Chief Prosecutor. How… nice to see you again,” the old man mumbled.

“Would you state your name and occupation for the record, sir,” said Catra.

“I am Hordak,” he stated, in a voice, small though carrying far across the room. “I am the Chief Prosecutor for Los Angeles. I retain the right to terminate this cross-examination at any time.” He sent a glower over at Adora, “so I expect no improper questioning.”

“Chief Prosecutor,” Catra savoured the words, flattering them, “yesterday we noted that you worked for the Dryl Institute at one time. Since leaving you removed some documents from them. Can you explain why?”

“They contained personal information. I had every right to remove them. I fail to see how this could possibly delay this particular case.”

“Chief Prosecutor, you share a resemblance to the defendant, Ron Guy,” Adora’s limbs were tense as she explained, “enough that a witness who thought she saw him mistook a picture of you when we showed her.”

“And what am I to say to that? I was not at the Institute on the night of the crime. You have no evidence to point to me.”

“It’s possible that your fingerprints were mistaken for those of Guy’s. If that’s true, then those fingerprints would tie you to the case!”

“Do I even need to object here?” Catra sneered, “I explained this to you yesterday but here we go again: the Chief Prosecutor’s fingerprints were not found on the victim’s body. Ron Guy’s were.”

“I wonder. Do we have the fingerprint data for the Chief Prosecutor?” asked the Judge. “Perhaps seeing it ourselves could help.”

“I took the liberty of procuring it,” said Catra, and she delivered the data to the court.

Three fingerprint scans were shown. In the middle was the actual, discovered upon the victim’s jacket. To its left was one that was labelled as Guy. To its right was one labelled Hordak. The swirling lines and loops, thin and sweeping in a clockwise direction, were a pair to the left. On its own, the sample on the right was squat, with a counterclockwise movement. Completely different to the other two.

The Judge gave a nod.

“I see,” he said, “then this appears to put a firm lid on everything. Hordak’s connection to the Institute is entirely peripheral, and Ron

Guy remains the most likely culprit. Does the defence have any other points to make?"

Smirking, Catra added, "make it quick though, we might be able to make it out by lunch."

Adora looked ahead, watching Catra's sly face, meeting her in the eye. Then she smiled herself.

"Come on," she said in a low, playful voice, "we're just getting started here. There's a contradiction between this and another piece of evidence."

The smile did not wash from Catra's face, although it did tense a little. Adora was displaying the results from the PCR test. The one she and the others had done the day before.

"The personal data suggests that Hordak and Ron Guy are related."

"Related? Oh, we didn't know that," said the Judge.

"Well that wouldn't mean too much on its own," Adora continued, "but we found samples of both his blood and Ron Guy's at the facility. They're a perfect match. Your honour, they're not just related, they're genetically identical!"

"Identical!"

Catra struck her own bench with her whip.

"So what?" she challenged, "relatives don't share fingerprints, not even twins."

"But they should be really similar," countered Adora, a gleam in her eye, "and these readings you've shown us are entirely different. Your honour, these fingerprints have been faked!"

Catra was ready to fire back. But then a loud, cold boom of a voice drowned her out:

“HOLD IT!”

There was a slam. Hordak’s fist had landed on the stand, and he glared at Adora.

“I did not agree to come here to put up with this kind of insolence! You accuse me of forgery? I’ll submit my own fingers right here for a test. They will match the data.”

“You’ve a longstanding interest in genetics, don’t you,” Bow posed, “I think you’d have figured out how to change your own fingerprints, not just the data.”

“But hold on,” said the Judge in a fretting voice, “we’re talking about the Chief Prosecutor here! I can’t believe that he would do any forgery let alone something of this magnitude.”

“Your honour, we have evidence,” said Adora. “You see, the documents Hordak had removed had a letter designation for the blood sample we found. The thing is, the designation was missing. A simple trace analysis discovered it.”

“Hmm. Well, perhaps you just had a faulty copy, or it was redacted by the prosecutor’s office.”

“Except this isn’t a copy,” Adora said, “this is the paper version Hordak removed himself! Isn’t that right, Catra?”

Snarling, Catra was stopped for words. She held back a biting retort, and regarded the other girl with a watching stare. Clearly her sabbatical had sharpened her lawyering skills. But Catra still held all the cards. There was no way for her lose. So she stood up straight, calm and merely said:

“Yes, this is the version I retrieved from Hordak’s own office. It would appear that he removed the designation himself.”

“What?!” Hordak looked at Catra, aghast.

“This is significant,” Adora argued, “this explains why he was so frantic to have yesterday’s proceedings suspended. He didn’t want that document, or his forgery, found!”

“That is quite damning,” the Judge marveled.

The crowd was alive with muttering, only fed more speculative and intrigued by the foul grimace on Hordak’s face, as the man hulked over the stand. Catra however, remained motionless and passive.

“This proves very little in the end,” she said, “you can’t say for definite his fingerprints were edited. Nor would that mean that the fingerprints we found were more likely his or Ron Guy’s.”

“Still,” said the Judge, stretching the word in rumination, “I feel like we’re stumbling in the dark here. Chief Prosecutor, could you testify as to your time at the Dryl Institute? And your relation to the defendant. Perhaps it would help us understand these things better.”

“That’s what we’re asking him about?” Adora groaned in a low voice.

“The trial’s moving forward. Just focus on that,” Glimmer reassured her. “It may even tell us why he was there at all.”

“So we’re really doing this?” asked Bow, “we’re going after the Chief Prosecutor himself?”

“Not getting scared, are we?” teased Glimmer.

“Hey, I’m as ready for this as anyone,” he said. “Just can’t quite believe it is all. Anyway, noticed how my analysis on the paper helped us in the end? Not thinking about apologising, Glimmer?”

She grinned at him, “no, wasn’t thinking about it at all.”

Though smiling too, Adora cautioned them, “look alive, guys. We’ve got another testimony to crack.”

Though filling every word with bitter hate, Hordak trawled through. He wasn't making good on his threat to end the cross-examination yet, so that was good, though with the strain in his face it might come at any moment. He explained his time at the Institute: he joined, looking to put his varied scientific interests to use, came to work with Entrapta, and put to test his utter drive to achieving perfection. The blood test itself was a comparison of how genetically similar people react under the same stimuli, and where differences appear.

"What about the gravity chamber?" asked Adora, "did you work on that?"

"One of my earliest breakthroughs," he said, allowing the smallest hint of pride to enter his voice. "Graviton-reversal is a precise art, one which most in the field had dismissed as unfeasible. Even Entrapta suspected it couldn't work, though she continued to aid me in my efforts. Without her, it might have been impossible, so—," he suddenly shook his head, "no, that was my success. A testament to perfection."

Adora raised her brow, but didn't think to press further. Sure, it could show the man knew how to use the chamber; the murder weapon as it were. But it was probable that Ron Guy easily knew the controls as well. The thought still mulled in her head for a second. Did that make sense?

"Did… Ron Guy play a part in that experiment?" she posed her tentative question.

"If you're asking could he use it? I am certain we ran a test with him later on. He would understand the controls, which Entrapta insisted be intuitive."

"Okay," Adora said, slightly deflated, although she kept on asking, "but was he not involved earlier on."

"No."

"Why not?"

“He wasn’t at the facility at the time.”

“Again, why not,” Adora knitted her brow. Was this going somewhere?

“He was junior,” Hordak said, in a nonchalant voice. Far less angry now, the topic was boring him, “didn’t even start working full time until I had left.”

“Your honour, can this statement be appended to the testimony?” Adora asked.

“This statement?” the Judge repeated.

“Yes,” Adora said, before quickly adding, “it’s very important.”

How, she wasn’t quite sure yet. But something within her was itching towards it. Her gut was screaming that it was the right track. But when Hordak repeated the statement, she sank. What relevance did Ron Guy’s age have to do with any of this?

“Adora?” questioned Glimmer. “Are we just playing for time?”

“I feel there’s something here.”

“A contradiction? You can find it, Adora, just think it through.”

Adora slammed her palms into the side of her head, “urgh, why did I have to take the thinking job. I could have been an equestrian, I could have punched bad guys. Why this!”

“Hordak doesn’t want us finding out the truth here. But he’s bound to have slipped up somewhere. Just focus on that. What doesn’t gel with the evidence?”

“The main thing is the document,” said Adora, closing her eyes, “he didn’t want us to find it. What we found out was that he and Ron Guy are, what, twins? Twins… genetically identical, but—”

She opened her eyes. Ron Guy was sitting at the dock, calm, but holding his knees tight together. Hordak was grimacing at the stand. They did look very similar.

“Objection!” Adora shouted. She hadn’t even finished her train of thought, but it was too late now. She would just have to go for it, “your honour, what the witness just said is a contradiction… against reality as we know it!”

“R-r-r-r” the Judge couldn’t quite fathom what had been said.

“Reality?” Catra raised an eyebrow.

“As we know it?” Glimmer and Bow said, practically together.

“Pretty egregious to allow that from the witness, I say,” Adora continued. “He just told us that Ron Guy is his junior. But how is that possible, when they’re genetically identical? I’ve never heard of twins being born years apart!”

Hordak spluttered as he gripped the stand. Any protest he wanted to make was caught up in his own throat. Astonishment was sweeping throughout the chamber. Catra, although scowling, kept her nerve still.

“I have file data,” she said, “we’re talking about an experienced Chief Prosecutor, former scientist with years behind him versus a lab assistant we can barely dig any records for. They aren’t the same age.”

“Then how do you explain the blood,” pointed Adora.

“This blood thing is a red herring.”

“How can you say that?”

“It’s far more likely a clerical error. You probably just compared two vials of the same blood.”

Adora shook her head, “that doesn’t make any sense. Look at how the witness is acting, think about the lengths he went to hide this. How do you explain the missing designation on the document?”

“Maybe,” Catra spoke, leaning over with a coy smile, “I was the one who rubbed that off to mess with you.”

“You—” Adora choked.

“The point is, you don’t have enough to prove any wrongdoing.”

Adora held herself back from any more retorts, rather just staring sullen at the prosecutor.

Catra laughed, continuing, “see, this is what you’re doing. You’re fighting just to prove that he *could* have been the one to touch the jacket. You don’t actually have any proof.”

“Emily was threatened by someone who looked by mr. Guy,” Adora argued. “I mean, look at them!” She gestured to the two men, one quite pleasant although a little shaken, the other hunched over and growling. “Which one is more likely to be threatening? And why would Ron Guy tell Emily to hide his movements? It would just implicate him anyway. Hordak has an incentive.”

“Your point?”

“My point is that just on probability alone it’s Hordak! If it’s equally possible that it’s either of them. At the very least we have to investigate the possibility.”

“Hmm,” the Judge interceded at last, “I’m inclined to agree with the defence, although—”

“You what?” spat Hordak, looking up with eyes glowing red.

“B-b-but it’s still an extraordinarily claim,” the Judge concluded. “So what ms. Catra says will have to stand. Although, there’s still a matter of this contradiction.”

“The contradiction?” Adora repeated. “Oh, right.”

“Yes, are they twins, or aren’t they? The prosecution claims they aren’t and that the blood tests are at fault. That would mean the evidence clearly points to Ron Guy. But you still claim they’re twins?”

“Well,” muttered Adora, “unless those personnel records were faked…, maybe they aren’t twins.”

“Adora?” Glimmer said in an agitated hush, “you can’t give up your contradiction.”

Gritting her teeth, Adora said, “you’re right, but I don’t know… I mean, what do we know?”

“They’re genetically identical,” said Bow, “we can’t doubt that now.”

“But they’re not twins…?” said Glimmer.

Adora threw back her head. If there was something, it would have been in the investigation. She recalled the facility. The huge gravity chamber. The robots. That magical horse — that the place was filled with weird wonder was undeniable. So maybe it was something that would otherwise seem impossible that was the answer. Not twins, but identical. Genetically *identical.*

“Oh,” she let out. She looked straight again, blinking. “No, that can’t be right. That’s…,” she was starting to laugh, “no, that can’t be right.”

“Adora, have you cracked?” asked Glimmer. “What’s so funny?”

“But it’s actually that!”

The whole chamber could hear her laughing now. Even Catra was disarmed by it, drawing back every so slight.

“What’s the matter with you,” she said.

“Oh Catra,” Adora said, finally containing her laughter, “you’ve really gotta start turning your thinking around.”

“Ugh. You’re going to suggest something really stupid, aren’t you.”

“I have a solution to the identical twin problem. So it’s either really stupid or really genius.”

“I’ll be the judge of that,” said Catra, snapping her whip.

“No, I’ll be the Judge of that,” the Judge postured. “What is this solution?”

“Ron Guy,” Adora threw out her pointer finger, directly at the witness stand, “is a clone of Chief Prosecutor Hordak!”

Catra seriously flinched now. Loud reactions sprung from the gallery, many of who were starting to fray against the twists of this trial. Even the expressions from Bow and Glimmer suggested real doubt. But Adora didn’t let her smile falter, nor her arm. Because right now, Hordak looked like a deer caught in the headlights. Adora had him.

“Of all the ridiculous,” Catra breathed, “are you delirious? I hope you get disbarred next for this mockery to the court!”

“I should say so,” added the Judge. “What is the meaning of this farfetched nonsense?”

“SILENCE!”

The order was obeyed. It had come in a bellow from the witness stand, where Hordak was finally straightening himself up and assuming a calm countenance.

“I will speak the truth,” he said, “since the defence is so insistent on digging this up. Though she is wrong to claim I was anywhere near the facility, she is correct on this one thing. Ron Guy… is a clone, the product of Entrapta’s and my research at the Dryl Institute.”

“Wh-Wha,” the Judge babbled, “WHAAAAAT?”

Adora slammed the desk, “so you admit it? This is what you were hiding from the court?”

Hordak turned to face her. His eyes were the coldest they had ever been.

“This was personal information. You have violated my privacy and dragged my name through the dirt. You and your compatriots should expect punishment of the most severe kind. I’ll make you suffer for this!”

“Oh dear,” the Judge was saying, “Oh dear, Oh dear. This changes… well, this changes a lot. Then not only should yours and Ron Guy’s fingerprints be near identical… they should be the exact same! This means that, well, the defence is right. You *could* have be involved. Chief Prosecutor,” he directed to him, with a grave, although apologetic expression, “I must ask that you testify to your whereabouts on the night of the murder.”

“Of course,” said Hordak, “I can provide a clear alibi. You will find that I was at my home, on a long phone call.”

“What was the subject of this—”

But Adora barely got in these few words. Hordak cut her off with another frigid glare.

“As I was saying,” he continued, “this call was long and took me through the night, at which point I gained hunger. I went to the kitchen to prepare some food, but the knife slipped, and I cut my hand.”

“Oh, how unfortunate,” said the Judge. “But I don’t see—”

“Then I shall explain. I can provide a phone record that shows I was having that call. The Hospital can confirm that I was taken there for a brief emergency. This is my alibi. I could not have been at the Institute that night.”

“What sort of person cuts their own hand?” posed Adora.

“Irrelevant,” Hordak gestured the back of his hand to show the scar, “what matters is that it happened.”

“Who were you talking to on the phone?”

“Irrelevant. That is none of your concern.”

“It might interest the court—”

“It doesn’t interest anyone,” Catra snapped, “you’re just wasting time. The witness’s alibi is tight.”

“No it isn’t,” Adora said, her voice fraying high. “Witness, how can we know for sure you didn’t get this cut while at the facility? You could have gone to the hospital after the crime!”

“The phone record, as I just said,” Hordak responded with a dry spiting tone, “how likely is it that I was having a chat while sneaking into the institute?”

“Let’s settle this, right now,” Catra said. “Come on, Adora, you say the witness cut his hand at the facility? Where’s your proof? Such a thing would obviously have left some sort of trace. So why haven’t you shown us anything yet?”

Adora stood up. She calmly said, “I have proof,” and waited for Catra’s response.

“Really,” Catra stretched out the word with a grin, “well why don’t you show it.”

With a tremor in her hand, Adora produced a photograph.

“This… I don’t believe we’ve seen this,” said the Judge. “It appears to be Ron Guy, or perhaps it’s Chief Prosecutor Hordak, or… well, I don’t know.”

“This is a picture McRaker took of the defendant,” Catra explained, “we didn’t think it was necessary for our case so it wasn’t added to the record.”

“Look at his hand,” said Adora.

Catra let out a high dancing laugh.

“His hand? Oh come on Adora, how slow are you? We checked that wound against the one on the defendant. He cut himself against the locking mechanism, not a kitchen knife. Is this really your best evidence? I knew you’d run out of tricks sooner or later, but this…?” Catra shook her head, still with that mocking grin, “I think it was less embarrassing when you just admitted you had no evidence in the Singer case. Come on, Adora, when are you just gonna give up?’

“Catra,” Adora merely said, “I meant the other hand.”

“The other… what?”

“Look at the other hand in the photograph.”

Catra looked at the photo. Ron Guy —she was certain— prowling the darkly lit Dryl corridor. In the hand closest to the viewer, there was the scar. But as her eyes shifted along the picture, towards the other hand, they widened, and then her pupils thinned until they were slits.

“Th-th-that’s….”

“Hmm,” said the Judge,” there appears to be something held there. A black block?”

“Wouldn’t you say, your honour,” a smile finally started to creep along Adora’s face, “that it’s look a whole lot like a—”

“No!” yelled Catra, “what is this? Why didn’t I notice this?”

“Come on, Catra, why don’t you tell the court?”

Adora could barely stifle her giggles now, as excitement burst within her. Things were starting to turn around. She could feel the end was near.

“This…is…,” Catra’s teeth were ground together, as she stared at the photograph, disbelieving, but unable to change the truth. “It’s a phone. The person depicted here has a phone.”

“Just like the witness said! He was having a chat while sneaking around the Institute!”

“That’s a lie!” shouted Hordak.

But he was unable to cut Adora off as she kept on going, “the picture shows that the victim saw him. She must have seen something in the facility —something he was trying hide. We already know he’s not above removing data he finds too sensitive.”

“But I would never—”

“He went to the anti-gravity chamber, and when she entered he activated it to kill her! He threatened Emily to not mention him passing through so it would look like it could only have been mr. Guy. The fingerprints are his. This picture is of him. The murderer of Nellie McRaker,” she thrust her point right in his direction, causing him to recoil, “is you, Chief Prosecutor Hordak!”

Hordak screamed. A piercing shout that filled what else would have been a deafened crowd of stunned watchers. Then, slamming the stand with two fists, he fell slumped over it. The silence remained. Catra was still stood fixed, stupefied in expression. Bow and Glimmer marveled without words. The Judge dare not even speak to move the trial forward, and so time itself seemed to stop in that room.

Until Entrapta, appearing almost from nowhere, came up to the stand and spoke:

“Is it true?” she asked Hordak, as if it were just the two of them alone, “did you kill someone and try to frame Ron?”

“No,” came Hordak’s voice, low and broken, “I would… never… no.”

Breaking from his reverie, the Judge finally said, “this is a damning state of affairs. The Chief Prosecutor? A killer? I can’t imagine it. Does the prosecution have any thoughts?”

There was no response. The Judge turned to look at her.

“Prosecutor Catra?”

But Catra was still motionless, but for her mouthing. Past and future were in conflict within her. The indignity of many years raging through her chest, versus the thoughts of promise in her mind should she play this right. She made a motion with her hand, placing it on the bench, letting it fall, then placing it back again. Finally, after a few false starts, she forced herself to speak:

“The prosecution would… the prosecution would,” she shook her head, trying to throw everything back into sense. At last, all she could say was,“… prosecution… rests.”

“You,” Adora blurted, “what?”

“The prosecution,” Catra said again, through grit teeth this time, “would like to rest its case.”

“You’re giving up?” Adora was blinking, lest what she was seeing wasn’t real.

“Well then,” the Judge said, streaming a hand through his grey beard, “this would mean, well, the facts clearly line up to indict the Chief Prosecutor. A picture that places him at the Dryl Institute, his threatening of the robot Emily so as to incriminate Ron Guy, and his fingerprints found on the jacket. I can’t say that this is an airtight case, but I think I can at least render my verdict on the defendant.”

Hordak looked to be crushed. He could not push himself straight by the stand, nor would he lift his head. He certainly wouldn't look at Entrapta, who continued to woefully watch him.

"Well then," said the Judge, "I suppose it's up to you, defence. Would you care to formally indict Chief Prosecutor Hordak?"

"Indict… yes, I, uh," Adora's mutters were too slight reach the Judge. The man leant over, trying to hear her words.

But Adora was stuck for them.

"What are you waiting for?" asked Glimmer. "This is it, you've won!"

"But… shouldn't Hordak have confessed?" Adora said in a strained voice. Her head was swimming, drowning. She didn't even understand why she didn't understand.

"It's alright," Bow said with an assuring smile, "he can argue his own case later. But what matters now is showing that Ron is innocent."

"But have we done that?" asked Adora, "is it right to stop here when we don't know all the answers?"

"Adora, you've done enough," Glimmer insisted.

"No. No, I haven't. I can't stop here."

"But it was obviously Hordak!"

"…and Catra thought it was obviously Guy." Adora said this with a note of finality. She had made her decision, and so stood up and addressed the Judge, "You honour, we haven't shown for certain who murdered the victim!"

"We haven't?" the Judge blinked.

“What the hell are you doing?” shouted Catra, “just take the victory and be done!”

“No,” said Adora, “we’re not stopping until we’ve considered every angle! Does the witness agree that he was at the facility as we’ve shown? Does he recall threatening Emily as we assert? Witness, testify.”

But Hordak did not look up from the stand. He remained collapsed against it, forbidden to shift by the painful gaze of his old colleague standing nearby.

The Judge shook his head, “I do not believe the witness will speak again. Honestly, defence, I don’t see what you hope to gain out of this.”

“The prosecution doesn’t have any other witnesses,” Catra stated. “Just accept it Adora, we’re at our end here. Either indict Hordak now, or your client goes to prison. And me?” she smiled something cruel, “I’m fine with it either way.”

Adora gnashed her teeth. Heat was rising to flush through her face. She’d been in corners before, but never one of her own making. She looked to Glimmer and Bow.

“Is there any possibility of other witnesses?” she asked.

“Of course not!” Glimmer said, streaming a hand down her face, “we would have been talking to them if there were, wouldn’t we? Unless you’ve forgotten, Adora, we didn’t think we had much chance of winning this until a few minutes ago!”

“I don’t think you’re going to have much luck with this,” Bow said. Even he had a pained expression, torn between agreement with Glimmer and wanting to remain helpful. “Maybe there was someone we overlooked? It would have to have been someone we just didn’t think would fit the mold of a witness. I bet no-one would have guessed Emily would take the stand until yesterday?”

“Maybe another robot?” asked Adora.

“I don’t know if any of them would have seen Hordak, though.” Bow shook his head. “I’m sorry, Adora.”

“I don’t understand,” Glimmer moaned, “a few days ago you were down because you thought you couldn’t beat Catra. Now you have and you’re trying to throw it away?”

“Glimmer!” Adora almost yelled, although keeping it to a hush, “this isn’t about beating her. This is about…. Look, we need to keep going, we need a witness. I just need a pair of eyes that could have… could have seen.”

It was something. At this point, she would take anything, because every fibre in her body told her this wasn’t over. The trial needed to continue. She was vibrating with the need —but perhaps that was stemming from a hum down by her golden vambrace. It was something. A bluff, sure—— no, it wasn’t.

She was borrowing time against the future. Time she desperately needed.

Holding out her arm ahead, she whispered, “for the honour of Grayskull,” and the sword emerged in her hand.

Both Bow and Glimmer flinched at the suddenly appearing weapon. Most in the court were watching confused, and no-one knew her intentions. Even Adora wasn’t quite sure why she needed the sword, but it felt right to feel the leather grip in her fingers. She lay it against her shoulder, and continued:

“Your honour, there is one other person who saw our mysterious third party travel the secret passageway on the night of the murder. Someone other than Emily.”

“Who?”

“The Horse,” said Adora, “the one known as Swift Wind.”

“What?” exclaimed Catra. Her voice cracked as confusion and anger mixed into one.

“Horses,” the Judge’s voice wavered as he tried to figure out what he was saying as he was saying it, “don’t usually give testimonies. I’m not sure I can allow this.”

Adora pointed with the sword-tip, thrusting it out with a sharp ring.

“It’s critical for this trial to go forward that we cross-examine that witness. If I’m wrong, then I’ll gladly go along with whatever penalty you see fit.”

“I, well,” the Judge mumbled, “you’re so insistent. Very well,” he sighed. “Bailiff, fetch the horse known as Swift Wind.”

The transition was quite quick. Despite having to head to the Institute, and wind through the many paths to find him —not to mention figuring out the logistics of leading a winged horse through a busy city to come to a court house— the Baillif managed bringing Swift Wind to the court with great efficiency. Now there was a horse tethered to the stand.

“I’m starting to think you’re even dumber than I thought,” Catra told Adora, “and that’s saying something.”

Adora couldn’t really retort to that. She had been so certain that this was the right thing to do, but now having cooled down a bit, was being burdened by the torturous reproach of common sense. Even having the sword in her hand seemed ridiculous now. At this point, she could think that half the room suspected her of madness, and she’d be right.

“There’s no way this is gonna work,” she muttered, “no, why did I do this. Why did I think this was going to work? Parrots and Robots can at least talk!”

The horse was giving her a blank stare. At last, Adora just sighed.

“I don’t supposed you can talk?” she asked.

“Well sure, but what do you want me to say?”

Adora blinked. It had been a male voice that had spoken, somewhat deep, peppy in inflection. She looked to her side.

“Uh, Bow?” she asked, “did you say something?”

But Bow could not answer, for he was staring gormless at the horse. He wasn’t the only one. The Judge’s eyes had never been so wide. The man’s beard ruffled as he plied for the right words, but nothing but stammering came out.

“Am I going crazy,” said Glimmer, “or did the horse just…?”

“W-witness?” the Judge managed to say, “that wasn’t you who just spoke right now, was it?”

“Of course it was me,” said the horse, apparently. It shook its mane with a sense of indignity, “why would I come to a witness stand if I wasn’t going to talk?”

“Uh… right,” said the Judge.

“It’s a talking horse,” Bow squeaked, dumbstruck.

“Yeah, we established that,” said Swift Wind. He looked to Catra, who was madly gripping at her own bench. “Aren’t you going to ask for my name and occupation?”

“Why would I?” Catra snapped, “you’re an animal!.”

“Well, so are you, ms. Kitty claws. So rude!”

“Witness,” Adora spluttered, having finally regained her composure. “Tell the court what or who you saw on the night of the murder!”

The horse talked (we established that already, of course.) What he was saying slipped by most people, as the gallery was still trying to figure out if they were having a collective hallucination. Even Catra found it difficult to focus on the word. Containing a frothing

rage inside, she dragged the sharp end of her claws against the woodwork in front of her.

Adora listened though. Swift Wind saw a man sauntering through the secret passageway. He had been holding something in his hand, though the witness could not make it out. But it was dark, and the man was barely more than a silhouette.

“I suppose,” said the Judge, “that the object in his hand was his phone? Or at least the object seen in the photograph.”

“Are you sure you couldn’t recognise anything else?” asked Adora.

“Well, his general shape was familiar. Tall, with pointed ears. But he could have been Hordak or Ron Guy based on that. But I couldn’t really make out his face, although if they were both clones it would have been hard to tell them apart anyway, right?”

“Only one of them was a clone,” Adora corrected.

“Oh, okay. Well still, they’d both have the same face.”

Adora leaned against her bench. “You sure you didn’t see anything else? Don’t leave anything out.”

The horse tapped his chin with the tip of his wing.

“Well,” he mulled, “I believe I saw some lights… ah, the eyes.”

“Eyes?”

Swift Wind bowed his head, “yes, eyes. They glow, I guess, and I saw two lights around his face. They glowed green.”

“I don’t see how this gets us anywhere,” the Judge said. “Do the colour of his eyes really matter?”

“They matter, your honour,” Adora said by instinct, although her follow up was a little quieter, “but… hmm. The contradiction is there, but if I go for it….”

“I’m sorry, I didn’t hear that last part.”

Adora shook her head. She’d come this far, knowing that it would have been expedient enough to quit while ahead. Nothing else mattered here but the truth, so it would be the truth she’d find.

“Your honour,” she said, in a loud clear voice, “you still have the picture of Hordak from yesterday’s proceeding’s, right?”

“Ah yes, it’s somewhere around here.”

“What colour are Hordak’s eyes?”

“Urrrrgh,” came the terrible and pained groan from the prosecution bench, “you’re leading us around in circles!”

“I don’t understand,” said the Judge, looking from one lawyer to the other.

“Hordak has red eyes,” Catra explained, “Ron Guy has green. So we’ve come back to Ron Guy as the murderer.”

“But why would the defence argue—”

“I’m not,” said Adora, quickly, “remember, Ron Guy wasn’t found with a phone.”

“But Hordak was.”

“Hordak’s eyes don’t glow green.”

“Ah, but Ron’s does!”

Adora shook her head, “it still makes no sense for Ron Guy to threaten Emily.”

“Adora,” Glimmer looked with tired half-lowered eyes, “are we gonna be here all day?”

“I concur,” said the Judge rubbing his head, “this contradiction seems impassable. But we have to break the deadlock somehow.”

“Your honour, you’ve got to open your mind to a new possibility,” said Adora,” it wasn’t Ron Guy, and neither was it Hordak! Which means, logically, that there was a third person.”

“But who?”

“To be consistent with all the evidence, well,” Adora chuckled, “I was wrong then. There *is* a second clone!”

“HOLD IT!”

The shout had been loud, deep, twisted and full of wroth. Hordak had shoved aside Swift Wind. The horse had ruffled his feathers and stamped his hooves, but ultimately cowered in the face of Hordak’s bellow. The man looked upon the court with a grim expression not yet seen.

“I…,” he said, tentative, hesitating, and then finally conceding, “confess.”

“You —what?” Adora took a step back.

“No!”

It was Entrapta. She almost went up to Hordak, but held herself back. Instead she just pleaded:

“It might not be you! Weren’t you listening?”

“Silence,” Hordak ordered, though unable to look at her still. “I was never like you… I cannot handle these imperfections. The trial must end now.”

Adora was about to object, but the sound of the surprised crowd drowned her out. Before she could try again, Glimmer held her by the arm.

“Adora, he’s confessed. It’s over.”

“How is it over?” Adora asked with an indignant scowl.

“It’s— Adora you only kept things going because he hadn’t.”

“No, I kept things going because we don’t know the whole truth yet. Think about it,” she gestured to the defiant witness, “he’s hiding something. But what’s there to hide if he’s confessing a murder? No, there’s something more that he doesn’t want us to find out, and we’ve gotta know. Your honour,” she called out, “have Hordak testify again!”

“He refused, remember,” said Catra “and he’s already confessed. This trial’s over, unless you think you’ve got another talking horse.”

“We don’t need another eyewitness,” Adora said, suddenly standing straight and with a clear head. “We just need someone with knowledge of Hordak’s genetic research.”

Catra held an uneasy look as she took a pace back from her bench.

“You mean… *him* ?”

“You saw the document yourself, Catra,” said Adora. “We can’t finish this trial until we’ve talked to him.”

“I’m sorry,” said the Judge, “but I’m not following. Is there another witness you wish to call, defence.”

“Yes, your honour. Please call the CEO of Prime Holdings.”

“Prime— wait, what does a businessman have to do with any of this?”

“I think we’ll have to see how much,” said Adora, “but I’m guessing with the money he was giving to their research, he knows something about the cloning.”

“And,” the Judge looked over to Catra, who was still reeling, “the prosecution accepts this?”

“I’ll… allow it,” she said. “The prosecution believes that Prime has some knowledge of the situation.”

“Very well. Baillif, go retrieve this Prime of Prime Holdings.”

“Where’s that sir?” asked the same bailiff as before.

“It’s right next to the Dryl Institute,” Adora explained.

“But…,” the man slumped, giving off a groan, “I was just there!”

With that, as the bailiff was rushing off, the Judge called for a ten minute recess while they waited for the arrival of their new witness. But even as others were streaming out of the room, Adora and Catra remained at their respective stations. One was gripping the hilt of her sword, the other her whip. They locked eyes for a fleeting moment. Both knew that what came next would be the endgame for this trial. Both tried to read the other in their eyes. Neither could fully guess what thoughts flowed within the other’s mind.

Synthesising the Soul, Part 2

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“Why are you doing this?” Glimmer interrogated Adora as soon as the defence team had reached the lobby. “I just don’t— Adora we had it! We could get the not guilty right now if we just let the trial end.”

“It was the right thing,” was all the other could say, in a small voice, seeming distant. “I don’t know how to explain it.”

“Adora, we’re trying to help you in there. We deserve a better explanation than that.”

“Well, what if Hordak didn’t do it?” asked Adora. “What sort of defence attorney would I be if I put one innocent life in for another? That’s not justice. I wouldn’t be worthy of this sword,” she gave the heavy steel a sharp swing in the air, letting out a short growl, “nnrgh! Look, I’m sorry, and I know it’s not great, making an already difficult task harder for us. But this isn’t a game. We have to do this right.”

“Adora—”

But before Glimmer could voice any more frustration, Bow lay a gently touch on her arm. It was enough to hold her back, and she looked at his face. He yielded a certain expression, both reminding her of something important, but also waiting for her lead. She sighed, and turned back to Adora.

“You… defended me even though it would have been easier to get me declared guilty.”

“We’re with you, Adora,” Bow said, mere but conclusive. “That said, are you sure that Prime is the key?”

“Key? I mean,” Adora turned to the pale Ron Guy, just coming in with Entrapta, and soon joined by Phoenix Wright. “They look kinda similar…. It’s a long shot, I know, but maybe Prime is the second clone?”

“That’d make a lot of sense,” came a male voice.

Expecting it to be Phoenix, Adora jumped when she found the horse Swift Wind standing right behind her.

“This guy is a billionaire, right?” he continued, “makes money of blood diamonds and underpaying stafd. Course he’s evil.”

“Hey, Entrapta? Can I keep him?” Adora asked with a fast grin.

But the scientist seemed completely away. She held onto Ron’s eye, nominally to reassure him, but mostly was using it to anchor herself lest her knees give way. A smile waited on her face, but never had she worn something so pained and vague.

“Prime aside, you guys uncovered a lot,” it was Phoenix this time, chiming in. “I didn’t even think of cloning yesterday.” He turned to Entrapta, “although it would have been nice if we were told earlier.”

“I…,” Entrapta said, “I couldn’t say anything. I didn’t want to betray Hordak’s trust.”

“But, he was the one who left the institute. On bad terms, you said yourself.”

“Why would that change anything?”

“Hmm, I guess it shouldn’t.”

“But I didn’t know anything about a second clone,” Entrapta insisted, “only Ron here. Earlier attempts didn’t work.”

“What happened?” asked Bow.

As she talked in recall of old research notes, a little of her old energy returned to her, "well, every attempt resulted in cognitively unresponsive specimens. Uh, that's to say, empty vessels if you want. Even with fully functioning brainstems, they just wouldn't react to any stimuli. I tried substituting their nervous systems with the personality technology, but they just acted like early versions of Emily."

"So you used the artificial magatama," Phoenix guessed.

"Yeah, and that's why Ron is alive and well today!"

"Well he won't be for long unless Adora gets him a not guilty. If only I was quicker yesterday we could have avoided this whole thing. Now I don't even have my badge."

"You can still make yourself useful," Adora said, caught by a thought. "Hordak gave us this phone data, but we didn't have any time to analyse it. Maybe there's a clue in who he was talking to."

"Good thinking. Time's nearly up so you better get in there." He looked to the squad collectively, "You guy's ready."

"We can do this," said Glimmer.

"Of course we can," Bow gestured to the sword, "we've got She-Ra on our side."

Glimmer smiled. "More than that, we've got *Adora* ."

Recess ceased, and everyone returned to the chamber. Adora was right where she had been, behind her bench, but this time Catra would not meet her eye. It was a little irregular, but Hordak had confessed and so had submitted to arrest. He was sat next to Ron Guy in the dock. They were now all joined by the witness when, the doors swinging wide open —and the baillif leading him in—— Prime waltzed forward and took his spot behind the stand. Tall, pale, with thin white hair and long pointed ears, the man even had a faint scar on the back of his hand. He laid his eyes upon the

surroundings and its people as if he were king and this were his court. Always he wore that smile.

“Name and profession,” said Catra.

“I am Prime,” he said, “CEO of Prime Holdings. That is to say I manage a vast conglomerate, a media empire, retail chains, that sort of things. I am a very busy man but I can always make time for our cherished court system. But I must say, I’m confused as to why I have been summoned here.”

“We won’t detain too much of your time,” said the Judge in a chipper voice, flattered by the man’s pleasant demeanour, “but the defence has some questions related to your dealings with the Dryl Institute.”

“You must imagine I have so many assets to deal with that I cannot easily recall everything,” Prime said, “but I will try my best.”

“We have a document that suggests your funding was involved in the Institute’s cloning research,” said Catra, “you must remember something of it.”

“Maybe I did once, but it was some time ago. I’m not sure I even really know which one Dryl was. I don’t think I can be much help to your trial.”

“OBJECTION!”

Peering, the man’s green eyes sidled over to the defence bench, seeing Adora for the first time.

“I find that unlikely,” Adora said, “your headquarters are stationed right next to the Facility. In fact, you have a telescope that conveniently looks upon the building!”

“Coincidences do happen—”

“You can’t wriggle out of this one. You clearly had a personal interest in their research!” She thrust out her sword so its point tip was challenging, directed at Prime.

Seeing this, his eyes widened, reflecting in the gleam of the silver. His smile deepened.

“The Sword of She-Ra,” he said, delighting the words in his mouth. “That is a priceless artifact. I’ve long sought it for my collection, but sadly it has eluded me.”

“Well tough, it’s not for sale.”

“Are you sure?” the man cocked his head. “I overheard you in my suite two days ago. I was under the impression you were giving up your career in law.”

Adora fixed her brow, but never let up her sword arm. The mention of this gave Bow an anxious look as he stole a look at her, and even Catra perked up. Nonetheless, Adora retorted:

“Well you misheard. Now tell the court what you know about the cloning program.”

“Very well… but it isn’t pretty.”

Prime delved into his testimony, explaining that he had indeed been interested on a personal level, and continuously supplied funds to see it completed. His point of entry was through Hordak, more reliable than anyone else at the Institute when it came to contracts and admin. So it was Hordak who handled the money, and Hordak who held the documents explaining this. As for the research itself, all Prime knew came from Hordak —and he was only supplied little. There were some failures, and then there was a success in Ron Guy. Hordak shortly left the Institute, and that was the end of the research, the funding and therefore any connection Prime had.

“You’re certain that there was only one successful clone?” asked Adora.

“Of course,” said Prime. “It would have been of great interest to me if there were another. But cloning so often leads to empty vessels, not particularly useful.”

“Why not?”

“The basic technology recreates the physical form, right down to the grey matter of the brain. But no matter how much the neural pathways simulate language, cognition, sense, it’s all just illusory. Advanced computers can create convincing simulacra of life, but they do not sense, they do not feel, and without an original being or essence, they cannot make decisions.”

“The soul, right?” said Adora, “that’s how Emily was able to defy her programming and lie. To preserve herself, she made a choice.”

“Sure, that’s the distinction between a real person and a clone. The latter does not have a soul.”

“I’m sure this is very interesting,” Catra rolled her eyes, “but it’s all academic. There’s no way to verify if someone has a soul or not.”

“Yes there is,” said Adora, quickly coming from behind the bench. “Mr. Wright provided it as evidence yesterday.”

She went over to the evidence table and picked up the 9-shaped metal object.

“What the hell are you doing?”

“Verifying Prime’s claim,” Adora said, approaching the witness stand. “If what he says is true and there isn’t a second clone, then this—” she held out the artificial magatama. It glowed. Adora’s face fell, and finished, “…should happen.”

“Exactly,” said Prime, chuckling, “was something else supposed to happen? I have a soul, so your little object reacts to it. Interesting piece of technology, and quite elegant. Perhaps I could acquire that for the collection.”

“Um, for now it will have to remain as evidence,” the Judge said, shifting. “But ms. Adora, what exactly are you trying to demonstrate?”

Adora pulled a cheek, trying to get her thoughts back in motion. She was so certain the pieces were coming to fit together —Prime looked the part, the mirror image of the other two save for a few defects. But he wasn’t a clone. Guy was. And Hordak — he was Guy’s originator, he couldn’t be Guy’s clone. Yet that didn’t preclude another possibility. And logically, it was all that was left.

“I just wanted to demonstrate that it works,” Adora lied, stealing away with a nonchalant air. “Now you’re all on board with me. This is the real demonstration.”

She walked to the dock. Hordak instinctively stood up, wearing a tentative expression. It was taut, but he was too drained of energy now to wear a typical scowl. Adora held out the magatama.

“Take it,” she said.

“I…nggrh,” he growled. “I have already confessed, why must we continue this charade?”

“Entrapta’s up in the gallery,” said Adora, “she’s still watching. After all that’s happened, doesn’t she deserve to know?”

Cheek twitching, and boiling heat rising through him, Hordak might have shouted again. Yet pangs grew in the back of his throat, and his head drew down by the weight of everything. Finally, he took the contraption into his spindly hand. It remained dark and cold.

“Hordak?” Entrapta marvelled, leaning over the gallery balustrade.

“I told you I was imperfect,” he said, looking down deeper so none could meet his eye.

Many others were amazed, not least of all the Judge.

“The cloning researcher was a clone himself? How fascinating. But what does this mean?”

“Surely that makes Hordak the suspicious one?” said Catra in a plain but fatigued voice. “Let’s call time on this. Your client will get a not guilty, and we can bring forward the real case against the Chief Prosecutor.”

“No,” said Adora, “this changes everything. Because this means there could have been a third person. Not Ron Guy, not Hordak, but the original. The first one!”

“Who do you propose?” said the Judge.

“It’s obvious, isn’t it?” Catra hissed, “she’s gonna indict Prime.”

“Well—yeah,” Adora stumbled for a second. “Yeah! The defence wishes to indict Prime!”

“Interesting,” said the witness. “I don’t believe I have a clone. I am just as surprised as you are to see that Hordak is what he is but… well, I don’t see how this concerns me.”

“He’s your clone!” Adora let out a breath of steam. How was he playing this dumb?

“But that would have meant I’d have cloning technology before I even started funding the Dryl Institute’s project. The order of events are confused.”

“That’s easy. You had the technology already when you made Hordak, and he learned it from you when he took it to the Dryl Institute. But you needed Entrapta to perfect it.”

“An imaginative narrative,” Prime laughed.

“It’s possible,” Catra granted, “but apart from physical appearance, you can’t claim that Hordak is Prime’s clone.”

“Exactly, we’d never met before a few years ago!”

“Then let’s test it,” Bow said, with a grin almost from nowhere, “a blood test should be enough to prove you a genetic match, just as it was for Hordak and Guy.”

Prime regarded Bow, his smile, while present, faltering to the extent that cold eyes dominated his features.

“You are a forensic investigator in training, I don’t see what you can provide to this little discussion of ours. And I will not be delayed from my business anymore than I have to. I came out of respect to the court, but I will not travel to your precinct.”

“We’ll do it right here then.”

“You clearly have not passed your test. That kind of technology requires an entire laboratory. Not something as portable as aluminium powder or luminol fluid.”

“You can throw your money around,” Bow said as he retrieved his pad and set it down on the bench, “but you clearly have no faith in the white heat of technology.”

“What are you doing, Bow?” asked Glimmer.

“I went back to Dryl this morning,” Bow explained, “Entrapta offered to help me when I told her about my problem. You know, the one about downloading the virtual PCR analysis onto my pad. Well we did it. All I need is a sample of Prime’s blood, and I can check it against the results from Guy and Hordak’s.”

Now positively scowling —with a grimness that echoed Hordak— Prime watched as Bow strode up to him and offered him a pin to prick on his finger. Bereft of any last excuse, Prime let Bow collect a small swab of blood and run his test on the electronic screen. A few seconds passed. There was a ding, and Bow pumped his fist in the air.

“Result!”

“Are they a match?” asked Adora, hurriedly, “please tell me they’re a—”

“They’re a match, Adora!”

“Yes! Bow, you’re amazing!” She turned to Prime, pointing her sword tip his ways again, “there he is! The second clone was Hordak all along. But the first one, the original —Prime!”

Catra slammed her own bench with a fist, and almost screamed. Her ears fled backwards. Her temples were about to burst. She had watched everything unravel before her very eyes. This was a case in which she couldn’t lose, and now she was losing. How had she been so powerless to stop it? Had it been inevitable from the start? Adora —this She-Ra— was destined to win.

How was she supposed to win against someone like that?

“These are very serious accusations,” said the Judge. “How does the witness respond?”

“Very clearly false,” Prime focused on his upheld hand, rubbing the trickle of blood between finger and his thumb. “I should be allowed to testify about my whereabouts, to show my alibi as it were.”

The Judge agreed to it. Before Prime began, Glimmer leaned over to Adora and whispered:

“You’re closing in on him. Don’t let up the pressure now.”

“I won’t,” Adora promised.

Prime gave his next testimony. According to himself, he was in the relaxation suite at the top of the tower, watching the views through his telescope.

“Hold it,” Adora said, “you were doing this at night? Not much to see, wouldn’t you think?”

“The city glows at night, of course there’s much to see. And the resolution is stunning, enough to see night-life up close.”

“It was a really good telescope,” Bow admitted.

“In fact, I was able to see Hordak as he entered the facility,” Prime revealed. “Something that left me wondering all night. I could not figure out why he would return to the Institute after so long and at that hour. Yet I never would find out until today, since I never left the tower that night.”

“What about the scar on the back of your hand?” asked Adora.

“An accident. Nothing to do with this case.”

“We have a photograph taken by Nellie McRaker of a person walking through the facility. He also has a scar on that hand. I think that person is you.”

“A theory,” he said, “but where’s the proof.”

“I thought that picture was of Hodak?” the Judge scratched his bearded chin, “he also had a scar, and a phone such as in the photograph.”

“It’s possible that it was Prime instead,” Adora suggest. “If we accept that, then Hordak’s original story holds up.”

“If a scar on my hand proves I was there,” said Prime, “then a scar on his hand shows that he was there.”

“Not necessarily,” Adora argued. She rubbed one hand on the pommel of her sword as she talked it through, “for example, you could have cut your hand on one of the locking mechanisms, then contacted Hordak and order him to slice his own to match! All designed to give you cover.”

Prime looked over to Catra with an impatient sneer.

“Shouldn’t you be rushing to put down the defence’s ridiculous proposals?”

Catra opened her mouth to speak, but nothing came out. Her expression was strained, and she only stayed propped by an arm on the bench, otherwise appearing to be falling down. Finally, she managed to say:

“We could… call Hordak up to confirm or deny this account.”

“That’s… rather feeble,” Prime remarked, “but it will do. Hordak!”

Hordak did not look up from the floor as he said in a curt, worn voice:

“I was not contacted by Prime. I was on a call, but that was unrelated. It was *I* who was at the scene of the crime, not he.”

Adora slammed a hand on the bench, declaiming, “he’s clearly under duress! Prime is controlling him! The evidence will speak where he will not.”

“What evidence?”

The door burst open. All the court’s attention was drawn to the person coming in. Phoenix, still a bit dishevelled-looking in his hoodie-suit mix, was aglow as he held papers in his hand.

“Wow, great timing,” Glimmer noted.

“He’s a man of variable luck,” said Bow.

“Mr. Wright, did you check the phone record?” asked Adora.

Hordak stood up, red eyes wide, and a panicked expression on his face. He tried to bellow, but his lungs gave way and he barely coughed:

“You cannot do this, you are disbarred!”

“Ironic isn’t it,” said Phoenix, “since I’m actually helping you now. It took me several tries to get through but I rang the same number Hordak was talking to. It led me right to Prime Holdings. Not just that, but one of Prime’s very own phones!”

“I knew it!” said Adora. “Prime called Hordak!”

“Then he was right about the medical and phone records,” said Glimmer, “they did show that he had an alibi. The only person who could have been at the crime scene was Prime.”

There was a low chuckle emanating from the stand, deep from the chest but completely without mirth. Prime slowly looked up. Then started to clasp his hands together in a sardonic cheer. But his eyes fixed on Adora, his pupils small and penetrating.

“A good attempt,” he said, “a good attempt indeed. But not at all conclusive. The cut on my hand in a mere coincidence.”

“But you called—”

“I might have called Hordak, but what does that really say?”

“You hid this from us—”

“You can’t prove that I was the one in the photo,” Prime declared, “and I will never confess. But Hordak. Go on, Hordak. Make your plea again. Bring this sham to an end.”

Hordak looked ahead, stiff in his face, and glazed in the eye.

“I am guilty,” he said, “I killed McRaker, fearing that my being a clone would be revealed. My not having a soul… This I could not allow.”

“There we have it,” said Prime with another cold laugh, “motive, opportunity, and a confession to boot. What more do you need, your honour?”

“Wait, Hordak just gave new testimony!” Glimmer slammed the bench with both palms, leaning forward to get the word in, “his ‘motivation’ is new information, we have a right to cross-examine.”

“What possible contradiction could be left?”

“I think,” the Judge shook his head, “that the witness is correct. We can’t keep this trial going on indefinitely. Yes, this witness’s behaviour strikes as secretive, but I don’t think we can avoid the fact that it was the Chief Prosecutor who did the crime. And to think that only a few hours ago I would have never believed that. Oh what a dark day for the court when we have to indict the top lawyer in the city, but I don’t see any other way. The objection from the defence is overruled.”

“No…,” said Adora, air stripped from her lungs that she could barely say it.

“You caution is admirable, defence,” said the Judge, “although your accusations are erratic, you’ve at least shown the aspersions on Hordak were merited. We certainly can’t hold your client in suspicion anymore. You’ve done enough.”

“No…,” Adora said again, even weaker this time.

“For now, I shall pass my verdict. The court finds Ron Guy….”

Silent anticipation rested in the court. Time itself held still, expectant. The Judge was about to speak.

“OBJECTION!”

Gavel still in the air, the Judge froze. Prime’s smile faltered. Bow and Glimmer looked to Adora, but she hadn’t spoken. She was looking ahead at Catra, who had extended her hand out to a point, thrust in the air.

“P-p-p-prosecutor Catra?” the Judge, bewildered, said. “You have an objection?”

“I….do.” War raged between Catra’s intent to speak and the bile in her throat, but she pushed on, saying, “the prosecution… requests that Chief Prosecutor Hordak… that Hordak testify again.”

“Catra?” Adora breathed. It was as if all the light in the world suddenly shone on the girl opposite.

Prime, however, looked to the girl with a grimace, “I don’t like to have my time wasted, prosecutor. What exactly do you think you’re doing?”

Not saying a word, Catra just stared ahead, at a point past the defence bench.

Prime continued, in a smaller but darker voice, “this sort of behaviour is unbecoming of an ambitious woman such as yourself. I thought you had greater sense.”

“The Chief Prosecutor,” said Catra, deepening her brow, “will testify again.”

Before Prime could announce his displeasure any further, the Judge assented and called Hordak back up. Powerless to stop it, Prime stepped aside as Hordak took the stand. Yet then the man regained his cool smile, and though the two men looked similar, it was a world away from the dread defeated stance held in Hordak’s bones, by the heavy slump in his great chest, to the face so weakened by the day’s events that it was entirely flat; too weak to scowl as it once had done.

“I went to the Dryl Institute,” said Hordak, “I cut my hand on the locking mechanism, and made a call on my phone as I travelled past. McRaker saw me. She discovered evidence of my secret, so I destroyed it, and killed her using the gravity chamber. I had no other choice.”

“This evidence?” asked the Judge, “what would this be?”

“A photograph,” said Hordak,” taken by her camera.”

“We couldn’t find the last one,” noted Catra, “it makes sense that it was destroyed.”

Glimmer leaned over to Adora, saying:

“There’s a few things you can press him on. Why was he there in the first place, who was he calling? There might be a contradiction somewhere.”

“He’ll just make something up,” Adora bit her lip, “he’s got nothing left to hide, so I don’t understand why he’s still covering for Prime. Except… wait, maybe he can tell us?”

“Adora?”

But Adora called out to Hordak with a “hold it!” and asked, “what did you mean when you said ‘you didn’t have a choice’?”

Hordak lowered his eyes.

“All the other early clones were failures. Empty vessels, only good for another consciousness to fill. The only reason I operate is because I’m defective. Imperfect, a failure. But still, I can only do what I must.”

“Because you don’t have a soul?”

Hordak nodded.

At that point, Entrapta, having remained in the gallery seat albeit anxiously tugging at her own gloves the whole time, finally clambered down by her hair. She approached Hordak once again.

“Do you really believe that?”

“Go away,” Hordak turned, cringing from her. “I did not wish you to see this side of me.”

“It’s the only side I can see,” she said, “but only because you’re turned away.”

The Judge peered over, “I don’t think you’re allowed to—”

“Hey, give em a moment,” Bow hushed him, and, although indignant, the Judge acquiesced.

Entrapta reached close enough to rest a hand on Hordak’s arm. Although he shuddered at the touch, he didn’t recoil any further.

“I’d very much like to do science again with you,” she said, smiling up at him though he still wouldn’t look. “Remember, imperfection is what makes science possible. It’s the only way we can reach the perfect.”

She slid her hands around his arm and hugged it into her chest. Finally the man looked back her, blinking, ears falling, and with the slightest hint of blush on his pale face.

”Entrapta….”

“And I already see you as perfect,” she said, glowing his way.

His expression struggled, and shied his face from her once again.

“Fool…,” he muttered, “there is nothing you can do. Nothing I can do….”

Entrapta then grinned of all things. She broke away from his arm, but only so she could reach over to the evidence bench and rummage around for what she needed.

“You know, you’re way too obsessed with this choice thing. Of course you have a choice!”

“Haven’t you been listening,” he protested, “I’m a clone, I—”

“Hordak,” she said, turning back to him. In her hand was the magatama. “Please….”

She held it out for him. He looked down upon it, uneasy, uncertain. He was silent for a while, ruminating upon the cold,

dark object. Then he spoke:

"The real breakthrough came when we created Guy. We used the Kurainist technology and fashioned this false magatama. However… I knew that *he* would come for it. No, he come'd for Guy. He would be unsafe from *him.* I knew it would be better for Entrapta that I left. Contriving a reason, faking a conflict, enough to make it seem genuine, I fled back to my master empty-handed, and told him that Entrapta was the one who locked me out of the research. Then I served him for as long as I could, although always knowing he would one day seek to get Guy on his own. At that point, I didn't care, or rather, I couldn't. I must follow the will of the first one. It was imperative that I get the clone in prison, and allow him to be taken by *him.* He was to be a new, permanent vessel."

Adora frowned.

"I don't understand—"

"Who was your master?" Catra enquired, cutting across Adora.

"The man is addled," Prime suddenly said. He was no longer smiling. "All his secrets being found out must be breaking him."

"Shut up," Catra growled. "Hordak, who was your master?"

"The one who called me at night as the crime occurred," said Hordak in a voice far stronger now, looking up with determination, "who ordered me to cut my hand."

"This is nonsense—"

"Who?!"

"Horde Prime!" Hordak said, "the man beside me!"

With that, the magatama glowed, white hot.

“NOOOOOOOOOOOOO!” Prime screamed. “What insolence—insubordination!”

“I defy you,” Hordak said, giving a grin, “my will is my own! All these years, the only imperfection I had was the inability to choose my actions, but now I realise I can. I recant all my confession. I did not killed McRaker. I was never at the facility that night!”

Prime shouted again, before turning his back on the court. In the following silence, Entrapta took Hordak by the arm again and tugged him away, back to where Ron was at the dock. No-one said anything for a number of long terse seconds.

Adora was starting to wonder if that had done it, when Prime turned back, positioning himself behind the stand. He had begun to laugh.

“Did you really think I’d give up that easy?” he posed. “So what if Hordak had chosen self-preservation at last? His recant means nothing if there is still no evidence to tie me to the crime.”

“Oh come on!” said Adora, “If Hordak wasn’t there, then it must have been you who threatened Emily, you who Swift Wind saw, you who switched on the Gravity chamber.”

“Yet there is no proof,” the man held up a teasing finger, and tutted, “and for what reason would I go to all this trouble?”

“To capture Ron Guy,” Hordak explained, “as was always your intention. He was to be your permanent vessel, a position only a perfected clone could provide.”

“I don’t know what you’re babbling about.”

“First you intended to merely kidnap him, but McRaker proved a snag. So you killed her and formulated a new plan, setting up Guy as the murderer. Once he was found guilty, you would have ordered me to transfer him to your care.”

“This is scandalous!” the Judge said, shocked, “you’re telling the Prosecutor office was colluding with external parties?”

“That’s exactly what I’m saying,” said Hordak, “recall the trial of the defence’s paralegal.”

“Wait, you mean Glimmer?” queried Adora.

“When that woman killed Hilda…,” Glimmer recalled.

“That woman was employed by Prime,” Hordak continued, “the sword was to end up in his collection. Just like her employer, she improvised by killing an innocent, leaving the sword to become evidence.”

Adora held the sword up, her own reflection sparkling off the broad flat face of steel. She look back to Prime with a grin.

“Seems I’ve been ruining your plans for a while.”

“You’re the one,” Glimmer shouted, “you’ve been feeding the corruption at the heart of the justice system all this time!”

Prime waved a dismissive hand, “oh please. I couldn’t have done anything on my own. Save your anger,” he lolled his eyes over to where Catra stood, “for the prosecutors.”

Catra snarled, but then turned her attention to Adora. She slammed her bench, and called out:

“Hey, stop being an idiot and end this already!”

“Wh-what?” Adora was taken aback.

“Nobody cares about what *could have* happened anymore. We just need hard definitive proof to nail this guy!”

“But, I don’t have that,” Adora spluttered.

“Think! The last photograph went missing.”

“Hordak said it was destroyed though,” said Glimmer.

“That was when he was lying. He was never at the facility, sparkles,” Catra groaned.

“Okay, then where is it?” Adora demanded.

“I don’t know,” Catra was defensive now, “but it clearly meant something. Maybe there’s some trace evidence or something—how the hell am I supposed to know?” Her voice cracked as she said, “you’re the perfect one, remember? The one who puts horses on the witness stand and sees hidden messages on documents and knew to send Wright to check the phone records! If you’re so perfect —if you’re everything Shadow Weaver said you were-– then fucking figure it out!”

“Okay!” Adora shouted back, her throat giving way too, “I will!” She held her face terse, and brought her voice down to the barest mutter as she quickly ran through her thoughts. “McRaker wanted to find something newsworthy… you’d have a field day in that lab so what was so big and interesting that it beat all the others and why would it anger Prime if it were found out? Okay, it must have something to do with the cloning; that’s the big connection. And big? The tank, with the body inside, that was pretty freaky. And we already have a picture that shows she tried to snap it. But when why would she even care about the cloning if that was the big scoop? Unless… unless… the cloning, and the body are related? Was the body a clone, but then why would that affect Prime, we saw that he wasn’t a clone —wait no, we found that he has a soul, but then, but then….” Her eyes widened. She spoke, loud enough to hear, but in a lax, breathy voice, as she still comprehended the magnitude of what she was saying, “what if we’re not talking to the original Prime, but his consciousness held in a vessel? What if the original Prime was the body in the depths of the Dryl Institute, and that was what McRaker found? That’s what the last photograph would have shown. It’d be a scandal. Imagine how it’d shake his empire!”

Prime growled, but held himself, merely stating, “that would be interesting, but again, no such photograph exists, so we will never know.”

“Maybe it does still exist,” Adora shouted, basically saying anything she could at this point. She couldn’t let up now.

“We searched the entire institute,” Catra said, “it was nowhere to be found.”

“Well did you check Prime’s headquarters?”

“He’s not gonna just lay it leaving around for us to find,” Catra creased her brow, irked, “come on, blonde girl, you can’t be this slow this late in the game! Bring your best!”

“Then he didn’t leave it lying around,” said Adora, the words falling out of her mouth as the pressure mounted and mind couldn’t keep up with her words, “he still has it!”

“Explain.”

“He….”

Adora blinked, a few times just to be sure. Her mind was clearing, and now she was no longer jabbering, she could catch up with her thoughts. She was realising something. She’d just done it. The answer was right in front of her.

“The collection is full of some of the world’s greatest treasures,” said Adora, breathing fast, chest full of light, tingling air, “and Prime does not discriminate between expert and amateur, he just cares about pure beauty. But if he could fit it all in his jacket pocket, he would. McRaker must have been good. She threw away the first attempt because it was a poor shot. And that room, with the dark ambience and the mysterious lighting dancing off the water… it must have come together in an amazing way.”

“What are you saying?” asked Catra.

“I would like to know that too,” said the Judge. “Defence, if the photograph that shows the motivation of the killer —and which the killer took from the victim— was not found at the Institute, nor could be found at Prime’s headquarters, then where do you propose it is.”

“I propose,” Adora could barely contain her smiles, “that it is located in the district court of Los Angeles, courtroom 3.”

“District court, courtroom… here!”

“Your honour, the definitive proof,” she thrust her sword out, with a great sharp sling as it sliced the air, the point-tip directed straight at Prime’s chest, “is in the witness’s pocket. TAKE THAT!”

“No!” Prime yelled, taking a step back. “NOOO!” he yelled again.

He looked one way or the other, seeking escape. But the Judge ordered the bailiffs on him. They surrounded him, and he could not resist. He screamed as they restrained him. One managed to reach into his jacket and pull out his stack of photographs, quickly flipping through them, and finding the picture of the figure in the tank.

“Here we are,” said Adora, “you came for Ron Guy, and chance had it that McRaker was looking for her scoop. You could not let her reveal the truth to the world, so you turned on the gravity chamber, bringing her up to you. You grabbed her by the jacket, leaving your fingerprints there knowing that your clone would have the same data! Then finding the picture beautiful, you kept it for yourself and flung her up to crash into the ceiling and then fall to the floor dead!”

“No, no,” Prime wrestled against his captors, breaking himself free. The truth may have been out but this body of his was still tall and built, and the menacing look on his face gave the bailiffs pause. “I am Prime! My empire is vast, you cannot detain me!”

“Your real body isn’t so strong, is it,” said Adora, “we’ll just take you there.”

“But I still have this vessel. And when I have the clone I will be free of my old body!”

Entrapta stood in front of Ron, shielding him from view and looking at Prime defiantly. She was small, even with the bunches, but Hordak was not. He joined her, and Prime’s threat became feeble in the instant.

“Hey, Prime,” said Adora, calling his attention to her. He watched her with now darting, infuriated green eyes. “You wanted this sword right?”

The hilt in her hand was starting to rumble, vibrating so that energy warped up her arm. The blue gem was starting to glow. Adora leant it against her shoulder, facing the gemstone away from view.

“It should be mine!” Prime spat, “part of my collection.”

“Oh really.” The jewel was incandescent now. She could feel it. “You want the sword? Then here, have it!”

Once again she swung it forward. With it thrust his way, Prime almost lurched forward as if to grab it. But then he shrunk back. Too late he realised what was going on. His eyes glowed bright green, and then white, and he let out one last final scream. He writhed, and twisted, attempting to resist the power, but what strength his physical form had was nothing against the truth. His image split. An eyeless reflection of himself was leeching off his physical form, rising and rising as the body fell. Soon this pale, transparent shade flew up, dissipating into the air as the last screams petered out into echoes. The body collapsed onto the floor.

The Judge blinked and stammered, though finding no words for some time. Eventually he asked:

“Prosecutor Catra, where is the witness now?”

Catra walked over to the slumped body, nudging it with her foot.

“I believe we were talking to a clone, or a vessel or… urgh, I can’t wait to never think about this again. We’ll turn this body over to the Dryl Institute.”

Entrapta’s eyes sparkled, “ooh, another subject to work on? There are so many possibilities! I can make you a brother, Ron?”

But the defendant was so white he looked ready to pass out, and so could only give a weak half-smile and nod.

“As for Prime,” Catra continued, “I’ll have to send detective Scorpia to detain him. But I’m assuming he won’t be going anywhere soon.”

The Judge let out a long deep sigh. “This trial has been quite the ride. Corruption and murder in the most shocking of places. And once again, ms. Adora, you’ve taken a case you weren’t initially meant to, and performed nothing less than miracles in the courtroom. I’m starting to wonder if all these rumours I’ve heard about you are true. Nonetheless, it is time I finally, at long last — and please, I beg no more interruptions— give my verdict. Mr. Ron Guy, on the charge of murder, I find you… NOT GUILTY.”

There was as much hubbub among the six people in the defence lobby as there was among the gallery as the trial finally concluded. No-one was getting this trial out of their heads for a while. All but Adora chatted away. She, however, just calmly breathed and smiled.

“We’ve got a lot of work to do now,” Entrapta announced, “so much science left unexplored, and these past few days mean we’ve got a lot of catching up to do.”

“What will happen to Hordak?” asked Glimmer.

“No doubt there will be an enquiry. I don’t think he’ll be able to keep his position after all this. But perhaps he can come back to the Institute. We’d be more than happy to see him back.”

“I’m just glad I can get my attorney’s badge back,” Phoenix laughed, “can’t think of what I’d do with myself otherwise.”

“I dunno, you did pretty good as my assistant.”

“Your assistant? Hey you were the one helping me in my investigation!”

“Well if I ever need help again, I’ll know where to look. That reminds me, what are we going to do about payment?”

“Well,” Phoenix crossed his arms, “it was technically *my* case.”

Glimmer matched him, “true, but Adora was the one who actually cracked it.”

“Based on my groundwork, I mean come on. If we’re gonna split it, we should be thinking 60/40.”

“60/40 works. Adora not only showed that Ron was a clone, but that Hordak was a clone too and then proved it was Prime, who wasn’t even on your radar. 60 for her.”

“Uh, yeah, but I figured out the gravity chamber, and the third party threatening Emily. I would have gotten further if Hordak hadn’t disbarred me!”

“Well why don’t we split it evenly for all our contributions,” suggested Bow, “25 each way.”

“I’ve gotta eat,” Phoenix whined.

“That does remind me,” said Bow, “we did *all* contribute. Didn’t you notice Glimmer?”

“Notice what?” she said, giving him a cool pleasant smile.

“Proving Prime’s blood match,” he said, “that was some advanced forensic technology, and a hefty amount of foresight and quick

thinking on my part. Admit it, forensic science is useful, and so am I.'

"Bow," Glimmer slunk her hand up Bow's chest, creeping her fingers upon his lapel, "I already know you have your uses."

Eyes widening, Bow replied, "oh yeah? And what would those be?"

Wrapping her fingers around his tie, she pulled him down, meeting him in a kiss.

Adora grinned.

"About time," she remarked.

It was as if some chain had been lifted from her neck. Even the sword in her hand felt lighter than anything she had ever held. The past few weeks were melting away in her mind, and all that she felt was this present moment, where she, Adora, was neither cheering nor laughing, but merely clam and content, at the summit of the world.

Then Catra's voice called from behind her, "hey. Adora?"

Everyone now saw her, the prosecutor, seeming small as she approached. Her cape almost fully wrapped her, with one arm underneath rubbing against the other elbow. She didn't quite meet Adora's eye.

"Hey, Catra," the other girl said. "Um, thanks for the help in there."

"What do you mean?"

"If it weren't for you, no doubt Prime would have gotten away."

"It wasn't as if I wanted to help you," Catra muttered.

"But you did."

Adora reached forward and took Catra's hands into her own. The girl jerked her head up, blush forming in her cheeks. She quickly lowered her face again. Adora continued to smile.

"I know it must have been hard, but thanks for choosing to—"

Catra yanked her hands free, "I didn't have a choice!"

Adora was stunned silent. She hadn't expected that. Now an itch crept along her neck as she awaited Catra's explanation.

"Everywhere I turn, I lose," Catra's tone was low and seething, "I could have become Chief Prosecutor today. But even then, what'd be the point?"

"I…"

Lights danced in Catra's heterochromic eyes. All the bitter thoughts flooded back to her, every memory, all the anger, replaying her mind.

"Ugh," she finally yelled. "To think… I thought I could put and end to… if I just saw you."

"Wait, what do you mean?"

"It doesn't matter," Catra snapped, "it would've been better if we'd not met at all!"

Her fist was closed now, held down by her side, but shaking.

"Why…" Catra said to the floor, "why do you have to exist? I've had enough of these confusing feelings." She looked at Adora again. "I don't need them, and I don't need you!"

She stepped forward, and grappled Adora by the collar of her jacket. Yanking her inward, she brought them to barely an inch between them. Fury radiated off Catra's face and burned Adora's skin, as did her bitter breath.

“Get out of my way” said Catra, “or the next time we meet, I’ll destroy you.”

She let go, and Adora dropped back. She hadn’t resisted.

“Catra….”

But the prosecutor had already turned around and left. Adora didn’t shout or call after her. She didn’t chase her down. Neither retort or accusation was ready in her mind. She just fell quiet.

“Please come back.”

But her voice was a whisper, and Catra was gone.

Chapter End Notes

> Not to go off smug or anything but I'm really fucking proud of this chapter. I'm actually quite ahead now on writing so I probably wrote this a few weeks ago, so coming back to this now, reading it through, I'm so happy with how all elements play out. Just moment after moment, small bits of humour, emotion, drama, great build-ups and fantastic pay-offs. Probably the best discrete thing I've written for a while although hopefully we'll top it soon.
>
> As you should tell by that ending, we've got a very special final episode starting next time, basically our very own Turnabout Goodbyes. I've already written most of it —it's 8 chapters long and after that there'll be two extra chapters to wrap up the whole fic.

Duty of Defence

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

No light, not even from the moon as new, hiding behind its clouds, could reach the top of the trees let alone the detrite foliage scattered along the forest floor. The two figures were but silhouettes. Neither could recognise the other. All they could tell of each other were their voices in the black and the dark.

"I watched your last performance," said the one, "to be honest, I had expected better."

"Things fell out my control," said the other, stiffly.

"I just assumed you'd have done more. I've watched you for a while now. You'll do anything it takes, isn't that right? Remember our little improv? The way you thought on your feet with the watch and all was a stroke of genius."

"Well, when there are enough variables I can control and account for, victory is assured. When there are… complications, then it's not so certain. And that *attorney* is nothing but complications."

"Ah, blondey?" the first voice enquired. "Yes, she does seem to cause you a lot of problems."

"It won't matter," said the second. "I just need to cut her off. Giving her an inch of mercy and she takes a mile, so I'm going to show her none."

"Are you considering having her… dealt with?"

"No, I just to make sure all the variables are controlled. The next trial will be perfect."

A cloud passed, and the slightest sliver of illumination passed into the scene. It glinted off the sharp teeth under a broad sly grin.

"Because you're right. I'll do *anything* it takes to win."

There was a bang. Burning smoke. A groan of pain, masked by the squawks of birds overhead as they all evacuated the trees.

The body fell to the floor. Dead.

It was the following morning, and far away from the woods but in another place surrounded by trees. Adora and Glimmer were sat on the floor by the latter's bed. The morning sun was rising and gleaming through the window, filling the bedroom with gentle light. It was another one of their sessions —as especially after the last trial, Adora wanted to know more about She-Ra and the sword— but it was entirely chill. They had soda and snacks by them on the floor, and conversation wandered easily.

Things had never been better at Brightmoon manor. Scarce a day passed without someone beaming at the joys of life, and where one was happy, the good feeling would pass to another. Sure, the occasional slow day happened. Adora could still wake up on the wrong side of bed and get into a slump. It wasn't as if her myriad anxieties had disappeared. But there was enough around her to remind her that life was good. Most often, it was Bow or Glimmer —or Bow and Glimmer.

Sometimes romance could change people, but the two were still as they were. Glimmer was high-strung and Bow was endlessly compassionate, and they knew how to push each other's buttons. They were still best friends now, and even before they'd been intimate, at least emotionally. Simply they had been steadily falling into each other for a while, and they were happy with that pace.

"You're not worried about becoming a third wheel?" Glimmer asked Adora.

“I’ve always been the third wheel, but like,” Adora crunched some crisps while saying, “but like one of those buggy things. You two are side by side, I’m the leader at the front.”

“I like to think we’re more of a tripartite partnership….’

“Hey I lead the court cases and have the sword. That’s leadership vibes.”

“You sure it’s not lonely being the, uh, front wheel, then?” Glimmer said, adding a teasing smile.

“What, you’re not suggesting we make a polycule?”

“N-no,” the girl was suddenly flustered, “I meant more like, about you getting a relationship? You thought about it?”

“Oh right, well,” Adora mumbled, “it has been hard to meet people.”

“Hmm, I guess you only get to talk to us and your clients.”

“Yeah, and I can’t go out with the clients,” Adora gestured, “I’m sure that violates some ethical code somewhere. I did hang out with that co-counsel from your case. You know, mr. Wright’s friend.”

“Maya Fey?” Glimmer looked up, intrigued. “How’d that go?”

“Oh, she was really fun and surprisingly down to earth for a miko. But there wasn’t much of a click, y’know, and we never scheduled anything else.”

“What about, um, that woman you danced with when we went to that bar.”

“Oh, hehe,” Adora gave a nervous giggle and couldn’t stifle her blush, “the big girl. Yeah, she was really… hot.”

“You like the strong types?”

“I guess I like the kinda girl who can kick my ass. But that was just a dance, didn’t get a number. I’m just not very good at that sorta stuff. I mean, I’ve never even kissed a girl apart from you.”

“Wait, what?” Glimmer started. “You can’t be serious?”

“I mean that’s just the truth,” Adora said with a shrug. “It’s not big deal.”

Glimmer however was slapped with a aghast look. She lay a hand over her own chest and silently castigated herself for being an ass.

Then she shook her head, “no, this isn’t right. We’ve got to find a way to change this. We’ll get you back on the dating market, and you’re going to get someone. You’ll kiss someone properly before the year’s end!”

“Come on that’s like a month away,” Adora said with a giggle. “I’m already a hopeless case, but that’s never going to happen.”

Far away, matter of more importance —from one point of view, that is— were under discussion. The blinds of the Chief Prosecutor’s office were fully open. Morning light filled this room too, revealing its bare contents. Boxes were scattered about, and little else was there but the desk —clean but for a small landline phone—, as well as Hordak and Edgeworth, both stood.

“You requested me, sir?”

“You shouldn’t call me that,” said Hordak, “it’s improper.”

Edgeworth shook his head, “as long as you remain my superior, then—”

“That is exactly what I wish to talk to you about. I shall no longer be your superior.”

Taking a step back, Edgeworth stared with a slight slack jaw. “Chief Prosecutor, I don’t understand.”

“It remains Hordak now,” said the ex-Chief, “I am submitting myself to a full inquiry by the PIC. To ensure the continuing function of this office, it is best that I…,” the man’s face wrestled taut for a few moments, “step aside.”

Then his face became relaxed. To Edgeworth’s complete surprise, he actually smiled.

“It is better this way. I can’t escape this judgement, but at least I can choose how to face it.”

“There’s no way for you to hold on?”

“I compromised the integrity of this office for too long,” Hordak said, turning away to face the window, “delivered evidence to an external party and would have done the same with a prisoner had there not been intervention. I must answer for these actions.” He gestured his head to the side, “But I know you will be different. That is why I am appointing you acting Chief Prosecutor.”

Edgeworth widened his eyes, although his brow furrowed deeply. Heaviness fell in his chest.

“I am honoured,” he said, genuine, “but this is must too great a responsibility for me. I still have much to learn. I was planning on taking to Europe to study alternative systems.”

“That will have to wait,” said Hordak, mustering his last ounce of authority to his tone, “there is simply no other for the job. At least not until we find a new permanent appointment. Look at your record. Your hand in the Gant-Skye affair, revealing Debeste’s own crimes… if anyone can keep vigilance for criminal activity both within and without, then it’s you.”

Edgeworth gripped at his other arm, holding for a few terse moments. Then he relinquished it.

“Very well,” he said, “I shall serve the role as best I can. In the meantime I certainly hope there will be no major scandals until the new appointment.”

“Thank you for this,” Hordak said, smiling again, “it will give me some ease of mind going forward.”

At that moment, the phone rang. The two men looked to each other.

“Well, it is your office now,” said the former Chief.

Edgeworth stifled a grumble and went to take the phone.

“Hello?” he answered, holding it to ear. “Yes… yes, hmm….” His heart dropped. Eyes bulging, he shouted, “she what?! Good grief. I’ll be on my way. Send detective Gumshoe to the scene.”

Hordak stared blankly, before remarking, “I never said it was an easy job.”

It was nearing afternoon now, and Glimmer was ready to leave the manor. The others had headed off, but she was still filing some work on the kitchen table, over a late brunch. Still, she was nearly finished. She shifted her files away, and jumped from her seat.

“Oh, hey, mom,” she said, “didn’t see you come in.”

Angella was there, by the door. She was holding a hand over the high cabinet, letting herself fall into thought. But Glimmer’s greeting called her attention, and she came to join her.

“Glimmer,” she said, although her voice faltered towards the end. She tried again, forcing a smile, “are you heading out today?”

“Yeah…,” Glimmer said, a little cautious.

“Perhaps I should wait then,” Angella suddenly decided. “I don’t want to disrupt your day.”

“Did you want to talk?” Glimmer slowly sat herself back down, maintaining a constant focus on her mother. “I can hold it off for a bit.”

“It’s just…,” Angella sighed, and sat down as well. “I want to apologise.”

“Apologise? For what?”

“For, well, everything. I tried to long just to keep you from trouble, but that only made you more vulnerable.”

“It’s okay, mom,” said Glimmer, smiling, “you only wanted to help. And you haven’t been as overprotective recently, so like, you’re improving.”

“I, well,” the woman puffed, “I don’t quite appreciate being graded like that, but I have been trying. And yet, I was referring to something deeper.” Angella looked to her daughter with soulful eyes, “I’ve kept the truth from you for too long, even though you deserve to know.”

“What truth?”

“About your father. About his death.”

As she told this, Glimmer watched her mother with a slacked look, but for a quivering in her lip. Her breathing hitched for a moment, her heart paced, but these were for a different reason. Her eyes begged her mother continue, which she thankfully did:

“Your father was a prosecutor, and I a defence attorney. We’d fought many battles against one another in court. But that didn’t get between us. We loved each other, and loved you. I didn’t think life would ever change. The night it happened it…,” Angella’s voice started to quiver, but she kept on, “he came home before I did. He was working on a case and he brought his colleague from the office to discuss it, I believe. But the prosecutor’s office… apart from seeing him in court, that was a part of his life that was completely distant from me. Whatever the meeting was about would have been gone by the time I came back, I never even gave it a second thought. And I was working so late that night. It was past midnight when I came home, and I saw him and I—,”

Angella let out a sudden gasping breath. She couldn't speak for seconds, just transfixed, staring a spot beyond Glimmer.

"M-mom?"

"I," Angella shook herself out of the reverie, "no, I…, he was… was…."

"I know what happened," said Glimmer, eyes falling. "He was shot with a gun."

"It wasn't just that," Angella said, now agitated, "there was sign of a struggle. He had a cut across his eyes… a-a-a scratch mark, four lines. The prosecution decided it had come from a fork." Angella shook her head, "but I know better. I *saw* the killer."

"Y-you saw them?" Glimmer gasped.

"I did. A small creature. Just there."

Angella gestured to the patio beyond the pane-glass sliding door. Further than that was the side garden, leading into the trees and ultimately the road beyond.

"I tried to catch them but they were quick, and easily lost me by the time I got the edge of the grounds. When it came to a trial… a culprit was found. A burglar, who had been here that night by chance. But he looked nothing like the person I saw. So I took up his case. I needed to find the real killer."

"But you were up against Manfred Von Karma," said Glimmer.

"The man with the perfect record, and the perfect evidence. But I couldn't let that stop me. Because I found her. The real killer. But I didn't have the evidence. Good god…," Angella placed her hands over her face, "I couldn't find anything. But I couldn't let the girl who killed Micah get away, so… so…."

"You forged it," Glimmer knew this part of the story. "And you were caught. But mom, please tell me. Who was it? Who killed

dad?”

Adora was leant against a brick wall, at the entrance to an avenue of dying trees. Autumn wasn’t quite fled, but the winter’s air had definitely joined, and so she kept her arms wrapped about her chest. Bow was with her, but no Glimmer yet.

“Keeping us waiting in this weather…,” Adora grumbled.

“You chose not to wear anything warm,” Bow said. He had exchanged his white gloves for mittens.

“Yeah well I ran here,” Adora countered, “but now all that heat’s gone.”

“Well it is Christmas season. You’re going to have to get used to the weather.”

“It’s November!”

“Okay, almost Christmas season.”

“Which means it isn’t Christmas season,” she said.

“Either way, it’s good to get into the spirit,” Bow smiled, “my dads make a great feast every year. I’ll be damned if I don’t get you, Glimmer and whoever else we can get over.”

“Do they know about you and her?” asked Adora, giving a sly look.

“Well, I did tell them but….”

“But?”

“They were confused. I think they thought we were together already….”

Adora spat out laughing, “Bow were you the last person in the world to realise you two work?”

Bow spluttered, "well if it was so obvious to everyone else you could have just told me!"

"Nah, it was funnier our way," Adora teased.

"Well, if I ever see you and someone else… 'working', I'll have the good courtesy to tell you."

"Man, both you and Glimmer, huh. You know, I'm probably just not a romantic person. I wouldn't be a 'do anything for love' kinda gal, I'm too… pragmatic," she decided.

"Right…," Bow threw a sideways glance. But he just contented himself with a satisfied smile and said nothing else.

"Like," Adora kept talking, a blush creeping up, "not that I wouldn't *mind* a girlfriend, but I just have a hard time imagining me…and someone…. I'll stop talking now."

"Probably for the best," noted Bow, "you might actually discover something about yourself."

Adora's face-saving retort would never be known. Their conversation was cut short by a far off voice calling out to them.

"Yooo!" came the voice, "aw man, I actually found you!"

They looked for the source. Detective Scorpia, —rushing to them so that her heavy overcoat billowed in the wind and her hat almost flew off— waved madly with her free pincer. She came up, broke down doubled over, and started huffing for a few seconds.

"Just a moment," she groaned, "gotta… catch my… right!" She shot up. "Man, I didn't know if I could reach you by phone, I thought to look for your office but you don't have an office, so I looked for ms. Angella's residence but that was a whole thing and I couldn't find it and I was just running around the city trying to think what to do and you know it's just a whole stroke of luck that I found ya here and—"

“Scorpia, slow down,” Adora said, stressed, “just start from the beginning.”

“I just needed to find you,” Scorpia kept on as before, “because you’re the best lawyers that I know and—”

“You need a lawyer?” enquired Bow. “Are you in trouble?”

“No!” a shocked look struck the detective, “no, no, I’m not in trouble. It’s Catra!”

“Catra? What’s she done now?”

“She’s —what, no!” she threw her claws down, aghast, “she hasn’t done anything wrong! But she’s been accused of murder. She’s at the detention centre right now.”

“Woah, woah,” Adora motioned her palms, “this is Catra we’re talking about right? About nyeah high, big ears, bad attitude?”

“This is serious,” Scorpia whined, “it’s prosecutor Catra. She’s under suspicion for a crime.”

“But like… no-one actually thinks she did it, right?” Adora said with an off chuckle, “like come on.”

“That’s what I keep saying,” said Scorpia, “but the office can’t find any other likely suspects and the evidence points to her. But they’ve been wrong before and you’ve proven people innocent a lot. So that’s why I came to you.”

“Wait, you want Adora to defend Catra?” Bow asked. “She’s kinda a terrible person.”

Scorpia was flabbergasted. She looked at them agape, eyes darting from Bow to Adora and back. Her insides went hot and twisted as she realised what they were insinuating.

“Sh-she’s not terrible,” said Scorpia, “sure, she it not the most agreeable person, sure. But she doesn’t care about popularity,

she's focused on results. She's hard-working, determined, gets straight to the point, and obviously that's going to ruffle a few feathers. But she's a good person! She…."

Why are you always following me , echoed in her head, *we're not friends!*

"She's just been under a lot of strain recently," Scorpia said, while shaking her head clear. "But she's not a killer."

"Let's… at least find out what's going on," said Adora. "The centre's not far. We'll get to the bottom of this."

With hurry, Scorpia led them across from the park entrance to the detention centre. It was busy inside. A string of crimes —met with the paralysis at the prosecutor's office following the recent scandal— had started to bottleneck the processing of incidents. So there were multiple police, legal professionals and family relations waiting around in the hallways. Scorpia, Adora and Bow however went to the visitation room.

There was no-one there. The room was cold, and the plastic glass just showed a mirror image of a bare grey room. It wasn't even manned by a guard.

"Wildcat?" called Scorpia. "You there?"

Moments passed. Silence rang throughout. But then there was a curt sniff, and a rustling, the sounds of which were muffled through the glass.

"Go away," came the muted voice. It was Catra. "I don't want visitors."

"I had to find someone," Scorpia explained, "the investigation's already underway and it's not looking good, and you don't even have a lawyer. So… I got you one.

At that, a small figure shot up into view. At first it was just a mane of shaggy grey hair, but then the creature stumbled, stabilising

themselves by the counter, and twisting themselves around, Adora found herself face to face, divided by the screen, with Catra. She regarded her back with weak but wide eyes.

“Oh…Adora.”

“Catra, what happened?”

“Go away,” said Catra. “I thought I told you to never show your face again.”

“She was apprehended in the Whispering Woods National Park,” Scorpia filled in, “they say someone saw her shoot the victim. The body has been identified as a performer called Double Trouble.”

“Wait, Double Trouble’s the victim?” Adora broke her gaze from Catra to stare at the detective.

“Oh yeah, now I recall. They were a victim in one of your trials. Wow, that was a while ago now, huh.”

Adora faced Catra again, “what were you doing in the woods with Double Trouble?”

“Why would I tell you?” She shot Adora a rancid glare, “why have you even here? Come to laugh at me? Finally see me in my place. Ha ha ha.”

“Catra, I’m not laughing. Tell me why you were arrested.”

“I don’t have to answer anything.”

“Uh, yeah you do,” Adora said, growing irked, “if you want me to defend you.”

Catra forced another laugh, harsh and derisive, “you are not defending me. I don’t want your help.”

“Well tough luck, because I’m—”

“Prisoner, you’re required for questioning.”

The guard had appeared in Catra's side of the room. He held the door open, impatient. Catra shot Adora one last look, taking the petty victory with a breezy smile, before slinking away. Adora scowled, but knew she wouldn't get the other girl back for now.

Bow, who had hung at the back the room, gave a tut. "That went… well,"

With no point remaining, they left. Adora didn't say anything at all as they passed. Her head swam —this whole situation was surreal. And Catra's behaviour stuck on her mind. Nothing new there.

Exiting the centre entire, they came across Glimmer, rushing up to them and waving.

"Hey, there you are," she called, "where have you been? We were supposed to be up at Gourd Lake, weren't we?"

"Something…," Adora tried to root herself in the present, although that damn cat's grin kept distracting her, "something sorta came up."

"What happened? Is it a case?" Glimmer's glance passed over the detention centre's entrance, and then to Scorpia

"Prosecutor Catra's been arrested," Bow explained, "on suspicion of murder."

"Catra?" Glimmer stared, with both her eyes widening and jaw setting. She was stiff for a few moments, before commenting, "well, I guess it was always going to come to this."

"Hey, no," Scorpia protested, "the prosecutor didn't kill anyone."

"Wait did you bring them to see her?" Glimmer asked the detective. As the pieces fell together in her head, shock and then incredulity warped her expression, and she looked to the attorney. "No, Adora, you can't be serious. You're not actually thinking of… defending *her* ?"

“She’s not interested,” Adora looked away with an exhale, “without a letter of request I can’t do anything.”

“I’m sorry about her,” said Scorpia with a crestfallen look. She stammered, “I j-just… I know she’s a difficult person, but I thought with you it might’ve worked out.”

“Heh, quite the opposite,” Adora’s low tone was filled with both rue and regret. “Something about me just sets her off.”

“Damn. I just thought… since you know each other.”

“They’re hardly on the best of terms,” Bow pointed out, “sniping across the courtroom, and outside of that, they’ve only met like what, three times? Less?”

“Yeah, but like before that.”

“What do you mean before?”

“They’re old friends,” said Scorpia, blinking. She didn’t get why the others weren’t following.

“What?” Glimmer twisted her cheek, “why’d you think that?”

“Well, I dunno,” Scorpia rubbed her arm, “the way Catra talks… I just assumed they knew each other before.”

“Well, now that you say about it,” Bow said, tapping his forefinger and thumb on his chin, “you remember Catra’s opening statement in Sea Hawk’s case? The way she talked to Adora was very direct.”

“Obviously she was just saying whatever she could to get under her opponent’s skin. Anyway, they’re clearly not friends, they’re….”

Bow made a suggestion. “Rivals?—”

“Enemies,” Glimmer said, simultaneous. “Right, Adora?” When there was no response, she said again, “Adora?”

But Adora was fully turned away now, looking off to the cold nigh winter distance. She wished she could fall. Or at least sit down. It was as if her body had doubled in weight, her hands like dumbbells dragging down her limbs, and with it her chest was on the cusp of giving way. The conversation was about her yet it passed her by, even though she knew where it was going. Taking in a deep breath, she readied herself. Then she let it out, and turned around.

Meeting her eyes, Glimmer just gaped.

"No way," she said, "no, really?"

"It was a decade ago, but yeah. We were friends. Best friends. We spent all of school together. We were practically adopted together by Shadow Weaver."

"Why didn't you ever say?" asked Bow, though with more amazement than shock.

"I dunno," Adora rubbed her wrists into one another, "maybe I didn't want to admit it. I mean, I didn't want to admit that the girl I knew was this prosecutor I was facing. Even now, I can't really believe it."

Glimmer faced away, and merely said, "I can."

Adora fell quiet. Although the full implication of Glimmer's dark words didn't set in, they made her ruminate. Yes, there were similarities, between the young Catra and the prosecutor. Continuities. Glimpses of the friend she'd had. Catra had always been sardonic to an extent. And even now, in some of Catra's laughs and smiles, even though they be evil most of the time, showed flashes of something Adora had once enjoyed more than anything on earth.

"I want to look at the crime scene," Adora decided.

Everyone looked to her, all with an expression of surprise though each with its own subtle difference. Scorpia's was twinged with

hope.

“So you’ll take the case?” she asked.

“Maybe,” said Adora. “I just wanna have a look first.”

“We can’t trust Catra,” Glimmer said, flatly. Not just matter of fact, but the operating fact. “We know what’s she like.”

Bow shook his head, “she’s corrupt, sure, but so are all the others. They can’t all be killers.”

“You’ve seen what she’s capable of!”

“The problem is systemic to the justice system, that’s what you’re always telling us.”

“It’s a system that yields a higher number of murderers than average,” Glimmer snapped, “but sure, they’re not all killers. But with Catra—”

Glimmer restrained herself with a sudden silence. She held still, with a wrestling expression, before letting out a sigh. She looked back cooly:

“Fine,” she said, “let’s look at the evidence. Just don’t be shocked when it looks like she’s guilty.”

The journey to the crime scene took them to the furthest bounds of the city they’d ever travelled. By trains, they were ferried to some of the low rises of the mountains that hugged the northern border of the metropolis. Though far below any of the cold peaks or mountain retreats, they reached a dense swathe of trees that formed the Whispering Woods National Park.

The crime scene was cordoned off, crossing tape wrapped around the thin barks of trees. Scorpia lifted up the picket line and — having learned her mistake from so many previous times— was gentle enough to not snip the tape. Adora led the way through, coming up to a tarp over a small mound.

“This it?”

“Have a look underneath,” Scorpia gestured.

Adora did so, lifting the cover. It was Double Trouble alright. Their body, even now, was in a dramatic repose, but otherwise undisturbed —even for the blood. The bullet wound was in their chest, but Adora’s eye was caught by something else. There was a stream of four lines along the victim’s face. A scratch.

“Okay,” she breathed, “maybe this isn’t a bad as it looks. Cats aren’t the only thing that could cause this mark.”

“We can check,” said Bow, pulling out his pad. He crouched down by the body and made a quick scan of things. The results sped back with a ping. “Keratin; Hmm….”

“What hmm? What’s keratin?”

“This is from a cat’s claw alright. Whatever else, Catra probably did scratch Double Trouble last night.”

Glimmer let out a, “hmph,” although quickly turned away when Adora tossed her a glare.

“You’re certain?” Adora asked Bow, “I mean can we trust your pad’s right from just a single scan?”

“In the old days you’d need to burn the fibres to see if they were man-made or real, and even that’s imprecise. But,” Bow shook his head, “I mean Entrapta helped me design this. We can find the fibres under layers and still cut them down to a specific source.”

“Ugh, great,” Adora grumbled. “Damnit, Catra, why were you out here?”

“What do we know about the murder weapon?” asked Glimmer, looking up to Scorpia.

“So,” Scorpia tapped her pincers together, “I’m kinda not on this case. Or rather, not allowed. Conflict of interest or something.”

“Your relationship to the victim?”

“Well it’s not a relationship, w-we’re just colleagues.”

“That’s a type of relationship….”

“Oh right,” Scorpia shook her head to get back on track, “anyway, that’s not stopped me from learning what I can. Rumour is… it’s an old weapon. Probably came from the vault.”

“What’s the vault?” asked Adora.

“That’s long term storage for evidence from certain cases,” said Scorpia, “although apparently a lot is missing because of the Chief Prosecutor’s corruption. My guess is that the gun is from an old case.”

“How’d it end up here?”

“Well…,” Scorpia’s expression fell, “for someone to have access to the vault, then… they’d need to be a prosecutor.”

“Oh.”

“Yeah….”

Bow stood up, and decided, “I don’t think we’re going to get much more from this. And with Scorpia out of the case, we won’t be getting an autopsy report soon.”

“There must be something,” Adora said with an anxious grit, “come on, what about the rest of the woods? If a third party were involved there must be some evidence.”

“We don’t have any reason to think there was a third party,” said Glimmer.

“I have to believe in my client.”

“You don’t have a client—”

“Guys,” Bow quickly stepped between them, “obviously we shouldn’t quit this early, but we can’t sweep the whole woods.”

“There is someone who might have been here last night,” Scorpia said. “She knows her way around and might be able to give you an overview.”

With no explicit protest from Glimmer, and getting a small nod from Bow, Adora had the consent to go forward with it. Scorpia led them further down path, south-westerly towards the forest skirt where trees were a little sparser. Here there were rose-beds and lush-bushes going stepwise by a stream, followed by dahlias and then flowers of summer, which refused the passing of season. When they reached a large gathering of high stalks in the garden, Adora took the urge to wade through.

“If there’s anything evidence hidden, this is the perfect spot.”

“Wait, don’t—”

But Scorpia was too late. Adora had trampled a path through, only to get ensnared by the thorny stems.

“Okay, just carefully untangle yourself and get back here,” said Scorpia.

“I can’t. Stuck.”

“Look, just wait and we can—”

“Nah, it’s no problem, look. For the honour of Grayskull!”

A flash, and Scorpia watched on in horror as Adora produced the sword. She hacked a way like the reaper and made her way free. In her wake, a lot of dead flowers.

“What are you— nooo!” A wail came, from an entirely new origin.

They all turned to see a tall thin woman rush in distraught as she saw Adora's handiwork. She crouched down to mourn the fallen.

"What sort of brute would…."

"Yeah, Adora, nice going," Scorpia scalded her.

"Oh. Sorry." Adora looked suitably guilty.

The new woman, dressed in a pink dress with detached seafoam sleaves and wearing garlands in long streams of hair, stood up with her wide slender shoulders coming to a hunch as she continued to stare out at the garden. But then she loosened with a long meditative breath. Turning, she faced them all with a expression quite pleasant.

"Nothing that can't be mended with time!" she said, in a voice that, while sweet and melodious, had a constant shakiness.

"Everyone, this is Perfuma," Scorpia explained, "she works for the NPS team that manages the Whispering Woods. She tends the gardens."

"It's nice to see you again, Scorpia," the gardener smiled up at the detective. The big girl rubbed her neck and gave a cheesy grin. Perfuma gave a more wary eye to the other three. "I don't recognise your friends though."

Adora stepped forward, although realising she still had the sword in her hand, she stowed it away.

"I'm an attorney, I'm here on a case."

"Is this about that, um," Perfuma's gaze shifted to a corner, "that murder."

"You were around here last night. That means you could be a witness."

Perhaps she was even more. If anyone could be the third party….

The expression on Scorpia's face showed that she could read Adora's mind, and she quickly cut in, "wh-why don't you just tell us everything you saw last night, Perfuma. You were mostly down here, right?"

"Yes," Perfuma recounted, "I was planting and plotting all day yesterday, there was still some work to do late into the night. I was checking the soil—"

"It's fall," said Adora, peering with narrowed eyes, "is it really the time you'd be doing all this work?"

"Are you cross-examining me?" Perfuma asked with a restrained huff. "I don't really know what I should do here."

"Hey, hey, it's okay," Scorpia said with a reassuring smile, before giving Adora a vexed look.

"Look," Perfuma sighed, "the prosecutor told me I shouldn't talk to anyone about what I saw last night until I'm summoned to court."

"So you are a witness," said Adora.

"Yes, but—"

"If you have some relation to the crime, I have to know!"

Bow stepped forward and grabbed Adora by the sleeve. "Hey, this isn't an interrogation. Leave her be, Adora."

"Hey," Scorpia was wearing a look of deepest concern, "are you thinking that… Perfuma was a killer?"

"Wh-what?" the thin girl exclaimed.

But Scorpia continued, "because that's impossible. No-one is less likely to hurt someone than Perfuma. She helped me out of a life of violence, she abhors the stuff!"

"She what?" Glimmer asked.

“Oh, did I say that out loud.” The detective blanched, and words abandoned her for a few seconds.

Thankfully (or perhaps unthankfully) Perfuma stepped forward, a glint in her eye, and offered to explain:

“Didn’t she ever tell you? Scorpia used to be in a gang.”

“Wait, really?” Bow asked, amused.

Scorpia grabbed the brim of her hat and tugged it down over her face

The girl reached into her tunic, which incidently had pockets. From it she withdrew a picture, passing it over to Adora. Though the colours were washed by time and repeated handling, the content was clear. Scorpia, in a black jacket with a high collar and with her clipped hair gelled up, looking rather cool as she laid back.

“A really rough crowd,” said Perfuma, “Just thinking about them makes me…,” a shudder crept along her body, but she summoned up a hand in mudra-fashion, and regained a calm. “But with Scorpia, I knew she was in the wrong place. Her aura was crying out that she needed to leave. All I did was give her that push.”

“I mean it was more than that,” Scorpia muttered. “Those kind of groups demand service and loyalty, but there’s no friendship. No warmth. You were the first person to ever treat me like a person….”

Perfuma smiled up at her, and rested her palm on her big arm, gently rubbing it. The detective peaked out from her hat to show back her own smile.

“So,” Adora said, “you absolutely trust her?”

“Absolutely,” said Scorpia.

“Okay,” she sighed. “I’m sorry if I was suspicious earlier. A-and destroying your garden was a jerk move too. But I need to know what you saw last night because I believe my client is innocent. Could you please tell me?”

“Your client is that prosecutor, right?” asked Perfuma. “I’m sorry, but I think I saw her last night. Twice actually.”

“You did?” Adora’s heart began to plummet.

Perfuma nodded. She pointed out to the edge of the thicket, noting, “that’s the route of approach if you want to get into the forest and out, usually. I saw her come in. And I heard a gunshot not long after.”

“And you didn’t see anyone else?”

“It was just one person, and it was the same person both times. I’m very sorry, I wish I could say I saw something else.”

Adora buried her face in her hands. Combing her fingers through her hair she slipped them back until she had slid her hands around her whole head, and was now tugging them back by her ponytail. Had she ever had so little before? In Glimmer’s case she’d had Phoenix Wright’s groundwork, in Sea Hawk’s she had the luminol and the photographs. Even in the cases she’d lost she had something to start with, and against the combined efforts of Catra, the Chief Prosecutor and a corrupt mogul she’d at least had a few genetic results.

“Maybe,” she muttered, “I’ll get a rookie like me at the prosecution bench? At the very least I don’t have to face Catra.”

“You saw the prosecutor, right?” Glimmer asked Perfuma. “Do you know which one it was?”

“Oh, it was that guy,” Perfuma said. “The one with the cravat? Edgeworth was the name, I think.”

“Oh,” said Adora.

She was so screwed.

After that, they left the woods. Scorpia elected to stay, so it was just Adora, Bow and Glimmer sat around a table on the train. Hedges and trees in the fore flitted past that they were a blurred stream, rust and orange going by. Further out the scenery passed at a gentler rate. There there were grasses still green, scattered trees, and further still winds and sands and mountains. Glimmer stared out. Adora rested her head back, closed her eyes, and let the movement continuously yank her backwards. Bow looked to the other two with concern.

"Guy's, don't you think we should talk this through?" he said.

"It's Edgeworth," Adora said, still not opening her eyes. "I wouldn't even know how to hope to beat him."

"…the same way you beat Shadow Weaver and Catra?"

"Edgeworth blows them out of the water. Sure, he's polite enough in company but he becomes a whole different beast at the prosecutor's bench. It's like… he's got his own She-Ra power but instead of a sword he's got logic. It's freaky."

"Don't let your guard down," said Glimmer. "You have to promise us that. Edgeworth was a student of Manfred von Karma —who makes Catra look like a girl scout."

Adora creased into a giggle. Bow looked over concerned.

"Adora?"

"Sorry," Adora stifled herself, though barely, "just the image of Catra selling cookies."

"This is serious," Glimmer pained, "Edgeworth will stop at nothing to get his goal."

"Well yeah, he's a tough prosecutor, but he's not what you're making him out to be."

“Really? You don’t think as the acting Chief Prosecutor and after all that’s happened he’s not going to choose what’s best for the office and its reputation?”

“What are you getting at?” Adora’s brow sunk. “Like, surely that would mean he’d try to get Catra off. I mean, wouldn’t that be good for us?”

“Sure, if you think just winning cases is what being a lawyer is about. But if all the evidence aligns with Catra’s guilt, you have an obligation to the truth, no matter what shenanigans the prosecution pulls.”

“That’s… not what a defence attorney does. I have to help my client.”

“Adora, you were the one who showed us otherwise. Remember Hordak. You had no contract with him but you chose the truth over expedience.”

“That was different,” Adora said, curt.

“Really?’

“Really.”

“Here’s the difference,” Glimmer said, tempo and voice rising, “Catra was doing her role as a prosecutor and trying to get the defendant guilty. You can’t trust Edgeworth will do the same. It’s not in his interest. Even if you think he’s somehow out of his teacher’s shadow, he can’t undo what the prosecutor’s office is.”

“Well I respect him, and mr. Wright trusts him,” Adora’s voice was rising too. “He’s not going to dodge his duty, and neither will I. I’m going to get Catra a not guilty verdict!

“Okay, can we all slow down for a second,” Bow struck forceful but gentle tone as he cut in. “I feel like everyone’s getting confused here. Glimmer you’re saying Edgeworth’s a corrupt prosecutor… so he’s going to go easy on the defendant. Adora you

trust him, so you think he's going to give you a hard time? Like, I'm not saying either of you are necessarily wrong but I'd have thought your positions would be switched."

"What are you getting at?" asked Glimmer.

"I'm just saying I think you're both really anxious and want to argue for the sake of it. Why don't you try saying what's really on your mind?"

Adora and Glimmer shared a look, and seeing the strain and confusion in each other's eyes, realised their friend was right. Glimmer sighed, and confessed first. She told them everything Angella had explained to her this morning —the circumstances of her father's death, falsifying the evidence, and of course, the sighting of the real killer.

"And she told me who she saw. The murderer was just a child, though she was quick and lost her. Mom saw her again though, especially as the trial for the falsely accused got underway. The killer was Catra."

"Catra," Adora whispered, "no…what?"

"She had been at the Manor that day, for definite. No-one else fit the description of a small lithe creature. My dad had scratch marks, similar to the ones on Double Trouble. There was other evidence too, though no definite proof. But it's clear that it was her. Catra…killed my dad."

"I see."

Whatever annoyance she felt towards Glimmer abated. Sure, this still sounded so surreal, she absolutely could not believe it. But Glimmer did.

"I'm sorry about your dad," she said, "and I know this must feel wrong because it looks like she's the murderer. But I can say with a hundred percent certainty that she didn't kill anyone."

“How?” Glimmer said in a weakened voice.

“Because I was there too that day,” Adora said. “If Catra had hurt someone… I would know. I would have told you, and I wouldn’t be defending her now.”

“You were there?” Glimmer looked with wide, blinking eyes, but seemed stopped for words in her amazement. Then her face returned to a fixed stared. She asked, “how can you have such faith in her?”

She could not answer. Glimmer did not press the matter, and for that at least, Adora was grateful.

When they got to the detention centre again, Adora asked the other two if they could wait outside. They acquiesced, so she went in alone. The visitation room was as before, yet now it was even more lonely. Catra was there, expectant, but not waiting.

“Oh, you again,” she said. “I thought you came to laugh at me earlier but you’re the one who keeps giving me entertainment.”

“Do you have a lawyer?” Adora asked, flatly.

Catra said nothing.

“Of course not,” Adora sighed. “You don’t like relying on people. Funnily enough I don’t like people relying on me. I can’t bear to let them down.”

The prisoner scoffed, “then why become a defence attorney?”

“I never really asked the opposite. Why did I become a prosecutor in the first place? Guess it was what was expected of me. It’s what Shadow Weaver wanted.”

A twitch touched Catra’s ears, though she mainly kept her rather tired scowl motionless. She was silent, watching. Adora continued:

“There was prestige and glory too, maybe that was a factor. But I never asked myself why until, well, when I switched sides. I knew I wanted to help people. Maybe putting away wrong-doers does but there was always that one person. Out there…. They could use my help, and I could give it if I were an attorney.”

“Yeah,” Catra was still looking down, “you told me. Well, whoever that person is, I pity them.” She looked Adora in the eye. Both sullen and mocking, her sight was conflicted in more than just colour. “You let people down. You let Shadow Weaver down, you let your clients down, no doubt you’ll let down your new “friends.” And if you ever found this person you oh so want to help, you’ll let them down too.”

Adora fell silent. Looking down, her mouth parted as thoughts emptied from her mind yet waves of something strange flowed through her. Her hand moved up, feeling about the hem of her jacket.

Catra continued watching her with a queer disgust. “Why are you here, Adora?

Hand reaching for her lapel, Adora felt for her sunflower-shaped pin. Her attorney’s badge.

“Like, come on?” Catra was growing louder now, growling in her voice, “you come here, not even to laugh at me but to be laughable? Are you pathetic or are you trying to show me pity? Like either way, I don’t wanna see it.” Anger flashed sharp in her face. “Damnit, Adora, why do you want to defend me?!”

Adora ripped the badge off her chest and slammed it against the window.

“Because this is what I’ve always meant to do!” Adora said, loud, forceful, but without fury, “this is what it’s been for. Being She-Ra, becoming a defence attorney, for the first time it makes sense.”

The sudden motion had caused Catra to cower. She watched, confused, “what the hell are you talking about?”

“It’s you! You’re the one I’ve wanted to help!”

Catra’s expression broke. It couldn’t burden the weight of what Adora had said. Although the girl tried to fix it back into a grimace, neurons were firing off in her mind, thoughts mad in their paces as everything suddenly came together.

“It was,” she spluttered, “…me?”

Adora nodded. She gave a small, hopeful smile.

Snarling, Catra looked away —although a blush, she could not hide.

“Then you’re even dumber than I thought.” She gave a sigh. It was long, whittling down to a groan as she expelled the last air in her lungs. She rubbed her palm into her face, and then groaned again, “ugh,” and completely resigned, said, “fine! I’ll write your letter of request.”

“Really?” said Adora, lights dancing in her eyes.

Catra blushed again.

“T-this doesn’t mean anything,” she said, “this doesn’t mean I like you now.”

“Sure, sure,” Adora said, trying to maintain a professional expression. Though she let slip few smiles to herself.

“And I don’t expect you to win,” Catra said, “certainly not against Edgeworth.”

“Of course, of course.”

Then Catra reached for her other arms and rubbed it. Her gaze fell. Whether torpor or something else, her voice faltered when she next spoke. For the first time, she seemed very small, alone in her side of the room.

“Just,” she said, “do what you think you have to do.”

Chapter End Notes

And here we go, the final episode begins. Enjoy as the gay lawyer angst is cranked up to eleven

Thanks for all who commented last time! I don't find I have the time to really answer them individually, but know that they are very welcome.

I Remember You

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Memories were difficult. After nine years they shifted about, merged. Details changed, subtleties washed away, while what was minor became catastrophic. And yet the basic feel of those times came back in such vivid ways. The rush of air as Adora ran, burnt with the smell of autumn leaves. The sound of laughter, as she chased Catra. The feel of bark and moss crumbling and sticking to her hand as she climbed. Both terror and thrill as she looked down on what to her was the plummet from the sky.

She slipped. She fell. It hurt, but she was laughing.

"You're dead!" Catra grinned, peering over her. "You only have one life, remember."

"You fell more than nine times!"

"Nah, I land on my feet."

"You can't do this though."

Adora kicked the air, and vaulted herself up off her back and onto her feet. Catra ducked and ran. Adora gave chase, all the way back into the house.

A hand grabbing her arm stopped Catra with a lurch. She was nimble and quick, but altogether a scrawny thing. Adora always thought if someone tried they could snap her arm in two. She'd threatened to do that once, when Catra had bitten her. They'd fought like that a lot once, but not so much these days. She assumed they never would in the future.

"Catra, you got Adora hurt," came the reproaching voice of Shadow Weaver, who was then holding the tiny girl still.

“She was the one who fell!” Catra protested.

“Chasing you.”

“It’s okay, Shadow Weaver,” Adora argued, as she suddenly hugged Catra’s other arm. “We were only playing.”

Relinquishing her grip, Shadow Weaver said, “I see. Well it’s alright, children, so long as you keep it gentle.”

Though she nursed her arm, Catra didn’t mind as Shadow Weaver stroked her hand along her cheek.

Their mother ushered them along. It was time for school, so they dressed. Long blue pleated skirt, sailor-style collar, red neckerchief —Catra wore her white blouse disheveled and with shortened sleeves; Adora’s full-sleeved was more neatly tucked in. With that, they were about to leave when Adora stopped the other girl. Her neckerchief wasn’t done up.

“Lemme just….”

“Ugh,” Catra moaned, “why do you always have to be so perfect?”

Adora reached across and fixed it about, and although Catra complained, she held still as to let it pass quickly.

Then they were ferried to school by car, and the day went on. They learned, perhaps, but nothing of note. In one class, however, the teacher set them a different kind of assignment. It was about prospects. The future. Not something children of their age gave serious thought to, but when the teacher asked Adora what she wanted her life to be about when she grew up, she had her answer:

“I want to be a prosecutor,” she said, “like my mom.”

“That’s exciting,” the teacher said, “though it’ll require a lot of hard work and studying. So keep up with your homework. Catra, what do you want to do?”

“I’ll…,” Catra gnawed the end of a pencil and thought, before saying, “I wanna be a prosecutor too.”

That drew giggle from the class. Though it left the teacher unamused, and they placed their hands on their hips.

“Catra, don’t copy,” they said, looking down with disapproval, “you’ll have to forge your own path, not just do what your friend does.”

Catra slunk into her seat. Then she scowled and threw herself forward, laying on her desk.

“She’s my mom too,” she muttered.

Adora leant over to whisper, “I think you being a prosecutor would be cool!”

“Whatever. I don’t care, I just had to answer that stupid assignment.”

Memories for one could only tell one story. But nine years ago someone else was about to have just as significant a day. Far from the school, the courthouse was busy all the morning. The defence attorney, Angella, was stood with folded arms, waiting. Her client was a small shivering man in an ill-fitted suit, and he was rubbing his hands incessantly. She place hers on his wrist to stay his rustling.

“It’ll be alright. We have a strong case.”

“But I’ve heard bad things about this place,” the man rumbled. “They’ll eat me alive!”

“Perhaps. Have you heard of the prosecutor on your case?”

“Not much.”

“They call him the magician of the bench,” she said with a wry look, “owing to his ability to produce evidence from thin air.”

“F-forgeries?! I’m doomed.”

“No, no,” Angella chuckled, “just that he’s very thorough at crime scenes. You leave it me however,” she gave him a smile. “You’ll walk free.”

In the courtroom Angella stood by her table and waited for the Judge to call for silence. When he did, he gave the formal introduction, and then stopped. He looked to the prosecution, and without a word gave him leave to speak.

The man at the opposite bench was one in a long, double-breasted purple jacket, with a full ever-so-grizzled beard and black hair up in a knot. While procedure demanded the Judge call on the prosecution to give its opening statement, both this man and this woman had been here before many times, and they had a different rote.

“I arrived quite early today,” said the man, “you would not believe the workload we’re getting at the office.”

“I’m sure that won’t bare on you ability to see this trial through, Prosecutor Micah,” Angella said with a blank expression.

Micah shook his head and smiled, “just thought you should know why I was gone this morning. But I made sure to prepare something for you. How was breakfast?”

Typical of that man, and it made Angella frown. Did he always have to draw attention to her inability to cook?

“Prosecutor, as always you bore the Judge—”

“Actually, I don’t mind at all,” the Judge said in a strange, oddly polite way, even smiling something nervous as if he had intruded upon their conversation rather than them into his trial.

“Still, perhaps we should begin? Maybe then your workload would actually decrease.”

Micah gave a bow, and said, “your wish is my command, defence.”

With that, the trial begun. Angella watched for the usual signs. The corner of Micah’s mouth would give the smallest of twitches if he was deliberately hiding something —usually in preparation for a dramatic reveal. Unfortunately, this time he was purposely turning his face away as he talked.

“…that is in fact an excellent point,” he was saying in response to one of Angella’s objections, “and I feel kind of sorry for deflating it —so, I hope you forgive me, honey— but you have to consider this evidence.”

“Ah, of course,” Angella said, dryly as she saw the object in his hand, “a pair of scissors? That conveniently didn’t show up in my own investigation?”

“Aha, the magician strikes again,” said the Judge. “I wonder how the defence would dare escape this trap?”

“I hope you don’t take me for an amateur, your honour.”

“With your elegance and radiance?” said Micah, genuinely breathless as he did, “I would hope not.”

“Elegance and radiance? I think you used that one last time.”

“Such things are endless, while the english language is so limited.”

“Ah yes,” Angella said with a pert smile, “would that include your first attempt which I believe was now fifteen years ago, in which you described me as… tall.”

“Aha…,” Micah coughed, seriously blushing, “well, we all have start with something? I was a foolish boy then.”

“And a wise man now.” Angella said this, fixing a gaze directly into his eyes, and without a hint of guile.

“I… ah,” Micah gave a low chuckle, “I believe you win this one.”

“I say,” said the Judge, sitting back, “the cross-court banter is never so pleasant as it is when you two are together. But defence, no matter what prosecutor Micah says, you haven’t won until you’ve addressed the matter of these scissors….”

After the trial, Angella and Micah met up again in the courthouse atrium. The man continued to wear his warm smile.

“You always give a thoroughgoing defence, don’t you,” he said as she walked up.

“No less than your attacks. But I’d ask for nothing less.”

“Everything I said about the workload was true, I’m afraid. I’ll be heading home but it’ll be following me. I’m having a colleague over.”

Angella nodded, “Glimmer is staying over at her friend’s, and I’m going to be working late at the office. We’ll be out of your way.”

“I wouldn’t have minded,” Micah said, insistent and apologetic.

“No, it’s alright. When it comes to the work our two sides shouldn’t fraternise.”

“Damn the sides, our paths keep straying.”

“True,” Angella sighed, “I do worry that we haven’t had any time together for our own sakes, or Glimmer’s.”

“Angie,” Micah took his wife’s hands into his own and looked up to her, “we’ll make time. Next time the stars align we should sit down and figure out a plan. We just need to figure out when.”

“Ah yes, we need to plan for time so we can plan for time,” Angella said with a rather pained chuckle. “How did everything get so ahead of us.”

“There’s no need to worry,” Micah assured, soft in voice, “We’ve made the best of what we could so far, but tomorrow lies ahead

of us all the same. We'll have to discuss this later, but we will."

"Of course," Angella smiled, leaning down into him, "but for now…"

By midday, Catra and Adora were free from classes for an hour. Adora loved to be free of the stifling rooms and into the open air. The other girl however was ambivalent. In class they could whisper when the teacher wasn't looking, or muck about if they were particularly rowdy one day. During most breaks, Adora went to the gym for a game, or to train up. Catra sometimes jokingly hyped her from the pews but it wasn't exactly her idea of a good time. At least today was an off-day. Still, it was on her mind.

"If you're gonna join the sports team next year, maybe I should become a cheerleader," the cat quipped.

"You'd be pretty lousy."

"Nuh-uh. I'll get some pom-poms. Go, Adora, go!"

She lazily punched the air. In response Adora gave her a tackle. Though it was gentle and playful, Catra's waist was undefended. She yelped, less dignified than she would have hoped. To regain lost honour she wrestled Adora into a headlock.

"Hey, lemme go," Adora laughed.

They soon came to rest on a wooden picnic bench that oversaw a stretch of lawn reaching out to the school gates. Beyond it, though it was barely past midday, the sun drooped in the sky —a November's glare over a chill nigh-winter wind. The two were joined by other friends of theirs —a girl Lonnie and two boys reptilian Rogelio and jittery Kyle.

"Hey we'll all heading over to the arcade after school," said the girl, "You guys wanna come?"

"Can't," said Adora, "Shadow Weaver's doing a thing and we have to go too."

“Aw that sucks.”

“We don’t have to do anything, it’s just we ‘can’t be trusted’ alone at the house.”

Catra shrugged, “I mean we did trash the place last time. Shadow Weaver freaked.” She assumed a crude impression, “ ‘you two cannot be allowed out of my sight again!’ “

This drew laughs from all of them. Catra grinned.

Time flew by as they chatted and laughed by the common. Words of no meaning passed between them, the topics lost to time, but the good feeling of being with friends was something that not even eras could wash away. Certainly not the glow that Adora had towards Catra.

“Hey I got some snacks,” said Kyle, offering out a small box. “Chocolate sticks I think.”

“You got those from Tiny Tokyo?” asked Lonnie.

“Yeah.”

“Hey give em over,” Catra snatched them, and before Kyle could protest she nimbly pounced back up onto the bench.

“No fair!”

“I’m just joshing you, Kyle,” Catra said, slipping away a single stick before graciously tossing the rest back to its rightful owner.

They might have just shared the confectionery and that would’ve been the end of it. But Rogelio noted in a growl that he’d seen something online about a challenge involving the chocolate sticks. Two people bite from either end, approaching in. Last to break was the winner.

“Sounds dumb,” Catra remarked, as she let her own stick sit by the corner of her mouth like it was a Cuban.

“Bet you’re just saying that cause you’d lose,” said Adora.

“Oho,” Catra gave a rather evil look, “this coming from Adora? C’mon you’re totally squeamish, you’d break easily.”

“Wanna put the challenge to the test?”

“Taking bets!” said Lonnie.

With that they gathered around. Adora knelt on the bench top, Catra faced her in her feline perch. Grabbing a new a stick, they carefully placed the tips at the end of their two mouths, the sweet chocolate end for Adora, the slightly dry biscuit to the other. This directly aligned their eyes. Adora’s light blue into Catra’s heterochromic set. There was always a determined flare in them. It was something Adora always liked, even though she intended to win.

“Start!”

With the kickoff, they crawled in, nibbling at either end. Millimetres at a time they moved, but never did they break eye-contact. So fixated on victory they didn’t even stop to savour the taste. By halfway, their faces were getting real close now. Their noses would soon brush against one another. While Catra was intent on not being moved at all, Adora thought strategic and slightly angled her head, even though it gave away on precious microseconds. They kept moving closer. This was weird, wasn’t it? On a collision course. Their mouths would actually meet…. But Adora wasn’t going to lose. Even if she was growing hot, even if Catra’s breath, right on her face, was tingling on her skin.

Yeah, this was super weird. But just a little further. She closed her eyes.

Catra broke. She ripped away, face scrunched and tongue out.

Making a cringing motion she squealed, “ew, I’m gonna get Adora disease!”

Adora opened her eyes, widening upon realising her victory. But then she quite forgot the chocolate, falling out of her mouth, as she laughed:

“Oh come on you barely even touched me! Who’s the squeamish one now?”

Catra pounced, landing on Adora. Giving her a light thumping, it restored a little dignity for the cat. Soon, the strangeness that had come before was gone, and the group spent the last few minutes of break laughing and playing until the bell summoned them back. The rest of the school day passed without remark. Adora had a sort of spring in her step as they took their bags and walked their way down a side street towards the car park.

Catra however straggled. Though she had been positively carefree at lunch, something possessed her with a quiet inertia. She stared at her feet as she made each step, heavy and slow. Adora stopped, as to let her catch up. Catra stopped too. Adora took on frown.

“What’s wrong?”

“Nothing.”

“Come on,” Adora walked back to her. “You can tell me.”

“There’s nothing to tell, I said it was nothing!” Catra said in a hiss.

Adora’s concern deepened as the other girl faced away in a sulk. She wanted to pry further, but Catra, unprompted, just said:

“Do you really wanna join the sports team?”

“I mean, yeah…?”

“You’re gonna be training a lot more. There wouldn’t be much for me to do then.”

“You can hype me up like before,” Adora suggested. “Could do that cheerleading thing if you really wanted to.”

“Yeah, cause I reeeeally wanna do that,” Catra said with a scowl. “Like, what am I to do you? Your pet cat?”

“I didn’t mean it like that? Why are you sniping at me?”

“Ugh, it doesn’t matter!”

Turning away, Catra looked ready to skulk off —but knowing she had to go the same direction as Adora, couldn’t quite bring herself to move. With a somber look, Adora just watched her.

Catra could get tetchy back then. Various scratching incidents around the time lent evidence to that. There was a pattern of her getting angry and then running off; though she’d always say she just preferred to be alone. She didn’t need to rely on others, she would say. Adora was too young to grasp all the cues. A poorly thought-out cry for help manifesting as lashing-out was a suboptimal message for an eight year old. If Catra got angry at Adora, she’d get angry back.

But if she saw that Catra was hurt, she’d always want to help.

“We’ll always be friends, y’know,” she told her. “No-one on the team if going to replace you, if that’s what it is. Remember how you didn’t like Lonnie or the others at first? But now we’re all a group.”

“Yeah, well,” Catra mumbled, “what if it’s different?”

“It won’t be different,” Adora insisted. “I mean, who knows what will happen when we leave school. But I know you’ll be there, whatever happens. We stick together.”

“You…,” Catra turned back to look at her, her two-coloured eyes wide and expressive, “you promise?”

The memories didn’t have much more to offer. They’d gone to Shadow Weaver’s car, and she drove them a ways to a part of the city they didn’t recognise. The journey slipped them into a world of green, a shrouded park-like grounds secluded from the constant busy of urban life. Then it delivered them to a large house. The memories were very hazy then on: the door and its silver handle so high above the small children, the two girls as they played the afternoon away, the feeling of cold metal in Adora’s hand.

The last thing was Adora, finding Catra alone and shivering under the car’s exhaust. After that— there was nothing more.

The detention centre waiting room was drab and cold, and Adora sat there, alone. Staring at the chequered tiled floor, she waited, even though her visit to Catra was over. She’d consulted with Glimmer and Bow one last time before letting them go. But Adora couldn’t leave. She just couldn’t leave

She let out a long heavy sigh.

“Catra, what happened to you….”

When the emptiness didn’t answer. Adora thought to stand up. Perhaps she should return to the manor and get some sleep before tomorrow’s trial. But a voice breaking the silence put that thought out of mind.

“Adora, what a pleasant surprise.”

It was Shadow Weaver, mask and and all, emerging from the interior corridor.

“It has been a while,” she said.

“What are you doing here?” Adora half-stood up, but the way the woman bore down her look at she approached forced her back into her seat.

“I still have my duties. More, ever since the Chief Prosecutor’s removal.”

“Did you know about all of that?” asked Adora, with a accusatory glance, “you were pretty chummy with him as I recall.”

“Hordak was a very secretive man. How I was supposed to know he was a clone let alone all about his illicit dealings. But you discovered it all. Your career path has certainly taken you in new directions, although I find it strange you’ve not contacted me at all. Is Angella your guardian now?”

“Well I’m an independent woman now,” said Adora, “I can live my own life.”

“Is that why you spend all your time at Brightmoon? Shouldn’t an independent person like yourself own your own place?”

“In this city, are you crazy?”

“Surely you’ve been earning,” Shadow Weaver said cooly, “tell me about your cases.”

“No, you tell me something,” Adora looked up with real intent in her eyes now, “why didn’t you ever tell me what happened to Catra? You never even acknowledged she existed let alone she was becoming a prosecutor like me. Why didn’t you say?”

“Isn’t that obvious by now?”

Shadow Weaver came to sit down by Adora’s side. Once again, she said:

“Tell me about your time as a defence attorney. Come on, let’s hear about your escapades on the other bench.”

Adora told all. She said of how she proved Glimmer innocent, and although Shadow Weaver was there, she learned more of what went through the girl’s mind that day. Following that was the Sea Hawk case. Adora recounted the unlikely criminal and her crime of

good intention. But then there were the cases she lost. The certainty of her faith in the client versus the incontrovertibility of the evidence. How the pain sank in as she found herself unable to keep the trial going. How Catra was always there, undermining her, undoing her.

“But it’s my fault,” Adora looked down, resolutely at a chequered tile, “every case was my loss, and I let people suffer for my failure.”

“I feared this would happen,” said Shadow Weaver, “leaving the Prosecutor’s office has shown you out of kilter. You’ve been left… confused.” She shook her head, “I should never have let this happen.”

“Oh yeah? And how do you know what’s good for me?”

“It’s merely what I see.”

“I’m not confused,” Adora said. “I’m meant to be here, as an attorney. I caught Prime. I foiled both his traps so neither of the people he tried to frame went in his place.”

“Did that end so well for you?” asked Shadow Weaver, raising a brow behind her mask. “What did Catra do?”

“She helped me,” Adora said, emphasising the words, reasserting their truth. “During the trial.”

“And after that?”

“I… well,” Adora rubbed her wrists, and said, “she came to talk to me.”

“And what did she say?”

Adora looked down again.

“She said she’d destroy me.”

Leaning back, Shadow Weaver took a second before giving a small, self-satisfied nod.

"It is far too late for that girl," she said. "And it's all because you strayed from your path."

Adora stared at her. The woman continued:

"She was never meant to take your place. You've seen the kind of ambition she has, and it has taken her far. But had you stayed, you would have won all those cases. You would have defeated Phoenix Wright. You would be well on your way to greatness within the office."

"I can't imagine Catra would be happy being told to stay put."

"Greatness was never meant for her. She can't handle it. She would have remained where she was meant to be, unhappy perhaps, but with her ambition constrained she would learn to be contented with a life fit for her. Instead… she's become obsessed with taking you down. And she'll never be satisfied. You will always be a threat to her because you remind her of what she's not." She shook her head once again, and sighed, "and now it's driven her to murder."

"She is not a murderer!" Adora stood up. Ire shuddered down to her closed fists. But she just maintained fixed eye-contacted with Shadow Weaver. "She's my client now, I have to believe in her."

"A foolish defence attorney's creed. What nonsense are they pumping into you over there?" Shadow Weaver's voice rapped like a cane against wood. "A piece of paper shouldn't cloud your ability to reason. This isn't about her being your client is it. This is your old friendship talking."

"And… so what if it is?"

The woman spoke softer this time, "I understand this must be troubling for you. This is another thing I worried would happen. For all the hate she gives you, you are an empathetic person to

the end. Cherish those memories of her if you must, but they cannot change what she is now. I'd consider ripping up that letter of request if I were you."

Shadow Weaver stood, and went up to Adora. She brushed her hand along the girl's cheek, although she slightly recoiled by the motion. Still, the woman's hand landed, and she gave a tut. Then she walked off towards the exit.

"This trial will not end well for you, child."

"I'm not going to abandon Catra now."

Shadow Weaver stopped just short of the door.

"Why?" she asked. "That wretched creature has shown you nothing but contempt. But more than that, she is in your way. Greatness lies just beyond your reach, but Catra is in your way. Cut her off. Destroy her."

Shadow Weaver left, but not before her parting words:

"Before she destroys you."

Chapter End Notes

> This was a weird one to write, a bit out of my comfort zone too, trying to write the characters as younger and doing these very cutsey almost slice-of-life scenes. Even reading back I'm only partially confident in it, although reading back, the Angella/Micah stuff actually stood out to me as really nice even though I had no idea what I was going to write for that going in.
>
> This last week has also just been hell for me. I'm not sure why but I've been having intermittent bad sleep, so some days I've been pretty productive, writing nearly 5000 words one day and just 300 the next. That said, I'm making progress towards the end, having already reached the last chapter. Apart from going back to some unedited chapters

and filling in a few gaps, I think I'll have finished the main writing of this within the week.

Conceiving the Impossible

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora and Bow were alone in the defence lobby. Glimmer was yet to arrive. Catra would be delivered to them by the bailiffs. The room was silent, though Adora could not say why. This was odd. It had only been a day since the two had chatted about trivial things, alone by the entrance to gourd lake. Yet everything had changed in such hectic ways, and whatever they had spoken of back felt too small for the moment of now.

"I'm starting to hate this place," Adora said to break the silence. It wasn't trivial, but it was small talk.

"Oh yeah?"

"It's always when things look bad that we're here."

"Maybe it's pavlovian," Bow suggested, "I mean, I think this is fine compared to when we're at the bench and everything hasn't started yet. Just standing there while everyone's watching."

"Yeah…." Adora clasped her hands to the side of her face and slid them down. She whispered, "I'm fine, I'm fine. I can do this." She looked to Bow and asked, "is Glimmer okay?"

He gave a half-smile. "She will be, I'm sure. I think she's just still processing things."

"Do you think she and Angella are right?"

"About Catra? Um," Bow glanced down, ruminating. He decided, "I can't really say. I can't believe they'd make the accusation lightly."

Adora shook her head, "she didn't do it. She was just a kid, it was chance that she was there. Where'd she even get a gun?"

“Look, I’m not saying she did but… it’s been nine bad years for them. They could really use some closure. But this is a separate thing, and Catra’s our client now. Glimmer will come around. I’m certain of it.”

“Yeah well,” Adora fiddled with the edge of her vambrace, “I’m really sorry about what happened to her dad. I guess I’d be mad if I were her and really did believe what she thinks.[?] So… you look out for her for me, will you?”

Bow laughed, “I mean that’s what I’m here for. But why can’t you look out for her too?”

“I’m busy. There’s someone who needs me more than Glimmer does right now….”

It wasn’t long for Glimmer to arrive, though she just merely took a seat on the sofa and said nothing. Then Catra arrived. [Eh repetittion]

“Oh god,” said Adora.

Catra’s hair, never before tidy, was now in clumps and sticking out at every end. It was uneven too, with some strands short and unseemly torn by their edges. Meanwhile the girl had dark rings sunk beneath her watery blue and sickly green eyes. She lumbered along with each step.

“What happened?” Adora asked.

“Nothing.” Catra was muttering in short bursts. “Up all night. Thinking about stuff. Didn’t get much sleep.”

“And this?” Adora gestured up to the shortened swathes of hair.

“Um,” Catra patted her own head, trying to remember, “I guess I grabbed onto this too roughly. Claws, y’know.”

“Maybe you’d have better been a barber than a prosecutor,” remarked Bow.

“Ha ha,” Catra said, not letting lethargy slow her sarcasm.

Adora’s eyes fell down to Catra’s neck where even her clothes were not hooked up right. Her collar was mostly buttoned up, but the white lace just fell untied about her upper chest.

“Your jabot….”

Adora reached out, and had taken the two sides of the ruffles in her hand, when Catra’s own snapped up, snatching her wrist.

“What are you doing?” she said with a snarl.

“Fixing you up.”

“I’m not a kid for you to dress up—”

“The client has to look presentable… dignified,” Adora said. “Otherwise the case might as well be lost.”

“Did your precious Angella teach you that?”

Glimmer, having overheard, scowled and said, “yeah, she did actually.”

Catra would have retorted, yet Adora cut her off.

“You’ll be grateful for what Angella’s taught me by the time we’re finished.”

Any attempt to refute this died in the prosecutor’s mouth. Se just swallowed her words, scowling as if were bitter. Finally she just groaned in acquiescence, and released Adora’s hand. Now able to tie up the jabot, Adora leaned in to better see what she was doing. Catra did not resist. The two were rather close.

“It’s done,” said Catra, shoving Adora away as she said, “can we go in now?”

The cat stormed ahead, pushing through the doors into the chamber. With a sigh, Adora followed. Into the courtroom they

went, taking their respective places and greeted by the usual pre-trial din. Bow was unsettled, as true as his words had been —this part was the worst. Yet his glances stole towards Glimmer, wishing he could unpick her mind to see if she was alright. And even Adora was changing her mind. As bad as waiting in the last room was, this was different. Her heart was racing, and no matter how much she set her hands on the bench, or rooted her feet on the floor, it was if she were on the precipice, always about to slip.

Miles Edgeworth stood at the opposite bench.

The Judge banged his gavel, calling for silence, and began, "we are here today for the trial of Catra. Are the defence and prosecution ready?"

"Ready, you're honour," said Adora.

"The prosecution has been ready for some time."

"Wait, why'd he say it like that," the attorney said in a small but agitated voice, "is he trying to imply something?"

"Adora, focus," Glimmer hushed.

The Judge was giving a nod, "some of you may be quite aware that this is another gravely sensitive case. After everything that's happened at the prosecutor's office, I think another murder accusation was the last thing that they wanted."

"What the prosecutor's office would like is immaterial," said Edgeworth, "instead we must focus on seeking the truth."

"In that case, would you give your opening statement, acting Chief Prosecutor?"

"Of course. Evidence will show that the defendant shot the victim at point blank range, deep within the Whispering Wood. We will also show her motivation and intent, that she lured the victim deep into the forest. All in the hope of manufacturing the perfect crime."

“OBJECTION!” Adora called out already. “If it was so perfect, how was she caught?”

“Wait, Adora, no,” cried Glimmer.

But it was too late. Edgeworth already had his finger by his temple, giving it a wag.

“Tsk, tsk,” he went, “I hope the defence aren’t conceding their client’s guilt this early?” He held out his hands, chortling as he shook his head, “I will say it would save us a lot of time.”

“Wait, what?” Adora’s voice failed.

“Just to say, I hope the defence aren’t arguing that the defendant’s crime was so perfect we should never have found it. However, the answer is simply that no crime is ever perfect. Like there so often is, there was an unforeseen witness, whom we shall call later on.”

“Adora,” Glimmer whispered, “don’t jump the gun on the objections! This is Edgeworth, you can’t bluff your way through this one.”

“I’m sorry, I just…um….”

Adora’s eyes were drawn towards Catra, sitting cross legged, arms folded at the dock. Her face was flat, so uninterested one would never guess it was her trial. And having seen what just happened, she was rolling her eyes.

To begin, the prosecution called a detective, Dick Gumshoe to the stand. He was a big man with a big green coat, albeit with short black hair over a blocky head. Upon Edgeworth’s prompting —and a few threats to his salary — he gave an overview of the case:

“The victim was a performer by the name of Double Trouble. They were called as a witness in a trial the prosecutor ran several months ago, so the two knew each other.”

“Objection! I was in that trial as well,” said Adora. “Edgeworth was somewhat involved too. How exactly is this relevant?”

“The majority of homicides are committed by a perpetrator who knew the victim,” Edgeworth explained, “it is in the court’s interest to hear that fact. But detective, explain what you found while investigating the defendant herself.”

“Alright, sir! Our boys looked into the background on prosecutor Catra, and it did not look good, pal. Hell, most of the people down at Criminal Affairs told me she was obsessive.”

“What about Scorpia?” It wasn’t Adora who asked, but Catra. She looked up strangely from her place in the dock.

“Detective Scorpia? Hmm, well she did say differently,” recounted the witness, “and she knew ya better than anyone!”

“Stay focussed, detective,” said Edgeworth, furrowing his brow. He folded his arms, and said with little patience, “perhaps tell them what the good detective specifically said.”

“Well… she said prosecutor Catra was determined, quick-witted, uh, some other words.”

“Witness!” Said the Judge., “do not refrain from telling us what you heard.”

Gumshoe ruffled the back of his hair, “well, there was ‘cute,’ ‘sexy,’ ‘sly’ and uh, ‘mean, but like in a hot way.’”

Catra was mortified. Gaping, spluttering, she stared. Flashing red at first, she then scowled and buried her face in her arms, regretting she’d even asked. There was a mix of whispers and titters from the gallery, although Edgeworth looked decidedly unimpressed.

“Detective, not the gossip, the background check. Keep going.”

Adora herself was a little confused, at any of the reactions. It wasn't as if Scorpia had said anything wrong….

Then she realised what she just thought.

She shook her head, quite violently. Must focus. No time for… whatever that had been.

"Right," said Gumshoe, "the detective said something after that last trial. Y'know, the one where the Chief Prosecutor turned out to be a clone or something? Prosucutor Catra had been furious. Like absolutely mad. She'd said something about making sure the next trial would go her way. Perfect to the letter. That nothing would stop her to bring down 'that attorney.'"

Adora didn't need to question who that was. Yet Glimmer did speak up, objecting:

"This is all hearsay. Unless Scorpia comes up to the stand and says this herself we can't accept it."

"Admittedly, I didn't expect us to go down this route," said Edgeworth, "but I doubt the good detective would willingly testify anyway. Instead, we have more conclusive evidence to speak to the same facts. Gumshoe?"

"Right," Gumshoe pulled out some print-outs from his oversized pockets, "have a read of these!"

Adora received them and gave them a look over. Fortunes sunk with every word.

Adora. Adora. ADORA. It went on like that for some time. *Why can't I get rid of her! This is ridiculous. She's like teflon, everything rolls off her even when half the time she doesn't know what she's doing. I did everything. I considered every possibility, didn't I? How am I supposed to expect a talking horse or cloning or any of this bullshit?*

Then there was a break in the text. Adora wondered if the writer was pausing for thought but that wouldn't make sense in text. The next line was a new but not a wholly unrelated topic.

Gonna head out. Had a call from them. Think this is the answer — I'm going to meet up, discuss that last case, probably… and maybe the next. This time, it'll be perfect. There'll be nothing unaccounted for.

"What… is this?" asked Adora.

"These are personal files from the defendant's computer," Edgeworth explained. "They confirm what the witness reported — she was furious about her last loss, and intended to make the next case perfect to her specifications. She even refers to her meeting with the victim."

"Does she?" asked the Judge, peering over his own copy of the text, "it doesn't refer to a name, only a group called 'them'."

"That's the singular them, your honour," Edgeworth corrected, "she refers to discussing the last case. It's possible that refers to the one Catra lost, but I believe it might refer to the Chas Singer case from a few months back."

"Why'd you think that?" asked Adora.

"There was some… unresolved questions. Not to mention the victim's testimony in that case revealed their own particular set of skills. Perhaps earlier on, as the defendant formed their plan, they hoped to enlist Double Trouble as an ally."

"That's a lot of assumption."

"Then disregard it. Further evidence and testimony will illuminate further."

"Just a moment, mr. Edgeworth," said the Judge, still looking at the document, "this text mentions 'Adora' several times. What's the significance of that?"

Edgeworth looked to her and asked, “should you explain or shall I?”

Adora sighed. “I was the defence in that last case, remember? The reason Catra was angry… well, it involved me.”

“That’s underselling it,” tutted Edgeworth, “the defendant is nothing less than obsessed with the defence. Only a week prior to that case, there was an incident. You were there, witness, perhaps you could explain.”

“Oh yeah,” Gumshoe rubbed his neck. He hadn’t expected to be asked about that. “I remember, the high prosecutor compared Catra to ms. Adora over there, and, well, things did not stay pretty.”

Adora glanced to the dock, but Catra was not meeting her eye. Looking back to Gumshoe, she said, “I didn’t know about this.”

“Yeah well, I don’t think anyone wanted to talk about it afterwards.”

“It should be clear to the court by now,” said Edgeworth, “that the defendant’s competition with the attorney Adora is so volatile that it continually drives her to an uncontrollable fury. This was only provoked by Adora’s ability to win, making use of unforeseen circumstances within the case.”

The Judge nodded, “I see. So she wished to manufacture a crime she’d have total control over, because she’d have done the crime herself! I don’t think I’ve ever seen such clearer motivation.”

Edgeworth gave a smug smile of victory, “indeed, you’re honour. Double Trouble was merely collateral to this motivation. The true target was Adora, whom Catra wished to utterly destroy.”

“Wait, no, OBJECTION!” Adora slammed the desk, “you can’t argue that! Look, I’m defending her, she agreed to let me defend her. Is this consistent with her trying to destroy me?”

“Objection!” Edgeworth called. “Your honour, strike that question.”

“Wh-what?” spluttered Adora. “Why?”

“Firstly, this is a fact of circumstances occurring after the event itself. It has no bearing on the crime or her state of mind leading up to or during it. And secondly,” a flash of something strange came like a grimace on the man’s face. It seemed his prosecutor persona died for a second, and he was touched by genuine concern. “I don’t think you’d much like to hear the answer.”

Adora silently mouthed. She itched to protest again, but there was something in Edgeworth’s face that was forbidding. It was a mercy to her. But how? How could her defending Catra make sense if Catra wanted to destroy her? But the answer was hidden in the question, and even Adora couldn’t ignore it now. Her legs felt weak. She had to stilt herself against the bench, hunched over, head dizzy.

The next few moments of the trial slipped by her, and now the detective was explaining more evidence his investigation had found:

“First there was the scratch marks. They appear consistent with the defendant’s claws and we found keratin traces in them.”

“Of course they were going to do the same tests,” Adora grumbled.

“Hey we get all the same training,” Bow said with a half-smile.

Gumshoe was continuing, “then there was the gunpowder burns. These only show up when the weapon is close to the impact. So the victim and defendant must have been close to one another.”

“Did you find the murder weapon?” asked Glimmer.

“Sure, and that’s the other thing. Only a prosecutor could have had it.”

“Because it was taken from the vault?”

“Sure thing, pal,” the man beamed, although his face quickly fell. “Wait, howdya know that?”

“Nevermind that. What case was the gun from?”

“Uh, lemme think here. It was from the SP-0 incident.”

“That’s hardly relevant,” said Edgeworth. “What matters is that Catra was the only one in the woods who could have brought that weapon.”

But Glimmer had perked up at the mention of that designation. Her fingers gripped into the bench. Adora wanted to ask what was up, but Edgeworth speaking up stole her attention away. Glimmer wouldn’t be explaining anyway. In fact, she wouldn’t speaking at all for the rest of this case.

“As you can see, your honour, the evidence is absolutely damning. And there is no room for contradiction or objection.”

“I see,” the Judge said, “I do feel I could hand down my verdict on this alone.”

“And yet, there is more,” said the prosecutor, saying words Adora really didn’t want to hear. “For we have a witness who saw the crime as it happened. This shall put the final nail in the coffin for the defence.”

Adora glowered, but really was powerless to stem the tide of this trial. She was bereft all of thought and sense, bamboozled by every new piece of evidence, whether she had known about it before or not, and felt no different to the gasping crowd. How had Catra been so stupid? Or had Adora been. Was Glimmer right? Was she just in denial. Was her faith in her client nothing more than the desperate hope of an old friend?

Well, if Edgeworth were right, then it would all be over soon. And Adora could throw away her badge and toss her sword into the

sea.

The new witness was a tiny woman. Purple, withered, but with huge goggle-like spectacles and an equally broad gormless smile. She looked like she had been plucked from either the woods or a large garbage can.

“Name and occupation?”

“No, Barry, why you asking me such silly questions,” the woman rambled. “We have to be going to the New Forest today!”

“Uh, what?”

“What, you forgotten your own name? Mr Zieks, I can’t believe you! What will your friends at the Old Bailey think!”

With grit teeth and sunken eyes, Edgeworth collapsed to the bench as he stared forward.

“What the hell are you talking about? This is Los Angeles and my name isn’t Barry or Zieks!”

“Oh, you don’t know Madame Razz, do you. I keep making these mistakes.”

“Uh, Mr. Edgeworth?” Adora was blinking, “who is this?”

“Mara, no!” protested the woman, “don’t tell me you’ve forgotten me too?”

“… My name isn’t Mara. It’s Adora.”

“Oh, I see,” the woman stroked her chin with a bony finger, “then perhaps you are this time’s She-Ra.”

“Ah, yes, I am She-Ra,” Adora showed her golden brace, “that’s right at least. Can you please answer Ed— I mean, mr. Ziek’s questions? This is the Old Bailey, you see. We need your help.”

“Quite,” Edgeworth assented, albeit in a low rumble, “well, Madame Razz, tell the court— uh, Bailey what you saw two days ago in the Whispering Wood.”

The woman rummaged through her thoughts, giving what could be considered a testimony; but a very scattered one at that. She recalled seeing two figures in the utter darkness talking with one another. They exchanged some words. Then one pulled out the gun.

“The other one, yes yes, jumping forward like a grasshopper! But pushed back, scratched on the left hand of the face with the other girl’s fearsome claws. Then… bang!”

Silence drenched the court the instance the woman stopped talking.

Adora tried to think through the testimony ,as she was desperately overdue on a contradiction. *Left hand* specifically stayed on her mind, but it was being swept away. It was hard to get the manner of the words out of her head, crowding out any thought about content.

“What was that?” she finally asked, not to Razz, but to Edgeworth.

He had his arms folded, and looked away with a rather stiffened lip. “I… admit I wouldn’t have presented such a witness were other options available to me. But I believe we can trust her memory—”

“Sure, so long as she gets it down to the right century!”

“Look, we can trust her memory because it’s consistent with the evidence. Namely, this picture that the witness happened to take.”

He produced the copy. As said, it was complete blackness that night, and had there not been the flash of gunfire, there would be no illumination for this picture to scan anything. But the flash was there, coming from the gun in the right figure’s hand. It pointed

towards the figure on the left. The two figures were about the same height. The similarity didn't stop there.

"I can admit this photograph into the record," said the Judge, "it's hard to make out but it does appear to be prosecutor Catra firing the weapon. And with everything else we know, this appears to be enough. It was her who murdered Double Trouble. But," he looked to Adora, "does the defence have any comment?"

Though her legs were still numb, crushed under the growing weight of this case, Adora was now fully stood up. Her hand was over her mouth, as she peered at the photograph.

"There is… one thing," she said. "Yeah, sure, it does kinda look like Catra on the right. But doesn't it also kinda look like Catra on the left?"

"How do you— oh," the Judge's eyes had tracked over and seen it. The same height, the same full mane of hair and the cape with the high collar, all just about illuminated by the flash of the gun.

"This is quite easily explained," said Edgeworth, unperturbed. "Double Trouble was a remarkable imitator. In the Chas Singer case it was shown they could do a perfect vocal impression. Well, our research showed that they were able to replicate appearance to quite a stunning degree also. Right down to the last follicle it seems."

"I… didn't know that," said Adora.

She was certain there was something big about that fact. Perhaps if she shelved it to the back of her mind she'll remember what was so important. For now she was too worried about this case.

"Logic tells us who is who," Edgeworth continued, "the one that fired the gun is the one hat lived to be arrested the following morning. The one that fell is the body we identified as the victim."

That seemed to cover the significance of the photograph. Adora tried cross-examining Razz's testimony itself, but there was little

yield. Even if Razz could have been twisted to say that she saw another person in the vicinity, it wouldn't matter. The gunpowder burns meant that the shooter must have been closer than five feet. And the trees of the wood were too thin for anyone to be hiding; they would have shown in the photograph.

"What about Razz herself?" Bow asked, leaning over to Adora, "she doesn't exactly have an alibi."

Adora shook her head, "I don't know. I was so eager to suspect anyone else but Catra. But I can't just throw accusations around without proof."

"That'd make you a bit like Catra," Bow remarked.

Adora shot him a strained look. Not him as well. In fairness, he regarded her with apology in his eyes. Glimmer meanwhile was silent throughout.

"Look," Bow said, "if you don't think it was her, then you've got this thing with Catra and Double Trouble; and they're the only two people together."

"And Edgeworth's logic is irrefutable," Adora moaned. She banged her head on the bench. "Urrgh! But I need a contradiction."

"Well, maybe it's there. Forget the logic. You've never let it stop you before!"

Adora looked up, staring ahead. She whispered, "I don't know if that's an insult or not but thanks. It'll have to do."

She took in a breath, and then let it out:

"OBJECTION!"

Bow stared. There was a glint of amazement in his eyes, but also a quiver of fear. Adora hadn't even look at the court record yet. He blinked, and wondered. Did she just screw it up?

“Defence?” questioned the Judge, “is there something wrong with the witness’ testimony?”

“Yes, your honour,” she said, “you ever notice how these witness’s sometimes throw out something really specific? Like earlier she said Catra scratched Double Trouble’s face on the *left* side. Like, personally, I wouldn’t throw out that kind of detail unless I was certain that’s how I saw it. But the thing is… Double Trouble’s left eye wasn’t scratched. It was her right.”

Edgeworth was shaking his head with a smile, “is this your big contradiction? It was dark that night, you can see in the photograph. This woman is certain we’re in Victorian England. How are we supposed to trust her memory on that level of detail?”

“But Barry, I remember it clearly,” Razz insisted. “The girl, she attacked with the hand facing me like this huh,” she demonstrated, turning her side to Edgeworth to make the motion. “That would hit the other’s left side of the face!”

“Perhaps you mixed them up?” suggested Adora.

“Mixed them up?” repeated Edgeworth, raising an eyebrow.

Adora pressed on, “if Catra were on the left side and attacked with the arm facing Razz, then she would have scratched Double Trouble’s right eye.”

“Very well then. The witness mixed the positions of the two in her memory. The defendant was on the left side and the victim on the right-— NGHOOOOO!”

Edgeworth had collapsed to the bench, suddenly bombarded with realisation.

Adora placed a hand on her hip and showered out a breezy smile.

“May I direct the court’s attention to the photograph the witness provided? Catra is on the left. But it’s the figure on the right firing

a gun!”

“This doesn’t make any sense,” Edgeworth said between clenched teeth, “it contradicts reality. Double Trouble was the one who died, not Catra.”

“Perhaps the victim fired the gun off to the side.”

“That raises new issues. Where was the second bullet? It would have shown up in our investigation?”

“Maybe it’s as a blank—

“Then how did the Double Trouble end up dead at all? No, there’s an even greater problem. It’s simply impossible for the victim to have been killed at any other time. We have another witness who can testify to that effect.”

“The gardener…,” Adora said. “But only Razz saw what happened.”

“While that may be true, the second witness was still able to *hear* the gunshot.”

“That would make her testimony invaluable,” said the Judge. “We shall call her. But first, let us has a short ten minute recess.”

He banged his gavel, and the court cleared away. Adora was still shaken and no less dizzy than before as she stumbled her way back to the lobby. Catra was there. Waiting. Things were silent, the four of them in the room. Bow sat down, and Glimmer came to him, and still without words, leant into his side, there to rest. Adora stood facing the cat, who stood facing away.

But before Adora could ask any of her thousand burning questions, detective Scorpia came in to join them.

“Hey, I’ve been watching,” she said, “I’ve never seen a trial so tight, but you’re just above water.”

“Thanks,” Adora was quiet.

“So uh, hey,” she rubbed her neck, “they’re gonna called up Perfuma next. I just wanted to warn you that you got to be careful in how you cross-examine her.”

“Why?”

“Well, she’s a lot more on edge than she lets on, and she’s actually been super worried about giving this testimony. Plus I’ve seen the way being on the stand can really set people off. Just… easy as you go when you question her, please?”

“Hm, I’m only on trial here,” Catra snarked, “just a life sentence on the line. Wouldn’t want to hurt anyone’s feelings.”

“No, we wouldn’t,” Scorpia whirled around, turning on Catra with a sudden angered look. Catra stepped back in recoil. “Her anxiety isn’t something to mock, sir! God, you can be such a…. Nrhg.”

With that, Scorpia stormed off. Adora hadn’t even had a chance to get a word in, and she left feeling guilty by proxy.

“What was that about?” she asked Catra.

“Just,” Catra’s insides were quite hollow as she said, “I… let people down.”

She seemed to shrink. Her cape fell about, wrapping her fully, as she rubbed her hands up against her elbows.

She stole a look at Adora, and said at last, “you’re… doing pretty good in there.”

“That all you have to say?” Adora’s voice was quiet, hushed and a little wrung.

“S-sorry?”

“Catra, why didn’t you say anything? Those files? What the hell was that about!”

“They didn’t come up in conversation, okay,” Catra said, now defensive, “and I forgot.”

“Forgot?”

“Yeah, a thing happened. I got arrested,” Catra jerked her head in her mocks, “and I’ve been bothered by an annoying blonde girl for the past 24 hours.”

“Catra, this is serious!” Adora shouted. “Why did you write that you were going to make the next crime!”

“I didn’t say that!” Catra’s voice broke, “I-I, look I was just venting okay! I was going to delete it. I got distracted when Double Trouble’s message came in.” She let out one long, heavy and fiery sigh. “I didn’t… I wasn’t going to,” every word caught in her throat. Even breathing was a difficulty. “Not like… I didn’t mean….”

A bailiff came to call them back into court. Whatever Catra was supposed to say never made it out. Rather stuck in her completely cold and caving chest.

They returned to their places. As promised, Perfuma was standing behind the bench, her hands interlocking and rested by her belly. For now, she smiled serene.

“Name and occupation?” Edgeworth requested.

“My name is Perfuma. I’m the gardener for the Whispering Woods National Park.”

“And you were at said park during late hours of the day two days ago. Tell us what you witnessed on your shift.”

“Of course. I saw Catra come up into the forest to begin within. That was around 1:00. Fifteen minutes later, I heard the gun firing.”

"1:15 is also the time at which Razz took her photo," noted Edgeworth.

"I was shocked when I heard the sound at first. I was worried it was hunters. Sometimes they come up to try and poach some of the woodland animals. But usually that hermit wards them off with her broomstick."

"That would be Madame Razz," said Adora.

"Right. So I thought something was up. I called the police at around 1:40 shortly after."

"HOLD IT!"

Adora pointed at the witness, prompting her to freeze. Then Perfuma went pale. Quickly now she muttered some sort of mantra under her breath, in a fraught attempt to stay her spiking nerves. Adora's finger faulted.

"Uh, wait, can I do that again? Um… *slow down* …."

"I'm, okay," Perfuma managed to say, although her voice frayed. "Just caught off guard!"

"Right. Explain— wait, how do you—no…." Adora looked up to the gallery where she caught Scorpia's eye. The big girl showed up her lower pincer, in what was possibly a thumbs up motion. Somewhat encouraged, Adora continued, gently paced, "isn't it weird that the gunshot was fired at 1:15 but it took you a while to make the call at 1:40? I was hoping you could clear that up."

"Oh, sure," Perfuma smiled, "it is a bit of a gap. But I don't carry a cell, so I had to go to the station platform to use the payphone. It's a ten minute walk."

"Hmm," thought Adora, "that's still a lag of about fifteen minutes. What happened?"

“Objection,” Edgeworth interjected, “I don’t see the relevance of this line of questioning. Sometimes people freeze. Perhaps it took her a while to realise what she needed to do.”

“Right, I suppose,” said Perfuma.

“What matters is what you witnessed of the crime.”

Perfuma nodded, and spoke it through, “yes, I saw her arrive. I heard the gunshot, and I saw her escaping. That’s what I witnessed.”

“Wait, wait, HOLD IT!” Adora slapped herself, “no, gently— look, witness, you just said something you didn’t before.”

“What do you mean?” Perfuma slunk back, smiling a nervous smile, “I told you the same thing I did yesterday.”

“You did, didn’t you,” Adora’s eyes widened as the recollection returned to her, “you said Catra left. But don’t you see the issue in that? That was 25 whole minutes, not to mention the time it takes to get up to the Woods from the City. Hell of a lot of time for a criminal to escape police clutches. Catra remained where she was the whole time and got caught at the scene!”

“That’s… true,” said Edgeworth. “That is peculiar.”

“Well, is it?” said Perfuma, “it took her fifteen minutes to get up to the crime scene and then back down again, right? I saw her going past, and that’s when I thought I should go call the police.”

“Yes, that would make sense,” said Adora with a smile, “if Catra ever left the scene of the crime. But the prosecution just admitted that she didn’t!”

Perfuma held her hands balled up by the side of her head, wailing, “noooo!”

“Witness,” said Edgeworth, slamming the desk, “you saw someone leaving, correct? But if it wasn’t Catra then whom?”

“It was Catra, I swear,” said Perfuma. “It was the coat she was wearing. I could tell it was her from that. The short jacket with the collar, that’s right.”

Though her eyes were twitching and her smile pained, Perfuma gave a confident nod, certain she’d given the conclusive answer. But both Edgeworth and Adora stared. So intent now that she cowered again.

“Wha… what now?”

“Catra… doesn’t have a jacket,” said Adora. “Look.”

All their eyes dragged over to the dock, where Catra sat, clearly in a cape.

“Well I…,” Perfuma squirmed, “I clearly mistook it because of the collar.”

“So you got a good look,” noted Edgeworth, “judging by your keen description. A short jacket with a collar. And you’re certain you couldn’t identify the person by anything else?”

“No, clearly I didn’t recognise them! I don’t think I’ve ever seen that jacket before either.”

Adora leaned forward. “That’s quite a claim, witness. Never?”

“Never.”

“What if I said there was proof that showed you must have seen that style of jacket before?”

“Well, there is none,” Perfuma said defiantly, though her voice shook. “Because I haven’t!”

“Do you really think you have such evidence?” the Judge asked, turning to the defence.

Adora gave a clear nod. Not for the record, instead she reached into her pocket. There she felt the folded card. She hadn't meant to keep it, but now she was glad she did.

"I do your honour," she said, before slamming the photograph onto the table. "TAKE THAT!"

It was the picture of Scorpia. The grainy quality notwithstanding, the significance was clear. She was wearing the exact shape of jacket Perfuma had described.

"Objection," said Edgeworth, "that is a fascinating resemblance, but it's hardly relevant."

"But mr. Edgeworth. That's the jacket! Surely it matters?" the Judge babbled with wide eyes.

The prosecutor folded his arms with an impatient glare, before explaining, "there are perhaps many such jackets in the world. There is no material way in which this photograph is tied to the case."

But Perfuma's nerves were not at all assuaged. Upon seeing Adora producing the photo, she had her hands over her mouth and did not say a word. Adora decided it would be up for her to elucidate the connection.

"Mr. Edgeworth you should let me explain myself before making a… well, a fool of yourself."

"A- a what?" Edgeworth spluttered.

"I wasn't presenting this evidence to show that such a jacket exists, but to show a contradiction in the witness's testimony. She said she had never seen such a jacket before in her life. But this photograph…" she thrust her finger, flying through the air such that it was if wind rushed passed, just as it came to point at a terrified Perfuma, "was given to me by the witness herself!"

“Noooooo!” Perfuma squealed, holding her hands against her head.

Shock flew through the court. Not just a flutter of whispers but agitated and loud voices, and it took the Judge quite a few bangs of his gavel to regain a sense of calm.

“Order,” he boomed, “I will have order! I can have the entire gallery thrown out if I must. Witness, have you lied to the court? Did you see detective Scorpia? Or did you think you had?”

“No,” Perfuma said, desperate now, “or well, I was unsure. I didn’t want to think it was the jacket because I couldn’t believe it.”

“Witness,” Edgeworth slammed his bench, “why didn’t you say any of this earlier? We could have easily cleared things up with a simple search.”

“I-I…,” Perfuma hung her head, “I just didn’t want anyone to suspect her. She’s soft and nice, and would never harm anyone. Please believe me, she would never kill!”

“Witness, please calm down,” Edgeworth, to the surprise of many, softened his tone. “As far as I’m concerned, no-one who has ever met the detective could possibly suspect of her of anything. But by hiding this detail you’ve made this process more difficult for us.”

“But… but,” Perfuma came to tilt her head, “you’re willing to believe your own subordinate committed a crime.”

“Subordinate… well,” Edgeworth shifted, “I’ve only been chief prosecutor —and only in an acting capacity— for a couple of days.”

“She’s still your colleague.”

“That may be true, but evidence is evidence,” Edgeworth said, trying to be decisive in his voice, although unable to disguise the

hint of discomfort. “But… well, I wasn’t entirely surprised, if that’s what you’re saying.”

“That’s kinda sad,” Perfuma said, in a soft note, “if you expect people to behave badly they so often do.”

Edgeworth was a little irked now, “well, that’s a fine and flowery sentiment, but I’ve been in this business long enough to know the worst sorts of criminals, those who are truly animals.”

Those words hung in the air for several moments longer then they should. Glimmer, though still saying nothing, gave a small inward nod. The witness remained melancholic. Adora’s attention however hovered over to the dock. She was expectant. What was Catra’s reaction to all of this? But Catra barely seemed there at all. Shoulders slunk, slumped in her seat, she was staring ahead in a vague way with mouth slack and eyes dim. Adora wished she could go over to her. But right now the best thing she could do was stand straight at her bench.

“Your honour,” she said, breaking the silence, “I know things look bad for us, but consider what we’ve discovered so far. Catra wasn’t the one holding the gun when it fired. Four people are accounted for —the defendant, victim and two witnesses. But someone was escaping from the vicinity of the crime. Someone we haven’t investigated yet. You can’t end this trial now.”

The Judge nodded, “on that we agree. I’m hardly able to believe it wasn’t the defendant, but until we’ve ironed out these anomalies, we will have suspend today’s trial. Is this acceptable, acting Chief Prosecutor?”

“Very,” said Edgeworth, although his arms were folded. He was still rather shaken from Perfuma’s penetrating question. “I’ll conduct a search and find this fifth person. Once it’s clear they have no bearing on the case, I expect we can conclude with a guilty verdict.”

Chapter End Notes

So I've finished writing! Everything is done except for a few gaps to fill and much polishing. Like damn was kinda left with that euphoric but slightly numb feeling when you finish a good game or series because it was good but also you've reached the end so there isn't going to be more of it. But we march ever onwards, and of course I get to come back to the last few chapters to review as I post them.

I uh apparently made a mistake, and I may need to edit two chapters back from this one because I forgot to have them get a certain bit of evidence. It's not breaking the story because they covered the fact it's attached to, but if you felt a little gaslit by that evidence coming somewhat out of nowhere... yeah sorry. Hopefully I can go back and edit that soon.

Super Pal Investigation

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“We’re not dead,” Adora kept saying as the four of them —her, Glimmer, Bow and Catra— came into the defence lobby. “We’re not… nrgh, we’re not dead!”

It was as if her body were fried. Her legs could give way any second. But damnit if her lungs weren’t lighter than air in this moment. Even now she couldn’t believe. Everything was against them from the beginning and they pulled through. Sure, they had gone from a 0 percent chance to a 1 percent chance, but that was an infinite scale improvement. Adora slammed the wall with her palm.

“We’re not dead!” she said again.

“We’ve got the long road ahead of us though,” Bow said, albeit through a heavy sigh of relief, “we need to find this third party immediately. We need to find that gang Scorpia was a part of. It’ll be one of them for sure. Glimmer, what do you think?”

But Glimmer had been completely mesmerised by her own thoughts. She jumped at the mention of her name.

“Oh? Right!” she said, forcing a smile. “Yeah, we should keep looking….”

With her hands clasped behind her back, she looked up at Bow with a strange innocence. He peered, uncertain.

“Is everything alright?”

“Absolutely!” she lied. “We just gotta go find that gang. Like you said. We’ll go do that. Yes.”

“Right…,” Bow said. His brow creased and he wondered if he should pry. He wouldn’t get the chance.

“Catra?” Adora had turned to face the other girl, standing small and aloof by the door. She went up to her, and took her hands into her own. “Hey we did good in there.”

“But…”

Catra was lost in a whirlpool of thoughts. Thoughts that were dimming as they circled around an abyss. She rubbed her thumbs against Adora’s hands, but in them she felt not what was presently there, but a memory. Cold, hard metal. The lever mechanism under her finger. The resistance as she pulled before the snap discharged. Click.

“If you never held the gun,” Adora was saying, “then how can they argue you killed anyone?”

“But if I didn’t shoot Double Trouble, then why do I remember….”

“What?” Adora frowned. “Catra, you look sick. Do you need help?”

“Help….”

“Catra?”

“Why… are you… why are you helping…. Adora—”

Fear crept into her throat now. “Catra?” she asked again.

But Catra had begun to cower. It was too late. She ripped her hands out of Adora’s, cringing with a shout:

“Get away from me!”

Adora took a few paces back, raising her hands in defence. But Catra was just stood, horrified as she stared at her own hands. Then she looked up.

“You should just quit,” she said. “Yeah… I killed Double Trouble. That’s the only explanation that makes sense! Why are you the only one dumb enough to not see that!”

She ran. Before Adora could register an objection, Catra was gone.

“I have to go,” said Glimmer. Her voice was stiff, and she only looked ahead.

“Glimmer?” said Bow.

Glimmer didn’t say anything. She just walked off, exiting the room so that only Bow and Adora remained.

Bow let out a great sigh, “well at least we can—”

“I’m going after Catra.”

The boy looked over with concern. “Adora we have to investigate.”

“I need to get to the bottom of this,” her voice welled with a pained creaking. “I’ve been waiting for nine years. I may not get another chance….”

Bow shook his head, “you saw how she ran off. She’s not going to want to talk for a while.”

“I’ll wait in the visitor’s room all day if I have to,” Adora said, already heading forward.

“B-but,” Bow protested, but there was nothing doing. Adora was gone. He was alone. “What about the investigation….”

Uncertain what to do, Bow just waited there in the lobby for some time. Yet neither Glimmer nor Adora came back. Soon he had waited so long that the defence team for the next case were moving in and a bailiff had to usher him out. By the time he left the court building —meeting a slight brisk in the wind as the late

year elements were growing rowdy— he flipped open his phone and started pressing away.

The first call failed. As did the next. He phoned again and again, eighteen or nineteen times, all without a response.

“Trying to reach someone?” came a passing voice.

“Yeah, my girlfriend.”

“Oh I’ve been there. Sorry about that. But there’s always more fish in the sea.”

“Hey, it’s not like that!” Bow protested, looking up.

He was quite surprised to see it wasn’t a stranger but a familiar face. With his shiny moustache and adventurous garb, Sea Hawk was beaming at him.

“Oh, hey,” Bow said. “What are you doing here?”

“Well, I was looking for you actually. Heard what was happening and thought to check it out. Seems I’ve missed things?”

Bow turned away, staring ahead at the courthouse doors. “Not much. The trial’s only continuing because we’ve opened more questions than we’ve answered.”

“And where’d everyone else get to?”

“Wish I knew,” Bow said, glancing back at his phone, once again making no connection.

“You don’t mean they didn’t show up?”

“No, they just ran off. I’m sure it’s fine. I’ll just have to….”

But as Bow returned to the futile task of making the phone call, Sea Hawk walked around to face him. He lay a firm hand on Bow’s shoulder. He was a solemn look:

“This is bothering you, isn’t it? What’s going on?”

Bow sighed, but he didn’t have anything better to do. After filling Sea Hawk in for the major details, he said:

“I can’t help but think about what Glimmer’s going through. Imagine how turbulent this whole thing is for her.” At that he lowered his head. “I always thought… well, if what happened from nine years ever came back, I’d be there for her, fighting her corner. But Adora had this need with Catra. She can’t accept that Catra might be guilty, and I don’t want to take that from her either. I don’t know how to explain it, but it feels like we’re being torn apart.”

Sea Hawk reached out his hand, and, laying a finger under Bow’s chin, lifted up the other boy’s head.

“You’ll find the middle, Bow,” he said. “It’s a hard thing, being the mediator among friends, but it’s a role you play admirably.

Albeit weak, it drew a smile from Bow.

“Yeah, but I can’t do it when I can’t even find them.” He gave another sigh, “it’s like everything’s slipping from my grasp. Not just that, but the trial. There’s this new angle of discovery and yet we can’t investigate.” He gave a jerk of his head and corrected, “well, we weren’t technically allowed to before, but with a lawyer you can always bluster in. I’m just a forensic investigator… and unless I’m suddenly called up to do a fingerprint analysis, I can’t do anything.”

“Pah, rules,” Sea Hawk said, throwing away a hand gesture. “Never put much stock in them, myself. I recall there was a storm on the Mexican gulf a while back. Now that was a day — started like this, you feel that nip in the air? It starts small, and becomes a gale. So terrible that you can barely dare to broach the seas. There were some sailors who had been caught off guard, but the official rescue parties were stalling. So I went in alone. Navigating

the turgid waters on that grim night to rescue those wayward lives —now that was an adventure!”

“That’s also probably illegal….”

“But that’s the point, I say. Ah, I even wrote a good shanty for it. Let me see. Ooooh—”

“Maybe that is it,” Bow said, his gasp of realisation quite inadvertently cutting Sea Hawk off. “Adora and Glimmer know what they’re doing, I’m sure; but someone has to follow-up the new facts. I can still be a good friend by pulling the slack!” He raised his fist with a new confidence, although it quickly faltered as he said, “ huh, feels like every group project I was ever in….”

Though mourning for his lost chance at a performance, Sea Hawk recovered enough to grin, “well that’s more the spirit! But where to start?”

“I’ve got an idea, and she shouldn’t be too far. We can begin this investigation without Adora or Glimmer. Come on!” Bow began to waltz off. Then he turned around, producing his phone again. “Let me try calling juuust one more time—”

Sea Hawk quickly snatched the phone, and this was enough to set Bow’s mind back on track. They went back into the courtroom and it wasn’t long before they found detective Scorpia. Twisting between her pincers, she held her hat, whilst wearing a fretful expression. She was checking over the witness Perfuma to see she was alright.

“I *am* alright,” Perfuma insisted, smiling up at her.

“You basically committed perjury,” said Scorpia, “you could still get in a lot of trouble!”

She shrugged. “Well they’ve discharged me for now. And I’m just happy the whole ordeal’s over. Oh, hello?”

She had noticed Bow and Sea Hawk's arrival, and Scorpia quickly turned to see them too. She greeted them with a half-smile, though strained in her brow —the proceedings had left her more on edge than they had Perfuma.

"Where'd the others get to?" the detective asked.

"No idea with Glimmer. Catra's convinced herself she did kill Double Trouble and Adora's ran off after her."

"Damn, how can she think that?"

"Well she was only one who really saw things up close…."

Scorpia's gaze fell and she retreated into a few moments silence. Then she gave a violent shake of her head.

"I'm letting down everyone today."

"No, it's not like that," Perfuma said.

"If it weren't for you trying to protect me, though…."

"Look, I'm sure it'll turn out well."

"Scorpia," Bow ventured to ask, "that wasn't you Perfuma saw, correct?"

"No!" Scorpia said. "I don't even think I still have that jacket. Got rid of it ages ago."

"That's a shame," said Perfuma. "I thought you looked good in it."

After a few rapid blinks, a wordless stammer, Scorpia went to scratch her cheek. She muttered, "well, when I said 'got rid of' maybe I still have it. I could give it a check…."

"The point is," said Bow, moving along, "if it wasn't Scorpia, then someone else must have been at the forest. We gotta find that person if we ever have hope of turning this trial around. Perfuma, are you sure you can't give any more detail?"

Perfuma shook her head, "it was dark and I mostly just remember the jacket. Although maybe I saw more of them… I'd have to jog my memory."

"The gang is almost always at the Crimson Wastes," said Scorpia. "That's the best place we should go."

"Ah, the dry part of town," Sea Hawk said, shifting the weight on his feet, "not so good for a seaman, but I never back down from a challenge. This shall be quite the adventure."

"Aw man, this is kinda exciting," said Scorpia, looking up with a new buzz. Suddenly, stretching out her broad arms, she brought the other three into a big and rather crushing hug. "Now this is an investigation team! We'll be the super-pal investigators. Or we could workshop the name."

"Let's do it on the way there," Bow managed to breathe. "We need to cover as much ground as possible before the day's end."

Hitting the streets by way of Scorpia's work vehicle, they embarked on the long road towards the Crimson Wastes bar. She drove the path familiar to her. Past the beige and dilapidated houses of this corner of the city, until she drove right up to the destination. Inside of course it was dark and gruesome as ever, though the day-time light from outside bounced in through a cool sideways stream. It was also a warm respite to the increasing cold of the outdoors.

"Those are the jackets," Perfuma nodded towards the figures all huddled in the corners of the bar. They were all especially wary of the detective's entrance now. Some still had the bruises.

"Anyone look familiar?" asked Bow.

"Somehow I don't think it's any of these," noted Scorpia. "They're actually a bit of a spineless bunch. It would have to be someone willing to go far from territory on their own, and have the guts to make a kill without backup."

“Assuming this gangster even is our killer,” added Sea Hawk.

“We shouldn’t leave without something,” said Bow with a furrow of his brow.

“Anyone want drinks?” asked Scorpia. “If we’re going to haul up here.”

“How about a good grog?” suggested Sea Hawk, “something from good Seguenay apples?”

“Well they actually do have a good cider here,” Scorpia said with a beam. “And Catra thought I was weird for it!”

“Guys wait,” said Bow in a vague voice.

“Well I knew I was right to not have a high opinion of her,” said Sea Hawk.

“Didn’t she whip you in your trial?”

“Ah yeah… perhaps that does bias me a little.”

“Guys, shshshsh.”

Everyone looked to Bow. Holding, both index fingers up, he bade silence. He strained his ears. There was a rumbling sound, growing from the far distance but rapidly shooting up as it made it’s steady and speedy approach. As it grew clear, each spitting and snapping hiss growing distinct from the gravelly chugging sound underneath, it dawned on everyone that it was the arrival and sharp scraping stop of a motorcycle.

The doors swung wide. In came a big figure. He marched his way to the bar and signalled for his bitter. Dressed in leathers, and the distinct jacket with the collar that they now knew so well, the man was a beefy fellow, with a mop of brown hair; and eyes hidden behind a pair of shades.

“That’s him.” Perfuma brought her balled hands up to her face where they quivered. “That’s the man I saw.”

“I don’t recognise him,” Scorpia frowned. “He must have joined after I left.”

“So,” Sea Hawk leaned to Bow, “how do you want to approach this? How do you, Adora and Glimmer usually take this part of the investigation?”

“Well, we’ve got to question him,” Bow laid out, “I go for a softer touch. Adora’s the aggressive one. And Glimmer… is also the aggressive one.”

“Catra’s also pretty aggressive,” said Scorpia, “although you already knew that.”

“Ah, well in that case,” Sea Hawk started to withdraw his rapier.

“Wait,” Bow was quick to place a restraining hand on the man’s wrist, “we don’t need to go to Catra’s level of interrogation. Here’s what we’ll do. Scorpia and I will lead the questioning. Perfuma you go to the left, we’ll call on you if we need your testimony. Sea Hawk, go to the right and block his exit path… just in case.”

The plan agreed, they took their positions. Scorpia and Bow lined up behind the man, and with a brief moment in which to take a preparing breath, they tapped him on the shoulder. Slowly he turned about, facing them with a tense scowl. Yet he remained rather aloof as they saw only their reflections in the darkened glasses. As he came to regard them, he leant back on the bar: one hand on the countertop, the other holding his drink.

“What are you? Cops? What you want?” He had a surprisingly high voice, and one that carried with a musicality, even in speech.

“I’m detective Scorpia, this is investigator Bow. What’s your name?”

“Heh, well it was about time you came looking for the great greaser. I’m Soter Michael. This gang is nothing without me. What’s an army without cavalry? That’s me. Did you see my ride?”

“No, we were inside,” said Bow. “You’re a biker?”

“That’s right. What’s it to ya?”

“It’s just interesting. Cars find it difficult to travel except on the roads, but a bike can go on dirt tracks if not more. You’d have quick and easy access to… certain places.”

“You driving at something, dude?”

Scorpia gestured to Perfuma, saying “this woman says she saw you two nights ago. At the Whispering Woods. Can you confirm this?”

“The what?” the man called Soter Michael twisted his face. But then he took a sip of his beer, “man, you’re some freaks.”

“Is that a denial?”

“You trying to do me for something?”

“Well, you were near to a scene of a murder,” Scorpia explained, “in fact, the timing lines up. You could have gone up, shot the victim, then came back down as the witness saw you. Do you deny that?”

“Yeah. I don’t know any of this bull.”

“Do you have an alibi?” Bow asked. “And if we were to, say, randomly ask any of the people in this room to corroborate, do you think they’d say the same?”

“Doesn’t matter, I wasn’t here. I was cruising along under the night’s sky.”

“But you can’t claim you didn’t divert from your route to go up the Whispering Woods, at least not without us being sceptical.”

The man gave a laugh, “I don’t care what you believe. You got nothing on me. Who was it I’m supposed to have killed anyway?”

“A performer called Double Trouble,” said Scorpia. “I suppose you claim to have never met them either.”

“You read my mind. Wow, what’s even the point of this questioning if you know my answers!”

“We’re nowhere fast,” Bow said in a mutter. “Perfuma, can you tell us how you recognise him.”

Perfuma nodded, although shortly balked when the man threw his black-glazed glare onto her.

“I, ugh… h-hi? Well I saw a person wearing that jacket, like I said.”

“We all wear these,” Michael flipped the ends of his own, “it’s the mark of entry.”

“Y-yeah, I know. But more than that, it couldn’t be anyone else here. The person had your hair.”

He let out another laugh. “Man, you can’t pin me on that! That could be anyone here?”

“Yeah?” said Scorpia with a raised eyebrow. “Wanna scan the room, mister?”

Though shaded, he blinked at her for a seconds. Then Soter Michael quickly stole a glance at his comrades skulking away in the dark corners. Reptilians, all of them. Not a single hair on their heads.

“Oh….”

“Yeah,” with a wry smile Scorpia folded her arms, “so it was you at the Whispering Woods. Wanna explain what you were doing?”

“N-nothing,” he said, masking his face with a chug of his drink.

Bow took a step forward, and while he barely drew up to the man’s height —and as consequence had to crane his neck to maintain eye contact — it upped the pressure.

“You were there, you can’t deny. You don’t have an alibi, so you might want to tell us what you were doing that night. Did you meet Double Trouble? Did you meet Catra?”

“I don’t have to—”

“I’m betting you were acting on your own. Since you didn’t bring any backup with you, this was out of the gang’s activities. So… personal project? You have anything you wanted to do up there?”

“I don’t do nothing!” the man barked, standing up rather straight and stiff. Though he began to lean back against the bar, a desperate attempt to put space between him and the investigator. “I’m not complicated. I’ve got one creed: Beer, Sex and Rock’n’Roll! You got something similar?”

“Uh… well,” Bow knit his brow. “I guess I’m into Forensics, Friedship and… I don’t really have a third thing.”

“It was a musical genre,” noted Scorpia, “don’t have a favourite, Bow? I guess I’d have to say jazz considering how much I sing.”

“Well on that note do I even need to say mine?” said Sea Hawk.

“I suppose you’re into some sort of meditation mood music, Perfuma?”

“Nope,” said Perfuma with a blank smile, “I like the Gavinners.”

“Huh.”

“Those posers?” Soter Michael cut in with a scoff, “I knew there was something wrong about you. What’s the point of Rock if there’s no Roll?”

“You sure you don’t have anything, Bow?” asked Sea Hawk.

“Well, I guess if I were pressed, I’d have to— wait a minute,” Bow shook his head, “why the hell are we getting off track? Scorpia!”

The big girl blushed and mumbled, “oh right, sorry.”

“Right,” Bow let out a groan, “this isn’t working. Should we try aggressive?”

“Yeah,” she blankly nodded. “Let’s try aggressive.”

At that, with lunging force, Scorpia pinned the man to the bar with her pincers. Bearing down a glare, she growled:

“Tell us why you were there! You’re the reason Perfuma got confused, so tell me why I shouldn’t pulverise you for—”

“Okay, okay,” he croaked and flapped his hands, “I’ll talk!”

Relinquished from Scorpia’s vicegrip, the man stumbled to his feet and nursed his neck. Then he began to stammer, muttering words so low none could hear. He looked the ground and fidgeted with his sunglasses.

“Yeah… I was there and uh,” his volume reached to a point that with a little straining of the ear one could pick it up, “I went up into the forest. Didn’t meet no-one. Didn’t even know anything was going on.”

“What were you doing then?” asked Bow. “Why go to forest on your own that late?”

“I was…,” he looked up, though with eyes screwed shut and a strain in his face. He mustered the strength to confess, “I was picking flowers.”

With a confused chuckle, Scorpia said, “wh-what?”

“Really?” Perfuma wore a look of pleasant surprise. “That’s sweet!”

“S-shut it, sister!”

Bow stared at him. He was perturbed and showed it in the tension along his face. Inside his heart was slowly going down.

“That’s what you were hiding?” he said. “Really?”

“It seems that’s all we could drag out of him,” Scorpia added with a sigh. “Perhaps we should move on?”

Yet Bow kept a fixed gaze on the man. His face, though wrought with anger and embarrassment, remained inscrutable. If there was something hiding beyond, it was well-concealed in this persona.

“Fine,” Bow said in a defeated hush, “but I’m not done with you. Perfuma, you stay behind and make sure he doesn’t leave. We’ll be back with more questions.”

“M-me?” Perfuma’s smile grew unsteady. “Okay, I’ll just wait here. Among the super violent gangsters. I’m sure nothing can go wrong!”

So Bow, Scorpia and Sea Hawk ventured on, taking the vehicle back into the heart of the city. The roads were thinning out —as much as they could in a major metropolitan city— as the day was a quiet one and the afternoon was progressing. Despite the long road, the journey did not feel long. They were soon stopped in the underground parking lot of the Prosecutor’s office.

Scorpia led the way, far more familiar to the place than the others. They went down however. Not heading to the offices, but to the below-ground levels that were used for important storage. There they came upon a cold room of concrete, facing a metallic door.

Off to the side a balding man with a toothbrush moustache flipped through papers in his booth.

With a little slick and wile, Scorpia was able to convince the man —who held a sceptical expression throughout— that he ought hand over a form. All the while, Bow's eye was drawn over the door. It was broad, and appeared iron-tight shut. Pondering thoughts trawled past him, and he couldn't stop himself asking:

"Is this the vault?"

"Yeah," said Scorpia, carefully slipping her form into her jacket.

"Think there might be something in there that could be useful?"

"Sorry, mate," grumbled the man at the booth, "you ain't getting in there. It's for top personnel only, and I already had a person cajole me into opening it against protocol today. I'm not doing it again."

But they didn't think much more on that. Having got Scorpia's form, they took back to the car. By the long road, thirty minutes at a good pace, they drove all the way to the Police Department. Bow was more at home here, and led them right up to the forensics lab. Before it's entrance, however, was a receptionist in a booth quite similar to the one at the vault. In fact, the man here was also balding. And he also had a toothbrush moustache.

"Hey," Bow tilted his head, "didn't we just see you?"

"Eh?"

"I don't suppose you have a twin brother? The man at the prosecutor's office looks just like you."

"Not that I ever heard of," the man scowled. "And unless you're saying I have a clone?"

"I…," lowering his brow and bringing his lips to a purse, Bow just said, "you know what. Nevermind. Not digging that up again."

Scorpia handed over her piece of paper, explaining, “we need to see the evidence under examination for the Whispering Woods murder? We want to examine the body ourselves.”

The man just shook his head.

“That’s gone.”

“What do you mean gone?”

“Well it ain’t here anymore.”

“Yeah, that’s what gone means, we got that,” Bow frowned. “Where’s it gone to?”

“The Vault.”

“The… the vault? But we were just there!”

“Well,” the man picked ups his papers and, with a bored air, went back to reading, “you best be getting back.”

So the three went back to the car. Bow sunk his teeth into his glove as he sat upfront, anxious as he watched the world move forward. As far he could recall, there wasn’t much precedent for this. The case wasn’t over, so why would evidence —no not just evidence, but the victim’s body itself— be transferred over to the prosecutor’s office? The boy grew increasingly restless as they travelled further.

“You know,” said Sea Hawk, leaning over to Scorpia, “this is a police vehicle and we’re on a tight schedule.”

“Well, I don’t wanna be reckless….”

“This is the time to be reckless!” Sea Hawk gave a hearty thump to her back, “you need to swerve like your surfing the waves here. You could cut this down a 15 minutes drive, and it wouldn’t matter so much that we’re going back and forth.”

“I don’t know if that’s such a good—” but Bow was cut off before he could register his caution. For Scorpia said:

“You know what, you’re right. Hold on to your seats!”

And so, with a few close calls, many screeches and skids along the tarmac, —and Bow’s heart flying all over the place— they reached the Prosecutor’s office in snappy time. They rushed back to the vault entrance with a collective huff. But Bow quickly pushed himself up. He managed to say:

“We need to see the body of Double Trouble. We were told it’s in the vault.”

“I told you, mate, I’m not letting anyone in,” the man said.

“But your counterpart at the forensics lab said—”

“Well I don’t know anything about a counterpart,” he grumbled. “But if you came from the Police Department, then maybe if you gave me a authorisation form, I could let you in.”

“But,” Scorpia’s face fell between her gasps for breath, “you gave us the authorisation form.”

“The authorisation form for the forensic lab, but you have to get an authorisation from them to see the evidence in the vault. I’m sorry, it’s the rules.”

“You’re tell us,” she panted, “we have to make another round trip!”

“You’d best get going,” the man shrugged. “I’m closing up in an hour.”

Dreading what was coming next, Bow returned to the car and strapped himself tight. His fears were realised. The journey there was grim (the man at the booth greeted them with a leer and asked, “didya forget the authorisation form then?”) and by the

time they'd come back both ways, Bow fell out of the vehicle on the verge of being sick.

"Please," he said in a whimper, "no more reckless driving."

Scorpia lifted him up and they clambered all the way down to the vault for the third time that afternoon. Bow still had to collapse against the wall and take in several deep breaths to purge himself of the nausea. As he did, he looked around. Then he froze.

"Where's Sea Hawk?" he asked in a small voice.

"Oh, he was just——" Scorpia's gesture faltered as she realised the concrete room was empty behind them.

"Did we forget him?'

"I swear he was in the car with us!"

"Ugh," Bow wiped his face with his hand. "Okay, one problem at a time. Give the man his form."

"Right," Scorpia reached into her coat, "I'll just—"

There was a shredding sound. Scorpia blinked, before turning to Bow. He stared back at her. She stared back at him, before finally withdrawing her gripped pincers. A ripped side of paper there in her clutch.

Bow continued to stare, albeit with a rather twisted smile and wide, twitching eyes. Scorpia gave a nervous laugh, before madly taking the ripped half and mushing them together as if that would do it. If anything it cut them up worse.

"So," Bow said, "this is what it feels like to be prosecutor Catra."

"I-I'm sorry," Scorpia said in a whine.

"No, no, I am," he sighed, "I shouldn't have said that."

“Are you two having a problem,” the man in the booth leant over to view them, though Scorpia and Bow stifled him with a simultaneous:

“Not now!”

And, because this wasn’t enough, Scorpia’s phone went off with a raucous buzz at that very second. She promptly dropped all the pieces of paper. This left Bow falling to the ground as he tried to gather them up. Scorpia took the call:

“Yeah?”

“Scorpia?” it was Perfuma on the other end. “Oh god, I’m so sorry!”

“What? What is it? Are you in trouble?”

“He’s getting away! Soter Michael!”

The detective clasped her claw to the side of her face. She threw an anxious look around until she found Bow, just then getting up. “You can’t let him get away. He might be our only lead!”

“He’s riding away, but I’m following.”

“Wait, how are you keeping up if he’s on his motorcycle?”

“I don’t even know, I’m just not questioning things at this point!”

Scorpia told her to keep it up and that she’d be coming. She then closed her phone and looked to Bow, gave him an awkward and apologetic smile, before speeding off. Once again, he was alone.

Hurtling to her car, hitting the pedal, and driving far more reckless than before, Scorpia shot down the main road. The sun was lowering along the horizon, and scraped along the beach and highway with a golden gleam. From what Perfuma told her in the call, she knew they weren’t far. Then she saw it. The long, chain-burdened and exhaust-pumping bike, parked astride the

uncharacteristically empty road. With a shudder and a shriek, the police vehicle came to a drifting halt. Scorpia jumped out.

“Hands up!” she shouted. “Where are you….”

Her commanding tone slipped as she saw an odd sight. Perfuma was there, a little spent from running. Yet she was not at all disturbed and was talking pleasantly with the man in front of her. Soter Michael.

“…are the ones I like the most. They have a supreme smell, you know?”

“You should keep those seeds safe for while,” Perfuma explained, “a plant after the new year. They’ll bloom by spring.” Then she noticed Scorpia, “ah, hey!”

The gangster whipped around, and yelped. Scorpia pummelled her pincers together.

“Right, what ever happened to staying where you were?”

“You can’t boss me! I’m outta here—”

Scorpia made a grab for him. He ducked, and tumbled his way forward. Past her, he hurried to his bike. He was nearly free. Only someone was already waiting there, lazing against the seat, and brushing a finger along the polished metal bar between the handles.

“Now this vehicle,” Sea Hawk said, “is quite a remarkable thing. But I think it’d get swept by the waves of the glorious main. Now have you!”

The flashy grin on his face was premature. As deft as his hand was to his hilt, Soter Michael beat Sea Hawk within the grip of the moment —he lunged. Catching the other man’s wrist before it could take out the rapier, Michael wrestled with him. They strained against one another, Fists were exchanged. But finally —and with

an undignified yell— Sea Hawk was tossed several metres and landed hard on the highway.

With the sputter of the exhaust, the bike rumbled on. Their suspect had fled.

“No…,” Scorpia watched as the last fumes disappear at the end of view. “Man, what are we doing?”

“I’m okay,” Sea Hawk managed a groan, though remaining rooted on his back.

“It’s my fault,” said Perfuma. “I got distracted.”

“Nah, you kept up with him,” said Scorpia, “he only gave us the slip. I’m the one who can’t do anything right. And all this is just for Catra anyway….”

“Is that so bad?”

Scorpia let out a sigh. She went to lean on the guard rail overlooking the beach and water, and Perfuma came up to be by her side. The sun was beautiful where it hung, even though the choppy waters refused to bask in its light.

“We’re not even friends,” Scorpia said, “she said as much. Have I really been so blind about her? Everything Adora and the others said about her was the truth…. Perhaps I was the one who misunderstood?”

“From what you’ve told me,” Perfuma knitted her brow, “you always enjoyed working with her.”

“Yeah, but looking back she was always quick to punish failure and assign blame. Even when we went out for a drink she was… kinda difficult about things. And clearly she didn’t enjoy working with me.”

“You don’t know that, do you?”

“Maybe not.” Scorpia fell silent for a few moments, just watching wave beat against wave in the sea beyond. Then she sighed again, “still, she hasn’t been very good. Was I a fool for trying to be a friend? Like being nice to her and she just throws that back in my face? What am I even doing here?”

“Well, do you think she murdered someone?” Perfuma asked, looking to her with genuine curiosity. She had no answers more than Scorpia could give herself.

“No, I don’t think that.”

“And do you think being nice to her in general was the wrong thing?’

“A bit. Doesn’t feel deserved on her end. But maybe that’s not the point? I can’t imagine me doing anything different. I should have just been more willing to call her out. But yeah,” Scorpia gave a deciding nod, “she didn’t kill anyone, and jerk or not, she needs my help.”

“Not that we seem to be giving her much.”

A third voice spoke: “Why’d you think that?”

They turned. Sea Hawk has just gotten. He was nursing his head, and softening his limbs, and —perhaps it was better to say he was in agony all over after that fall. But he smiled nonetheless.

“Well, we lost Soter Michael,” Scorpia noted, “and we haven’t even found any evidence.”

“I wouldn’t be so sure.”

As all this happened —Scorpia’s rush over and Sea Hawk’s ill-fated duel both— Bow continued, by himself, trying to get access to the vault. Nothing had ever been as futile in his life.

“Look,” he pleaded with the man in the booth, “it’s clearly a document from the police department!” He gestured to the pieces

of shredded paper laid out, “you put them together, you can still see what it says!”

“I told you,” the man explained, exasperation in the face, and sharply flicking his head as he did so, “I need an authorisation document, not documents! And I’m already going to get a real headache when they find out I had to stretch protocol to let the last person inside today. I’m not getting fired because you can’t follow clear instructions.”

“I’m not the one who—” Bow stayed himself by planting his palm on his forehead. “Come on, there’s got to be a way to verify this is the document.”

“Unless it’s intact, I’ve got to question it’s veracity. How am I supposed to know you didn’t pick this out of a shredder or the trash?”

“Because you literally just saw the detective rip it up in front of you!”

Bow couldn’t remember a time when his voice cracked on every word, so this was an experience. He wrenched his eyes shut and dragged his fingers down the side of his face, ploughing for an idea, just some solution to help him get through this.

“Ah!” he said, “what about this?”

Digging through his pockets, he pulled out a small bottle. He then sprayed it over the paper, dusting it with a white aluminium powder. Then with a quick blow, he cast the excess off.

“There, fingerprints. Belonging to the man at the department. Ugh,” he suddenly groaned, “but it’s not like you can recognise them so what’s even the point.”

But the man looked down. Then he stopped. His eyes were bulging as they landed on the swirls along the paper, and the lip under his moustache trembled. He tossed his gaze up, although looked down a couple more times. Finally he finally stammered:

“This… this is almost exactly like my fingerprints? But if that—then that must mean….”

“Mean what?” Bow was confused.

“My long lost twin brother.”

“Oh.” He blinked. “Well, in that case, great! So clearly that means—”

The man jumped up. He swung his coat on and was flinging out of the booth. “I gotta go find him.”

“Wait, but what about the vault?” said Bow. “My investigation?”

“Nuts to that, I’ve gotta find my brother!”

And with that —as Bow watched, reaching out a limp hand, powerless to stop him— the man ran out. The last steps echoing by the concrete walls disappeared in the distance. As they did, Bow stood there, this time really alone. He gave one last, forlorn, longing look at the vault entrance. Just beyond, he could imagine what it was like. The endless repository of evidence. Among it, just one body —just one look was all they needed.

It was metal. Iron-tight. It was not going to open. Expelling all breath in defeat, Bow looked away. Finally, he left too.

Bow was gone. The room was empty. No sound touched the space within for a few more seconds. That was before a great churning filled it. The vault door rumbled, with the metal sides pushing apart, and out came a girl. A number of folders under arm, Glimmer came into the empty room.

“Thanks, mister, that’ll be enough for—”

She stopped. The man at the booth was gone. In all fairness, she had been in there for a while. So she shrugged, and went on.

Outside, Bow was ambling, down the long way from the Prosecutor's office. Though he moved without purpose or direction, he came across Scorpia, Sea Hawk and Perfuma on the roadside. He frowned as he realised what was missing.

"You lost him?" he said, his lungs becoming more crushed than before.

"Yeah, sorry," said Scorpia. "But hey, I don't think we'd have gotten more out of him."

"Not without evidence," Bow sighed. "I didn't get into the vault in the end. This whole thing has been a waste of time."

He came by and leant on the guard rail, burying his head in his hands. The world was swirling around him, although that might have just been the increasingly frisky wind.

"How could I have let them down?" he muttered. "I can find minute details by bare traces of fibres, yet I can't even find one measly bit of evidence to bring to the trial tomorrow. We were already doomed and now we have less than nothing."

"Why Bow, you have so little faith," said Sea Hawk. He came up to him and gave him pat on the back. "And if you and the team are ever going to win, you'll need that in abundance. Come on, take heart!"

"We can't win a case on faith—" But Bow's protests died in his mouth. He had turned to face the other man. In Sea Hawk's hand was a mass of cold black steel. "What… what is that?"

"Well if I had to take a guess," Sea Hawk flipped it around by his finger, "it looks like a gun."

Bow blinked. "Where'd you get that?"

"From Soter Michael. He threw me away from his bike before he ran off. Little did he know, I have a deft finger."

“You… got that from the witness?”

“Ours wasn’t a gun-carrying gang,” Scorpia noted. “And there’s something more. Show him, mr. Sea Hawk.”

Sea Hawk obliged. He threw his hand up in the air, gun directed straight, and fired. The bang was enough to send a clench ripping throughout Bow’s whole body. Yet as smoke wisps flew from the barrel, he realised something, a very particular something about this gun. Something that could change everything.

Eyes widening, he turned to Scorpia, looking to confirm, “a blank?”

“That’s right, I checked it myself,” the woman drew up a little proud, “and a damn good likeness to the one we saw in the trial.”

“We know it isn’t much,” said Perfuma, “but do you think this could help?”

Bow took the object into his hand. The weight was pleasant as it weighted down, and the stiff metal resisted when he curled his fingers around it. Weight and resistance, it was real, and in his hands. Evidence, just a single article, but more than nothing.

“Yeah,” he said, looking up with a smile. “I mean, god, I do not feel at all good about tomorrow. But if I can just find Glimmer and Adora, we can make this work!”

The other three were all smiles as they gathered around him. But they shortly decided to return to the vehicle and head off. The winds were foul now. The sunset glare was replaced by a cold grey shadowy-ness before the dark, and the ocean waves raged in some sort of torment. Something was coming in the weather, that would be most unforgiving. And all the while, Adora stayed on Bow’s mind.

She must have found Catra a while ago, so why hadn’t she shown up since? What had gone down between them all this time?

Chapter End Notes

I'm a little uneasy about this chapter. It's a light-hearted break (and much needed I feel becuase wow things are gonna get heavier from here on out.) It was written during a rough time and trying to explicitly do humour is not my forte. But there's a few fun moments I really like and I can say with confidence that everything from next chapter to the end is golden.

Reminiscence

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

When Adora stormed into the visitor's room with such force that the door slammed against the opposing wall, Catra was there, waiting behind the glass. She was in a calmer state now. Cape thrown back, and leaning into her chair, her eyes followed Adora's approach with a smug gaze.

Of course. It was the end of their rope, but Catra always had to play things cool.

"You know," she said, in a sly purr, "when it's not my case to worry about, it's actually pretty entertaining to see you in action."

"Really?" Adora said as she sat down. She bit back on her more biting comments. For now.

"You're a force of nature. Can't believe I ever agonised about trying to beat you. Bit like trying to fight a thunderstorm."

"You've done this before you know," said Adora, "pretend to not really care so you don't look vulnerable. Catra, it's just the two of us. No-one is going to judge you here."

Catra did not let up the facade. "What are you now, a therapist? Who made you talk like that? The forensic boy or sparkles?" She tittered, "Nah it won't be her, she's too emotional. Maybe it's your mentor Angella? She's nothing but problems; maybe first hand experience gives you insight."

"Catra, trying to get a rise out of me won't work. I'm not leaving."

"Yeah that's the part I don't get," Catra looked away with a terse pout.

Adora sighed. No point avoiding it now. She began, "when we first met in court, you told me I was easily distracted… confused. You told me I'd worry about having the weight of a client's fate in my hands, and that I'd blame myself if I lost. Well… it's all true now."

"Yeah, you're easily readable."

"No," said Adora, revulsion in her face, "no! Damnit, Catra, none of this makes sense! The dance, our investigation together, your obsession over beating me."

Catra tapped her fingers in succession as she lifted off her ripostes, "I wanted to mess with you, I let my guard down for a bit, and you keep getting in my way. All easily explained."

"Stop treating me like a fool," Adora jumped up and leant forward, almost touching the glass, "just tell me! Why do you know me so well after all this time?"

"You want to know?" Catra grit her teeth and dug her hands into the table, spread wide as she hung low over it. "You really want the answer, Adora? Fine." She breathed. Holding for a second it was as if she were going to hold in that air until she choked. Then she let loose, and explained: "After *that* trial, after Shadow Weaver sent me away —well did you think she'd stop being my foster mother? She still raised me just as she was raising you. But she never told you about me, right? She erased me from existence to those that mattered, of course. Man if she had her way, maybe I'd have stopped existing altogether! She couldn't get rid of me, no, but she wasn't going to let me forget how much I had screwed everything up. And so she came. Day after after day. I got instruction, but I didn't get any love. And she'd never stay long, of course, because I was just a liability; you were her project. But in that short time every day, she's talked to me about you. Oh god how she never stop talking about you. Adora has made the sports team. Adora has graduated from high school, Adora's gotten into law school, Adora's passed the bar. The Chief Prosecutor has taken a special interest in Adora. He's impressed with Adora. Adora's going to get her first case, only at seventeen.

How impressive is Adora. Everything comes naturally to Adora. Adora's a real prodigy. Adora. Adora. Adora. Always Adora. You were there. Your every success thrown into my face. Because that was the best instruction Shadow Weaver could give me. To remind me what I was. But I wasn't going to take that. I read between the lines, you see. Soon I started asking questions, and because Shadow Weaver so looooved to talk about you, I'd get answers. The right questions for the right answers. I got details. Not just your accomplishments but also your weaknesses. Your rashness, your insecurity, everything. I figured out every contour of you, every aspect so I knew that when we'd finally meet again I'd be able to destroy you. I read law books that weren't my own. I went behind Shadow Weaver's back and took the bar. I fought for every scrap of success I ever got and I made it to the prosecutor's office. I was going to show everyone than I was better than you. Th-that… I don't need you!"

Adora hadn't said a word throughout. She had just stayed sat, hands nested in one another, while Catra had risen to a standing position as she had talked. Now the cat laughed. A pained laugh. More a cry than mirth.

"This is where I end up! This was always me, Adora. I killed Double Trouble because I wanted to manipulate the next trial. I was going to control every aspect of it, so you'd have no chance of winning. Then I'd finally prove *I'm* a better lawyer And yet all it's done," she waved her hands, marvelling at it all, "is shown you are!"

"You didn't kill Double Trouble," Adora said, looking up sharply. "You didn't!"

"Yes I did, you idiot. Can't you see? I'm a murderer. I've always been."

"No," Adora's throat tightened up. She was beginning to cry. "Please don't say it. It's not true. You didn't…."

Catra fell to her seat in a heavy slump. She just stared forward at the table.

“I killed that man,” she said, now quiet. “Nine years ago. I killed Micah.”

Adora had been running. She remembered the feel of wind against her bare knees. She remembered the breathlessness. The rush. She and Catra had been playing. Shadow Weaver, busy with her meeting, had given them free reign of this magical place. Cold metal was in Adora’s hand. Something she’d stolen from the kitchen. Catra had annoyed her, so she playfully threatened to stab her with it. Perhaps they were getting a bit too rowdy.

Then Adora lost her. For several hours, she searched. Though at first it was a game, worry started to sink in as nowhere could she find the girl. She sweeped the manor first, then the broad grounds, its greens dim and grey under the black sky. At last she found her. It was under the car, right on the outskirts of the field and beyonds the trees.

“What’s wrong?” Adora asked.

“Nothing,” Catra said between a sniff.

She was laid on her side, foetal, not minding the scratch of tarmac or the rust of the exhaust on either cheek. It was dark, cold, and she was shivering; crying.

“Were you hiding here the whole time?” Adora wondered.

“…no.”

“Then why-—”

“Don’t…wanna talk….”

“Come on, Catra,” Adora smiled, though darkness hid it.

Catra would have preferred to stay under there forever. But Adora's voice was enough to calm her, just enough to oblige. She crawled out from under the hub and stood up. She was a complete mess, but Adora hugged her all the same.

"It's okay," she said. "We can go home."

Troubles began the very next day. Law enforcement came before daybreak and Shadow Weaver woke Catra up for them. By the time Adora was up, Catra was gone, and she couldn't get a single answer to her many questions. Shadow Weaver wasn't on the case officially, but she was involved, and took it upon herself to manage her child. They were set in a metal box of a room, lit only by the harshest of cool light. The police officer did the questioning. But Shadow Weaver stood behind him, baring her stare down on Catra all the while. She brought her eyes to a narrow whenever Catra didn't answer properly.

"Please," Catra said, "I just wanna go home."

"That won't happen for some time," said Shadow Weaver. "You've caused a serious headache and this will take a lot of effort on your part to make up for it. Do you understand?"

Catra gave a weak nod.

Finally the questioning was over, but that was not the end. It was just Catra and Shadow Weaver now, the latter taking the seat across from the first. She spoke in a hush that grated along the metallic ambience of the room. She explained what Catra had to say, and what Catra had to do. There was no room for error.

"And Catra," she said, "you will not mention Adora's being there."

"E-even if they ask?"

"No-one alive knows that Adora was at Brightmoon manor except you and I. You do not want to cause any more problems, do you?"

"No." Catra looked down.

She had to protect Adora. She could do that, couldn't she? But Adora would never know how terrible things would become.

The man who came to the defence lobby on the day of that trial was called Rob Rees. He was alone there for a while, and was wondering if his attorney was ever going to arrive. Then the door opened, and in came a husk. Slow in her movements as she walked, barely able to restrain her hands from jittering, and with eyes so tired as if they'd born the weight of many centuries. The defence attorney, Angella, barely gave her client a look. She wouldn't have any smiles for him.

And faith? This was a woman who had become numb to the air and the sound of birdsong. Food was mush, merely texture and no sweetness. Even water was sickening. She couldn't even look on her own daughter without feeling nothing but hollowness or guilt. Faith was far beyond her reach. Faith in her client, this thief who had broken in her home was laughable.

But she would defend him. He didn't kill her husband.

When the trial was called in, she ambled her way to the bench, coming face to face with her opponent. He was as pale and gaunt as she was, but with none of the weary. The undefeated prosecutor, Manfred Von Karma.

"There is a simple proof and witness," he barked. "Move this trial along speedily."

"Justice will take its time," Angella said. It took all her effort not to slur the words, but she meant to say them. "But we will get there in the end."

She reached her hand to her light-coloured lapel. There the metal of her badge met her hand. By now the old gold of the sunflower had flaked away, and so it shone silver to show experience. The gripped onto it tight.

Catra took the stand. They placed a stool for her to reach, whereupon she held her arms clasped down to her sides. Looking

queasy, with her ears down flat.

“Explain what you saw,” said Von Karma, gripping into his sleeve within folded arms.

“I was in the kitchen and I saw the burglar come in,” Catra said, in a high, rehearsed voice, but still keeping calm as of now. “He fought with the man who was in the kitchen too. He fired a gun and killed him.”

Angella stared at the girl for a few moments. It was enough to draw pain from Catra’s face, but Angella didn’t notice. The girl was small and lithe, and she had been at her home.

“A claw mark was found on the victim’s face,” Angella finally said, “you did not explain how that came to be.”

Karma snapped his fingers, “but she did. A simple scratch which could easily have come about from the struggle. They were in a kitchen, yes. This scratch was likely from a fork.”

“I know my own house. Most of the utensils were in the dishwasher, and were not disturbed. Micah had only had ramen that day, he was using wooden chopsticks. The scar remains unexplained.”

“Bah,” the man scoffed, “any number of explanations can fit. But the mark came from the fight—”

“There was no fight!” Angella shouted, slamming her bench with a fist.

“Defence, please calm down,” came the worried voice of the Judge from his high table.

But Angella kept on going, “there were no powder burns on Micah’s wound or anywhere else. If there had been a fight and mr. Rees had a weapon, then he would have shot at point-blank range. Instead, what happened was that the killer both scratched

the victim and then leapt back to fire the gun from a longer distance. Now how do you explain that?!”

“Objection. This woman is hysterical,” said Von Karma, “she is not fit to defend.”

“The victim…,” said the Judge, with a sad look in his eyes. Then he shook his head, “I will have to overrule your complaint, prosecutor Von Karma. But ms. Angella, you will have to maintain a professional tone, even with the circumstances.”

“Very… very well,” said Angella. She struggled to swallow, so her voice was choked.

“But as to your argument. Didn’t this gun belong the defendant? Surely if you propose a third party, where would they have gotten it?”

“That’s incorrect, your honour,” she said. “The weapon was a piece of evidence for a prior case, something Micah had been investigating.”

“Objection,” interjected Von Karma again, “this theory is preposterous. There is no evidence that the prosecutor’s office sanctioned the removal of evidence. Unless,” the man sprouted an evil grin, “you wish to implicate the victim of violating protocol?”

Had it been another time, Angella would have grimaced. But she was so tired, her face could not shift. Nonetheless, her eyes smouldered at Karma’s vile words.

Something was twisting this case. Someone behind everything, unseen in the shadows, was changing the facts. Evidence had gone missing, details misreported, and it had tortured Angella who could not tell what was imagined —a product of her being ripped from reality and numbed in her all senses— and what was a real conspiracy. It wasn’t fair. Now was the time when she could least do what she needed to; and when she most needed to do it.

If she let this chance go now, the true culprit would elude her forever.

“Whether there’s been a mistake at either end is of no importance,” she managed to say. “The gun was there and a person far nimbler than Rob Rees took it and fired. Then… then I showed up.”

“You?” said the Judge. Then he shook himself, “why, of course. It was your home, wasn’t it.”

“I saw a creature, small and nimble, just the right fit for the kind of killer I described. I gave chase but she shook me off.”

“This is irregular. Eyewitness testimony should be given from the stand, not the defence bench. But if you’re so certain… can you identify the killer?”

“Yes,” said Angella. Though it was a great weight to her aching bones, she lifted her finger and pointed. “It was that little girl on the witness stand.”

“Wh-what?” Catra gasped. “Wait, I didn’t kill anyone!”

“The girl?” the Judge was stunned.

Karma chuckled, “what did I say? Hysterical.”

“I couldn’t have done it. I-I was hiding the whole time,” Catra stammered.

The Judge banged his gavel, summoning silence. Then a pause took him. He ruminated for a second. By instinct he would say this was out of order, but the last thing that was said pricked on his ears.

“Witness, you just said something new that wasn’t in your original testimony. You were hiding?”

“I— yeah,” Catra rubbed her arm. Her eyes shifted about, looking for instruction. But no-one was here to give it. Just the expectant look of the Judge. “Okay, I was playing a game. I was hiding up in the cabinet where no-one could find me.”

“Who were you hiding from?” enquired Angella.

“No-one,” the girl quickly said, “just… hypothetically, y’know.”

“You were hiding from a hypothetical person?”

“Just, no-one could have found me if they were trying. I watched everything from up there.”

Angella shook her head.

“That is impossible. You see Micah,” her throat caught, and a strange wave of emotion came into her voice, —even over this mundane thing—, “he built those cabinets. He mixed up the instructions and set them the wrong way up. But they still functioned so we never bothered to change them. So,” she cleared her throat and, setting her brow, said, “perhaps if I showed you a photo, you could see.”

That she did, providing the court with a photograph of the entire crime scene. She didn’t look at it herself. Too long had she stared at it. The image was burned into her mind. The body, on a heap on its front to the right, by the wall-mirror; a pool of blood undisturbed as it spread along the floor. The rest of the kitchen was in full view.

“Ah, these must be the cabinets on the left,” said the Judge. “And the handles… why they’re in a strange place.”

“The lid to the cabinet moves vertically, you’re honour. Even if she pushed them open a peep, the witness could not have seen the crime from there.”

“What, no,” Catra fretted again. “I didn’t… I mean—”

“What matters,” Karma came in, “was that she wasn’t present in the crime itself. If I throw my windows wide open on a hot summer’s day, does that place me outdoors and sunbathing? Of course not,” he rapped with his voice, “the girl merely opened the cabinet door and saw what happened.”

Angella peered over at Catra and asked, “is this true?”

“Y-yeah,” she said, “I saw everything from the cabinet like I said. I pushed the door open, but they were so busy they didn’t notice me. A-and I didn’t leave until way after it was all over.”

For the first time in a long while, Angella smiled. Nothing kind, but not something particularly sly either. Just a smirk at watching someone fall into a trap of their own making.

“Witness,” she said, “what you’ve said contradicts the evidence. You’ve been caught in a lie.”

“A lie?” Catra eyes drew small and quivering.

“That’s right. You said you left until after Micah was dead, or least after he was shot. At that point, he would have been bleeding over the floor.”

“Ah yes,” said the Judge, “just like in this photograph you provided.”

“Don’t you see the contradiction, you’re honour? It’s right there. For if Catra waited until after Micah was bleeding, then she would have stepped in the pool of blood. There would be tracks, and they would show up in the photograph. Your honour, it’s a matter of logic. The witness must have left the cabinet before Micah was shot!”

“No!”

But Catra’s protests were drowned by a growing din. The gallery were torn between confusion, anger and shock. Von Karma remained undisturbed. The advantage was still his.

The Judge however was flabbergasted, “I just can’t believe it. A sweet little child perjuring herself in court.”

“I didn’t lie,” Catra made her mad protests, “I was told—”

“This is farce!” Karma snapped his fingers once again. It called the attention of all. “The defence is continuing to act hysterical and unprofessional. Addled perhaps by her grief, but addled nonetheless.”

“How dare you,” Angella breathed, but Karma kept on going:

“The evidence does not lie. A simple cut is all that links this witness to a victim, a cut that can easily be assumed to be a result of the struggle. There is no motivation, no reasoning and certainly no evidence that this girl shot the victim. A mere scratch is all you have, and not even that.”

“But you’re wrong. I have evidence.”

To this, the old man’s temple thrashed. He stared at the defence, gaunt in his look, but remained quiet.

“You have evidence that this girl shot the victim?” the Judge asked.

“Not quite,” Angella said, “but as I said, only a quick nimble creature could have both attacked him up close, and gotten away to fire. I have evidence that she gave the scratch.”

“Well, we must see it.”

Catra covered her ears with her hands. She was rocking. A ghost of terror was wrenched across her face, and her eyes darted.

“I didn’t scratch anyone,” she said, “I didn’t kill anyone. Leave me alone! I just want to go home!”

Angella’s hand shook, as she slowly reached into her coat pocket. She’d already declared it. It was impossible to back down from

this action now. Yet even as she pulled the plastic bag out, her shoulders ached, her chest was heavy, and it was a pain to keep her gaze forward. She imagined Micah across from her, as he had done so many times. That he wasn't alive to see this was the only solace left.

"Take this," she said, "this contains fibres we collected from the wound."

"Fibres?" repeated the Judge, "trace evidence? Perhaps a hair, although I'd struggle to see how it'd end up there."

"Not hair, but nail. Or rather, claw. Our analysis showed this to be keratin, and it can be no doubt that it came from the hand of a cat. The person," she looked over, a menacing gleam in her otherwise pale eye, "who attacked my husband and then killed him was this witness — Catra!"

There was a scream. A shrill, wailing scream that turned to a furious hiss. Angella had heard and seen many a witness break down in court, and always knew that she had them. The child was no different.

But then when she turned to look at Catra again, Angella flinched. Catra leapt onto the witness stand, shaking, gripped by an intense violent frenzy. Then she lunged.

"THAT'S A LIE!"

Angella froze. Even a small creature was a terrifying sight when it hurtled its way over with claws outstretched, a writhing grimace on its face. She closed her eyes. Shrinking back, she braced for the attack.

It never came. When Angella dared open her eyes again, Catra was held mid-air, struggling but restrained. Holding her by the arm was a tall woman in red robes and a mask.

"Prosecutor Shadow Weaver?" Angella said.

“The girl is hers,” said Von Karma, “it was appropriate to have the prosecutor on standby.” He grinned, “And good thing too.”

“Foolish girl,” Shadow Weaver threw Catra to the floor. She hit with a thud, and fell still thereafter.

“This is a serious action,” the Judge said, with a grave and stern tone. “Violence is not permitted in court.”

“Believe me. She will be dealt with. Bailiffs.”

The men came up. Catra was pliant as they ushered her away. Under the cold narrowed eyes of Shadow Weaver, following her until she was gone from the room, she offered no more resistance. For the briefest moment, Angella felt the urge to go after her. Shadow Weaver’s reproach towards her child lingered unwell in the woman’s chest. Although the feeling quickly numbed.

“That was a confession,” she said, decisive, even triumphant.

“Perhaps,” said Shadow Weaver, “or perhaps an impulsive child thrust into a difficult situation. She could not control her behaviour, sure, but that doesn’t mean she was wrong. She was affronted with a lie.”

“It’s not a lie,” said Angella, “I have the evidence here.”

Shadow Weaver snatched the bag from her hands. Eyes widening, the thought to take it back screamed across her mind, but her better sense stayed her. If she panicked then it would be all over. But it looked like it might be anyway.

“Please,” Angella said, in the barest of whispers, “Micah was your friend.”

“That’s no excuse for what you’ve done,” Shadow Weaver said in a dark lolling voice. “Your honour, this is falsified evidence. Forged to tie Catra to the crime.”

“Falsified evidence?” gasped the Judge.

“I should have suspected at much,” von Karma added with a terse nod.

“But how do you know? How could this be?”

Shadow Weaver explained her clever little ways. Indeed, it had been her who had called the police to the manor that night, just as Angella was supposedly chasing her lithe creature. Since Catra was a minor, Shadow Weaver had been monitoring her in preparation for her testimony. Throughout she had had an eye on this case. She’d noticed Angella’s strange behaviour. It was enough. Angella’s work had been sloppy, borne more out of desperate grief than any predetermined malice.

Nonetheless, forged evidence was forged evidence. The Judge cleared the court. Reflexive, Angella held onto her silver badge once again. These precious minutes were the last she could.

“I am going call this a mistrial,” said the Judge,” and schedule a new trial for Rob Rees. Never have I seen a case leave such a bad taste in my mouth. I know this situation has been dreadful for you, ms. Angella, but I expected better of you. You were an exemplar to your profession.”

Von Karma shook his head, “I have never seen something so disgraceful in my 35 years of prosecuting.”

“You will have to submit to an inquiry by the bar,” the Judge continued, “No doubt lose your badge.”

“I understand,” said Angella. “I will take any punishment anyone sees fit but please, reopen the investigation. That girl… she….”

No more memories. In the detention centre, Catra wore a wretched look. She craned her neck to the side so as not to see Adora.

“Stop defending me,” she said.

“Catra….”

The world was swirling around Adora, draining down to a hole in the deep of her stomach. After nine years, she knew. The trial Catra had been hauled off to as a witness, and her resulting near-assault on Angella, the reason she was never seen again…. Perhaps it was better when she didn’t know.

“Everything I’ve done,” said Catra, “everything… it’s been to bring you down. All I do is destroy. Just leave before I destroy you too.”

“Catra, no,” Adora said, standing up, “you… well, you’re not a good person exactly, but you’re not a monster either.”

“I hid the watch. In the Singer case.”

“Yeah, well,” Adora dismissed it with a wave, “that came out in the end. You didn’t hide the evidence.”

“That’s a technicality. I was going to hide it until I realised I could use it.” Catra screwed up her face and rocked her head, “no, look: I went to Prime the day before that last trial! I knew there was something between him and Hordak and I wasn’t going to do anything! I just wanted to know to keep ahead of you. And then he offered to make me the new Chief Prosecutor if I helped him.”

“But you didn’t,” Adora said, leaning forward that she pressed against the window, “you helped me in the end.”

“Only because it didn’t matter!” Catra’s eyes burst open. They were quaking, with anger, with regret. She cried out, “because everything Shadow Weaver ever said about you was true! You’re better than me. You’re the damn hero, you’re She-Ra the goddess of law for fuck sake.” She spat out a broken laugh, with a mad smile that seemed sadder than even her cries. Waving her hand ahead she said, “flying above us in the skies, and I’m down here in hell, trying to drag you down, because that’s what I do.”

“You don’t have to bring me down,” Adora’s hands were up, frantic, palms against the plastic glass, as if desperate to pass

through and just reach her. “Just come up to my height. Let me lift you up.”

“That,” Catra’s face fell to a scowl again, her ears flattening too, “is the dumbest, sappiest thing I’ve ever heard.”

“Yeah,” Adora managed to laugh, “well it’s how I feel.”

Catra tore away. Wrapping her cape around did nothing to stave the shivering, yet inside she was a concoction of radiance and fire and heat, burning up in her chest, burning up to her cheeks. Fury on one side, gratitude on another. Nothing about her own feelings ever made sense anymore.

Adora sighed, “Catra, there’s no reason you can’t start doing the right thing. I believe you can. It’s… it’s not so much what you are but what you do that counts. I… I don’t care that I’m She-Ra. That’s not why I’m doing this.”

She broke from the glass, standing up straight, and taking her wrist into her hand. The well-worked gold of the bracelet was hard to her fingers. Then Adora felt around for her lapel, bringing the sunflower pin into her hand too. Like it were some relic or totem, she gripped onto it tight. She looked to Catra again. The girl was still turned away, but felt Adora’s eyes on her back.

“I became a defence attorney because it was right,” she said, “because I can help people. Because I promised to… because I promised….” Her voice was breaking down, cracking into a thousand pieces, tears and breath and every register coming in at once. “I promised I would help you so goddamnit, Catra, let me!”

Having been turned away for what felt like so long now, Catra turned to look back at Adora. Her expression was softened, though for pained brows. Her chest was growing heavy. She stood there, disoriented, exposed under the harsh detention light. But when she breathed, it was easy. She had something she’d not had for a long, long while. Clarity.

“Very well,” she said, looking down. “I’ll do the right thing.”

Adora's eyes widened, and there was a pause long enough for hope to settle in. What a cruel thing that was. Because Catra now turned to face her proper, brow set, and, with a new determination, said:

"I am officially rescinding my letter of request."

"Catra, no—"

"Don't come to court tomorrow."

"No! You can't—"

"Adora, please," Catra said, "you don't need this distraction anymore. You don't need the demoness prosecutor clawing at you and trying to drag you down. Just… go. Help someone who deserves it."

Under barrage from all Adora's protests and pleas, Catra turned and ran. She banged on the door, and the guard was prompt in escorting her out. She was gone. All Adora could do was shout:

"CATRAAAAA!"

And Catra was taken away. She padded along quickly, staring at her feet all the while that she didn't realise the guard was lagging. No matter. She was returned to her holding cell and locked up all the same. Throwing herself into her bed, she cried. There was no punching of the furniture or shredding of the pillows. This wasn't a furious wail, but something quiet. Something she tried to stifle into the rough sheets that the facility had provided for the hard steel-frame. Those sheets would become stained with all her torment, her guilt and regret, as the water hot in her eyes effused with every wretched sob.

She was pathetic. That was the only thought that crossed her mind now. What right did she have to feel this way after all she'd done.

The thought would have festered, but to her luck, something came to steal her attention away. It was a baritone voice, reaching out:

“Now what’s got you so down in the blues?”

Catra looked up. The wall was blocked between the cells, but the bars let the sound carry. She pushed herself up and went over. Slim as she was, even able to slip her head through a little, she couldn’t see who was in the cell over. But she recognised the speaker.

“Chas Singer? What are you doing here?”

“I got my appeal,” the man said. “While my lawyer is no better or worse than Adora, I’m feeling pretty good based on the prosecutor alone.”

“Who you got?”

“Called Winston Payne, I believe.”

“Oh yeah,” Catra let slip a chuckle between her residual sniffs, “you’re a free man.”

“What they’d get you for?” Singer asked.

“Killing Double Trouble.”

“Oh dear… well they weren’t always the friendliest, but I admired their routines. You actually did that?”

“Probably. I don’t remember it exactly but I….” Catra shook her head, flinging loose tear droplets onto the bars, “it doesn’t matter.”

“So what’s got you all upset?”

“Nothing.”

“Nah,” a knowing tone struck Singer’s voice, “it’s something. Is it about Adora?”

“Yeah,” she admitted. “It always is.”

“Well, it ain’t ever easy with love, now is it.”

“Yeah,” she said again.

She let out a sigh, letting her head fall. Then she jerked up.

“Wait, what? Love? I-I don’t love her, I hate her.”

Singer cocked his head. “Oh?”

“Well, yes… no, urgh,” Catra grabbed onto her head with both hands, “I don’t know.”

Though she could not see him, Chas Singer wore a reassuring smile. He slid his hands down the length of the bars, letting out a soaring whistle as he did.

“Hey, hey, it’s not so bad,” he said, “These things aren’t easy to figure out. You two have had a complicated time. Love and hate, people say they’re straight opposites—”

“They are,” Catra said.

“Now let me finish,” Chas said, making an easing gesture with his palms, “They may be opposites, but that doesn’t mean they never interact. They’re both expressed in passion. They’re both sources of pain and fixation. Hate is sure bad to have but love can be unhealthy too if unchecked.”

“They can’t be related,” argued Catra. “That’s a contradiction.”

“Heh, you lawyers. Well let me give you an example. Whenever I give a rendition of *My Way* , it guarantees a tear from the audience. And yet they always come back. Now why would a

fellow come to a gig to feel sad? There are a enough tears in the world aren't there."

Catra rubbed her palm against her eye.

"Yeah… So what's the answer?"

"Well something happens, I suspect. A transformation happens in the music. Despair is displaced by joy, arousing the same passion. As if the latter lays in wait as the former does it work and then strikes at the last moment to steal the limelight. And hey," he smiled, "maybe hate can turn to love and love to hate and you wouldn't even know it."

Letting out a long, deep sigh, Catra said, "I don't… I don't want to hate Adora. All my life I've had everything kept from my reach, because of her. Or for her sake. I suffer just so she can live in her perfect world, naive of what's going on. And when I try to get what I want, I have to fight at every turn, just to get what was handed to her on a plate… and threw away without a thought. Yeah… she makes me mad. So am I just gonna sacrifice my own freedom for her own sake now?"

"Well," said Chas Singer, "are you?"

A long pause took her. Everything was quiet, everything calm. Both in the cell and within. Perfect clarity.

"Yes," she said. "This time, it's on my terms. I can do it for her."

Chapter End Notes

Yo these two dumbasses, I love them.

I'm really procrastinating on uni work so I might not have been able to publish today but I decided to do the revision of this chapter anyway and I'm glad I did. I can cram on essays over the next couple days if I have too. I think this chapter is real good and I'm really glad because I know it just gets better from here on out.

Next week it's the beginning of the end. The last trial day starts with the first of a trilogy of chapters that make up the climax.

Turnabout Promise, part 1

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

A torrent of rain battered the empty streets. Adora paid no mind as she tumbled out of the Detention centre and became drenched under these watery storms. She was in pain. She was scorned. The world before her twisted about and her head throbbed with a grievous ache.

Winds, climbing down the mountains far away —perhaps even the slopes of the Whispering Wood where this all began— flooded down into the city. There it became a gale. Furiously ripping past the towers, it pulled any wayward trees to a harsh lean. When it reached Adora, the winds screamed and howled, rainwater crashed into her from every direction, and the world slipped into a haze of white.

Until a dark figure emerged in the middle distance. Tall, with a robe and long black hair, down and damp in the rain.

"Is this what you meant?" Adora shouted at her. The figure, Shadow Weaver. "The catastrophe of choosing the help her?"

Shadow Weaver came up close. She was undisturbed by the raging elements. Even as she spoke, her voice was clear above it all, yet still purred like a deep whisper:

"It is but a shadow of what would happen, if you continued the defence tomorrow. I foresaw a terrible thing, and I cautioned you in hope that you would make the right choice. But I will say I did not see this." She gave a strange low laugh. "Catra has been kind to you. For once. Letting you go from the case. You were never meant to be a defence attorney, you do realise that now, Adora."

Looking down, Adora wrapped her arms around herself. She began to shiver.

“It’s time,” said Shadow Weaver. “Come back to the prosecutor’s office. You know this has gone on long enough.”

“O…okay.”

It didn’t take Adora much effort to agree in the end. Her voice was weak. She had no will left to resist.

The office was a warm respite. The hating sounds of the world beyond was kept at bay from inside, though it had left its mark; Adora was soaked through, and stood in a growing puddle.

“Oh, poor thing,” said Shadow Weaver, and she quickly drew a silk handkerchief from her wrist. “Take this.”

Not really thinking, Adora did. Tears were lost to the deluge across her rain-covered face, but she buried it into the cloth nonetheless. Then the taller woman came behind her, laying hands that almost reassured on her shoulders. Shadow Weaver gripped too tight, yet Adora worried she’d feel unsteady without the hold; that she’d fall without it.

“I am going to dry off,” Shadow Weaver said, now slipping Adora’s damp red jacket off from her. “Go wait for me in my office.”

Adora gave a weak nod, though remained still as the woman walked away. Her jacket was in Shadow Weaver’s hand, rested by her side. A glint of gold was the last Adora saw from it as she turned the corner and out of view.

Heavy in her step, Adora finally moved. The winding path through the Prosecutor’s Office was long, and she had to go all the way to the high prosecutors’ floor. This was familiar. Not so long ago she had led Glimmer and Bow through here. Where were they? She hadn’t heard from either of them since the end of the trial. They would have no idea she was back here. Would she ever get the chance to tell them? Would she ever see them again….

When she had been here before, it had been full of reproachful stares. But now it was barren. It was late, and most had gone

home. Few had been coming in of late, and despite the backlog of cases now growing, this was considered better. Taint had infected this place. Scandal and duplicity, as Glimmer had always said and shown bare by the Ron Guy case.

And of course, this office had harboured a murderer called Catra. All this time.

Nausea suddenly gripped Adora and she double over. She had reached some of the High Prosecutor's offices, but the need to steady herself brought her to a halt. She leant against the one door, and took in heavy breaths.

"Ah, the Thompson fork. How interesting."

"What do you mean— hey you're naming random moves to put me on edge, aren't you?"

"Well, you would never know."

"… how did I lose that game to you."

The voices were coming from the office beyond the door. One dark and crisp, one much higher and full of snark. Both were recognisable. Friends to her ears.

Adora pushed the door open, and was greeted to a room full of burgundy. The sofa, fine and tufted, the same colour as the drawn curtains —not to mention a framed prussian-style coat on the wall. Gathered on both sides of a chess-set were Miles Edgeworth and Phoenix Wright. The former's smug expression as he regarded the flustered opponent shifted to surprise as he saw the girl by the door. He stood.

"Ms. Adora, what are you doing here?"

"Nevermind that. Why are you two playing… chess?"

"Well," a giddy smirk broke across his face again, "he did promise me he would play me a game under a certain condition, which I

met.”

“What about tomorrow’s trial?”

“Ah yes, well,” he said, “I’ve got everything I need, and I thought perhaps it’d do me good to clear my head. Or rather, Wright thought it’d do me good.”

Phoenix’s attention had not budged from the chessboard. He was giving it a ceaseless stare.

“What’s up with him?” asked Adora.

“He’s having to use his brainpower. Not something he’s used to.”

“Tell him to stop bullying,” Phoenix said, even now not looking away from the board. “I’m trying to make my move.”

Adora smiled. Pain still pulsed through her body, especially her head, and there was a phantom feeling that she had been sick. But she could mask it, even from herself, with this distraction.

“I never got chess,” she said. “Too slow paced for me, I guess.”

“Well perhaps you were suited for the defence attorney’s life after all,” said Edgeworth

This made Adora’s shoulders fall. With her badge on the jacket now gone, she had no idea what she was.

“Wasn’t it your father who taught you chess, though?” asked Phoenix. “He was a defence attorney.”

“Well… I like to think he had a different approach to you two.”

Adora came to kneel down by the chess set and watched them picking their moves. Split seconds preceded every placement by Edgeworth —Phoenix was slow and deliberative. Irony not lost on the girl, she came to smirk, though said nothing for the longest time. Eventually, she wondered aloud.

“How did you two come to trust each other so much?”

Edgeworth let out a long whistle, though seemed to shift his gaze. Phoenix however looked at Adora the first time this night, studying her. Then he leant back, streaming his fingers through his spiky hair.

“It’s hard to say when it happened,” he sighed, “just realised it one day. In the middle of a very important trial. This man has been there, opposing me, guiding me, always there when I needed something important. I wouldn’t be where I am today without him. Sure, he could be less stingy about handing over evidence—”

Edgeworth ruffled, “it’s standard policy—”

“And the time he pretended to be dead wasn’t great. He’s a work in progress, but I wouldn’t change any fundamentals.”

“Wright that’s… surprisingly deep and sincere.”

Phoenix shrugged. “Hey, I can do sincere.”

“Usually you hide behind a veil of sarcasm to hide your deeper vulnerabilities.”

“Well you didn’t have to tell everyone.”

Adora laughed, “it’s okay it’s just me. I won’t be telling anyone….”

“Hm, you never told us why you’re here,” noted Edgeworth.

“It doesn’t matter, I’m not staying.”

She stood up. Something was hardening within her, but not her throat, nor nothing like tension or pain anymore. Her lungs loosening, filling with a light air, but she couldn’t think as to why. She wasn’t really thinking at all. But right now she didn’t need to.

“I’ll see you around, Edgeworth,” she smiled. “At tomorrow’s trial.”

Night passed. The storm, terrible as it was, wrenching through the city and blasting every wall with chilled rain, died by morning. The gale was gone, and a cold but calm day began in Los Angeles.

One last day of the trial.

The defence lobby had never been quite this lonesome. Only Bow and Catra had arrived. The former was exhausted, having spent a night wracking his mind to fit the pieces together without help. Sea Hawk and Scorpia had offered to do any more that they could, but he couldn't ask it of them. He needed two others, both still missing. For Catra's part, the shadows under her eye were no better and the night, rough, had taken a few more clumps out of her hair. But she was fine, she felt. Better than she had been for a while.

There wasn't much talk between them for half an hour. The silence fed discomfort in the air, especially for Catra, who wrapped her cape about herself, gripping tighter as she watched the man. He shouldn't have been here. If anything she should have told him that he could go grab the rest he sorely needed. But if she had to say that Adora wasn't coming, that would invite questions. She didn't have the stomach to answer.

But the more she didn't speak, the more time of his she would waste. Even now she couldn't do things right.

Then the door opened, and in came Angella. Catra shrunk a little to see her, but the woman didn't see her. She promptly asked Bow:

"Is Glimmer here? I haven't seen her for a few days, she didn't come home. I-I know," she bowed her head and gripped her hand up by her chest, "I know I must seem overprotective again, but the last time I saw her I said… I told her something. I'm worried that it might have something to do with that."

When Angella mentioned this last part, Bow stole a glance at Catra. But he was quick to look straight at Angella as he explained

that he hadn't seen Glimmer for a while now.

"I'm sure she's alright," Angella said to console herself. "What about Adora? Is she late?"

"I haven't seen Adora since the end of yesterday's trial either," Bow said, furrowing his brow ever deeper. "And it's really starting to concern me. There's a lot to catch her up on."

They didn't know. Of course they didn't know. For some reason Adora had run off and left it up to Catra to explain. The girl let out a short sigh. Then she took in a long, steadying breath, and spoke:

"Adora is—"

"Hey, guys. Hey, Catra."

Catra was left stuck and blinking. Even as Angella and Bow turned to greet the voice, she remained motionless, facing ahead. It was only when the other girl came around to show herself did Catra utter:

"A-Adora?"

Adora just wore a smile and patted Catra on the shoulder. As if yesterday were but a memory even more distant than the ones that still haunted the two of them combined. Incredulous, Catra continued to stare.

"Where were you yesterday?" Bow asked. Then he shook his head, "ah, nevermind. I need to tell you about Soter Michael, and the gun, and—

"Right, right," said Adora, "well we'd best get started."

"Adora…," Catra said, "I told you—"

"Catra I'm doing this and you can't stop me. You think I could just give up before we've reached the end?"

“This can only end one way. I don’t want you to see it.”

“Tough.”

“Adora!’ Catra said, even with a small growl in the back of her throat. “Please, I’m trying to do one good thing to you for once in my life.”

Adora let out a laugh, “once?”

Catra peered. “What’s funny about that?”

“You don’t remember giving me that cape to keep warm, and then stopping me from slipping from the beam. And then we laughed about good times we had together.”

“I, nrghh,” Catra looked away, trying her hardest not to redden. “Yeah, sure….”

“I mean, I dunno how to say this. I like you. I’ve missed you… the real you.”

“What the hell are you talking about.”

“I don’t what the hell I’m talking about,” Adora laughed again, “but I know I’m going into that courtroom with you. So what if I do?” She waved her hands, “ *oh something bad will happen* , at least that’s what you and Shadow Weaver believe. Look, at most I’ll get the reputation as an idiot who never quits on their client. I can live with that.”

“Adora, how many times do I need to say this. I’m not worth—”

The doors to the courtroom were opened, and the bailiffs summoned their entry. Adora and Catra shared one more look. If this conversation would ever finish, it would have to be another time. Catra paced ahead and went inside, but Adora lingered. Angella was shining towards her a warm smile.

“You’ve gotten good at showing a brave face,” she said. “I imagine you must be terrified.”

“Well yeah,” Adora said through a weak chuckle.

“Although I think your client is more annoyed than reassured.”

“It’s better than complete dread. And I meant what I said, every word. I’m going to see this to the end, no matter how bad it is.”

Angella gave her one parting gesture, laying a soft hand on Adora’s shoulder and smiling at her once again, before she too headed off. Finally, Adora went inside.

Edgeworth stood across from her in the courtroom, and this was Edgeworth the prosecutor again. As good-natured he had been last night, he would pursue his case with a single-minded drive which Adora needed to match if she had any hope of victory.

The Judge banged his gavel and began, “yesterday we learned quite a few new facts. The victim, disguised as the defendant, possibly held the gun when witnessed and caught on camera. Seemingly this would suggest that it was they who shot her and not vice-versa.”

“The prosecution maintains that this is impossible, your honour,” interjected Edgeworth. “For only one still lives, while the other does not.”

“And secondly, the person that a second witness saw leave the forest —who naturally could not have been the defendant who entered the forest, as they never left it — must have been someone completely new.”

“That is the mystery which we will shortly dispel. We will show that this third party had no involvement in the crime whatsoever. And with his possibility being eliminated, logic demands that we must convict the defendant Catra for the murder. To that, the prosecution would like to call Soter Michael to the stand.”

“This is the man,” Bow said to Adora. “I imagine if Glimmer were here she’d say everything rides on getting information out of his testimony.”

“Are you sure you don’t want to go looking for her?” asked Adora. “I can handle things from now on.”

“No offence but you don’t work the best on your own. You need someone to fire your ideas off. I’m worried about Glimmer but you need my help right now.”

“Thanks Bow,” she said, smiling. “Right, let’s do this.”

The witness stand did not suit Soter Michael. He tried leaning against it, with an aloof distant gaze, but his arms were too bulky for the surface. A few tries yielded wobbles and slippage, and eventually he just resorted to standing up, though with hands in pockets.

“Name and occupation,” said Edgeworth.

“Yah, I’m Soter Michael. I’m the great greaser. The real muscle of the East L.A. The cavalry of the Crimson Wastes! Ya get me?”

“That’s not what I asked. Perhaps we can put you down for a punk.”

“That’s an insult. I’m old school Rock ’n’ Roll, baby!”

“You’re a gangster,” said the Judge, setting his brow low and disapproving. “And you’re wearing that jacket, the one the witness described yesterday. Very well, mr. Michael, you will testify as to your actions in the Whispering Woods three nights ago.”

Soter Michael rode on through his testimony, though he said much the same as he told the super pal investigators. Taking his bike, he broke off from the freeway to start climbing the ascending foothills. He parked somewhere out of sight, on foot continuing. He went about his business then returned back the traveller’s footpath, only to realise his ride was far from the train. He thus

slipped from the platform and down onto the dirt track before Perfuma arrived to ultimately phone the police.

"And as ya see," he concluded, "there's no reason for me to be here. I was in the forest, and I left. Someone saw the back of me? What about it? I didn't see anything, I didn't hear anything or taste anything or smell anything. I have nothing to give ya!"

"Hold on a minute," said Adora, "are you seriously saying you didn't hear anything that night?"

"Objection," Edgeworth called in, "he didn't say he didn't hear anything, just nothing from the crime."

"But he was further into the forest than Perfuma was," Adora argued, "and she heard the gunshot. There's no way he missed that." Adora folded her arms, as a buzz took her. "Good," she muttered, "contradiction right out of the gate."

"It should get him talking," noted Bow.

Michael, however, just laughed. Adora's arms fell and Bow watched with a confused look at the man belted out his gnarly, "ha!'

"Come on," Adora whined, "you can't say you didn't hear anything that night —or rather, anything from the crime."

"I heard *nothing* that night!" he said.

"Wait… nothing?!"

"I was down on the ground," Michael explained, "one ear to the ground. That way I can see the little petals right up and close… wait, forget that. What I mean is that with my one good ear to the ground, I couldn't hear anything in the air. Because in the other ear," he pointed to it in dramatic fashion, "I'm completely deaf!"

"What!" protested Bow, as Adora fell face first into the bench.

“It is… possible,” Edgeworth suggested, “a background check revealed the witness does in fact have an ear problem. Here’s the proof.”

Edgeworth produced a sheathe of documents. Medical records, clear as day. Adora quickly trawled through them, hoping for an error or mistake. Yet the dense jargon was hard to parse in a quick scan.

“Give them to me,” said Bow, “I’ll see if there’s anything we can use.”

Meanwhile, Edgeworth continued, “there’s no reason to doubt what the witness is saying. It’s possible, even probable, that he spent the entire time in the forest unaware that something was going on.”

“That’s unlikely,” Adora said, teeth tensed together.

“How so?” asked the Judge.

Heat crept into her neck as she found herself on the spot. How did such a good contradiction fly away already? She needed to make her case, quick and strong. Yet there she was, barely hanging along by the thinnest of strings.

“Look,” she said, “yesterday we found that Double Trouble fired at Catra.”

“That is even more unlikely,” Edgeworth cut in.

“But it would make sense if the weapon fired was a blank….” She held for a few moments. Rubbing finger against thumb, she looked ahead in a vacant stare. Then she went ahead, declaiming, “your honour, I think this witness killed Double Trouble, and I would like to indict him.”

“A-already?” said the Judge. “I mean, I saw this coming but I didn’t expect this so soon.”

Inside Adora was screaming. But she had to throw herself to the brink. Yes the evidence was contentious, perhaps even circumstantial. But unless she tried, she may never get the chance again.

"Your honour, I have evidence to seriously put the witness's testimony into doubt."

"Very well. Let us see this evidence."

Adora breathed, just enough to steady her nerves. Then she said, "Your honour… TAKE THAT!"

"AAAGH, put that thing away please!"

The Judge's eyes had shrunk to shivering dots. The defence attorney was holding out a pistol and presenting it to the court.

"N-no, I"m not threatening you," Adora groaned. "This weapon is the bank. May I also direct the court's attention the evidence bench. There you will see the weapon that was supposedly fired. The gun from the SP-0 incident."

"Of course," said Edgeworth, "and they do appear to be perfect copies of one another. And perhaps this does confirm your theory of Double Trouble making a false shot at the defendant — assuming we can confirm that this was the weapon used that night. But what relevance does this have to this witness?"

"Mr. Edgeworth, isn't the better question, *where* did I get this gun? Perhaps the witness can answer that?"

Soter Michael's expression was stony, and shades hid his eyes. But sweat was pouring out in beads again and again by his temple. Even as he spoke, he could not mask the uncertainty in his voice.

"I've never seen that thing in my life."

"Oh yeah?" said Bow, "then how come it was on your person yesterday?"

“Yeaaargh,” the man exclaimed. Clutching onto his face, he pulled at his own cheeks, such that his shades fell off.

“We’ve dusted it for fingerprints too,” Bow continued, “his are on it. The boys at the lab had it on file due to a small DUI incident from a couple of weeks ago. Unfortunately, any of Double Trouble’s have been wiped away, assuming they left behind any in the first place.”

“But if its true that this gun was with Double Trouble that night,” Adora jabbed out her finger, “then that means he must have met them that night.”

“A fanciable theory,” Edgeworth said in a dry tone, “but not conclusive. Perhaps that gun’s similarity to the murder weapon is incidental? You still have to contend with the fact that there was only one bullet heard that night.”

“Perhaps a silencer was used—”

“Does the defence take us for amateurs?” Edgeworth said with a slam to the bench. “Of course we searched the witness and his property for any connecting evidence. No such thing has been found, nor in our multiple sweeps of the Whispering Woods.”

“They searched the witness,” Bow repeated, deflated.

“So it’s not going to be like Prime or Mermista then,” Adora said. “We’re going to have to find some other evidence to make this all fit.”

Calmer now, and sporting a grin, the witness held out his hands and leant forward to say, “lemme ask you a question. Why would I even want to kill this person? I’ve never met them. I’ve nothing to do with them. I ain’t gonna back down from a fight sure, but to go find someone I’ve never met, kill ‘em and then frame a third person I knew nothing about? This all sounds like a bad trip!”

“As I said yesterday,” Edgeworth added, “very few homicides are ever done between people who don’t know one another. And I’ve

never heard of a case where a person organised to have an identical real weapon to make a potential switch should the victim have a fake."

"What?" Adora said, twisting her face in confusion.

"Adora, think it through. In your scenario, Mr. Michael somehow gets the gun from the SP-0 incident from the vault. Then he goes up to the woods where Double Trouble is firing a fake weapon at Catra —for reasons unexplained. Then he shoots them and makes the swap, and lo and behold the fake weapon is a match. And, of course, all of this for what? We have reviewed the victim: they have a sordid past, but there's no connection to this witness. So what is it? What is the motivation?"

"I…"

There was nothing. This person's world was completely apart. A biker rocker gangster and a sultry performer mimic? There was a tenuous link, but with two degrees of separation: Michael to Scorpia to Catra to Double Trouble, and no logic could force that to explain a motivation.

Desperate, Adora turned to Bow, who had been reviewing those documents.

"Please tell me you have something?"

"Well," his expression was queazy, but the situation called for a bit of help. He sighed and said, "well I've been looking at the medical records"

"And?" Adora said quickly. Her eyes lit up.

"They're perfect."

"Of course they're perfect," she grumbled.

"No, they're too perfect," Bow said, stroking his chin as he recounted, "we're talking a rough tough biker who gets into fights.

He's only gone to his preferred hospital once, and that was for the ear problem. And then, another thing comes to mind." He knitted his brow as the miring thoughts grew deeper and stranger, "we only had one incident to get fingerprint data from. Even though he claims to have been in the gang for years."

"That is weird."

"Everything about this case, man," Bow said, letting out, "it's bizarre. We weren't allowed to look at the body. We've got this witness out of nowhere. It's like someone's in the shadows pulling all the strings."

"Yeah," said Adora, "but I don't know what to do. We can't present the feeling something's fishy as evidence. And even then: one thing's about the victim, the other's about the witness. Not a clear pattern. No clear connection," she screwed her eyes tight and held onto her head with her palms. "Think, think, Adora. Why isn't there any connection?"

"Without it, the case is as good as over."

Adora threw her head back. Thoughts rolled around inside, and finding it hard to clear them out, she vocalised:

"I've been trying to make all the evidence fit. I need to think this through. Maybe I can turn my thinking around." She breathed, and began: "Alright: Michael was the only other person who could have fled the scene. He must have switched the guns, but he wasn't seen with Double Trouble. In fact , nothing at all connects him to Double Trouble. No silencer, so only one bullet was fire that night. The blank. Double Trouble fired the blank. Something must explain what allowed Double Trouble to be the only person to fire the gun. And then for the gun to be in Michael's possession, even if they never crossed paths."

"It's a paradox, or a contradiction, I guess," Bow said, with a half-smile. "But you've figured this kind of thing out before. You just need to have one of your crazy solutions, right?"

“Something far out?”

“Something amazing.”

“Okay,” Adora said, with a curt sigh, followed by the strangest smallest smile touching her lips. “Let’s try this one.”

She look ahead again. But even now a weight dragged down in her chest. Could she really make this claim and not lose all credibility for good?

“Defence?” came the Judge’s voice, “if you cannot answer the question posed, then I must be forced to stand down the witness.”

“Hold it.” It was barely a whisper.

“Um, what was that?”

“HOLD IT!” She threw out her hand, “I said HOLD IT! I have an answer. I know what the connection is between Double Trouble and Soter Michael. Every missing puzzle will be explained. But it’s going to turn this whole case on its head in a way you’d never believe.”

“Stop stalling,” said Edgeworth, “and tell us.”

“The true culprit behind this ‘murder’ of Double Trouble… is none another than Double Trouble themselves!”

“What?” spluttered Edgeworth.

“Wh-wh-whaaaa—”

The Judge barely had his astonishment heard before a shouting sprang from the gallery, one that not even the bangs of his gavel could quell. Soter Michael meanwhile let out a rapid yelp, and tore on his face so much his skin stretched from his eyesockets.

“That’s right,” Bow shouted over them all with a fierce grin. He did however lean over to Adora and quietly asked, “that is right, right?”

“It’s right.”

‘That’s right!” he declared again. “This explains it all.”

“But how,” cried the Judge, “the victim is… the victim! Not the perpetrator.”

“There is no victim,” Bow said, “and there is no witness. Soter Michael is a false identity.”

“This is a murder trial without a murder,” Adora kept on going, “a complete sham. A total performance!”

Edgeworth slammed his bench, but then fell hunched over.

“This is preposterous,” he coughed, “if the victim isn’t dead then where are they?”

“Bow just said it. They’re on the witness stand.”

“Everything about him is constructed,” Bow explained, “a perfect medical record except for a convenient ear disease; and a single incident with the police to register fake fingerprints.”

“This is ridiculous,” the witness protested, still clutching onto his now rubbery face, “I’m me! I’ve never even heard of this guy. I’m the mean greaser. I’m the cavalry. I like the little petals, I—”

“Who’s the best performer around?” Adora posed, fresh determination swimming in her eye, “who could pull off the performance of a century? Pretending to be a different person while you’re presumed dead. Faking every detail and document to make the character believable. It’s you, isn’t it. You’re Double Trouble!”

"OBJECTION!" Edgeworth's brow was so deep and furrowed that his forehead was engraved with trenches. He slammed his palm flat onto the bench again and said, "I will not allow this farce to continue any further! I've seen some bluffs in my time, but this… this tops them all. This witness's whole existence couldn't have been cooked up for one performance alone, there are too many unexplained details. What about the body we found at the crime scene? How did no-one at the forensics office notice they were dealing with a fake corpse?"

"Well maybe— no," Adora shook her head, "I don't have to explain any of that now. It doesn't matter. I've got the witness where I want them. All I need to do is prove that this witness is Double Trouble."

Edgeworth folded his arms and scoffed, "well that would certainly be nice for you. But how can you prove that? How could one person be someone else?"

"If there were something about Double Trouble we knew to be true, and this person is Double Trouble," Adora walked it through, "then logic tells us that this person must have that something as well."

"And is there indeed such a thing?"

"Of course. And it's called Keratin." Adora pointed to 'Soter Michael' and said, "since Catra scratched Double Trouble that night, there should still be trace elements of Keratin on you, even if we can't see the scratch!"

"That's bull, that's—" the witness was muttering, stepping back, searching for escape with his gaze.

"Bow!"

He was quick. Leaping over the bench, Bow rushed to the man and held up his pad to scan. The burly fellow lurched forward. Bow shifted to the left, and the man missed. Ping. He got his result.

“Eureka,” he shouted in delight, “a match!”

For Edgeworth, there was no more words. He gaped, and could draw no more than a stilted wheezing from his breath. But noise swelled from the gallery to fill the silence. First they were whispering, conferring with one another that what had just happened had happened. Then it was becoming louder, confused and agitated. It took several swings of the gavel to bring it under wraps

Then the witness spoke again:

“Oh well done… well done.” Michael’s voice was strange. Higher, gentler, and with a sultry quality. “I’m feeling really giddy now. Real shivers down my spine. You are quite something, ms. defence attorney.”

“We’ve got you,” Adora said, “show yourself. Double Trouble.”

Obliging, the figure spread out an arm, and with a dramatic flourish wrought it around until —elbow high and hand low— they clutched the skin around the neck. Then they pulled. Soter Michael’s ‘face’ stretched and contorted, and with the snap of rubber, peeled off. There was no Soter Michael. It was as Adora said. Double Trouble at the stand, gleaming green with that sharp-toothed grin.

“Oh my,” said the Judge, again and again, “oh my, oh my, oh my. I’ve seen some theatrics before but this one takes the cake!”

“It takes the whole platter, darling,” said Double Trouble. “This has been the performance of a century. It took a while to find the best character of course, but I found it. The rough-riding rock’n’roll tough-as-nails biker with a soft spot for flowers.”

“Did you really think that was going to be the least suspicious?” asked Adora.

“Oh child,” Double Trouble clapped one hand into the other by the side of their head, radiating with a mocking smile, “the role was to

trick you into thinking I was dead. To give you a fleeting hope."

"What do you mean?"

"Obviously I didn't do this alone. Who arranged for a fake body? Who faked records and kept evidence under lock and key to keep the illusion up? Someone inside the prosecutor's office, clearly."

"I object," Edgeworth now said. He was still shaken by this sudden turn, gripping on the edge of his bench. "I object to that… objectionable statement. It's slander."

"Oh please," Double Trouble rolled their eyes, "no-one's going to suspect you, Edgey. We all know the role you play —the grumpy prosecutor with a heart of gold, the tortured antihero under the shadow of his unscrupulous mentor. No, I'm talking about a real bad girl."

"Witness," said the Judge with a new urgency, "if you're telling us you had an accomplice, you must tell us who this person is!"

"Not like it'll change much, but I'll tell you. It was… Catra. Ta-da. Anyone surprised?"

"No!" Adora exclaimed. "Or rather, yes. I am surprised. Because it's not true."

"Oh, would I lie?"

"Well, yes," said Edgeworth, "perjury doesn't even begin to explain what you've done."

Adora continued, "Catra is the least likely person who would organise this mess."

"And why's that?" asked Double Trouble, wearing a cool look.

"It doesn't help her. Why would she want to frame herself in this way?"

“Because it was the only way she could, obviously. She’s obsessed, you know. This was all about you.”

“Me?”

Adora wanted to refute Double Trouble on the spot. She wanted to say they had no idea what they were talking about. But the facts uncovered in yesterday’s proceedings were still on record. She couldn’t ignore them. *Adora, Adora, Adora,* they went in the journal entries. Catra had gone to meet Double Trouble with intent. A gun from the vault ended up there, even if it wasn’t used. A prosecutor had to be involved. If it wasn’t Catra, who could possibly fill that role?

And Double Trouble continued to explain, each word hitting Adora like a repeated stab to the chest, “Catra wanted a case that you would find irresistible. One you would go to every length to solve.” To Adora’s utter disgust, Double Trouble then stole her voice to say, “Catra was my childhood friend! I made a promise. I want to help her.” Seeing Adora’s reaction, they laughed, and then with their own voice said, “there was supposed to be a clear ‘true’ murderer. Soter Michael. I mean, I had this whole backstory you were supposed to uncover. It was true drama, betrayal, emotions, vengeance —motivation for him to kill me. I never expected you to sniff out the real truth.”

“Well sorry to disappoint you,” said Adora in a fiery huff.

“Disappointed? I’m loving every moment of this.”

“Oh yeah? Well forget what Edgeworth said about perjury, I’d be more worried about murder. You can transform your entire image. You killed Ma-Nan Jia back at the princess promenade, didn’t you. Then you disguised as him to confuse Chas Singer.”

Double Trouble’s face fell. Speaking acidly, they said, “I don’t to have to answer that, I think.”

“Ms. Adora,” the Judge protested, “that is in fact a different case, and I’m not sure it’s truly relevant here.”

“Exactly.”

Edgeworth however smiled, wagging his finger by his temple.

“Tsk tsk, I wouldn’t be so confident if I were you, witness. It may not be relevant to this trial, but that doesn’t mean it isn’t irrelevant to another trial.”

“What the hell are you talking about?”

“The courtroom next door, Chas Singer is having his appeal. With the facts we’ve learned today, and knowing that you as a witness in that original case are still alive, I’m sure that mr. Shields would be very interested in having you on the stand.”

Their face contorting as if tasting sour, Double Trouble watched Edgeworth with thinning pupils. But then they shut their eyes. Their ears flicked, and they when they looked again they reassumed that disinterested smile.

“English,” they said in Edgeworth’s voice, “although with the tiniest hint of German in the inflection.”

Resolutely unimpressed, the prosecutor continued, “perhaps you’d like to continue your impromptu testimony.”

Throwing a look to Adora, Double Trouble said, “Ma-Nan Jia was a foul man. He’d stiff you over and tear down your soul. I was always meant for more than just comedy routines. Even Chas Singer, with all his clout, was screwed over by him so many times but he’d always walk about with that so-so friendly air and try and make peace with everyone,” they made a gagging motion. “The man got what he deserved. Singer was the foolish fall guy. But Catra,” they gave a chuckle in a deep, evil tone, “she caught my eye in that trial. Ruthless, willing to bend the rules for her own aims. Now she gave me a dramatic performance.”

“And yet you’re still willing to sell her out now,” noted Adora.

“I’m sure she’d do the same for me. There’s no trusting people in this world. We all wear our masks, silly girl. But I’ve told you the truth now. This was a trap for you — because only you would defend Catra to the end, even though no matter what you did, you’d lose.”

“But I figured out your game! There wasn’t even a murder here.”

“And yet I’ve named her as an accomplice to forgery and hiding evidence. Is this much of a victory?”

“You’re wrong,” said Adora. “You’re still lying. I don’t believe Catra did any of this.”

Not quite yet over the shock of the discovery, Edgeworth felt an anxiety as he watched the witness and defence go back and forth. He stood weight towards one foot, and folded his arms. Then his attention was taken by Catra in the dock. Her expression was the most queer. Her eyes followed Adora to Double Trouble as they talked, and although there was a knit in her brow, her face was flat and unrevealing. But her eyes seemed sunken and hollow. Not just unspeaking, she was enmeshed in an aura of quiet.

Edgeworth rubbed his head with the base of his palm for a few seconds. Then he found the best course of action.

“Your honour,” he said, “the prosecution would like to request an end to this trial.”

“What?” said Adora, caught off-guard.

“I’ll admit I’ve pushed cases beyond reason in the past. Cases where it was clear that another and not the defendant was guilty, but I felt a certain duty to my profession to keep up the attack. Not here, though. I have never, nor will I ever, continue to prosecute a murder where there is no victim.”

“You make a good point,” said the Judge, raising his gavel, “and I agree. Further investigation is certainly needed. How these events came to pass will need a proper explanation. I expect the witness

to be detained until the prosecutor's office can decide what to do with them. But as to Catra's guilt, well, it's not even a question. I shall now pass a verdict."

A rush of energy flowed through Adora. She was lighter than air. Her face broke into smiles although she tried to restrain them. She shuffled her feet about, tapped the wood of the bench, even began to breathe heavy. Was this it? Had they won? She looked to Catra, and there she was; looking back at her. The girl was pale, on the precipice of sickness. But there was the smallest trace of a smile on her lips.

"HOLD IT!"

Adora's face drained. She looked around, madly. It wasn't Edgeworth. He looked just as surprised as anyone else. The person who had shouted was at the witness stand, but far shorter and shriller than Double Trouble. It was Glimmer.

"You can't stop the trial now," she was saying, "there's too much unexplained."

"But there is no victim," the Judge said again, in a smaller and unsteady voice. "We can't continue."

"Catra may not have killed Double Trouble, but she is a killer. And as a prosecutor she sees the law as beneath her. It was her who's been manipulating and hiding the evidence."

"Slow down. Who did she kill?"

"Defence Attorney Micah. Nine years ago."

"M-Micah?"

"Objection!" It was Edgeworth, now slamming the bench. "I will not sign onto this. Now that Catra has been cleared of murder, she remains my subordinate. I cannot allow this kind of reckless accusation against her."

“It isn’t reckless,” Glimmer said, giving the man a defiant stare. With rapid motion, she drew out a series of manila folders from her jacket, “I’ve uncovered evidence of a cover up that happened in that other trial. Similar to what we’ve seen today. The connective tissue between this trial is Catra. She’s the common denominator, so it’s in the court interest to hear what I have to say. You want to know why a body ended up in the Whispering Woods two days ago, this is the answer.”

“OBJECTION!” This time it was Adora. She restrained the pain in both face and tone as she said, “you can’t do this, Glimmer! That’s way too tenuous a link. Where’s the evidence that that other case is relevant to this one?”

Glimmer didn’t look at her. Instead she faced up to the Judge and posed her question:

“Your honour, do you recall what case the weapon was from? The weapon found at the Whispering Woods?”

“The case it was from? Ah yes, it was taken from the vault. As for the case, it was the… SP-0 incident.”

Taking from one of her folders, Glimmer produced a sheet. She read, “ *SP-0 incident. Date: 2/12/2011. Charge: homicide by shooting. Defendant: Rob Rees. Defence: Angella. Prosecution: Manfred Von Karma.* ” She took in a deep breath, and continued, “ *Victim: Micah. Witness: Catra.* The case is relevant, your honour. So please, let me present evidence. Let me show the court how Catra killed my father.”

Chapter End Notes

Hehehe it's getting spicy now.

Also happy almost Christmas. I was considering ramping up posting of chapters so the last one (which actually has some scenes set at Christmas) would be on Christmas day but I

thought not to risk the usual schedule so this will go a few weeks into 2022. But I'm really enjoying coming back to this project every week even though it's largely complete.

The next chapter is going to be a real doozy, so be prepared!

Turnabout Promise, part 2

Chapter Notes

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Now when Adora looked at her, Catra was turned away. Clamour persisted in the courtroom, even with the Judge's half-hearted attempts to subdue it. The trial would extend, and Glimmer was up on the stand ready to give her testimony. But Adora kept staring at Catra. She couldn't fathom the crashing waves and shifting tectonics of this damned trial anymore. Her head was growing faint, but where before she had felt light due to the brief moment the end of their journey was laid out before them, now she just ready to pass out. Catra looked worse.

"Would you really do this just to beat me?" Adora said in a whisper. She didn't even know if she wanted Catra to hear, but under this noise she clearly wouldn't. "Would you throw your whole life away just to destroy me?"

Bow glanced at her, though he knew better than to intrude on her out-loud thoughts. He just tore into his gloves' tips with his teeth. He was gave his anxious stares more to Glimmer than to Catra.

"Witness," said the Judge, and this called enough attention to settle down the crowd, "please give an overview of the SP-0 incident so we can begin."

Glimmer filled in the court on the facts. Micah, found dead in the kitchen at Brightmoon manor, on the same night a burglar had attempted to pilfer some valuables. The victim, a prosecutor himself, had been working on another case with a colleague. That's why the gun was there. According to the investigators, the burglar Rob Rees and the victim got into a fight, ending with the former shooting Micah with the gun.

“That’s the official story,” Glimmer said, “but yesterday I was able to get access to the vault. I believe that the prosecutor on the case, Von Karma, —who we now know to have engaged in forgery on many cases— was the one who hid key pieces of evidence. These pieces would have shown the true murderer to be Catra.”

“Objection,” Adora said, forcing her voice to rise It weakened nonetheless. “Von Karma tried to frame Mr. Edgeworth for murder, and he was his own ward! Why would he do any of this for Catra?”

“He had a close working relationship with high prosecutor Shadow Weaver,” Glimmer argued, “the adoptive mother of Catra at the time.”

“This is immaterial,” Edgeworth said, rustling at the mention of the old man. “What matters is the evidence itself. Let’s see it.”

Glimmer nodded, and produced the first piece for the court to view, “to start with: a medical document. The gun would have been difficult for a child to wield, though not impossible. If Catra had fired it, no doubt she would have dislocated her shoulder.”

“And did she?”

“Yes. That’s what this paper says.”

Sceptical, Adora demanded a copy. She and Bow quickly looked it over, and once again reliedon the forensic investigator’s ability to parse through the jargon. Adora remained doubtful until they reached the last page. It was an attached file, or rather an attached picture. It wiped away all doubt.

“What is it?” asked Catra, slightly irked. Adora and Bow were just staring at the picture, mesmerised. “Come on, show me!”

Bow picked it up, and beamed as he showed it. “Aw, you look so cute as a kid!”

“I—what!?”

It was Catra, in her short-sleeve shirt school uniform. She was smaller here, with a mane that seemed to dominate the whole body. And she just had the littlest grumpiest pout, having been forced into taking this picture. Her arm was in a cast —that was the relevant detail— but for now Adora and Bow were just fawning over the girl.

“Urgh, I’m not cute,” Catra was indignant.

“I mean, you kinda are,” Adora grinned.

“Damnit, I’m on trial here. Get your act together.”

Adora whirled back into focus –-although stole one last glance at the picture. Now with a fixed brow, she posed to the witness:

“Why couldn’t it have been Rob Rees? Why not just accept your father’s death was a senseless act of violence and try to heal?”

“What the hell sort of question is that?” Glimmer expression mixed shock and outrage.

“Well what sort of testimony is this? Why are you doing any of this? I need you by my side, Glimmer.”

“I’m not going to help you defend the girl who killed my dad!”

“Guys, guys,” Bow positioned himself as best as he could behind the bench, but in a way to stand between them. He frowned, “look we’re all trying to find the truth here.”

“Bow, you know more than anyone what this means to me,” Glimmer said in a demanding yet pleading voice, “do you really think I’m wrong?”

“I-I don’t know what to think. But Catra is our client.”

“Are you really going to believe her over me?” She looked to Adora, “are you going to choose her over my dad?”

“Glimmer you—,” Adora clasped her hands around the roots on her hair. “Why are you being difficult?”

“Why are you so stubborn,” Glimmer talked over her.

“We’re a team here,” Bow wailed. “We can’t get at each other’s throats.”

“Look,” Adora snapped, “I was there too, remember. I don’t know when Catra could have run off to kill someone. I just can’t imagine it. The girl I saw. That girl I knew….”

“You can’t trust your memory,” said Glimmer. As she did, she pulled out a new document and gleaned from it, “the court record specifies that Catra never mentioned you being there, at least not in the kitchen when she was hiding.”

With a bang of his gavel, the Judge put an end to the squabble. He said, “I say there is no point in further cross-examination of these facts. Especially… that style of cross-examination. It’s clear that the prosecutor’s office was tampering with the evidence. But I’m unsure that this is enough to show the defendant truly killed Micah.”

“Then we should call a witness,” said Glimmer. “Mr. Edgeworth, please call Angela to testify who she saw that night.”

“Very… very well,” said Edgeworth.

The man never let his arms fall from their folded position. He had watched the last few minutes with a uneasy look, yet he could find no strong grounds to object. For now, at least, it was the witness driving this case, not the prosecution.

Angella arrived at the stand within a short span of time. She hadn’t left since talking to Bow and Adora earlier the morning, instead taking to the gallery to watch. When her daughter had

burst in and thrown the trial in this new direction, she'd been more shocked than anyone. Now she had to dig up memories, old pains and shames both.

"Name and Occupation," said Edgeworth.

"Angella," she said, soft but clear. "Former attorney."

"Former because you were disbarred," he noted, "during the SP-0 incident itself, correct?"

"Correct. As Glimmer says, the truth was being perverted. I falsified evidence because I felt it was the only option left to me. I am ashamed nonetheless."

"I disapprove," Edgeworth said, a little stiff but managing some warmth, "but I understand. Please, tell the court what you saw."

But before Angella spoke, she turned. She gave Glimmer a querying look.

"Is this truly what you want?" Angella asked.

"I'm making it right," said her daughter. "No false evidence, only the truth. And whatever it is, we'll accept it."

Angella gave a deep, understanding nod, and then proceeded to her testimony. She said all that she did before. Coming to the manor, late at night. Her husband, dead. In the dark she saw the girl, small, lithe, a child, moving remarkably nimble. Giving chase into the cold shadowy greys of the outside garden, until the creature was lost. This last detail sprung Adora's own memory. When she found Catra alone and weary underneath the car.

"When did you start suspecting Catra?" Adora questioned, "and how? Surely you'd never met before."

"I knew Shadow Weaver's child had been over at the manor, when she and Micah were reviewing evidence. When I saw the girl on the witness list, it clicked. It had to be her."

“But… you didn’t actually recognise her then? It was dark, you weren’t able to.”

“It wouldn’t be hard to pick Catra out of a crowd,” Edgeworth noted.

“Exactly,” said Adora. “She’s the most distinctive person in the world! Look at her: her mane of hair, her freckles. Her ears. The colour of her eyes….” Adora’s voice fell away for a moment, before picking up, “If you had seen Catra, you wouldn’t have noticed how nimble she was or whatever compared to that.”

“That is a good point,” the Judge thought. “Although the first thing I noticed about prosecutor Catra the first time I met her was that horrible whip of hers!”

“It was dark, yes,” said Angella. “I didn’t see any real features.”

“Then it could have been anyone so long as they were small and nimble as you said,” argued Adora.

“No it couldn’t. It was a school-aged child. She was wearing a white jumper.”

“But you couldn’t—”

“Objection,” came in Edgeworth, “but I think you’ll find it’s perfectly possible.”

Adora pressed her hands onto the bench, “but she couldn’t see anything.”

“She couldn’t see Catra’s features —her ears and hair were dark enough to fade into darkness. White clothing however can usually capture enough residual light, visible enough except in the most extreme cases. There’s no contradiction here.”

Adora looked to the witness again; her own mentor on the stand for cross-examination. She took a hard swallow, but she couldn’t summon another question for a few torturous moments. Of course

Angella would be prepared for this. The event that had tormented her for years, and she was a lawyer, proofing out her own recollection to make sure there were no errors or mistakes. And Adora was supposed to pick her apart, make her doubt what she saw on the day her husband died?

And what if Adora were wrong, and she was twisting this old knife for nought?

"Angella…," Adora's thoughts were winding in two directions now, leaving her briefly mouth bereft of words. "Can… you at least tell me more about this jumper?"

"It was part of the school uniform. I remember it well, I used to buy those for Glimmer. White with blue collar and cuffs. Long baggy sleeves. And the only schoolgirl there was the girl Shadow Weaver brought over. It could only have been Catra."

Catra watched, in silence, in apprehension. But the strained look she wore was not towards Angella with her damning testimony, but held on Adora. The lawyer was engrossed in the testimony at this moment, and so didn't notice. But Catra stared, wishing she could read what was going on inside that girl's head.

When would she give up? Perhaps she would have been gratified to know Adora was on the percipice, facing her own mentor, both unable and unwilling to tear this testimony down. Had she known that, Catra might have calmed, it might have soothed her restless soul. But then the great irony would be that a lifeline had just revealed itself. The smallest little detail had become clear to the attorney:

"Wait, did you say long sleeves?" asked Adora.

"Yes," said Angella, a little confused, "yes, all those uniforms had long sleeves."

"Well, they didn't," Adora noted, fiddling with the lobe of her ear as she remarked this, "there was an option. You know I used to wear that uniform too, so I actually remember this. In fact," a

light picked up in Adora's eyes. "In fact, in fact, in fact, why doesn't the court draw its attention to this piece of evidence."

"What piece of evidence?" asked the Judge, peering over.

But Adora had already picked up the picture from earlier. She displayed it for all. Catra was in her uniform when it was taken, and though one arm was completely white covered by sleeve and then cast, it was clear that the shirt itself came short.

"Hmm," said Edgeworth, "perhaps the witness misremembered."

"It was the worst night of my life," Angella said darkly, "I remember every detail exactly. It was definitely a long-sleeved jumper."

The Judge took to pondering, "if the premise is that Catra was the only one who was there, and she fits the description, then that seems a strong case. Is the length of the shirt really that consequential?"

"It isn't."

Adora turned with a gasp. It had been a voice not uttered for a while now. It was Catra. She was now standing up from the dock.

"Your honour, please let me testify," she said. "It's time… to tell the truth."

"Catra, no!"

"Don't stop me, Adora!" Catra shot her a forbidding look, the terseness in her face not enough to hide the disquiet in her eyes. "This has gone on long enough."

"Very well," said the Judge, "I shall permit you to take the stand, defendant."

Catra went up. Angella watched with uneasy look, even as she stepped away to stand by where Glimmer herself had waited. Now

all eyes were on the girl with her uneven mane and tired look. She just stood straight in pose, though her gaze fell onto the floor.

"The court has now seen the evidence that was hidden. You heard a direct witness. Yes," she said, "I killed Micah nine years ago."

No words had ever wounded Adora so. Even when Catra said the same the day before, it had still seemed so surreal. Now it was here, in this sacred place, before all these people, they had such a power as to feel true. She could barely stand. She held her hand firm on the bench to support her weight but there was an ever-present urge to fall, fall not just to the floor but further, into whatever dark abyss would take her. Bow could see her trembling. He leaned over with a hand on her shoulder to see her okay. Even Glimmer felt a pang of guilt, even though Catra's words should have vindicated her.

The defendant continued, "While I usually wore short-sleeves, I didn't that day. It was cold, I guess. Adora just remembers it wrong because she was so used to me not wearing them. I hid in the kitchen cabinet before Micah came into the room. He had the evidence bag, with the gun. I jumped in. I attacked. I scratched him before jumping back and grabbing the gun. It's all as Angella says. And sparkle—uh, Glimmer, she was right too. By firing the gun I broke my hand. Then when Angella showed, I ran."

And now Adora could do nothing but watch. She watched Catra seal her own fate, confirm her own guilt, and time seemed to stretched to minutes, to hours as she just watched. Why was she doing this? Was this still the game —was this her plan all along, to destroy Adora? Or was this to save her?

Which Catra was more likely?

"I promise…." Adora said, the faintest of a hush.

She had to trust her. Catra was her client. Catra was her friend. She had to trust Catra, even if she didn't trust herself.

“Your honour,” she said, louder now, in a flat albeit steady voice, “I request to cross-examine this confession. The statements of the defendant do not change the position of the defence. That broadly right, Glimmer?”

“That… that’s technically true,” Glimmer admitted.

“You can try pick apart what I’ve said,” said Catra, “but don’t be disappointed with what you find.”

Adora pressed. She stopped Catra on almost every word, trying to find something that could help her. But there was no way to dispute that she hadn’t worn her usual short-sleeves that day. Just Adora’s own hazy memory. Everything else seem to fit the evidence so far.

“You were hiding in this cabinet?” Adora repeated.

“Yes.”

“And when you were a witness in the SP-0 incident, you said you were there the whole time as you saw the crime.”

“I lied,” said Catra, “Angella proved it. There’s a picture —should be in Glimmer’s folders over there— that shows the pool of blood was undisturbed. No foot tracks.”

“But in that case, maybe you left before Micah died altogether? You could have given him that scratch by accident and ran away—”

“And then Angella saw me back at the kitchen. Adora, why would I leave and then return? No, I killed him and then Angella found me.”

Adora gnashed her teeth but wouldn’t let herself be swayed. She turned to Glimmer now and asked:

“Can we see the court record from the SP-0 incident? There must have been other evidence including that photograph.”

Glimmer walked over with stiff step. But as she placed the folders on the bench, she shot a look directly into Adora's eyes.

"Why are you still trying? You're hearing this from Catra's own mouth and you still believe her innocence?"

"We can't stop!" Adora protested, her voice carrying enough for the whole court to overhear. "It doesn't make sense."

"Why not?"

"Catra was only a child. Why would she want to kill someone?"

"Because that's what she is…."

It hadn't been Glimmer. Angella had said this, back over by the side of the witness stand where she lingered. Her expression was rent, exhausted to the point of stillness. Her eyes fell to a corner, not looking at anything in particular. Yet she spoke with a clarity that all heard.

"At least, that was my reasoning," she continued. "Trying to rationalise everything that happened. I was so certain that Catra must have been the killer, I ignored anything that didn't fit. When I saw what Catra became, the demoness prosecutor willing to do whatever necessary to win, I thought I was proven right…."

"Mom?" Glimmer said with a tentative look.

Angella looked over, first at Glimmer with mournful ruin. Then she looked to Adora.

"You said you were taking this to the end no matter what. Do you truly believe in your client's innocence?"

"Yes," said Adora.

"Then you should look at every gap and every contradiction possible and keep on going until it all makes sense. And should you lose her… then it's better to lose having tried all you could."

Eyes glowing the light, and quivering with an awe, Adora had to wrench her sight away. Yet if she could radiate gratitude, it would burst from her towards her mentor. Now she looked down. Bow was already spreading out the court record from SP-0 but right in front of her was the first picture. Catra, so young, just a child. And a cast all along her arm. Strange thing for just a broken hand.

She blinked. That thought didn't make sense.

"Bow, did you look over the medical record?" she asked.

"The one for Catra? Yeah it seemed in order. Dislocated her shoulder after firing the weapon as she said."

"But she said… wait she said— HOLD IT!" She suddenly shouted for the court. Then she turned to the witness. "Catra, can you repeat what you said about your injury? The one you sustained after firing the gun?"

"Yeah, I sprained my hand," she said.

"No you didn't."

Catra buried her brow, "what do you mean 'no you didn't?' It was my injury."

"Well, you weren't supposed to sprain your hand. Logically, speaking of course. You were just a child and you supposedly fired a gun, and, you know, that's what this record is telling me. But you're telling me something different."

"I did fire that gun. I remember—"

"But you said you sprained your hand, when you should have dislocated your shoulder."

"But I— oh." Realisation spread across Catra's face. She rubbed the back of her neck, "yeah… maybe I made a mistake. I dislocated my shoulder, that's right."

“No,” said Adora, “I don’t believe you got it wrong. Because you did sprain you hand, didn’t you. I was chasing you up a tree. I thought I got it bad, falling down on my back, but you were quick in your landing too. You sprained your hand landing from the treetops. I remember now, you refused to wear a cast for a few days because… well, because you’re Catra. But that injury was already there!”

“I, nrghh!” Catra stepped back as if slapped. By instinct she reached up her hands grabbing into her hair, and her claws dug in deep.

“But what about that record?” said the Judge, “surely that’s the more trustworthy evidence; not her memory? Why does it say otherwise if she’s telling the truth?”

“It has to say that,” argued Adora, “because it’s faked. Someone has been twisting the truth of this case from the beginning. That’s why we’re here. I’m betting it’s the same one pulling the strings behind the Double Trouble case. Maybe Catra wasn’t meant to take the fall — that was Rob Rees’s role, but she was next layer of defence. In other words —we’re still in the mastermind’s trap!”

Mutters flurried around the gallery, although the Judge was able to call for order. Edgeworth had his arms folded, albeit with less impatience and more contemplation.

“That’s plausible,” he granted, “if Von Karma was involved I can see how it was faked. Yet there is no direct proof to say for certain. And we can contend with a new fact as well —if it wasn’t Catra who killed the victim… wasn’t her who Angella saw, then who killed Micah?”

“It was me,” Catra insisted, slamming both hands on the stand, “I don’t know what this crazy girl is talking about. I shot Micah, I dislocated my shoulder!” She looked up to the Judge. “Please, you have to hand the verdict down now!”

The Judge shook his head with a solemn aura, “I cannot do that. There are still questions let unanswered.”

Then she turned to Adora and begged, “please, don’t continue. You have to stop now or there will be consequences.”

“I’m sorry,” said Adora, “but I told you already. I’m seeing this to the end.”

Catra was restive now. She alternated between hands clinging at her hair, and wrapping her cape around tight as she clutched at her chest. She burned. Knowing she was being seen, she tried to stifle her fidgets and her agitating mouthing, but her body betrayed her. Her eyes cried out, desperate as they looked from Adora to the Judge to Edgeworth, yet none could give her what she wanted. Adora needed to move quickly. She needed to get Catra a not guilty soon before she entirely broke down.

“We need to keep going,” she said.

“But how?” asked Glimmer. “Catra’s already confessed and the evidence still points to her. We have these inconsistencies but what do we do with them? Have her testify again?”

“No,” said Adora, “not all the evidence!”

“What do you mean?”

“There was that one piece of evidence remember. It’s in the court record. Wait no you wouldn’t have seen it, it’s been blacked out.”

“What are you talking about?” Glimmer said growing wary.

“You should remember it though, because it was the one piece of evidence Angella couldn’t find. It was the piece of evidence she had to make up.” Adora pointed out her finger and said, ”the keratin traces!”

Glimmer shied for a second, taking paces back. But she protested, “but she had to forge it! The real evidence was being hidden.”

“But that’s not the point,” said Adora. “There’s a better question here that we need to ask… where is the real keratin?”

“I… what?” Then Glimmer’s eyes widened as everything became clear in her mind. “Oh….”

“I’m not following,” said the Judge.

“It’s simple,” Bow said, “if the keratin were real but it was hidden by Von Karma, why didn’t Glimmer find it in the vault?”

“Uh, well, hmm.” The Judge screwed up his face, beard ruffling, yet finding no answer just said, “ah….”

“But this doesn’t make any sense,” said Edgeworth, “if Catra didn’t give Micah that scar… then who did? The SP-0 incident decided that it was Rob Rees in the end, having used a fork, I believe.”

“That’s impossible,” said Angella. “I said it back then, the cutlery was in the wash, Micah was using chopsticks for dinner that night. Where would someone get the fork?”

“None?” Adora pulled her cheek, “are you sure? If the person who used the fork fought with Micah, they were the killer, right? So… maybe there was a fork someone took with them but was never found again?”

“Well,” Angella threw her hands out by her sides, “I never counted them if that’s what you’re asking. But everyone was checked, including both Rob Rees and Catra. Nothing was ever found. Who could have taken it? It would have to have been someone the investigation didn’t consider.”

Adora breathed. Time was coming to halt all around her. The world was quiet, though her thoughts screamed. It couldn’t be. How could it be possible — she would have known all this time. Did she forget? Did she not allow herself to remember because it was too terrible? But the feeling of metal was clear in her hand. That she had been running too was there as well. Memories came

in fragments, but it was all consistent. But it couldn't be true — could it?

She opened her mouth. She had to speak. She couldn't. It would be throwing away everything, not just her badge, but her life, he freedom, everything; even Bow and Glimmer. She'd never be able to look Glimmer in the eye if she knew….

And yet there was Catra. If she didn't see this to the end, it would be Catra. Adora rolled her shoulders back and breathed easy, as it all came to lock into place in her head. This was how it was meant to go. She knew now. Catra would tear Adora down, but Adora could send Catra up. And that made it worth it.

Hauling up her arm, Adora breathed again. It was about to spring to a point and objection was already on her tongue, when the sight of Catra gave her pause. She was staring at her. Her eyes quivered. She knew. Of course Catra knew. She was always smarter than Adora. Often she had been able to grasp things before her: see things, figure them out first. She hadn't known at the beginning of the trial. But she knew now, as it all held in her small gaze, gripped with terror. It would leave Adora wondering. Was it the split-second before, or had Catra figured it out way back now?

Either way, she already knew.

"Adora," she said, a strained whisper. "Please… you can't."

"I have to," was all Adora said before she did. She shouted out, "OBJECTION!" and sent her finger straight into the air. "We have been going forward based on a misinterpretation of the facts. A basic contradiction. Once we resolve it, we can say who the true criminal was."

How she was able to speak in that confident projected voice defied even her. Inside Adora's very being was crushed. What happened next would hurt, but she had to see it through now.

“Defence, you must explain,” said the Judge, “who is this criminal?”

“This person has been under your nose the entire time, and so close that even I wasn’t able to see her. That fork was at the crime scene, you see. This person used it to scratch Micah in an altercation and then took it with her. A small nimble person in a long-sleeved shirt and who was deliberately ignored by the investigation. This person shot Micah. I don’t know how or why, but all the evidence lines up. The killer of Micah—”

Slowly, with a wrenching effort but it came, she bent her elbow. Her forearm curled back, and her finger turned around.

“… Is the defence attorney Adora!”

Uproar. Pandemonium. Complete shock and awe descended upon the courtroom, such that the internal screaming of Adora’s head and twisting of her chest was drowned out by the noise. The gallery was shaken. The Judge was flabbergasted. Edgeworth slipped and only caught himself by doubling over onto the bench, with hollow sunken eyes looking forward.

“No,” Glimmer was oddly quiet. She was certain she misheard, “what? That doesn’t… that doesn’t make any sense.”

“It’s the only thing to make sense,” Adora continued, loud and propelled by the forward momentum, “we’ve been going on the assumption that Shadow Weaver brought only one of her adopted daughters to Brightmoon manor. Apart from making no sense that she would do that, I remember being there. I was playing with Catra. I stole a fork and forgot to leave it there. And it wasn’t Catra wearing the long-sleeved shirt. She never wore them! That was me!”

“Th-that’s a lie,” Catra protested, tearing her claws into the wood face of the stand, “you’re just being a dumb… stupid idiot trying to save… Goddamn it, Adora, stop doing this!”

“Face it, Catra. There were two of us who could have fit Angella’s description. There was no keratin found in the victim’s body, but I can remember having a fork that day and I was the only one the investigation didn’t check. The logic is clear:”

“No…”

“The real murderer…”

“No!”

“Is me!”

Catra screamed. A high, breaking wail. Starting as ‘no’, but devolving into a mess of sound. She clutched the side of her head. She dug in with her claws, grasping again and again. Lurching over, her face hid under her hair which she grabbed at continuously, sharp claws ripping and tearing. The scream unending, her head became a dust-cloud of loose hairs and fast-moving hands, until finally, she threw herself back up. She outstretched her hands either side. There was a sharp ching.

Then whole clumps of her hair fell about at once. With a poof, her mane was gone, leaving behind a short sprout of uneven hair. Tears were streaming down her face, and exhaustion at long last took her. She fell.

In place of the last lingering echoes of Catra’s outburst, silence filled the courtroom. After all the bewilderment, none could bring themselves to speak next. Except one.

“Oh I warned you,” said the voice, “I warned you this would happen.”

Adora turned to look. It was Shadow Weaver, waltzing in, fingers pressed together by her front. She was giving a rueful shake of her head.

“H-high prosecutor Shadow Weaver?” the Judge said, “when did you get here?”

“I’ve been keeping an eye,” she explained, “as some have already explained, the defence and defendant are both my wards.”

“What did you mean?” asked Adora. “You warned this would happen?”

“This is how Catra destroys you. This has always been how. Not through conscious effort, not through blind hate or even her efforts to take you down. No. It’s because you are too kind to her. It was just as true back then.” She glanced over at Catra collapsed on the floor against the stand. “She has always been like this. Destructive, even to herself. It was for the best that she was taken away from you. So you would become what you needed to be.”

“Did you know about this?” Adora asked in a heavy hush, “about… about me being—”

“Of course not,” Shadow Weaver pressed her spindly hand against her own chest, and with a horrified voice said, “I don’t even belief this nonsense. But she does this to you. You were never meant to be caught up in this, and I have been proven right in my decision to keep you shielded from the case. But she brought you back in.”

The Judge was staring out. He blinked, but could not break his vacant stare. Not knowing what else to do, he just said, “this is unprecedented. A defence attorney indicting… themselves? Mr. Edgeworth, how does the prosecution wish to proceed?”

Standing up straight again, Edgeworth streamed his hand down his face, only to reveal a tense expression.

“If the defence wishes to confess,” he said, “then I’d like to hear what she has to say first before she gives testimony.”

“Very well. We all need to recuperate after… that. I shall call for a short recess.”

He banged his gavel. People streamed out of the court. When they’d return, they’d see this trial come to its end.

Turnabout Promise, part 3

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"What is happening?"

"I don't know!"

"Oh god what did I do? What did I do?"

"What did *you* do? I just let her go on with it!"

Bow and Glimmer's reunion in the defence lobby was a lot of pacing about, talking over one another and mutual excess of trepidation. Finally it came to them meeting in the middle as Glimmer cried:

"She didn't do it! I can't believe it."

"Glimmer, Glimmer," Bow said, holding on her arms and leaning down, "you've got to calm down. Panicking isn't going to help anyone. Look into my eyes, are you okay?"

"I'm feeling terrible!" she moaned, before taking in a deep breath and adding, "but okay, I'm calm. I'm calm."

"Right," said Bow. "Okay. Okay. Aah. Aaaagh. AAAAGGH!"

He held onto the sides of his head with his knuckles, hunched over the floor and vented out all the dread in one large howl.

"Bow!"

Glimmer took him by the shoulders and propped him up straight, although he wobbled and continued to hyperventilate. She threw her arms around him and softened:

“You’ve got to stay calm, alright. Oh god, I’m sorry. I’m so sorry this is my fault.”

“We’ve gotta move forward,” he managed to say, “but… aaah.”

The door opened again, and both threw a look its way, hoping. But it was Catra who entered. She was barely able to stand, and wouldn’t have made it if it were for Detective Scorpia helping her up.

“I thought you were mad at me?” still weary from passing out, Catra struggled to look up at the big girl.

“I am,” Scorpia admitted, “but I told ya. I’m loyal. And things aren’t over yet.”

Looking now to Bow and Glimmer, Catra asked, “where’s… where is she?”

“Being questioned by Edgeworth,” said Bow. “That… confession has thrown him off as much as everyone else. Did you know about this?”

“I do remember Adora being at the manor. But I only realised what was going on a few minutes ago.”

Glimmer stepped forward suddenly. Holding back from rending Catra’s neck, instead she said, “how dare you. Adora would never murder anyone.”

“You think I don’t know that?” Catra said in a cry, “but the evidence is there. Of course she had to do the stupid thing and throw her own life on the line just to save me. Why is she like this?!”

“She did it for you,” said Bow.

“But why? I’m not worth any of this.”

She wrested herself free of Scorpia's arm, only to there collapse on the floor again. In the polished tiles she could see her own face, though imbued with a golden glow under the way the light scattered. She tapped her head. Her hair was shortened now. But in her face she saw herself, quiet, tired and wrought with guilt. She stroked the tile where her cheek showed in the reflection.

"But I didn't make that scratch," she muttered, "and I wasn't wearing the long-sleeved shirt. I didn't dislocate my shoulder either. Then… then maybe I didn't do it? But I remember it though. I fired a gun."

"Maybe it wasn't at Micah then," said Bow.

"I didn't kill Double Trouble either," Catra recalled. "Heh, that was what this trial was about an age ago…. But I didn't do it. Adora showed that I didn't do it."

The reflection showed a girl. Not a murderer. Just Catra.

"Adora was… right about me."

Scorpia crouched down, and offered a pincer to help Catra up again.

"Hey, I believed in you too, wildcat," said Scorpia.

Catra let out a weak chuckle, "you didn't, didn't you." Taking the arm, she let herself be raised, and then reached out a hand to brush Scorpia's cheek. "Thanks, detective. And I don't suppose you can help a jerk like me again. But there's a lot of fake documents about, two of them medical. If we could figure out what's going on there… but there's not much time."

"It's a tall order, sir, but I can do it. And I got friends who can help me. Sea Hawk and Perfuma still want to help." Scorpia grinned, "super pal investigation is back on!"

Once she was certain Catra could stand, Scorpia gave one final salute, and then headed off.

Shortly after, the bailiffs came in, and there she was in tow: Adora. Glimmer as much as ran up to her.

“Adora, I’m—”

“I’m sorry, Glimmer. I don’t know why I did it, and I understand if you hate me now.”

“Wh-what?”

Adora blinked. “For you know? K-killing your dad.”

“Adora, you didn’t do that!”

The girl looked away, “I guess it’s still hard to believe.”

“Hard to believe, it’s ridiculous,” said Bow, fixing his Brow, “there’s so much foul play here I bet you were framed!”

“… Catra?”

They all looked to her, who stood there, with her cape fully wrapped around. She seemed so unbalanced without her full mane, as her head was dwarfed by the high collar. Regarding Adora back, she wore an expression both tensed and forlorn.

“Why,” she said, “why did you do that?”

“Because it was the right thing to—”

“Oh shut up,” she snapped, voice cracking. “You’re like a car crash. I hate to look at you and yet I can’t… just can’t turn away.”

Adora stepped forward, coming up to her. She wore a half-smile. Simple, and nothing like the concoction of feelings burning through her chest.

“It’s up to you now, Catra,” she said.

“What is?”

“You can retain the right to self-defence.”

“No,” Catra cringed, “nononono, I am not going to try and prove you did it.”

“Catra please. You didn’t kill anyone.”

“Neither did you!”

She had grabbed Adora by both wrists as she said this. They were so close they could feel each other’s breath on their face. The same thought brushed over both of them. But there was no time for that. Catra let go, but slowly, and as she did, Adora watched her face. Up close, she could bask in it. Tears were formed in multicoloured eyes, prompting Adora to reached deep into her pocket.

“Here,” she said. It was the handkerchief.

Catra’s eye tracked it, and without much thought reached out. But her eyebrow tilted and she looked back up puzzled.

“What…?”

“I dunno, just take it.”

Catra looked down again. There was something stitched into the fabric.

“What’s *LS* ?”

“I really don’t know,” Adora huffed, “Shadow Weaver gave this to me, I guess.”

“Well,” Catra squirmed, but couldn’t think of anything but to say, “thank you—”

“Defendant, times up.”

Both girls looked to see the bailiff who had spoken. The recess was over, and despite the man’s error, it was Adora’s time to go

back in.

She sighed out, “look, it’s up to you, as I said. I… I don’t know what you should do, but I’m going rely on you to do it. To make the right choice. It’s all in your capable hands now, partner.”

“You trust me?”

To that, Adora did not say anything. Instead she reached over with the other hand, and slid the long golden bracelet off her wrist. She nested it between Catra’s own grip, and their hands gladly glided against one another. Looking up and straight now at Adora, Catra’s eyes caught the light dancing in them. Adora smiled.

“You’ll be needing it more than me.”

With that, she broke away. Her hands parted from Catra’s, now holding the vambrace, though a need to reach out and snatch them again shot through the cat’s nimble fingers. Yet she did not. Instead she just watched as Adora followed the bailiffs back in. The three remained.

“What are you going to do now?” asked Bow.

“There’s still a cross-examination,” Catra said, “it’ll be my only chance to save—” the word caught in her mouth, and weaker now she said, “for me to save her.” She threw a glance to the other two, though faced away as she muttered, “and I could use the help, i-if you’d be okay to….”

“We’re with you,” said Glimmer. “Wow, never thought this day would come.”

Catra gave a pained chuckle. Then she looked down to the gold in her hand.

“So uh… how do I use this thing?”

“Just say the words Adora always does.”

“Right, of course.” Catra sighed, as she held up the thing in her hands and regarded it with a look of both suspicion and embarrassment. But she had no pride left anyway. So she threw away care and said, loudly, “for the honour of Grayskull!”

Holding outstretched and cringing her head as if the object were about to explode, she didn’t see what happened. Instead a beam of golden light shone her face, visible even to her closed eyes. Then, with caution, she peeked them open again. A long, shimmering, golden whip was laid spread across her hands. Her eyes grew wide.

“Oh!” she uttered, blank. Then a spreading grin gripped her face, “cool!”

Court returned to session, and it was a most unfathomable sight. A prosecutor —the defendant no less— stood at the defence bench, while the defence was in the dock. It was enough to draw sustained murmurs from everyone else. The Judge, thankfully, was the same and, as he was, he banged his gavel for silence. Edgeworth too was where he should be. He was looking over at the ‘defence’.

“I hope when this is over, you can return to the prosecutor’s office,” he said. “Assuming we have completely exonerated you.”

“You think I’m innocent?” said Catra, wary.

“I should have believed it from the beginning,” he admitted. “You know, I see a lot myself in you. I think you have what it takes follow a prosecutor’s path.”

“Heh,” she chuckled and gestured to her new table, “yet here I am.”

“You wouldn’t be the first forced to take that place to help a friend. You know what you must do. Are you ready?”

“Wait, just one thing.”

Catra clasped at the hook between the two halves of her collar, and with a small rustle, it was undone. With a single swinging motion, she cast off the cape. It thrust into the open, catching the air with its wide surface so it made a smooth glide to the ground. Now Catra held ready her new whip in both hands.

“Looked unbalanced with my new haircut,” she said, “now I’m ready.”

“Then I call Adora to the stand,” said Edgeworth. “To give her ‘confession.’”

The girl stood, straight, arms down. Light blue eyes held straight ahead, and her face was flat. Inside she rumbled uneasily, but keeping her breathing steady, kept every other emotion in check. She was ready.

“Name and occupation?”

“Adora,” she said. “I’m a defence attorney.”

She told them everything that now formed in her memory. Playing with Catra in the manor of course, but now more was coming clear. She had found Catra’s hiding spot in the kitchen, but she walked in to see something that filled her with terror. A dark figure reached up, gripping Catra by the arm and ripping her from the cabinet. They threw her to ground, first crashing onto an arm, and head impacting the floor.

Catra gaped as she heard this.

“I don’t even remember this,” she said. “Though… I remember the pain in my arm. Was it my sprained wrist?”

“I think it was that arm,” said Adora.

“And if I hit my head, maybe that’s why everything still so fuzzy for me.”

“What happened next?” Edgeworth enquired.

“I was scared,” Adora continued. “Catra was in danger so I jumped in. Standing between her and the figure. I don’t… I don’t remember shooting Micah exactly, but I was there. I had the fork and I scratched him. Catra was on the floor, she was in pain. It had to be me.”

“So you killed him to protect your friend?” asked the Judge.

Though her hands were curled and fixed to the bench, Catra could not keep them shaking.

“Why… why do you always have to be the hero?”

But Catra wasn’t heard. Glimmer now leaned forward and made loud protest:

“This isn’t right! Dad would never hurt anyone, let alone a kid!”

Edgeworth folded his arms, though wore an uneasy look as he said, “I wouldn’t be so certain. Between the power cut and the home invasion by Rees, things might have been enough to set him on edge. It would have been the same for anyone. Enough to lead this tragic misunderstanding.” He now looked to Adora. “But this testimony is much too vague to stand so far. Keep going.”

Adora pressed her palm to her forehead. She was trying to draw more memories, hazy that they were, to the fore, but it was met by a convulsion in her chest.

“I… saw Micah’s dead body,” she forced herself to say each word. “It was then Angella showed up. I ran. She tried to follow me but I was quick and circled back through the bushes, giving her the slip.”

“She was an adult and you escaped from her?”

“I’m quick. Was back then too. After that I found Catra under the car. I comforted her then we went home.”

“Now are you certain that it could have only been you?” Edgeworth further probed. “Perhaps you gave him the cut, but Catra fired the gun.”

“No,” Adora quickly said. “I was with Catra the whole time, I would have seen, I’m sure.”

Catra’s ears perked up, and she cut in, “not the whole time.” Even as Adora looked to her, anxious in her gaze, she continued, “the witness just said she found me after running from Angella.”

“Perhaps you left during the struggle?” suggested Edgeworth.

Adora shook her head, “we left together, I’m certain.”

“Well then we have a contradiction,” said Catra with a smile. A tingle was creeping up along her back. So this is what it felt like. “And there’s only one explanation. Adora went to the kitchen twice.”

“Twice?” asked the Judge. “Explain?”

“It’s simple,” said Catra. “The fight happened, and we fled together. But Adora doubled back on her own.”

“But why would she do that?”

“We were kids who’d just found ourselves in a bad situation with an adult. Perhaps we felt a need to check everything was okay. Adora was simply the one to brave it.”

“Interesting,” the Judge gave a stroke of his beard, although by the time his fingers reached the tip, gave pause. He looked to Catra again and asked, “But uh, what does this mean?”

Catra blinked. A nonchalant response was reflexively on the tip of her tongue, but thinking it through she found she couldn’t really say it. People were expectant, looking at her for the answer. She found her neck growing hot under the ruffles —it was a new feeling for her.

“Oh. I guess it doesn’t really mean much.” She let out a groan, “damnit! Isn’t finding a contradiction what *she* does?”

“Don’t give up now,” said Glimmer, “the more of the truth we get the better.”

“Okay, Sparkles, so what do we do now?”

“Ask Adora about the thing she remembers the most clearly. Ask about the scratch and the fork.”

“Right.” She said, looking back up at Adora. “Witness, or defence or— whatever. Look, did you see the scratch on the victim’s body when you came back?”

“I came back… and before I met Angella?”

“Yeah, that.”

“It was dark,” said Adora, stretching out the words as she recalled, “but I don’t think I did. Maybe I was spooked and then lashed out? Sometimes I’ll just start fighting things when I get startled. Still do that these days too.”

“Yeah, that sounds like you,” Catra muttered. “Okay, what happened to the fork?”

“Well I must have taken it home right.”

“Forget what must have happened, just tell me what you remember.”

“Okay… it was in my hand. And then… it was snatched from me. But that was during the fight. I must have gotten it back if I scratched him later—”

“I said forget about—— nrgh.”

The blonde was still effortlessly getting on her nerves. But she couldn’t deny there was a charm to her steadfast determination to

incriminate herself. The earnestness of a idiot. She shook her head. If Adora were an idiot, that'd make Catra something much worse. In Adora's place at this bench she was out of her depth. If she could take just a fraction of that girl's inexplicable knack to turn a hopeless situation around —perhaps she needed to think like her. What would she do with this testimony? How could Catra even go about figuring that out?

Then it struck her. Adora had already dealt with this before. An inconvenient scratch that incriminated her client. And she asked a most innocuous question, and it changed everything.

"Do you," Catra began, hesitant as ventured her question, "remember which side of the face you made the scratch?"

"Yeah," said Adora. "I attacked the left side, so from his perspective his right eye."

"So that's how you do it…."

"Do what?"

"Nevermind." Catra struck the bench with her whip, causing Bow and Glimmer to flinch in opposite directions. "Oh, sorry. Anyway, I have an objection!"

"Really?" the Judge said with a ponderous voice, "but I don't see anything wrong with what the witness, or uh, defence —what does protocol suggest we call her here? Anyway, what's wrong with her testimony?"

Catra reached over to Glimmer's manila folders, which were still on the defence's bench. She withdrew one of the documents.

"Your honour, Angella provided the court a picture during the trial for the SP-0 incident. It showed the crime scene exactly as she found it after she chased Adora away. You can actually see Micah's body on the ground here. And which side the scratch is on."

The Judge peered over. There didn't seem to be much going on in his dulled eyes. But then they widened. "Ah. Aaaaah! I see. This is exactly like yesterday, isn't it? When we had the two Catra's and the scratched side didn't match what was found."

"I scratched Double Trouble," said Catra, "but the body we found was a fake, remember. The whole point there was that the culprit's got confused. Well they got confused back then as well. The scratch is on Micah's left eye!"

"What?" Adora exclaimed. "But how?"

"Perhaps she missed," said Edgeworth. "Let's say she fought the victim during their first encounter, and thought she made a strike. She found his dead body later on, and as she was said, was startled. This time she made the real strike."

"But that doesn't feel right either," Adora pressed her hands into the side of her head. "I remember a person yelling in pain. I made my scratch and they were stunned, yowling out. That was a window for us. I grabbed Catra's wrist and pulled her away so we could escape. But before that… before that," her arms fell, as a shadow, containing a tapestry of realisation, fear and dread came over her face, "before that I heard a sound."

"What sound?" asked Edgeworth.

"Click," Adora was quiet, but all still heard. "It was a clicking sound. The sound of a gun. That's when I shot him."

Quiet sunk in the room. With nothing else, Adora's last word hung on every mind. Her testimony, clearer than anything else that had come before. Concrete admission of guilt.

Catra wanted to shout. To strike Adora with her whip until she stopped this nonsense. She wanted to shout at her as she had back in the detention centre. With cries and despair, the two of them alone, not burdened by the eyes of court or the space between stand and defence bench. But instead all she could do was watch.

“Hmph,” breaking the silence, Edgeworth said, “that doesn’t seem at all likely.”

“What do you mean?” asked the Judge.

“The witness had a weapon –-the fork—- wounded the assailant and stunned them. There was enough time to make an escape, and Catra was no longer in any immediate danger. Why would Adora choose to seek a new weapon to further incapacitate the assailant?”

“I saw something,” said Adora, “it made me panic.”

“And that was?”

“A gun,” Adora’s eyes quivered as if she were seeing it right now in front of her, “a gun in Micah’s hand.”

The Judge wore an expression, deep and grave, and said, “a terrible thing. Shameful to befall a child. It was self-defence, but terrible all the same.”

But Edgeworth shook his head, and a smug smile he held enough to make the Judge falter in his solemn words. Yet he didn’t elaborate, instead looking to Catra and saying:

“I leave the rest to you.”

“What?”

“The job of every lawyer is to see the truth. Logic is your keenest friend. Simply remove that which is impossible. The truth will remain.”

Catra gave a nod of understanding. “Right,” she said.

“What are you talking about?” Adora asked, although Catra simply pressed on:

“Adora, you do realise that there was only one gun at the manor that night? It would be impossible for you to have the gun, and for them to have it too.”

“But then,” Adora’s brow fell, “how did I…?”

“The mirror,” Catra decided, “you were facing the mirror.”

“What mirror is this?” said the Judge, “I don’t remember a mirror.”

“In the photograph,” Glimmer pointed out, “dad’s body is by the mirror in the kitchen.”

Adora looked even more confused now, “I don’t remember there being….”

Emerging quite from nowhere, Angella walked forward into view. Returning to where she had been lingering before by the stand, she explained:

“I removed it. You haven’t seen the mirror in the kitchen since because I tore it down. Seeing that room once over every day was bad enough. Seeing it from every angle was just torture.”

“So,” Catra continued, “it was dark, but the gun caught in the mirror’s reflection. That’s what you saw, and it looked like there was one pointed at you!”

“But then that means only I had the gun!” said Adora, clasping her hands to her head again. “It wasn’t even self-defence, I was scared of myself and killed—”

“No,” Catra said, with a whip-smack to the bench, “you didn’t. You couldn’t have seen your own reflection in the mirror. The assailant was in your way!”

“But the gun she saw, nonetheless,” Edgeworth pointed out, “so she must have seen someone else holding the gun in the mirror. Someone behind her.”

“Exactly,” said Catra. “She saw me. I held the gun.”

This drew another round of gasps, marred by a few groans too. Once again they watched a trial with endless twists, and pendulous to one end or another.

But they were fools. Catra could see it now. The road out.

Adora hadn’t. She now slammed the stand with both hands and cried out, “No! Catra, it wasn’t you. Stop trying to take the blame for me!”

Catra laughed. A high belting laugh, that felt like freedom to the girl as though her lungs had been drawn down by weighted bricks this whole time. She couldn’t even remember the last time she had laughed like this. Nor could Adora, as she now faltered and stared. By now she had gotten so used to a Catra in pain, where even taunts and grins were just plastered over to hide the anguish. At first she thought it was the prosecutor returning —the girl who had gleefully tormented her over the Singer case and so many others. But then a second thought came, deeper memory flooding back. The girl she had known. Her ‘real’ Catra.

“Wow,” Catra was saying, “I knew you were slow but come on.”

“I don’t understand,” said the Judge. “If it wasn’t her, then doesn’t that place the suspicion back onto you?”

Catra shook her head, “I know now that I couldn’t have killed Micah. It took me a while. Just needed to stop being an idiot. But it couldn’t have been Adora either. There was a third person that night, and the proof is in Adora’s testimony. That gun only had one bullet when it arrived at Brightmoon manor, and it was only fired once that night… before either of us were even there!”

“The witness claims someone fired the gun,” noted Edgeworth.

“And what was the sound it made?” asked Catra. “Witness, remember what you said. The sound the gun made was—”

“Click,” Adora said in a breath. Now it all hit her. Catra’s logic. Catra’s wonderful logic.

“The gun,” said Catra, launching out her finger into a point, “was empty when I pulled the trigger!”

“This must be the truth of the matter,” Edgeworth declared, “Catra and Adora met the real assailant that night. Adora scratched them with the fork, just as Catra fired the empty gun. With the person still stunned they fled the scene. Adora returned, finding the dead body of Micah, only to be chased away by Angella.”

“Leaving the third party to come back and leave another scratch on Micah,” Catra concluded.

“The question is, of course, who was the real killer? You must get this right.”

“That’s okay,” Catra said with a broad grin, “I’ve got a pretty good idea now of what happened.”

“Defence — I mean, defendant,” the Judge stammered, “I don’t know if this is allowed but you have to tell us. Who do you believe this true killer to be?”

“There’s only one person it could be,” said Catra. “Now we’ve eliminated all the other possibilities. And I think this has been a long time coming. The defence indicts Shadow Weaver for the murder of Micah!”

The silence that followed was immense. The shuffling in seats and the creak of old wood could be heard in every detail. Dark horror was folded into the realisation across Angella’s face, almost matched in the deep concern in Edgeworth’s. The court had been bludgeoned by a true collective shock.

“A-another prosecutor?” first to break the silence, the Judge exclaimed. “Now just what the hell is happening in that office?”

“That’s what we’re about to find out,” Edgeworth said with a fixed expression. “The prosecution consents to this summons. Not only was Shadow Weaver present at the manor that night, but she was uniquely privy to the SP-0 incident proceedings. We must hear her testimony.”

With that, the Judge agreed. He sent the bailiff, and it wouldn’t be long before he’d find Shadow Weaver, who had been keeping by ever since her intervention before the last recess. In the meantime, detective Scorpia arrived. Sidling into the chamber quickly, she came up to the three of them at the defence bench.

“How’s everything going?” she asked.

“Much better than we even hoped,” said Bow, giving Catra a smile, “thanks to our surprise lead.”

“Yeah well,” Catra shuffled, “we’re not nearly out of the clear yet. Picking apart Adora’s confession was one thing, but now we have to actually show Shadow Weaver did it.”

“Wait, you’re taking on the high prosecutor?” Scorpia gaped.

Catra shot the detective a deep, strained but telling look, “It was her. All this time, she did it, and she’s been manipulating everything. Not just the evidence, but both our lives. Mine, and Adora’s. We have to confront her.”

“Well, on that front,” Scorpia hastily pulled out documents from her inner coat pocket, “this is what we found. Sea Hawk knows who does the forgeries in the underworld, and Perfuma had some friends at the hospital we could talk too. Both yours and Soter Michael’s papers lead back to a figure called ‘Light Spinner.’”

“An alias,” Glimmer said, “definitely. You think it could be Shadow Weaver?”

“We’ll find out somehow,” Catra assured her. “Thanks, Scorpia.”

“Hey, Wildcat?” concern was drawn across the big girl’s face, “I’m worried, you know. Shadow Weaver… she knows how to set you off. Push your buttons. You’ve gotta be careful how you go or she’ll make everyone see you as… well you know what’s she’s like.”

Catra gave a sigh. She knew exactly. “I’ll keep my cool, I promise. This… isn’t about just me anymore. That woman has done too much to so many. I have to bring her down for all of us.”

Scorpia smiled. Giving Catra one last gentle pat with her pincer — strong enough to give solace yet light enough as not to knock her over— then took her leave.

Now it happened. Shadow Weaver, crawling into the room. As the woman took her place behind the stand, Catra glowered at her, gripping the golden whip firmly in her hands. Then Shadow Weaver turned her head. Her eyes landed on Catra, filling her with a sudden chill though she did all to remain firm. Then those eyes narrowed.

“Catra,” Shadow Weaver said. “Why have I been brought here?”

Edgeworth took to explaining, “the defence believes that the true killer of Micah, nine years ago, was none other than his mentor. High Prosecutor Shadow Weaver.”

“The defence?” said the woman in a light croon, “you mean the defendant? And what a ridiculous claim. My alibi was watertight. I was not even so much as brought to the stand during SP-0; that’s how far removed from the crime I was.”

“We’ll get to that,” Catra said, masking the unsteadiness in her voice by pushing forward. “First, why don’t you tell us about something else. A person under the name of Light Spinner faked a medical record a long time ago, making it look like I dislocated my shoulder when I only sprained my hand. More recently they helped Double Trouble fake the existence of Soter Michael, part of a plot to frame me for murder. This person… this is you, correct?”

“I have absolutely no idea what you’re talking about,” Shadow Weaver’s voice remained cool. “I know nothing of this Light Spinner.”

“Oh come on,” Catra said with a smirk, “this person must have been a prosecutor to have all the influence and connections needed to pull this off. As an accomplice to Double Trouble, they supplied the weapon that only they could take from the vault — where one of these faked medical records was so conveniently stashed away.”

“Perhaps it was you? You are in fact the person Double Trouble named. What evidence is there to tie me to this?”

Catra couldn’t stifle a grimace this time. Even Glimmer looked to her concerned and said:

“I don’t know if this is the right tack. Shouldn’t we just try and focus on the murder itself?”

“Yeah,” Bow said, fiddling with his gloves, “no matter what we tried, we couldn’t get a hold of any evidence from the vault. Forget investigating a trial. Whoever Light Spinner is covered their tracks too well.”

“Urgh,” Catra slid a palm down her face, “I blundered in without thinking, didn’t I. That girl’s rubbed off too much on me. Yet she’s always be able to pull the evidence she needs out of nowhere.”

“Well, think,” said Glimmer, “is there anything at all in the court record or even out of it that could tied Light Spinner to Shadow Weaver?”

“So many long names,” Catra muttered, “L-S to S-W, S-W from L-S, what could it— wait,” her eyes lit up. “Wait, wait,” she was now rummaging around in her own jacket pocket. She withdrew a square of white silk and slammed it on the bench, “TAKE THAT!”

“What is that?” the Judge asked, with a tilt of his head. “Is that a handkerchief?”

"It is. Adora gave it to me when I… well she gave it me anyway. And she was given it not too long ago by none other than this witness."

"….and?"

"And," Catra said, deftly picking up the square by a corner pinched between her claws "it's emblazoned with the initials 'L-S'. Light Spinner, it's your alias, isn't it."

Shadow Weaver, far from being rattled, just let out a small titter.

"That argument is as flimsy as the fabric you hold in your hand, girl," she said. "Why would I so blithely hand away apparent evidence of my 'secret alias'?"

"Why exactly is 'L-S' on your handkerchief then?" asked Edgeworth.

"It's a brand name," she said, a little stiff. "Light Spinner happens to be a company that makes silk fabrics. I'm rather partial to it." She turned back to Catra, and questioned, "you do know why I was comforting Adora yesterday?"

Catra looked at her. But she didn't respond. The woman continued:

"Because of the burden she has been given. All the confusing feelings that you give her have caused all this trouble. That's why I moved heaven and earth to keep her away from that dreadful trial. She had no involvement and yet this questioning has dragged her name through the mud. She's even gotten herself remembering false things you've implanted into her head. Do you feel no shame?"

Teeth clenched, Catra fought back with, "Adora's innocent, and I'm going to prove it."

"If she had merely taken my advice and left you to your fate, we could have avoided all this." Shadow Weaver let out a

performative sigh and, shaking her head, said, “and I thought you had come to see this. I was proud of you for that moment. For once, selflessness — you had done the right thing. Is that all gone now?”

Heaviness buried deep into Catra’s limbs, rending an ache through her joints, and bringing her whole body to bear down into a slump. All the spark to keep going, that drive to bring Shadow Weaver down was dying in the presence of her voice —yet speaking words so intimate to her. Because Shadow Weaver’s words echoed deep in the back of Catra’s mind. They had been plucked from her inner critic and thrown back into her face. She felt tired again. How was she supposed to refute her deepest belief.

No. Stiffening herself, she straightened. She couldn’t let this happen. She was standing at the defence’s bench. Taking Adora’s place, taking her sword, taking her bluff and bluster; for this moment, she had become Adora. So why not look at herself through Adora’s eyes? Because for some reason, some bizarre foreign logic that maybe Catra would never grasp, Adora didn’t hate her.

“Stop lying,” Catra suddenly burst out with a shout. Her whip flew, cracking against the base of the stand —enough to cause even Shadow Weaver a flinch. Catra unleashed in a frayed, cracking voice, “you keep pretending that you know what’s best for us. But you don’t! You just twist us for your own ends. Well Adora is not your plaything. She is not your prodigy. And you were wrong. She was involved in the SP-0 incident and she had as much duty as anyone else to give testimony. Now that she has, we’re much closer to the truth. The bullet was fired before either of us arrived!”

“Then it’s simple,” Shadow Weaver said with a delicate shrug, “the burglar who now rightly sits in prison was the murderer all along. I knew Adora had nothing to do with the crime, and I even guessed you were innocent too —despite knowing your destructive behaviour even then. She was to be kept away, and

you were prepped to make your testimony quick and painless… but you couldn't even get that right."

Catra let out a growl, though tensed her lips to hold it in. Filter out the taunts. Her eyes were drawn to an absolute fix on her prey. With focus, she could get her.

Shadow Weaver continued, "now I was the last one to see Micah before the incident. Is that what you want me to testify about next?"

"Actually," said Catra, "why don't you tell us about a different point in the night. After the murder."

"But what could that possibly reveal—"

"Oh you'll see. Angella had come home. She saw Adora and chased her out. By then Rob Rees had long fled —later to be captured due to his fingerprints left at the house. And I was shivering under an exhaust pipe. That would mean that there was only one person left alive still in the building… was you, correct?"

"That's right," Glimmer came to add, "when mom returned she found you calling the police."

"Well, yes," said Shadow Weaver, "I had come upon Micah's body. Of course I was shocked. I called the police and made sure not to disturb the crime scene. What else could I possibly testify about?"

"You didn't disturb the crime scene?" Catra peered with a raised brow, "I find that unlikely."

"I don't care what you do or do not find-—"

"Witness, maybe you weren't here earlier but Adora testified that she found the body without a scratch when she arrived the second time."

"But wasn't it she who scratched him?"

Catra grinned. “Well that’s the question isn’t it. This whole trial hinges on this fact. Because we now know Adora didn’t hit Micah, so the person she scratched was likely the real killer. Wanting to erase their trace from the crime scene, they faked a scratch on the body —and there was only one person who had the opportunity to do that.”

“Aha…,” a dry tone stretched across as Shadow Weaver spoke, “so I mimicked the wound, you mean? And why would I do that? Remember the claw and fork debate? Wouldn’t I want to avoid that debacle if I were really pulling the strings?”

“Uh, it’s not like you minded me coming under suspicion.”

“Of course I minded,” Shadow Weaver’s voice grew dark now, “you think I wanted to see that little… episode in court? And had I really wished to frame you, why didn’t I contrive keratin traces like Angella did?”

“Then it wasn’t about the trial,” Catra decided. “You did it for a different reason. You needed someone to never know you were in the kitchen that night.”

“And who would that be?”

Catra looked over to the girl in the dock, and said, “Adora.”

“Me?” said the other girl.

“She didn’t want you to know. You saw her attack me, and then you attacked her —your own mother. Would have made things awkward to say the least. You couldn’t know. She got lucky when you started thinking you’d dreamed it up anyway and never asked any questions. But it came in handy nine years later all the same. Imagine how things would have been different without that scratch.”

“Don’t listen to her, Adora,” Shadow Weaver said, turning to her as well. “You know what’s she like. This is still part of her quest to tear you down, whether she realises it or not.”

Adora was gripping her arm and sat perched uncomfortably on the hard wooden seat. Now she looked from one to the other with a cornered look. Finally she gave uncertainty to Catra with her eyes and said:

"I dunno, Catra. If I really hit her… why would she then mistake which side of the face the scratch went on?"

"What, you're defending her?" Catra spluttered.

"Look, maybe it's more likely I misremembered and—"

"Are you so surprised?" Shadow Weaver goaded Catra with a croon. "I raised her. I gave her everything and fashioned her to be a top-rate attorney. All you've caused her is pain and heartbreak."

"Shut up!" Catra shouted back at her. "Just shut up!"

She lurched forward over the bench, so rapidly that Bow thought she was going to pounce over and attack. He instantly put a hand to her shoulder, holding her back.

"The defendant— well, the defence actually," the Judge rubbed his brow as he stumbled over his words, "look, ms. Adora raises a good point. The contradiction in Catra's account seems to be quite a hiccup."

Edgeworth however wagged his finger by his temple and said, "not at all, your honour. For a gifted prosecutor such as herself, it should be easy for Catra to resolve."

Catra's ears flicked. "Wait… what?"

"Simply single out a cause that could induce the killer to switch the sides."

"The court record," Glimmer said in a sudden excitable hush, "there's bound to be something at the crime scene that could explain it."

“The picture,” Catra’s said, fumbling for it again, “yes, it’s here. Good thinking, Sparkles. Your honour,” she now called out, “it’s like the prosecution says. It’s really quite simple.”

“It is?” the Judge said blankly, “how so?”

“You see, I’m thinking that the killer was focused more on getting the body in to set up the fake crime scene; they didn’t even think about their own wound then. But after Angella chased Adora away and they came back in, something at the crime scene drew attention to it. They realised their problem. That’s when they decided to mimic the wound on the body.”

“But what was the thing at the crime scene?” said the Judge, “and how could it simply explain why they mistook the side—— ah….”

Dawning across the old man’s face, a certain thought connecting the pieces shone through. So long he had watched brilliant minds solve conundrums and cases, so it was a rare treat when he figured it out himself.

“The mirror!” he said, “they saw themselves in the mirror!”

“Exactly,” said Catra, “and acting too hasty they just made the scar exactly how it looked in the mirror, and not in real life. And remember, your honour. There was only one living person in the manor that night. It was Shadow Weaver!”

The woman gave out a bellow. It was an excruciating sound, close to a scream, yet with dark colour in its resonance. She pounded the stand with a closed fist, and stared down that her floating black hair masked her mask.

Then she looked up. She shot Catra a chilling sight — white eyes narrower than ever.

“You pernicious little creature,” Shadow Weaver said in a husky whisper, the sound of which hollowed out the girl’s insides. Yet when the witness spoke again, she stood up straight and with

calm voice, “it makes no difference. You have told us a lot of what the killer might or must have done. But I am not they.”

“You can’t deny—”

“I deny!” she snapped. “I deny it all. There is no proof that I scratched Micah, even less than I murdered him. You cannot say for certain no-one else had the opportunity to do the things you’ve described —perhaps it was Rob Rees after all, or even Angella….”

“Haven’t you dragged enough names through the dirt,” Glimmer was burning in her eyes, “Adora, Catra, even the burglar. Now you want to accuse my mom after what you pushed her to?”

“Oh please, she ruined her own reputation well enough on her own. The only one suffering from false accusation here is me. All because of that girl there. Catra is simply abusing the court to unload her resentment onto me. She makes a subpar prosecutor, and an even worse defence attorney.”

Catra’s ears were back. Her fur was standing. Hovering lower behind the bench, she now couldn’t suppress any of her flight and fight instincts, firing off all at once. All because of Shadow Weaver’s cold, forbidding stare.

“Guys I…,” she murmured, “I can’t think.”

“What?” said Bow. “Catra, she’s the one who’s cornered! We just have to find conclusive proof that ties her to the killer’s actions.”

“What proof?” Catra whined, bereft and hopeless. Her voice was cracking, “we’ve used everything!”

“There must be something else!”

“Where? The crime scene? The prosecutor’s office? It would have shown up in the vault! There’s nothing! Aaaagh,” she clutched at her head, digging her claws into what little hair she had left. “Damnit. Damn it! What would Adora do in a time like this?”

“It seems the defendant is at a loss,” Shadow Weaver said, a laugh creeping along and echoing in the chamber. “Your honour, if there’s nothing else, I can leave.”

“I… I suppose you’re right,” admitted the Judge.

“If she stands down, she can’t be considered a suspect anymore,” Glimmer spoke agitated and high.

“Then either Adora will be found guilty…,” Bow began.

“Or Catra,” Glimmer finished.

“Adora is not going to prison for this,” Catra said through clenched teeth.

“But you’re innocent too!”

“I know, but—”

“She won’t let go.”

“Then it’s simple.”

This last voice came not from the defence’s bench, but drew all their eyes to the dock. It was Adora, now standing up and looking at them with eyes that gleamed, not just by the light of the courtroom, but by some hidden internal glow.

“We pin Shadow Weaver,” she said.

“Adora!” Catra gave her a longing, bewildered look.

“Hey, haven’t you figured it out?” Adora smirked. “I knew you were slow, but like—”

“Hey!”

“It’s really simple if you just turn your thinking around. You need something that couldn’t be hidden in the prosecutor’s office, yet was taken from the crime scene anyway. But why wouldn’t it be in

the vault? Maybe it wasn't her choice. So don't ask what she took from the crime scene, ask what she couldn't leave behind!"

Catra gave a groan. "Oh, you think your soooo clever!"

"Well," Adora now wore the cockiest, most slippery grin she'd ever had. She lay a hand on one hip and tossed her ponytail, "I am kinda She-Ra —the reincarnation of the goddess of law. Best lawyer around."

"Ugh, you are not," Catra said. Then, as she turned back to face the stand, laying both hands on the bench, she smiled herself. "Because I'm better!"

Energy was rising along the entire length of the whip. As it reached her fingers in her grasp, a dancing tingle spread across, burrowing under the skin and shooting up her arm with a light sensation. And the word rose through her lungs, bursting out with all will and determination:

"HOLD IT!"

With a single smack, the tail-end of the whip flew across the chamber. It landed on Shadow Weaver's wrist, holding her in place as Catra held a firm two-handed grip on the golden length.

"You are not leaving the stand," she said. "Whoever attacked me in the kitchen only did so because they were about to bring in Micah's body. They brought the emptied gun there as well. Then the person Adora scratched was the killer."

Catra clambered over the table, pouncing off that she landed in the space before the stand. In front of Shadow Weaver.

"And now, ladies and gentlemen of the court," she said, "I'm going to show this killer's true face."

But then Shadow Weaver yanked. Catra lost her footing, fell to her knees. Only with a new clasp did she keep onto the whip, but Shadow Weaver was strongly resisting her tug.

“You were always a disappointment,” the woman snarled.

“Yeah, well good,” Catra fired back, “I can’t believe I cared about what you thought about me all this time. Can’t believe I was jealous of Adora —who needs that kind of attention?”

“I should have prevented you ever coming near a court. Look at this. Violent. Unprofessional. And once again you’re just using this as an opportunity to dump your resentment on me. Because I never coddled you, is that it? You pathetic child. Oh did you think your treatment was unfair? I gave both of you what you needed. I provided for Adora’s rise to greatness. I was protecting her—”

“She doesn’t need your protection!” Catra shouted. Her voice was strained as she struggled to hold on. “She has real friends who love her now,” she glanced to Bow and Glimmer, before staring ahead again and saying, “and… and she has me!”

“You!” Shadow Weaver laughed, “and do you love her too?”

“I… I…”

“Haven’t you dragged her down far enough?”

“SHUT UP!”

Catra leapt a stride forward, gaining more of the whip in her grasp. Yet Shadow Weaver still resisted, that the length of gold became as taut as a steal beam.

“Angry, are you?” said the woman, now able to look downwards on the crouching girl. “Enraged? Go one, then. Attack me. Like you tried to before. Like you tried to attack Angella. Creature of instinct. Unable to control your impulse. Attack me. You are a criminal, you only do what you must. That is what you are!”

“AAAAAAAARRRGH!”

Finally she broke. With a single pounce, forward, she struck her victim.

Shock was all that remained in the court. Shadow Weaver fell, and all thought she was badly hurt. Looks of concern were worn around the room, especially by Bow, Glimmer, Adora and Edgeworth, none of whom had quite expected to see what just happened. And there Catra landed back on the ground. Yet she didn't seem gripped by animalistic fury. Just a fixed look, grit for sure, but one of calm. Then, to further surprise of all, Shadow Weaver picked herself up.

Catra's strike had been precise. A gleam of light burst, follow by the metallic slinging sound. Shadow Weaver's mask cracked, then fell apart.

"No!" Shadow Weaver yelped in anguish, agony, far more than when Catra made her attack. She grasped at her now bare face, but even with her long fingers could not hide the disfigurement.

It wasn't a fresh mark. It was faded, but clear. Four lines streaking across the eye. The right eye.

"I'm not what you think I am," said Catra at last. "Cause I'm nothing like you."

"You…," Shadow Weaver whispered, follow by the splutter, "you… you…" and then, in a scream:
"CAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAtraaaaAAAAAAAaaaaaaaaaAAAAAAA!"

It was a terrible thing. Adora looked away. Edgeworth gripped his arm as the sound awakened painful memories of his own. Glimmer buried her face into Bow's chest, and the boy wrapped his arm around her, keeping her tight.

At length, Shadow Weaver collapsed, falling forward over the witness stand. Yet she was not spent for words. In a dark, deep croak, she spoke again:

"You were always ungrateful. I tolerated your existence, because I thought even you could amount to something one day. But I never liked how you always tried to bring Adora down to your level. To pull her from her great path. When I saw you in that

cabinet, about to see what I had done… I don't think I had ever felt as angry as before that moment. But I could never have guessed what happened next. Adora, rushing in, to protect her precious Catra. But she was turned away. She could never see what was actually there. The little monster behind her, holding a gun, ready to shoot her own mother…. Click."

"You're the monster." It was Glimmer, still lingering in Bow's embrace, and her voice running dry. Yet she kept on nonetheless, "why did you kill my dad?"

"I hadn't planned it," said Shadow Weaver, "Micah forced my hand. He was always smart, too much for his own good. And with a misguided sense of honour. Criminals are destroying lives out there everyday yet he was always poking around the office, looking for something. It was because of that woman of his, Angella. Filling him with her lofty notions. She rubbed off on him too much. So when he figured out what had gone on with a previous trial, he refused to understand. He wouldn't accept that a prosecutor must do everything," the woman clasped her hand into a fist, "everything in their power to win. He was going to take the forged evidence into the prosecutor's office. He was going to explain everything. I couldn't allow that, so… I improvised."

"All along," Angella, staring ahead at Shadow Weaver as if truly seeing her, spoke in a slack voice, "it was you. It was always you."

"You shouldn't sell yourself short," said the guilty. "You felt a deep instinct and pushed that with every resolution. The keratin fibres were a genius idea. Just poor luck that it didn't work."

"No," said Angella. "I was wrong. My instinct was wrong! I didn't see the girl I thought I did, and the one I did was innocent."

"You're not the first person to think that only fools know restraint," Edgeworth remarked, glaring at the witness with a look of scorn. "Yet every man I've known to dabble in falsity and cover-ups had been undone in the end; from Chief Prosecutor Hordak to Manfred von Karma."

“What happened to you?” Shadow Weaver gave Edgeworth a sideways glance. “You used to be a real prodigy.”

“A similar thing to what happened here,” said Edgeworth. “In the end, even painful truths are more liberating than lies. And now all the truth is out.”

“Adora,” she now looked around, fraught, desperate. “Where is Adora?”

But Adora had gone now. Not carrying the defence, and no longer a suspect, she was just another witness, and could be released. She had returned to the lobby beyond.

“But if I could just explain,” Shadow Weaver began to mutter, crawling her hands along the stand as she could barely stand up. “Adora, please, let me explain. Where is Adora? Where is she… ADOOOORA!?”

The Judge gave a shake of his head, before looking up.

“Yes, everything is clear now. The witness shall be taken away. I’ll leave that business to you, acting Chief Prosecutor Edgeworth.”

“Of course, your honour,” said the man.

“There is truly something rotten in the justice system I fear,” a stroke of forlorn crept into his voice as he spoke. “I shan’t think there’s any of the old leadership left. And with such a reputation now… I fear bad days are ahead for us all.”

“Not at all,” said Edgeworth, now wearing a knowledgable smile. “With Prosecutor Catra and Defence Attorney Adora, how could you go wrong?”

“Perhaps you are right, mr. Edgeworth. Very well. It has been a long ride indeed, but now at last I believe it can end. Ms. Catra?”

Catra, who had remained quite still by the witness stand, turned to face the delivery of judgement. Even now she gulped. The one

verdict she would now get, while immeasurably preferable, would be just as hard to accept as the other. Yet she looked up to the Judge with what remaining strength she had.

“Yes?”

“You were certainly guilty,” he said in a marvelling voice, “and yet Adora showed that the crime never occurred. And then of the SP-0 incident, you told us of your guilt and yet she showed that wasn’t true either. But it seems both of you were caught in a deeper web, yet both of you together pulled yourselves out. And here was me thinking you didn’t like one another.”

“I…” Catra’s face fell vague as the full weight of all that had happened came down in one collapse, precipitated by the Judge’s retelling. She thought she’d fall into some deep reverie, when, even surprising herself, she managed a small half-smile, and asked, “whyever would you think that, your honour?”

“Of course. It is time then. I hereby declare a mistrial for the case of Double Trouble’s murder. And on the count of murder nine years ago, the court finds you… NOT GUILTY!”

Chapter End Notes

> And there we go. The last trial and thus the last episode is finished. What follows however is just as important. Two more chapters to wrap the whole story up.
>
> And whoo what a rollercoaster this trial has been hopefully. I know this last chapter probably was on the longer side of reasonable but I think it was well worth it to really hammer down that big final confrontation.

Choosing Death

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Tranquility, still silence: they reigned over the Brightmoon estate even at the height of day. Frost clung to glasses and the manor windows both. Some patches of snow and ice joined also. The air was filled with a crisp wintery chill, though was calm with not a gasp of wind, nor a single rustle of the twigs and branches that were shorn of leaves. It was Christmas season at last.

Inside things were quiet too. Angella was in her bedroom, joined only by the occasional ticking of a clock. Although even that seemed faded at times.

She stood by a mantle. Watching a single framed pictured without much thought, she was soothed by its polished framed and clear resolution. A younger Angella, her daughter a tiny girl, and her husband Micah were held within.

There was a clear, although hesitant knock on the door. Angella told them to enter. In came Glimmer. Her hand clasped around the other wrist, not so tight as to hurt but firm nonetheless. Not turning, Angella just bowed her head with a strange smile. But it faltered just as quickly as it graced.

“I keep thinking about that first Christmas,” she was speaking in a bare whisper, and it was more to herself than anything. “The first since I had lost not just him, but my badge as well. The manor felt so large for the first time in ages. I was small and lonely within it. The world beyond was so cold. You were young then, inconsolable and needed your mother, and yet I retreated into myself. I considered everything over.” She gave a hollow sigh. “I don’t really remember what happened after that. Maybe I pulled myself together, but then that wouldn’t matter; I’d keep failing, again and again. Even just knowing I’d spent so long failing my

daughter made it hard to start doing the right thing. It was always too late for me."

Glimmer shook her head, and insisted, "you shouldn't think like that. We got through it all in the end. We made it here, didn't here?"

Angella turned, offering a pained look. Her hand still rested on the picture, and it lingered, there, her fingers brushing down Micah's image, as she took a slow pace away. Daylight from the window drew her over, and she stared out with longing.

"But now I can't stop thinking about what all this means," she said. "It was all for nothing."

"Mom?"

"My misplaced accusations, and using forged evidence… I'd be ashamed if he knew."

"He would have understood," said Glimmer. "And that was years ago now. You knew him: you know he'd have forgiven you by now."

That brought the ghost of a smile to Angella. The reminiscence was vivid, for Glimmer was all too right.

"He would," she admitted. "We were going to figure things out. Have that talk. Maybe Christmas would have been the perfect time for it. Now at least I can let him rest for good." She now turn to face Glimmer, "and it might not have happened if I didn't train Adora. Perhaps that's redemption enough?"

"See," Glimmer gave her a look of cheer, "there never was such a thing as too late."

Yet in the girl's hands, held together by her front, there was shuffling, and her smile was twinged with a hidden pain. Finally she sighed, and found herself coming to sit on the bed. Angella sat by her side.

Laying an arm around her daughter, she asked, “what is it?”

“I went behind their backs,” said Glimmer. “My friends. I was selfish. I shut Bow out like I’d never done before, and I don’t even know how I could have done it. All for a false accusation.”

Angella was rueful, “well, it was me who gave you the notion. Everything comes back to my original sin.”

Glimmer shook her head.

“I should have talked to them about it. But I was scared of the possibility that it wouldn’t be Catra. I mean, who would it have been? I didn’t want to lose the answer forever.”

“Perhaps that was the whole point….”

“I guess we were all played for fools. But I still had a choice, and I got it wrong.”

Angella just let her eyes fall on the girl, tired yet holding warmth in watery eyes. She pulled Glimmer in tighter and leant her head against hers.

“Don’t become like me, constantly looking back on the failures of the past and doing nothing about it. And look to where things went right. It all worked out. If the trial had ended at Double Trouble’s reveal, Shadow Weaver would have had more time to prepare. Perhaps even enough to get Catra guilty. Because of you, they were able to draw her out.”

“That’s one way of looking at it,” Glimmer said with a sigh. “But you’re right, I should make things right. I have to apologise to them.”

“Of course, that seems right.”

Angella relinquished Glimmer, allowing her to set off. Out of the room, down a hallway and descending a stairway, before making the approach to where she knew they might be. Her heart stood a

little elevated in its beats. It wasn't that she thought this would be bad, but not knowing how they would react, even now, kept her apprehensive. But she would do this. She came up to the kitchen door, already ajar.

Of course it was here. The room was so strange to her now. Almost alien, with a floor oddly clean, the cabinet that she had never known to open but had once held hidden eyes and the blank wall opposite —where a girl that Glimmer would not meet for years saw a reflection in the dark. Perhaps the mirror could return now, now that the old ghosts of this scene were gone.

Bow was sat at the table. He was alone. Yet Glimmer imagined that Adora wasn't far. In the days following Catra's not guilty verdict, the blonde girl had been electrified, filled with a constant need to expend energy. Whether angst or thrill, she was compelled to head to the grounds, or even beyond and take to running around the block. But she would always come back, so there was no isolation to Bow's solitude.

Glimmer took in a heavy breath, and forced a "hello?"

Yet Bow just gave her a neutral expression, and said nothing back. Glimmer returned an awkward smile and apologetic eyes. Then she took a few steps forward, and when she reached him, leant down to give his cheek a kiss. He didn't resist, but was keeping silent for now. So the wait began.

At last, the glass-pane door threw open, with Adora jumping in and still giving a few hops on her feet to banish the outdoor cold. Then she caught Glimmer in her eye and stopped. The two girls locked stares. Scratching her arm, Glimmer kept pause, hoping that the first to speak wouldn't be her. Yet heat sank into her neck as she realised it would.

She sighed, saying, "look, I'm sorry."

A second pause followed. Adora maintained the stare.

“You were right about Catra,” Glimmer continued, “you were right about her being completely innocent. And you were right to trust her, and you were right about Edgeworth too and I should haven’t abandoned you in the investigation and I shouldn’t have gone behind your backs and… Adora?”

She gave the girl a pleading look. Yet apart from flicking her mouth to the side, Adora gave no reaction.

“Come on, Adora,” Glimmer now whined, “I’m saying I’m sorry. Please answer.”

Adora looked to Bow, who gave but a shrug. With nothing more to do, the girl then lifted what she had held in a bag and dropped them with a soft thud on the table. They were three white boxes.

“Good broth from Eldoon’s today,” she said, “let’s dig in.”

“You…” Glimmer blinked, “got ramen?”

“Yeah, thought it’d be nice for lunch. Sorry I didn’t ask first but I got your usual.”

Adora passed her the box, and Glimmer, not really sure what else she could say, just took it with a thanks. As they all began to eat, uncertain thoughts crossed Glimmer’s mind, and her shoulders remained tense. Yet the taste was the salty goodness she’d come to expect from that vendor and realisation came upon her that she was having what would be a normal time with her best friends. That was enough to make her smile inside, though her confusion didn’t relent.

She had to ask, “so, are you not angry with me?”

“I think we made you suffer enough,” Bow said wryly.

“Oh, so is that how it is?”

Glimmer gave him a punch in the arm. He flinched though kept that devious grin.

“I’m just saying,” he chuckled, “twenty missed calls is a bad record. You’re kinda lucky we’re not putting you on grunt work next case.”

“Well I already do all the paperwork, Bow, so maybe check where you’re standing before you have to start hiring a new paralegal.” Her smile, though lingering, came to a falter, “but seriously, we’re okay?”

In response, Bow came over, and returned the kiss from before.

“Well,” Glimmer grinned broadly again, “that’s good to know. And, Adora…?”

Adora’s gaze shot up from where she was steaming noodles into her face. She looked from one the other, gulped and said, “I’m not kissing you if that’s what you’re asking. Those days are over, remember.”

“No,” Glimmer laughed, “I meant you’re not mad?”

“I was,” she said with a shrug, “but I just kept wondering what I’d do if it had been me. Something stupid probably.”

Though Adora had been merely nonchalant, and shortly returned to her bowl, the mere sight of her shot Glimmer with a feeling of lightness throughout her body. Gentle tears were brought to her eyes, though easily hidden. She was thankful she was here, with these two. She would never fail to trust them again.

With a surreptitious wipe of her eye, she brought back a cool grin, and eased in to saying, “since you mention acting stupid… I’ve been wondering. Have you see Catra since that, uh, incident?”

“Incident?” Adora repeated, vague.

“You know,” Glimmer insisted with devilish intent, “that little thing that happened as soon as the trial ended?”

“Oh yeah,” Bow said, catching on, “when Catra found you in the lobby.”

“I-I don’t know what you guys are talking about,” Adora blurted. “Oh, you know, it was a real tense trial I’m sure a lot of things happened, I don’t remember them all.”

“Really?” Glimmer said with a raised eyebrow. “So you don’t recall how Catra came in, threw herself into your arms, nuzzling her head under your chin and began to purr?”

“And wrapped her tail around your back,” added Bow, “I didn’t know she could do that.”

“I can understand the hug,” said Glimmer, “though you placing your hand on her head and threading your fingers through her hair seemed a bit overkill.”

“Not to mention caressing your other hand down the small of her back—”

Adora shot up. Doing so rustled the table, though she didn’t notice, just staring ahead and stammering:

“I-I’m sure you guys were just t-taken by a collective flight of imagination!”

She quickly sat herself down again. Glowing red, she buried her face in her box and didn’t say another word on the subject. The other too restrained their giggles, though shared amused looks.

That kind of torture aside, the days of December were immeasurable in their joy. Things were as they were after the McRaker case, and on some days they could hardly imagine there had been any break between that time and the present — especially one as fraught as Catra’s trial.

Yet it had happened. And it had changed everything in a way that Adora couldn’t ignore forever. But thinking about Catra filled her with such strange emotions all running criss-cross and never

making any coherent sense. Most were hard to describe. They were cool and warmth, lightness and weight, taut and lax all at once. But they were good. That's what she believed, at least. Good feelings, exciting even, but perhaps too much to comprehend. Too much to dare deal with.

Whatever the case, she chose not to take on any new clients until the new year. So she wouldn't be seeing Catra for some time.

Catra was doing fine on her own. Surely she was.

Yet it was about a week later, when once again she jogged against the brisk winter wind to Eldoon's stand. To her pleasant surprise, she saw a familiar man also waiting for his midday dish —Phoenix Wright. He was in his usual blue suit though with mittens, a scarf and a cyan beanie. He smiled when he noticed her.

"Hey, small world, huh."

"Well you live near here, right?"

"True, but if I had some sense I could have just cooked something myself. But I feel bad that the man here runs a kiosk in this season."

As they waited for their food, however, Phoenix fell into calm quiet. Adora didn't say anything either but there was nothing on her mind as of then. For Phoenix, he couldn't stop himself stealing glances at her. Eventually he decided to probe:

"So… how about that last trial?"

"Yeah," she gave a half-smile, "that was real crazy. I thought that mr. Edgeworth came off strong."

"He'll do that," Phoenix chuffed, "despite the grouch, there's really no-one better than him."

Once again, he spent a few seconds in silent. He was so deep in thought he didn't notice as his food, and then Adora's were served. She gave him a farewell and was about to leave, before the man could hold in no longer and asked:

"Have you checked up on Catra since then?"

"Check up on her?" Adora closed her brow, "like as a legal precaution? I've fulfilled my contract defending her. I didn't think there was anything else."

"Not like that," Phoenix shook his head, feeling a sigh come along. How to explain? He proceeded, "checking up on her… as her friend."

"Friend…." The word rung in her head. Was it right to call her that again? "A lot… a lot was uncovered both in the trial and out of it. Things between us are… weird, to say the least. But I'd like to have her as a friend again."

Once again, the word stayed with her. It was hard to explain why, but it didn't quite fit.

"Everything she thought she knew has been ripped out from under her, right?" Phoenix now began, his voice rather dark as he said it, "her whole world is upside down. A contradiction."

"I guess so," Adora said with a half-shrug. "I'm not in her head, but I imagine she's still feeling a bit lost."

"A bit… sure." Phoenix fixed his forehead and said, "you should go check up on her. Just make sure she's adjusting well to her new truth. If she doesn't… well, things could get ugly."

"What do you mean?"

"I'm sure I'm overreacting. But I think you're going to have to be there for her. Might has well be sooner rather than later. Or else you'll be waiting for a long time. And that assumes that later ever comes."

Adora didn't grasp the portent in Phoenix's words. She thought to ask more, but they both needed to get going. So she returned home with the boxes of noodles, even as the conversation stayed on her mind. And stay on her mind it continued. Even as she returned to life at Brightmoon manor, thoughts about Catra, and being her friend, and everything that might have been plaguing the other girl all this time crystallised into a sense of purpose. An urge to act.

Bow and and Glimmer were spending the evening together, giving Adora free time. Phoenix had said sooner rather than later, and today was as sooner than anything else. So she decided to head out. It was just as the daytime passed, and a grey sky flung overhead.

The Prosecutor's office once again, and this time she went in alone. There was no-one now to give her wary looks. The office was dead. Brightly lit halls that should have housed people were more eery than they would have been dark; only she walked through them now, her every footstep a palpable clack.

Then she reached the door to Catra's office, and she froze where she stood. Her heart raced. Catra was beyond that door. What sort of girl was she going to be greeted with now? Would she revert, pretend nothing had happened and be the conniving prosecutor once again? Or even further, and assume the young the girl that Adora had once known. Or would she face something entirely new?

She summoned the courage to lift her hand, and gave a knock. No reply. She knocked again, and when nothing came again, she went to push the door open, and cautiously said:

"Hey, Catra?"

The room was empty. Bare even. Cabinets for case files were empty. All there was was the desk. On it sat a computer. It had been returned there that very day, finally released from evidence.

Adora made a slow approach. When she came around and saw the screen, her eyes widened as there, still up, was Catra's personal journal. It wasn't the right thing to do, but her curiosity was too strong to ignore. She sat down and started to read through.

First Entry: This is so cool! Not professional language, I know, but only I'm going to be reading this. I wish I had a picture of the look on Shadow Weaver's face when she saw me. She must be so mad. And we have a case already. My first posting as a prosecutor, and _she_ is going to be there. I'll be ready for her. She won't know what hit her when I'm through.

Scrolling down, Adora found a later entry:

I won't be caught off-guard this time. The watch is the key. I'll keep it just in case —perhaps it'll be useful to me after all. But I control what happens in this trial. Victory is assured. Now this will be a dance to remember. Still, it was interesting meeting her face to face. Sure, I knew everything I needed to from Shadow Weaver, but words can't explain everything about a person. The girl is grown-up now, but in a way she's just like that kid. The thing is, she wasn't even completely intolerable when we were alone. If things had been different, I wonder what would have happened to us. But they weren't, so I shouldn't think about it anymore.

Then Adora's finger trembled as she scrolled down to the entry she knew was coming.

Adora. Adora. ADORA. She screwed her eyes shut, but couldn't stop herself stealing another peek before seeing, *why can't I get rid of her?*

She was about to stand up, rid her eyes away from it and get out of there. But her finger had scrolled again, and she saw a blank page. Or rather it was mostly empty. It was the end. With that, Adora let out a sigh.

“Why, Catra?” she said in a weak whisper, “I just wanted us to be together…. Friends.” She said, a little clearer, “friends, together.”

Her eye was caught by the screen again. She had missed something. The last section of text:

Final Entry:

#

Fuck this

Adora stared at the mostly empty page, about half of it used a space between the entry number and the content. She mouthed, repeating the phrase ‘final entry’ as her thoughts began to churn and digest what she was seeing.

Then she stood up at last. Terror gripped her. Terror from the sudden understanding of Phoenix’s ominous words and Catra’s last entry.

She ran. No object, door way or tight corner could stop her. Nor the heaving of her own breath —she knew how to run, and she would put every last wisp of will she had to push herself forward. Harder than she had ever sprinted before, she went. She skipped the elevator, instead jumping up stairs four at a time. She reached the high prosecutor’s level, and then up again. She ran until she reached the Chief Prosecutor’s office itself, at the very zenith of the building.

Only then did she stop, as she came face to face with Miles Edgeworth. The man wore a dark look. A knowing frown if there had ever been such a thing.

“Adora,” he said with stiff voice, “this is… difficult.”

“Just tell me where she is,” she said.

He pointed up.

She nodded. “Then I need to get up there.”

“If you go through this window, onto the balcony you should find some grating. But it’ll be risky—”

“Nah,” she said, with a remarkable grin that surprised even her, “I’ve had practice.”

“Then good luck,” Edgeworth said, smiling too.

Adora was off again. Throwing open the window, she clambered through the balcony, not minding the freezing gusts of such a height. Nor would she dare look down. As bid, she took a hold of the grating, and pulled herself up. Her foot almost slipped on the frosty metal, but she wouldn’t lose footing this time. Not when she needed to climb.

With one last pull at the top, she lugged herself over, and landed on the roof. She had made it. Under the dark sky, above the great city, there she was. And so was Catra.

The girl was stood, erect, perched on the very edge of the roof. Her hair rustled, though short and tufty it was small in its movements, nothing like the cape that billowed out behind her by the wind. Adora’s heart leapt to see how precarious Catra’s feet were, with only the balls holding her weight. An urge to shout, yell, call out in a cry swept through her. Yet she controlled her impulse. She took cautious steps forward. She would not jump her.

“Catra?” she said, in as gentle a voice as she could when her own chest was taut and her own eyes quivered in fear. “Catra, it’s me.”

The cat turned, with a grace and balance that did not disturb her delicate stance on the edge. And she looked at Adora with an oddly relaxed smile.

“Hey, Adora,” she said, both conversational and breaking with emotional at the same time.

“Come on down, Catra,” Adora spoke with more panic now, “what are you doing?”

Catra turned back, and let her gaze fall. The streets were thin lines below, glowing orange with tiny lights flying about like fireflies. The distance seemed to extend as she looked at it longer, a sight that sent a spasm through the entire length of her spine. Her breath was heavy as she took it. Her head was swimming. Yet it all fit. Her whole world was upside down now.

“That’s a long drop,” Adora said through clenched teeth, “more than your nine lives and you won’t land on your feet this time!”

Catra looked up. Throwing her head back she stared at the sky. Wiped black by the corrupting glow of the city. No light, not even from the moon that was long gone. Just a dead canopy.

“Why would you care?” she said in a low exhale.

“Catra… surely you know by now that I do care. Please, just come down.”

When Catra turned again, Adora had come right up to her. Her hand was outstretched, and her eyes were wide and soulful — perhaps that’s where the stars had gone. Catra took her hand. Adora pulled her from the edge, and Catra landed right up next to her. Their arms were in one another’s, and they were face to face once again.

“The breeze is nice,” Catra suddenly broke away from Adora and began to pace. “And the view up here is cool too. And I never came up here so I thought why not.”

“Right…,” said Adora, her eyelids falling. “That’s why you came up here?”

Catra just gave her an unbothered look before continuing on with her pace. Adora followed, in silence. Even now Catra couldn’t let herself be vulnerable. Adora didn’t know what she could say if Catra wasn’t willing to talk.

But then, as they reached the the cold metal of the ventilation tubings, Catra sat down against them. Adora sat by her side.

“You know it’s alright,” she said, “if you don’t wanna talk. If you want me to leave and never show my face again, I’ll do that too—”

“Stay,” Catra said, in a very small voice. “Just, stay.”

“You sure?”

“I’ve tried too long to get you out of my face, and yet you always come back. Why fight it anymore?”

Adora smirked. “I’ll take that as a victory.”

The two fell silent for a few moments, just staring out at some of the peaks of fellow tower blocks nearby. Yet Adora’s thoughts were in motion —Catra had let her stay. She needed to check up on her, properly. If she didn’t take this chance, she may lose it forever.

“I saw the final entry on your computer,” she said, breaking the silence.

“You shouldn’t be looking at that,” Catra muttered.

“I’m sorry, but I saw it anyway. Were you planning on leaving the office? The exit is usually downstairs, not up here.”

“I was trying to be dramatic,” Catra stared down at the concrete beneath her, “but the words wouldn’t come. I haven’t been able to do any work really. If I don’t quit I’ll be fired, I’m guessing.” She let out a groan, and continued, “I’ve been having bad nights. Non-stop since that meeting with Double Trouble. First I was certain I killed them. Then I was more than certain I killed Micah. Now… well, I just don’t know, but I can’t sleep. Have you ever had a bad night, Adora?”

“Yeah, I mean everyone gets them every now and then.”

"No," Catra said in a bitter laugh, "no, you've never had a bad night. You had a rough time getting to sleep, maybe for a few hours, but you make it eventually. I *can't* sleep. Now that, that's the worst thing you can ever face, I've recently learned. When you can't sleep, you feel the world around you, quiet, dead. Even in a city like this, you can't help but imagine everyone else has gone, but you're still there. You've been left behind, alone, tossing around. Unable to break free of the dull dark reality around you. I'm so tired," she buried her face into her hands, "I'm constantly aware of the world, and yet it feels melted, not quite there. I'm hot, I'm sick, I'm constantly aching, and I feel like I'm going to be like this forever! Awake, exhausted but never sleepy, I'm going to be like this until my body just gives up."

She threw a glance back at the edge of the roof, where mere minutes ago she had been standing on the precipice.

"That way is just the same end, but quicker."

Adora felt sick herself as she also looked over, but she forced herself to only look at Catra now.

"This isn't just about sleep, now is it."

"Course not," Catra snarled, "because when I'm lying there I'm faced with two possibilities. Either I try to think about nothing, in which case I can't distract myself from the fact I'm awake. The other is let my my mind wander. And where will it wander but you?"

Adora gave a nod, understanding. "Do you want to talk about what happened?"

"Whatever," Catra sighed, "fine. I wish I could be happy Shadow Weaver's finally gone. But even then I'm just… sad. I have some good memories of her, few that they were."

"She drove the two of us apart. Now that she's gone you'd think… well, it's not going to fix things on its own, is it."

“Yeah well,” Catra breathed, “I still chose to be shitty, didn’t I. Or maybe I didn’t.”

Adora stared at her, eyes widening. She waited for Catra to continue. The girl’s expression tensed as she realised what Adora was thinking.

“I mean… she was right, wasn’t she? I tried to shoot her, it doesn’t really matter that there wasn’t a bullet inside there. At the end of the day, I am violent and destructive and—”

“You were trying to save me,” said Adora, “I didn’t even give that a second thought. We were both stupid kids in a tough situation. But at the end of the day you did what you thought would protect me. I mean, I cut her face. Am I violent and destructive?”

Catra squirmed, rustling where she sat. She couldn’t find an answer.

“You can move on,” Adora argued, “you can improve your attitude, you don’t have to scheme or lie or cheat to be a good prosecutor — I know you’re a great lawyer without any of that. You can be something new.”

“That’s the point isn’t it,” Catra said, her gaze falling again, “I can’t see what this new person would be. Would it even be me anymore?”

“Of course it would! The new person is a new Catra, not someone else.”

“Catra… who is Catra to you? You know, I look a whole lot better through your eyes.”

“Yeah well, I reckon you can’t see yourself at all,” Adora said, sporting a half-smile, “maybe I’m able to see to it because I’m the one looking from the outside.” Then, letting her eyes rise to the sky, leaning back, Adora listed off, “you’re amazing. You’re quick, witty albeit rude. You used to make me laugh like nothing in the world. And even since we’ve met again, we’ve had some crazy

times together, haven't we? You're… wonderful, you're cute, you're—"

"I am not—" Catra had started, although quickly stifled to a mutter as she finished, "I'm not cute."

"Well I meant… well, yeah…."

Adora's thought died into silence. She held an anxious tension between her teeth as she watched Catra. As the pause lengthened, she worried her outpouring was to met with nothing more than that last comment. But then Catra spoke:

"You're not so bad."

Letting out a laugh, Adora asked, "is that all you have to say? After all that happened?"

"Nngrh."

The two girls could agree that 'heartfelt' didn't come to Catra naturally.

"You're not gonna be satisfied until I tell you what I think of you, aren't you," the girl sussed.

"Yep, and don't tell me you don't like me again because I know that's not true," a teasing note crept into Adora's voice on these last few words.

It was enough to draw a scowl from Catra. But then she sunk her head lower into her pulled in knees and curled up, ruminating for a few moments.

"I... I am obsessed with you," she said. "But you knew that already. You occupy all my thoughts. And every time I think about you my chest constricts."

"Adora, Adora, Adora," Adora said in a vague echo of what she recalled.

“I so wanted to destroy you,” Catra confessed, “I thought that’s what I wanted, what I needed to become who I wanted to be. But that was stupid. And yet you’re still there, rattling around in my head. A… friend told me that passionate feelings can get mixed up. I know I don’t hate you, but I’m just not sure what the feeling is now. It’s like uh… I dunno, like a drug? Like I’ve got this need to see you even though it hurts.” She let out a soft sigh, “some sort of craving for Adora.”

Adora gave a wry smile, “well maybe you just need a little Adora in moderation.”

“Ugh, that’s so cheesy.” Catra groaned. “And how would that even work? How do I… *have* you in moderation?”

Catra had been turning her head as she fathomed this, just as Adora had continued to watch her. Once the first had finished speaking, their gazes locked into one another. There was a pause, during which Adora’s thoughts turned to mush. Frying her ability to think more was the fact that she had just been asked a question, and every attempt to find an answer threw her. Catra too gaped and mouthed as the full weight of that that question and a potential answer could mean dawned. Both girls quickly turned away. Staring ahead, resolutely.

“Y-y-you’re on my mind a lot too,” Adora said, pressing on. “Shadow Weaver was right, I guess. You do distract me. You give me confusing feelings.

Catra gripped her cape and pulled it around a little tighter.

“But I was right too,” Adora continued, “I trust you. More than anything, I know I trust you. I could close my eyes and fall and know you would catch me.”

“You were right about another thing,” Catra spoke in a low murmur, acutely aware of the racing of her own heartbeat, “you lift me up, rather than me dragging you down. So…. Where does that leave us?”

Finally, though heat in her face begged her not to, Adora turned to look at Catra again. She summoned a strength from inside, feeling the answer what just ahead if they keep going. Perhaps this was like on her trials. Knowing that the key to turn around a case was just a few bluffs away. But she wasn't bluffing now.

"Do you think we could… now that we're… could we… figure out what we are?"

"What we are?" Catra twisted her cheek.

She continued to look forward, holding an uncertain look. Yet in the back of her mind, she knew.

"B-because," Adora continued, "if you want to *have* me, maybe that could mean… well, whatever it means for you, I'm happy to do it."

Catra froze. It was impossible to ignore the meaning of Adora's words now. Yet, not just the inkling from the back of her mind coming forward to the fore, but the memory of everything Chas Singer had told her was coming back in a full tide as well. She had been falling into this for a long time. And with the unravelling of her life, the twists and turns beyond her control, the sleepless and restless nights and the way her mind had consumed itself with this obsession, a moment had appeared to her, one small beacon of light and hope, a chance to do things how she saw fit.

She could do this her way.

"Adora," she said, her throat quavering but her voice determined, "I love you."

For a moment, Adora's expression was blank. But it was a weak moment, powerless to withhold the crashing of emotion that came over her. It was a sense of relief, loosening throughout her limbs, but for her throat which grew tight and thick. Her eyes glistened by a distant light, perhaps a wayward star breaking through the polluted sky.

And she wondered. Had Catra realised the split-second before, or had she known for a long time. Either way, of course she had figure it out first. Catra always did.

Adora smiled. She was confused, sure, but deep down she was accepting. This was where it had always been headed. This is what she wanted.

“I love you too,” she said.

“Wow,” Catra gave a weak titter, “that’s all I needed to say, huh. I feel….”

“Good?” suggested Adora.

“Yeah,” the other girl smiled. “Good.”

“This isn’t gonna stop being confusing.”

“No, not at all. But my head already feels clearer. Maybe I can sleep a little easier tonight.”

Adora’s hand moved forward, quiet on its own. It brushed up against Catra’s fingers, before entwining. She looked up again, meeting her two-coloured eyes. Without needed another word, the two leaned in, closer to one another.

Millimetres at a time, not breaking eye-contact, though drowsy-like their eyelids lowered. Adora slightly angled her head. Her movements were smooth and gentled, cautious as not to make Catra bolt. But Catra did not mean to break now. Breath touched upon skin, with a light tingling where it streamed over, and finally, at long last, and unfurling delight across their entire faces as it did, their lips caressed against one another. Just a little further. They closed their eyes.

Chapter End Notes

> Man, so close to the end now. It's been roughly half a year from first doing a rough drawing of the two girls as the AA

lawyers which inspired this whole project up till now a week away from the end. But it's also weird that like maybe only half of that was actually the writing where there was a good couple of months writing out the story notes and now the last couple of months just editing and releasing the last reserve of chapters.

Anyway how about that chapter eh? Finally the big smooch. Funny thing about Catra's insomnia: I wrote this chapter when I was having some really terrible nights, so I thought I might as well turn that experience into something valuable and use it to illustrate her emotional state.

For the Honour

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

As close as once could ever get to normal, life at the Prosecutor's Office had reached it. Of course, so much had changed. The outside world now looked on with keener eyes, and anger and suspicion would continue to flow in for years after. The scandals had not died down, but at least the initial shocks had passed. And there was work to do, even in the last weeks of the year, and so work they would do.

Catra was the incarnation of the Office itself. She carried herself, poised, as if nothing had ever happened. She built up a portfolio of files, papers, documents to sort and work through that her office became overburdened with the mess. And yet she knew this was a new reality, one in which everything she thought she knew would be discarded, and she'd have to navigate by quickly learning a new way of doing things. But as ever with something so daunting, she preferred to ignore it. There would be times to figure things out in the future. And she much liked her chances now than she had before.

For now, she'd rather just focus on work.

"I really don't know why this couldn't wait until after the holidays," Detective Scorpia opined as she came into the room, just managing to hold her own collection of papers. "It's only the trials that have to be sorted in three days, the paperwork doesn't have that deadline. Right, here—"

With a very delicate grip, she slipped a piece from the pile, without tearing, and placed it on Catra's desk.

"With that kind of attitude, is it really any wonder your bosses haven't raised your salary?" the prosecutor snarked. "I want a

clean slate by the time I come back. And trust me, you'll be grateful to be on top of everything as well."

"Hey it's not me that can't keep up, it's the space," Scorpia said, quickly shuffling to keep a hold of everything, "I can't keep putting evidence in my own office; I'm gonna trip on something."

"Can't you requisition a second locker?"

"They don't have spares! Why can't we transfer stuff over to the prosecutor's office?"

"The acting Chief put a moratorium on it," Catra rolled her eyes, "the vault is still being searched by the PIC, and so unless you happen to have a spare…?"

Scorpia sighed, "okay, sir. I'll just have to put more on my desk then. Just don't get angry if some of it finally arrives in pieces."

The big girl went to leave, but before she did, Catra called after her:

"Hey, Scorpia."

"Yeah?" she looked back, watchful.

"Thanks for all the help," the prosecutor wore a smile. "And enjoy the holidays."

Scorpia gave back a grin, "you too, wildcat."

Miraculously, she found a way to free a pincer without dropping a single file, and used it to tap her hat before she left. Catra returned to typing away on her computer, and was ready to churn the day away. However, it wasn't long after that there was another knock on the door. It was acting Chief Prosecutor Edgeworth. She stood up.

"Ah, hello, sir."

“Ms. Catra,” he said with a short nod, “I just came to check up on how you’re doing. I cannot express enough how grateful I am that you’ve taken up all this slack. It would be understandable had you wished you take an early break after your ordeal, but with all the dismissals I’ve had to make, you’ve made a worthy sacrifice. So again, thank you.”

“It’s alright, sir. I don’t actually know what I’d do otherwise.” She rubbed her elbow, “it’s good to be busying my mind, I feel. It’s… better than reminiscing.”

“Hmm. I’m not so sure that’s a good idea.”

“Sir?”

He folded his arms, “I’m not really good with this kind of discussion. But I have some experience with being accused of murder. Ah well, I can’t really tell you any more than you know about your own inner life.”

Edgeworth paced in, finding himself drawn to the window. There he slid a finger along the frame, and pondered aloud:

“I heard some rumours. I’d have thought you’d had quite the reason to want more downtime, not less.”

Catra’s expression was stabbed with pain, though with Edgeworth faced away it was hidden. Still, she was ruffled.

“You heard about that?”

“I hear things, here and there,” Edgeworth said with a small smirk. “Don’t worry, this isn’t an intervention. There is precedent for cross-bench fraternisation, I believe. So long as it doesn’t interfere with your work, I won’t register any complaint. But so long as you’re on top of things, you should take your entitled off-hours and enjoy yourself.”

“I don’t really know what to do yet,” admitted Catra. “Everything’s still fresh and… god, I’m not even ready to face her in court

again."

"So you have no plans to… how would you say, meet up? Have you even seen her since she came here?"

"We've kept contact," Catra mumbled. "And I did agree to Christmas with her. Her friend's having a meal and invited people over. I'm going to that, I guess…."

"It must be hard to know where to start."

"Yeah…."

Now that girl was on her mind. Nothing new to that.

"It's hard to believe this is real," Catra mused, almost to herself.

"You've lock heads in court a number of times now. I imagine that it won't be any less fiery when you return. But nonetheless," Edgeworth gave a certain nod, saying more a statement than a question, "you see her in a different light."

"She has her charms. Even if she is an idiot."

"Sometimes I feel that way about Wright," the man noted.

Catra broke into a chuckle, "nah, your boy is more intelligent than he lets on. But Adora? Complete fluff inside her head."

"I feel you've rather underestimated her," the man said with a fresh grin. "She might be headstrong and engages in bluster, but my impression is that she can be quite strategic when she needs to be."

"Strategic?" Catra laughed now, "she doesn't think before she acts. She's a complete danger to herself. Can't count the number of times she's nearly fallen or actually fallen to a months worth of hospital bills."

“Has she ever fallen from a burning bridge?” asked Edgeworth, and before Catra could try and retort, added his finishing blow, “and has she ever eaten glass?”

Catra blinked, quite stumped there. Then with a wry though somewhat nervous expression, ventured to asked:

“Do you… do you think we’re… attracted to the stupid things they do?”

“I—,’ now Edgeworth was flustered as he tried, but couldn’t quite dismiss the idea. “I’d prefer we didn’t think on that….”

But the conversation with the Chief Prosecutor did leave something staying with Catra. Christmas. It was getting closer. Once the last day of work was over she had a week or so until it finally arrived. Her plan was to spend the days for herself — downtime, selfcare, or whatever. But every time she got out of bed, ready to think her way through the day ahead of her, she mired down in the calendar. She wasted whole hours on it. It was coming —she was going to see her again. It was dizzying. She felt faint. Yet just looking at the calendar and the days crossed off slipped her into smiles.

When the day came, a glorious morning greeted Brightmoon manor and Adora and Glimmer spent a pleasant morning with Angella. It was a quiet affair, mostly drinking hot chocolate around a rustling hearth. The real event was the dinner. When dark had fallen, the two girls made their way across the city, arriving at Bow’s home. There the driveway was covered by a blanket of snow, bluish-grey in the winter darkness, though bespeckled with warm glows of yellow, red and green from the fairy lights all-around.

The house was unassuming by its facade, so Adora and Glimmer were quite amazed by the broad entrance hall, lined with an impressive collection of books (almost all about history.) Bow’s dads were a festive bunch in a festive mood and greeted them

with sufficient cheer. The table was all set up so they invited them to come into the next room.

But before they could follow, a knock came on the door. Bow and Glimmer looked to Adora, who nodded.

“That’ll be her,” she said, taking in a breath, “You guys go on ahead.”

Giddy as she got to the door, Adora stood there for a second. Her hands were all tremor, hanging loose by her side. Then she opened the door, revealing Catra in the cold dark beyond.

“Hey, Adora,” the girl said. “I… don’t really know what to say next—”

But Catra was then yanked forward. Adora had gripped her arm as quickly as she had seen her and pulled her in, and with a yelp, Catra made an instinctive struggle

“Hey, let me go!” But then a growth of green just above caught her eye, and she said, “oh…” She gave a single shove and that broke them apart. With a sort of accusing glare, she said to Adora, “no, no, that’s cheating. You’re gonna have to earn a kiss from me tonight.”

“Oh really?” Adora smirked, laying a hand on her hip. “Is that how it is? Reward and punishment? I didn’t think you went in for those kinds of relationships. But then again, you do have the whip….”

“N-no,” Catra stammered, voice giving way, “that’s not what I meant. Ugh, you better not be like this all night.”

She flicked Adora on the forehead for her folly, and pushed her way past her. Adora gave another laugh and followed.

“Everyone’s at the table, through there,” she pointed. “So… how are we gonna do this?”

“Do what? Enter a room?”

“Well, Lance and George have met me now, so if you come in with me it makes sense that I’m going to explain who you are.”

“Then just tell them, why are you making a big thing out of this?” Catra shot her an exasperated glare.

“Well, am I gonna say ‘hey, this is Catra,’ or ‘this is prosecutor Catra?’ Or, well,” Adora gave a funny half-smile off to the side, as she came to rub her shoulder, “I kinda wanted to introduce you as my girlfriend.”

Catra’s tail shot up, causing her to stumble to a stop. Blushing so much she couldn’t even thing to hide it, she stared at Adora. The girl met her eye with a wide look, and even bit her lip as she awaited Catra’s answer.

“G-girlfriend,” Catra repeated. The words brought a wrangling to her stomach, but also a floating, fluttery feeling as well. “It’s… very direct.”

“It’s fine if you don’t want to pull labels on this yet or—”

“Okay,” Catra said.

“Okay,” Adora said, with a quiet nod.

“No, I mean it’s okay,” said Catra again. “I… I’d like it if you called me that.”

Adora looked up again, a shimmer in her eyes. Then a broad smile spread across her face and she came up to Catra, locking her hand into hers. Catra couldn’t stop herself smiling back.

The dining room was full of glory —tinsel and decoration surrounded the walls, that stood basking in the presence of the broad table in the centre, adorned with platters of food, all the stuffings and trimmings of a true Christmas meal. The dads were still serving and carving, while Bow and Glimmer were sat side by side on one end, chatting and laughing among themselves. Just coming into the room, Catra felt different. Her ears fell, and

uncertainty crept up within her. But Adora still held her hand, and the warmth of it was reassuring.

"Hey everyone," said Adora, "this is my girlfriend, Catra. She's… sort of a colleague for us as the courthouse."

Catra gave a weak chuckle and said, "yeah, you could say that."

Bow's dads were more than welcoming of the newcomer. Lance was excitable and talkative off the bat, to the slight chagrin of George who was struggling to get a word in. They were so warm and receptive of Catra that she wondered if it were even her they were talking to —that perhaps this was some dream or fancy and it was some other girl, taking the seat by Adora's side on the table. Perhaps the real Catra was back at the office, brooding in the dark and plotting the blonde girl's destruction.

These were bad thoughts to infect her mind on such a festive day. Yet even when she pushed them aside, Catra remained rather quiet, even as everyone began to dig-in and conversation took off. The well-roasted meals went down, along with laughter. The odd game or joke followed, and there was general good mood and fun. And though quiet at first, Catra was grateful to be here.

After a few ill-advised drinks, however, Catra found the tongue loosened, and in a rowdy way. Her comments were wry, as usual, and perhaps well suited to wind the squad up —but the instinct she had for malice was dead today. Everything was in good humour now.

"I think," Catra swirled a finger around a champagne glass, her voice sultry and ready to pounce, "I can start controlling mr. Bow as he progresses as a forensic investigator. Then I can beak him up with sparkles here during investigations."

"Heh," Glimmer said, meeting the challenge with a grin, "I say good luck to that."

"Protocol's on my side. You have to use the precinct's kit, and you can't meddle. That means you do your PCR analysis or whatever

the traditional way… I can have you on a computer all night!”

Glimmer leaned over and hugged Bow’s arm, declaring, “you can’t take him away from me, and you can’t take his technology from him!”

“We’re a very resourceful team,” said Adora, “we’ll survive any challenge you throw at us.”

“Come on, don’t encourage her,” Bow said with a laugh, one that was only slightly nervous.

“So Catra,” said Glimmer, sitting back up straight, “what are you doing about your hair? Going to grow it out again?”

“You should keep it,” suggested Lance, “it’s a real fashion statement.”

Catra felt for her own head, streaming her fingers between the short tufts. Despite the unorthodox method of cutting, it had come rather stylish. On the other hand, it was almost unbalanced against her cape’s high collar. It had been terrible to beat off the winter’s chill, but by the time the mane came back it’d be hot summer. She wondered. With a gesture of her eyes to the left, she looked to Adora and waited for her input. The other girl reached out her hand, and patted Catra’s hand.

“I like it either way,” she smiled.

“Heh, so much help you are.” She sent Adora a devilish smile, tapped her fingers on her chin and she pondered loudly, “now your appearance, I’d like to edit. That stupid poof has long needed to go.”

Adora felt for her own hair, “what? What’s wrong with it?”

“I mean, what’s right with it?”

“It’s iconic, you can’t get rid of it,” protested Bow.

“I mean, yeah,” Catra admitted, “would you even look right without it?”

In response, Adora put down her current glass and reached back to fiddle with her hairband. Slipping it off, she still held her ponytail by a hand. But as she unclasped the locks, and they started to fall about, the strands around her forehead unwound, falling in front like a forelock. She shook her head, and finally it came all loose and long, draping around her shoulders and covering the side of her face like wings. Catra watched all the while with a gape.

“How does that look?” Adora asked.

But Catra was now standing up. She held her own glass, and grabbed Adora with her free hand.

“Wh-what?”

“I-I need you to come with me,” Catra ordered, and quite confused, Adora stood up and was dragged out.

She took her to the other room, shut the door, and then pressed the girl back into it.

“Catra, what’s wrong?” stammered Adora, wearing a wide, worried expression. “I thought you having fun, what’s going on—”

“Shut up,” Catra whispered.

She downed her glass in one, and dropped it was clink as it hit the floor. Then, with lowered eyelids and a heavy breaths fermented with festivity, Catra slunk up to her. She stroked her hand against Adora’s now lowered hair, curling it in her fingers. Then she pushed her mouth into Adora’s, meeting in one long, and restless kiss.

When they parted, they continued to stare into one another’s eyes. Then Adora broke into a small laugh.

“You’re such an idiot,” she said.

“Yeah, well I learned from the best.”

So, as the year came to a close, so did the story. Adora was not the novice she’d once been, nor was she that prosecutor as when it started. The folding of the year into the next brought a new page for them all, and undoubtedly a new story could begin. Certainly, as the two girls had fallen into each other’s eyes that Christmas evening, they could see there was truth to uncover that not even the courtroom could penetrate; and a friendship that neither time nor the space between the benches could rend apart.

Of course, they would be joined by the same old crazy cast of characters. And as the days grew longer and the new year set in, there were many chances to drop in on a few of them.

The Princess Promenade swam in its usual dark and velvet ambience. Its patrons were drinking, dancing and chattering as if the half-year disruption it had endured had barely passed them by. Chas Singer, of course, came up in his usual smart tuxedo and white gloves, and, with a broad smile, greeted the visitors.

“Now I’ve been wondering when you would all be coming,” he said. “Now —hey, I won’t be hearing any apologies. I won my appeal, that’s all that matters. No more hang-ups in the detention centre for me. And I’ve got a new manager, one who’s an absolute joy to work with. Well, I understand that you feel you failed back in that old case. But that’s the past now, and I say let it go like a wrong note played. Events can move against you, that’s just the way of the world.” He looked out to the side with a sigh. “I will admit, I’m weary. But I’m back where I belong. Now, excuse me. The music calls!”

With that, the man sprung his way back to the stage, and, with the tapping of a hi-hat followed by the verve of the brass, he began to sing

I'm gonna lay down my sword and shield

Down by the Riverside….

There were songs all around, as down by the Sushi Salinity, Sea Hawk was finally able to belt out his jolly shanty. While Mermista rolled her eyes as it began, she wasn't about to put a stop to it. And when it finished, she let slip a small smile and muttered:

"It's not that bad."

"I knew you were starting to warm to me," Sea Hawk came down to lie on the table he'd been singing on, so as to bring his head level to her. "It's taken years, but a sailor often must spend years in anxious wait for the sea to give him favour."

"I said *it* wasn't so bad. Never mentioned you."

Promptly, she shoved the man off the table so she could hand the visitors their drinks. He bounded right back up, perched head on hand ,and watched her with an almost drunken look. She however addressed the others:

"Please give ms. Angella my thanks. Her advice really helped. Like, without it, I'd definitely be in prison. I'm ashamed of what I did, but I still prefer to have this light punishment. Although, it does involve… ugh, more customer service."

Unlike the jazz club or the sushi bar, getting into the Dryl Institute was a tricky task. With no reception and with only an ad-hoc appointment system at best, they really just had to show up one day and hope for the best, navigating the twisting paths. But they made it to the panel up by the gravity chamber as they had before, where Ron Guy was cheery in greeting them.

"I am glad that my brother Hordak has come to peace with himself and is free of Prime's influence," he explained, "even though he's going through new trials now."

At that point, Entrapta, floating in the air beyond the panel, hovered up to contribute, "I'm visiting him everyday! He's already agreed to come back to Dryl once he's served his time!"

Though still smiling, Guy's face became rather nervous.

"I do worry about how much riskier the goings-on of this facility are enduring, especially since—"

There was a boom. Distant, but enough to cause a tremor even all the way up here. Now Ron Guy went pale —as possible as his white face could— and he lost the smile altogether. Entrapta however just pulled out her recorder by her hair and began to report:

"Perhaps in future we should restrict Swift Wind's access from the munitions development program…."

Going to the detention centre was work, not pleasure. There were still some mysteries to that last case, and one who could answer them. Self-styled agent of chaos that they were, Double Trouble was willing to explain how Shadow Weaver employed them in her schemes —though they often frustrated the interrogations the best way they could.

"You know, this place isn't as bad as I thought it'd be," they noted, stroking the side of the glass pane, striking a nonchalant tone, "meals are better than what I could get on the Promenade's pay. And it's worth it to have done my magnum opus performance. Ah, but there are always more roles to conquer. You know that more than anyone, don't you," they gave a sharp-tooth leer, "this new nice girl act, for example. But I remember what you're really like. I've taken your voice before, and worn your face. I know how you think." They leant back and cooly added, "And I liked the old you — so much fire, so much edge. I don't think this new role can last. Do you?."

Heading over to the Wright and co. agency, however, was just a meet-up of friends. Not only Phoenix, leaning against his desk,

but Miles Edgeworth visiting and there was also Maya Fey, back from her training in the mountains.

“I missed quite a lot, didn’t I,” she said, amazed to learn the story from the other two.

“Well, we were hardly involved,” Phoenix said, in consolation.

Edgeworth folded his arms, “we had our effect. You were the defence for the McRaker trial and I the prosecution for that last affair. And we were both present at the crime for that other case.”

“Barely involved,” Phoenix said again with sly chuckle.

“Well, I for one had a… change of perspective. Now I think we can expect many great things from our prosecutor Catra.”

“Not if she keeps running into ms. Adora,” said Phoenix. “It’ll be a real challenge if she’s there to thwart her every action. Must make the dates quite awkward, huh.”

“I’ve managed to maintain my friendship with you, Wright,” Edgeworth replied with a harrumph. “I think they’ll do quite fine.”

Maya had kept silent, her eyes darting from one man to the other in their exchange. But now she could hold back no long. She started to titter.

“Okay, spit it out, Maya,” Phoenix sighed. “What’s so funny?’

“You really don’t see it, Nick?” she asked. “I mean, look at yourselves?”

“What are we supposed to be seeing?” asked Edgeworth.

“You two are just like Catra and Adora,” said Maya. “So why aren’t you dating already?”

“M-Maya!” Phoenix said, almost tripping up.

Edgeworth stammered for a few seconds. He looked to Phoenix, who was looking to him. Yet they immediately broke eye contact as they both try to retain a resolute and dignified face. Then the stood up, a little straighter than before. Maya held silent, watching and waiting. The two men exchanged another awkward glance. Phoenix gave a half-committed shrug.

Voice strange, Edgeworth said, "Wright. Perhaps we should get away from this."

"Yes, Edgeworth, that… might be good."

"The two of us should take a breather. Alone. Perhaps a stroll?"

Phoenix gave a nod. Stepping forward, he and Edgeworth left the office, leaving Maya to burst into uncontrollable laughter.

Far from the town, there were no more cordons at the whispering wood. Rather it had returned to its peaceful state, with the gardener Perfuma returning to her work tending the flowers after the new year. Sometimes Detective Scorpia was found, giving her a hand. She dug at the soil with a cumbersome shovel, and it was a wonder how the gardener would have managed without the big girl's help.

"Oh hey," she beamed at the arrivals, "fancy seeing you all up here. Don't worry, wildcat, I'm not quitting for this line of work."

"She's been a great help," said Perfuma, and with a wrestled smile, said, "she said it was make up for almost getting me in trouble? Even though I should be doing something to make up to her."

"Ah, either way it's been nice hanging around with you. It's been a good Christmas, but with all the crime still happening in the world I'll be getting back to beat soon."

"I wish you all the luck. For me, I'm always happy to see the Springtime bloom."

Scropia suddenly stood straight, facing the others. There was an earnest weight in her expression, and she gave a salute with her heavy pincer.

"You know it's been an honour working with you. All of you, in fact, and I can't wait to get back to it all."

Of course, no matter the course of day, or the distance of whatever place they went to, home awaited by its every end — Brightmoon Manor beckoned. On the return from their most recent excursion, Angella could be found in her bedroom, once again pensive as she inspected the photograph of herself, Glimmer and Micah. But when she noticed she was not alone, she turned. It was clear that while the last time was tinged with regret, longing; instead now she wore a smile that was serene.

"I wanted to see you," she said. "It… well, I went and did it. It's just a symbolic gesture, of course. My time at the bench is long over. But, this feels right. The old wounds are closing. I can't express enough how thankful I am to Miles for making this possible."

She showed them. In her outstretched palm was sunflower pin — old and silver, with any of the gold chipped off by time and the years away. It was the same one as before. Angella's Attorney's badge.

"And I have to thank you," she said now. Her eyes fell on the subject of her gratitude, and they were soft, glowing with an endless warmth. "None of this would have been possible if it weren't for you. I'd feel a fool to try and teach you more, but it would be my privilege if you want me to stay as your mentor. But now, for everything you've done, accept my thanks."

Home that the manor was, where would Adora, Bow, Glimmer and Catra be if not in the courtroom. Because the new year was underway, and there was much work to be done. Someone was called for to compile evidence, to investigate beyond the surface of the petty violence and murder that plagued the city. There was

a need for knowledge and science to construct and deconstruct the case. And there were the innocent, wrongly accused, to defend to the very last.

“Order, order!” the Judge bellowed, banging his gavel to summon silence against the riotous gallery. “Now, defence, is that really the argument you want to go with?”

“I…,” sweat trickled at Adora’s templed. She was gripping the bench to hold herself up, and desperately trying to clear her head to think this through. “Maybe I can try again…?”

“Adora, you can’t keep doing this,” said Glimmer in an agitated hush, “we know it couldn’t have been her, so push on that! Just —eep!”

The crack of a whip, —just on the edge of the defence bench— caused Glimmer to flinch. Catra smirked at them from across the chamber.

“No sneaking the answers across now, sparkles. It’s test time. What’s your answer, Adora?”

“I still don’t understand how you can think a child did this,” remarked Bow with a frown. “Like, isn’t that a bit much?”

“Well, if it’s so easy to dismiss, why are we still here” Catra shrugged.

“I’m inclined to agree,” said the Judge. “The evidence seems insurmountable. I’d put down my verdict now if the prosecution allowed it”

“I said wait, okay.” Catra threw Adora a teasing grin, “it takes the defence a few minutes to boot up her brain, so at least give her a chance.”

“You think you’re so cool, don’t you,” came Adora’s rejoinder. “But I know how to completely fry your head, so don’t push me.”

“Th-that,” Catra straightened a little, and muttered “the hair trick is not going to save you every time, defence.”

“Well I’ll save it for a tight spot.”

“You seem pretty cornered right now.”

“Nah,” Adora laughed, “I’m barely even surrounded. Your honour, do you remember what the minimum age for the snowpack ride was?”

The Judge blinked. “The uh… snowpark ride? Ah yes, the witness said it was a minimum of 12.”

“And how old is my client?”

“Did she say?”

“Of course she did,” Catra rolled her eyes, “eleven and three quarters, that’s what the defence is driving at. But who’s to say she didn’t lie to get pass the barrier?”

“Oh no,” said Adora, energy building up within her, “she didn’t lie. The defence can provide proof of that. In fact, this proof not only shows the administrator must have known her exact age, but it’s going to throw everything we thought we knew under a whole new light!”

The Judge’s eyes widened. “A whole…”

“…new light?” said Bow and Glimmer together.

“Really?” Adora said, looking to one then the other, “am I the only one who sees it yet? Whoo boy, I said all along I was smart.”

“Wow, Adora,…you really make this exciting.”

Catra was now leaning over the bench, lazing her head on a hand. She began to purr —another deliberate tactic to throw Adora off

her game. But Adora was ready this time, and nothing was going to dampen the electricity running through her core.

“You should expect nothing less, prosecutor Catra,” Adora returned with a grin.

“Okay then. If this is your pivotal evidence, why not give us the full light-show?”

“The light-show?”

“Come on, Adora, give us She-Ra!”

“To be fair,” said Bow, “this is the point in the trial you usually do.”

Glimmer nodded, “and you look good with the sword.”

“I concur,” the Judge said, knocking his gavel as if to make an official statement. “The defence should accompany her next point by brandishing her sword.”

“Well,” said Adora, heat creeping along her neck as every expectant eye was on her, “if you guys really insist. Okay, let’s do this!”

She held out her arm, ready grasp the oncoming sword in her hands. The power rose in her chest. Summoning it, along with air and force, she was ready to burst it forward. Then she proclaimed, in a loud, springing voice:

“For the honour of Grayskull!” Light gleamed, followed by the sharp sling of steel. And Adora the defence attorney shouted:

“OBJECTION!”

* * *

Chapter End Notes

So that's it! I'm feeling very happy with this work looking back, and even though by now I'm way past shifting gears

away from it (think I finished the first draft way back in november, around the time chapter 13 was published) it's been really good reading them back every week as I've uploaded the last episode.

This chapter is all endnote really. While the final episode had the dramatic climax in Turnabout Promise p3 when Catra defeated Shadow Weaver, the penultimate chapter has the emotional climax within the denouement, when Adora and Catra worked out their feelings towards each other. So this chapter was about gently lowering the stakes while still having some engaging content. But it's a GREAT excuse to dump a bunch of fluff and there's some choice scenes in this one that always made me smile reading them back. Plus I thought I ought do those endcredit scenes they do in the Ace Attorney games where you catch up with all the characters

Cliched to say and I think I might have said it already but if so I will again: I hope you've enjoyed reading this as much as I've enjoyed writing. I don't know if I'll be writing anything more for this account soon let alone for either of these fandoms but I'm certainly not averse to it.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!